

DUNGEONS & DRAGONS
**FORGOTTEN
REALMS**
HEROES OF FAERÛN

PLAYER EXPANSION



INTRODUCTION: A WORLD OF EPIC HEROES

Welcome to Faerûn

Chapter 1: Character Options

Chapter 2: A Guide to the Realms

Chapter 3: Gods of Faerûn

Chapter 4: Aurora's Whole Realms Catalog

Chapter 5: Magic of Faerûn

Chapter 6: Factions of the Realms

Other Resources

CHAPTER 1: CHARACTER OPTIONS

Character Species

Subclasses

College of the Moon (Bard)

Knowledge Domain (Cleric)

Banneret (Fighter)

Oath of the Noble Genies (Paladin)

Winter Walker (Ranger)

Scion of the Three (Rogue)

Spellfire Sorcery (Sorcerer)

Bladesinger (Wizard)

Backgrounds

Feats

Feat List

Origin Feats

General Feats

Epic Boon Feats

CHAPTER 2: A GUIDE TO THE REALMS

Time in the Realms

Currency

Adventurers

Regions of the Realms

Regions and Languages

Anauroch

Arcane Empires

Forgotten Lands

Heartlands

Lands of Intrigue

The North

Old Empires

Sword Coast

Trackless Sea

Vilhon Reach

Beyond

CHAPTER 3: GODS OF FAERÛN

Forms of Worship

The Afterlife

Religious Institutions

Divine Magic

Deities of Faerûn

CHAPTER 4: AURORA'S WHOLE REALMS CATALOG

Equipment

Mechanical Wonders

Mounts and Other Animals

Tools

Travel

Vehicles

CHAPTER 5: MAGIC OF FAERÛN

The Weave

Circle Magic

Spells

CHAPTER 6: FACTIONS OF THE REALMS

Faction Descriptions

Special Facilities

Faction Relationships

Cult of the Dragon

Emerald Enclave

Harpers

Lords' Alliance

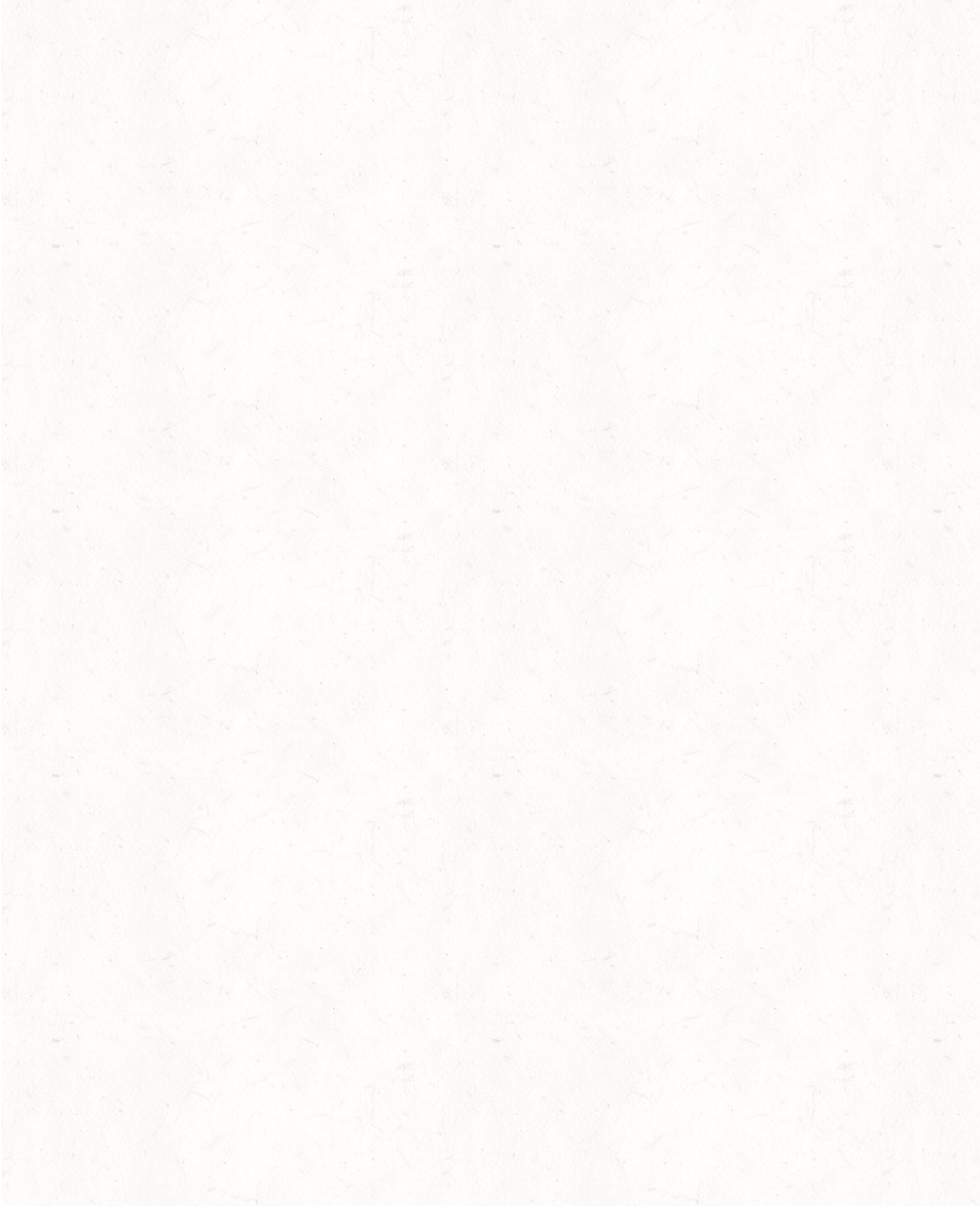
Order of the Gauntlet

The Purple Dragon Knights

Red Wizards

Zhentarim

CREDITS



INTRODUCTION

A WORLD OF EPIC HEROES



HEROES IN FAERÛN COME FROM ALL SPECIES, ALL CHARACTER CLASSES, AND ALL WALKS OF LIFE.

*BUT THEY HAVE ONE **THING** IN COMMON: THEIR EPIC NATURE.*

ARTIST: ANDREY KUZINSKIY

This book is your comprehensive guide to creating and playing a character in the awe-inspiring Forgotten Realms.

WELCOME TO FAERÛN

The world of Faerûn is filled with countless heroes who have undertaken amazing adventures—Drizzt Do'Urden, his wife Cattie-brie, and their daughter, Briennelle; Alustriel Silverhand and the rest of the Seven Sisters; Karlach Cliffgate, Astarion, and Shadowheart; and many more. Now, the world has new heroes: the ones you and your fellow players create.

Heroes in the Forgotten Realms are larger than life. *Forgotten Realms: Heroes of Faerûn* gives you everything you need to create adventurers that fit right into the Realms, including new and revised subclasses and dozens of new feats and spells.

Like the heroes who populate Faerûn, magic in the Realms is epic. This book introduces the Faerûnian technique of circle magic: a way for spellcasters to work together to make their spells more flexible and powerful.

Heroes seldom work alone. This book details eight famous factions, each of which has a reach that extends across all Faerûn. Some of these factions, like the Harpers or the Lords' Alliance, are honorable and just, helping the needy and protecting the innocent. Others, like the greedy Zhentarim or the power-hungry Red Wizards, oppress their victims and focus on amassing power. Your character can join any of these factions, earning rewards for loyal service. Or, your character might oppose a faction and brave its ire.

Welcome to the Forgotten Realms, a world of epic characters and adventures!

CHAPTER 1: CHARACTER OPTIONS

Chapter 1 helps you create the next hero of the Forgotten Realms. In addition to new character options—subclasses, backgrounds, and feats—this chapter provides an overview of the species of Faerûn and each one's place in the world.

Adventuring is a well-known occupation in Faerûn, and there's no shortage of common sellswords or petty mages rummaging around in old ruins hoping to find hidden treasure or a long-lost spellbook. And yet, in the Forgotten Realms, characters stand out among these adventurers as epic figures, even beginning at level 1.

Throughout the history of the Forgotten Realms, epic heroes are distinguished from everyday adventurers by their extraordinary natures. Alias, hero of *Curse of the Azure Bonds*, is an artificial person created by an alliance of evil spellcasters that included a lich and cultists of Moander, god of corruption and rot. Karlach, one of the heroes of *Baldur's Gate 3*, has a magical *Infernal Engine* for a heart, which grants her incredible power but brings unusual, life-threatening complications. Several heroes of the Forgotten Realms, such as Tristan Kendrick and Randall Morn, have been heirs to a throne. You can use the nature of these heroes, and others who've adventured across Faerûn, as inspiration for your own character's epic nature.

Beyond their nature, an epic character is distinguished by their destiny. Perhaps your character is fated to wield a powerful Artifact or become the ruler of a realm. When creating a character for a Forgotten Realms campaign, work with your DM to develop an epic destiny for your character. *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn* has additional guidance on crafting epic characters and how their stories might play out in a campaign.

CHAPTER 2: A GUIDE TO THE REALMS

Every corner of Faerûn has a distinct flavor born out of local stories, traditions, notable personalities, and memorable locales. Chapter 2 describes many locations across Faerûn that might have played a crucial role in your character's origins—perhaps where your character grew up or where they learned their adventuring skills. The backgrounds in chapter 1 can connect your character to those locations.

For example, a Sorcerer might have mastered wild magic while studying under the Simbarchs of Aglarond, a land that's been ruled by sorcerers for generations. A Fighter might have gained bitter battlefield experience serving Sembia in border disputes with the Dalelands or Cormyr.

A LIVING HISTORY

The Forgotten Realms are littered with ruins of ancient civilizations that fell millennia ago. These once-mighty societies still play a role in everyday life in Faerûn. A tall tower from the giant kingdom of Ostonia might have been scavenged for stones that now make up a humble crafter's cottage. An ancient relic of Narfell demon worshipers is now used by a blacksmith to stoke their forge. Sheep graze in the shadow of once-mighty Myth Drannor. What contact has your character had with these fallen realms, and how did that contact influence your character's motivations and behaviors?

CHAPTER 3: GODS OF FAERÛN



***THE TWIN BLACK DRAGONS VOARAGHAMANTHAR AND WAERVAERENDOR
ARE MORE THAN A MATCH FOR FOOLISH ADVENTURERS.***

ARTIST: JONATHAN KUO

Faerûn is a land of many gods, and chapter 3 describes many of these gods. Most folk offer prayer or other forms of worship to several gods, though they might feel closest to a particular deity that is a patron of their occupation or to which they have some other special connection. For example, a merchant who gives daily obeisance to Waukeen, the god of trade, might offer up a propitiatory prayer to Umberlee, god of the sea, when faced with a long and difficult voyage.

Every city boasts multiple temples to various gods, and shrines can be found in the smallest village, along roads, or even deep in the wilderness.

Temples and shrines are staffed and maintained by priests, most of whom have minor spellcasting abilities, but Clerics, who channel their magic directly from the Outer Planes, are rare.

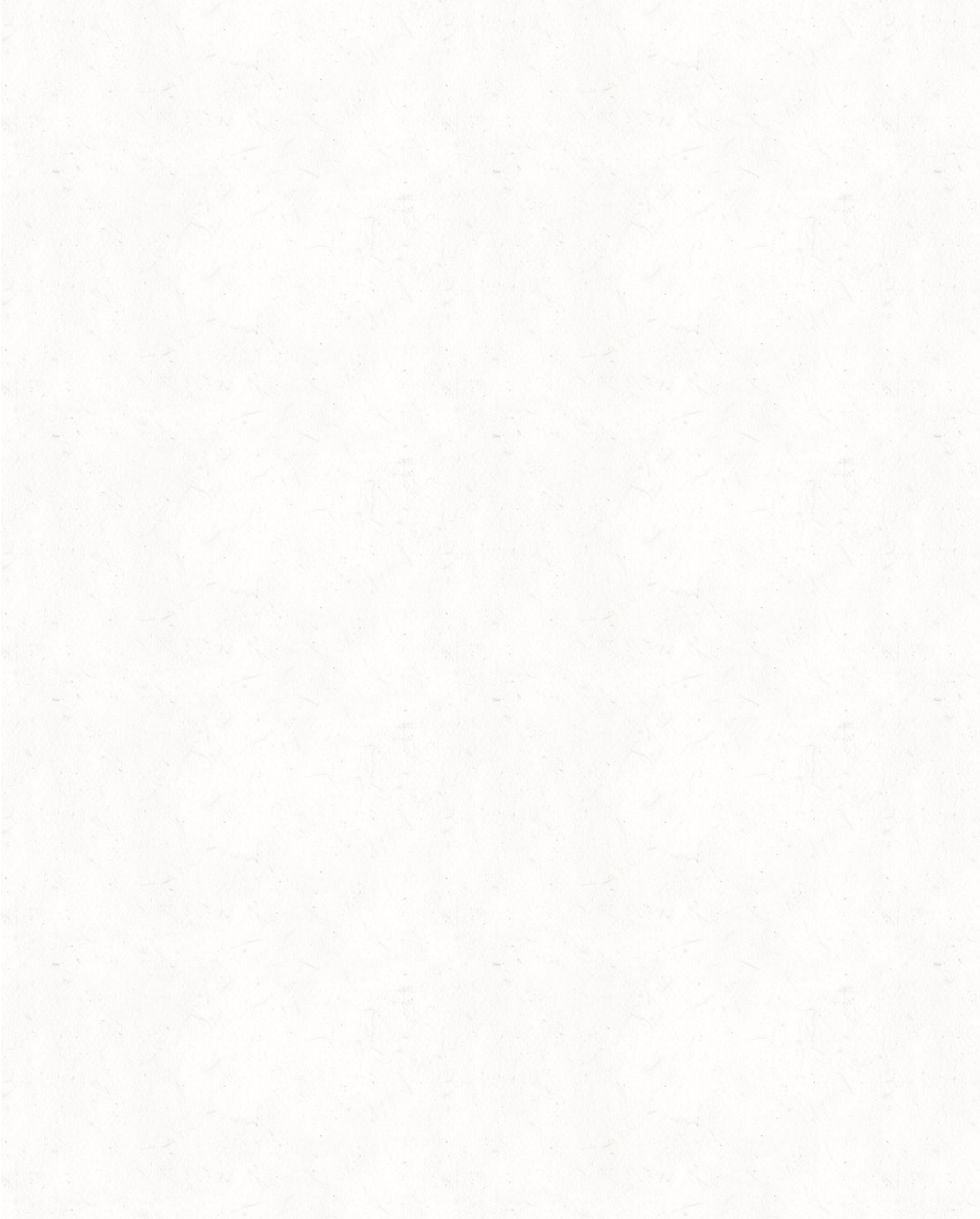
Think about your character's relationship with the gods. Which gods does your character consider especially important or relevant? For example, a character who is a Ranger or has the Farmer, Guide, or Hermit background might feel a personal connection to Chauntea, a god of agriculture, or Mielikki, a god of the forest. Are you—or do you aspire to become—one of your god's Chosen?

Conversely, what gods does your character especially resent or avoid? Your character might seek to thwart those who carry out those gods' divine agenda. Such deities might embody the opposite of your character's values. For example, a character that reveres Chauntea or Mielikki might despise Malar, a god of the hunt, or Auril, a god of winter, both of which represent nature in an evil, destructive form. Or you might carry a special enmity toward one of Malar's Chosen.

While most ordinary people in Faerûn speak to deities only through priests or the occasional divine messenger, characters in a Forgotten Realms campaign might meet a deity face to face, though the deity might have been in disguise. If your character wields divine magic, they might have gained their connection to the Outer Planes when they met a deity.

CHAPTER 4: AURORA’S WHOLE REALMS CATALOG

No adventurer is complete without a wide array of adventuring gear. Chapter 4 provides an excerpt from the famed *Aurora’s Whole Realms Catalog* to help equip your characters with new gear. Aurora was a former adventurer who outfitted heroes across Faerûn, and the business she founded is now led by her descendant.



CHAPTER 5: MAGIC OF FAERÛN



KARLACH, WITH HER INFERNAL ENGINE HEART, IS AN EXAMPLE OF AN EPIC CHARACTER.

ARTIST: IGNATIUS BUDI

Magic is woven into the very fabric of Faerûn. Chapter 5 discusses how magic works in the Forgotten Realms, including new spells, and introduces circle magic—a way for characters to cooperate in casting spells.

The fundamental framework through which magic functions is called the Weave. Mages, priests, and druids who work magic draw upon and manipulate the Weave, and damage to the Weave can be catastrophic, as was the case in the Spellplague and other disasters.

The vast majority of magic in the Realms is humble and geared toward practical matters: healing wounds, assisting with a craft, entertaining crowds, or accomplishing menial tasks. Mages are common, creating a large demand for magical academies across Faerûn. While many mages turn their command of magic into a professional career, others retreat from society to a life of study and magical experimentation.

Magic affects everyone in Faerûn, from common farmers and crafters to adventurers and monarchs. Even if you're making a character that doesn't cast spells, magic might have affected your character's life, their family, or their occupation. Perhaps your family has a magical heirloom that's passed down through the generations, or perhaps a magical creature—like a dragon, genie, or lycanthrope—is lurking somewhere in your family tree. Does your character view magic as a mystery worth exploring or simply as a utilitarian method of solving difficult problems?

CHAPTER 6: FACTIONS OF THE REALMS

Faerûn is home to powerful, realm-spanning organizations that can be powerful allies or fearsome foes. Faerûn's factions are described briefly below and detailed further in chapter 6:

- Cult of the Dragon.** Although this faction is most known for evil plots, the worship of Tiamat, and turning dragons into dracoliches, adventurers can get caught in their schemes.
 - Emerald Enclave.** This organization of druids, rangers, and others protects the wilderness and those traveling through it.
 - Harpers.** The Harpers are a legendary band of do-gooders who combat tyranny across Faerûn while keeping a low profile.
 - Lords' Alliance.** A coalition of independent cities along the Sword Coast, the Lords' Alliance stands for peace, trade, and mutual self-interest.
 - Order of the Gauntlet.** An organization of warriors motivated by faith in gods of goodness and justice, the Order seeks out evil and destroys it with force of arms.
 - Purple Dragon Knights.** Cormyr's legendary knights now travel Faerûn on dragon steeds, hunting Aberrations and furthering the cause of their queen.
 - Red Wizards.** Although their home is in the eastern realm of Thay, Red Wizards travel throughout Faerûn to increase their personal power, seeking out magic in all its forms.
 - Zhentarim.** This vast criminal syndicate provides everything from mercenary work and travel services to murder-for-hire, operating openly in cities throughout Faerûn.
- Many of these factions have associated character backgrounds presented in Chapter 1. By taking one of those backgrounds, your character becomes a member of that faction. But characters can also be a member of a faction without taking a particular background, and many characters join a faction later in their adventuring career.

What faction might your character be a member of or aspire to join? And what faction might they oppose?

OTHER RESOURCES

No single book could include every detail of the Forgotten Realms, a setting many decades in the making. *Forgotten Realms: Heroes of Faerûn* is only part of Faerûn's grand story.

Your most important companion to this book is *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn*. There, you'll find five chapters that expand on five regions of the Forgotten Realms, providing much more detail on locations, people, and the environments therein, as well as showcasing the unique kinds of adventures that take place there:

The Dalelands, home to classic fantasy adventure (see "Heartlands" in chapter 2)

Icewind Dale, a frigid land of survival horror (see "The North" in chapter 2)

Calimshan, a high magic setting of genies and magical innovation (see "Lands of Intrigue" in chapter 2)

The Moonshae Isles, filled with fairy stories and tales of adventure at sea (see "Trackless Sea" in chapter 2)

Baldur's Gate, an urban setting of morally ambiguous heroes and antiheroes. (See "Sword Coast" in chapter 2.)

That book also includes new magic items and monsters, as well as many adventures set in the Realms, including a complete starting adventure to launch a new campaign.

Two digital products have been designed to supplement this book and your games in the Realms. You can find these titles on DnDBeyond.com:

Astarion's Book of Hungers focuses on Astarion, the elf vampire from the *Baldur's Gate 3* video game.

Netheril's Fall provides insight into the ancient empire of Netheril and its magic. (See "Anauroch" in chapter 2.)

Many books in the Dungeons & Dragons line detail locations in the Forgotten Realms, which can be helpful if you want to make a character from that region. Here are some of those books:

Baldur's Gate: Descent into Avernus provides further detail on the city of Baldur's Gate.

Icewind Dale: Rime of the Frostmaiden has additional details on Ten-Towns and the North.

Tomb of Annihilation describes the jungles of Chult.

Waterdeep: Dragon Heist explores the city of Waterdeep on the Sword Coast.

NOVELS

Hundreds of novels have been set in the Forgotten Realms. A great place to start is the *Legend of Drizzt* series by R.A. Salvatore.

VIDEO GAMES

Baldur's Gate 3 is an epic game set in and around the city of Baldur's Gate (described in the "Sword Coast" section of chapter 2 and in more detail in *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn*).

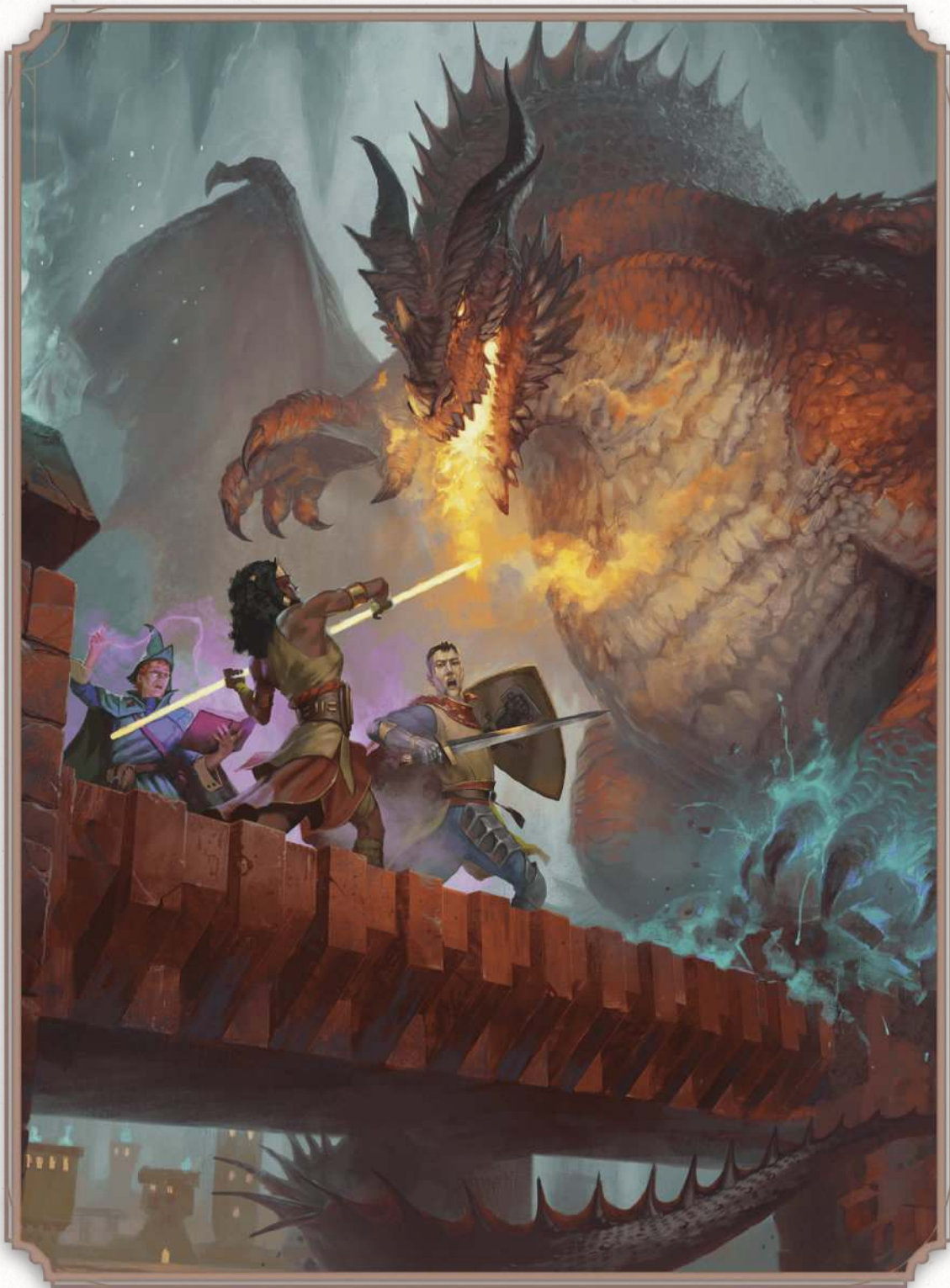
The *Neverwinter* massively multiplayer online roleplaying game is another way to play in the Forgotten Realms.

MOVIES

The movie *Dungeons & Dragons: Honor Among Thieves* takes place in the Forgotten Realms and includes factions such as the Harpers and the Red Wizards, places such as Neverwinter and Icewind Dale, and infamous characters such as Szass Tam and Themberchaud.

CHAPTER 1

CHARACTER OPTIONS



**PRESTO, DIANA, AND ERIC BATTLE THEMBERCHAUD
WHERE HE LAIRS IN THE DUERGAR CITY OF GRACKLSTUGH**
ARTIST: PINDURSKI

THIS CHAPTER IS FULL OF CHARACTER OPTIONS YOU CAN USE TO MAKE CHARACTERS UNIQUE TO THE REALMS: NEW AND REVISED SUBCLASSES, NEW BACKGROUNDS, AND new feats. The chapter begins with information on the species of the Forgotten Realms.

CHARACTER SPECIES

The following sections discuss the species detailed in the *Player's Handbook* and their place in Faerûn.

AASIMAR

Aasimar are among the rarest of Humanoid species in Faerûn. Although born to parents throughout the Forgotten Realms, aasimar are so unusual that no realm, city, or town is made up primarily of aasimar. Instead, individual aasimar grow up within the society and culture of their parents, and their outlook is shaped by the tension between that culture and the aasimar's connection to the Upper Planes.

FISH OUT OF WATER

In much of the Realms, an aasimar often feels like an outsider. When aasimar are children, their celestial nature easily goes unnoticed or is hidden by concerned family members. But eventually that nature becomes impossible to conceal. This is a dangerous time for aasimar, for Shar and other evil deities—and their worshipers—prey on innocent aasimar ignorant of their true nature and full power.

Throughout an aasimar's life, they frequently receive visions, prophetic dreams, or powerful feelings that hint at their destiny. Sometimes these prophetic instincts are sent by the aasimar's angelic ancestor, but they can just as easily be uncontrolled manifestations of celestial power.

CELESTIAL PATRONS

Many aasimar are found or adopted by followers of a good deity, such as angels or animal lords—or even by a good deity herself. Their connection to this celestial being informs the aasimar's life separate from the culture into which they were born. Corellon, Eilistraee, Lliira, Milil, and Selûne are frequently patrons of aasimar.

In the Old Empires, where gods and demigods rule openly, aasimars are more common. The current generation of aasimar often trace their lineage to a mortal specially chosen to serve a good deity. Many aasimar wander the realms, eventually gravitating to a great city such as Waterdeep, Baldur's Gate, or Calimshan, where their unusual nature isn't particularly remarkable.



ARTIST: AURORE FOLNY, SVETLIN VELINOV

DRAGONBORN

Many dragonborn families in Faerûn are relatively recent arrivals—victims of the Spellplague who came to the Forgotten Realms when their world of Abeir temporarily merged with Toril. But dragonborn are as old as Toril and have long lived in the shadow of dragons and other folk.

ABEIR AND TYMANATHER

Dragonborn were widespread on the world of Abeir, notably in the realm called Tymanchebar. When Abeir and Toril merged during the Spellplague, Tymanchebar came to Faerûn, displacing the realm of Unther. From this devastation, dragonborn of Tymanchebar and refugees from Unther formed the realm of Tymanther. Tymanther's culture was a fusion of Tymanchebar's customs and the ways of the Old Empires, valuing honor, tradition, and family.

But the Second Sundering saw Unther return, and Tymanther is no more. Many dragonborn who once lived there have scattered across Faerûn, bringing Tymanther's ways with them.

HIDDEN IN HISTORY

Not all dragonborn come from Tymanther and Abeir. They are, however, rare and have often been mistaken for other species of similar appearance. After all, Faerûn has never had a shortage of dragons, and uneducated folk might easily mistake dragonborn for lizardfolk, troglodytes, or any number of other creatures.

Dragonborn trace their origin to the god Io; in Faerûn, Io is known as Asgorath the World Shaper, Creator of Dragonkind. Asgorath's worship is extremely ancient, going back to the Dawn Age, and dragonborn were far more prevalent in Faerûn during that time.

DRAGONBORN TODAY

Dragonborn can now be found throughout Faerûn. Many reside in the Old Empires, in villages and towns settled primarily by refugees from Tymanther, and there they preserve Tymantherian customs. Dragonborn have also adapted easily to the intense heat of the Calim Desert; some live in the cities of noble genies, while others serve in Sultana Songal's honor guard.

DWARVES



ARTIST: MANUEL CASTAÑÓN

Dwarves, sometimes called the Stout Folk, built grand city-strongholds in Faerûn's ancient past, and dwarves still live in some of these holdings today, defending them from subterranean monsters. Moradin is the chief god of the dwarves, and according to legend, Moradin forged the first dwarves on the Soulforge out of iron, mithral, earth, and stone.

DWARVEN CULTURE

Dwarven society is structured around clans, each of which has its own distinctive traditions and folklore. While some settlements and regions are dominated entirely by a single clan, it's not unusual to find clans living alongside each other, especially in cities. The Dwarvish language uses a set of runes called Dethek.

SHIELD AND GOLD DWARVES

The two most common dwarven ethnicities are shield dwarves and gold dwarves.

Shield dwarves are common in the North and Sword Coast regions. Their greatest surviving city is Citadel Adbar, near Silverymoon. Shield dwarves have a long experience with war, which has made them slow to trust but steadfast in their loyalty. Their creations are sturdy and practical, lacking in decoration but designed for long, reliable use.

Gold dwarves, in contrast, are more populous in south and east Faerûn, including the Great Rift south of Unther. These lands have grown up in relative peace and prosperity, and so gold dwarves embrace trade and travel while welcoming strangers. The work of gold dwarf artisans often includes elaborate designs and embellishments that don't get in the way of a tool's usefulness.

DUERGAR

Duergar (as seen in *Mordenkainen Presents: Monsters of the Multiverse*) are dwarves shaped by the Underdark and the horrifying threats that dwell there. For millennia they were experimented upon by mind flayers. Now they live in subterranean settlements hidden from the light of the sun, and many duergar wield strange powers taught by or inherited from underground Aberrations.

ELVES

Elves of the Realms call themselves tel'quessir. The ancient realms of the elves are even older than those of the dwarves, but most faded long ago. Most elves eventually leave Faerûn behind and sail to the magical haven of Evermeet.

SUN ELVES AND MOON ELVES

The high elves detailed in the *Player's Handbook* includes the culturally distinct sun elves and moon elves.

Sun elves, also known as gold elves, value excellence in all things. They have a keen sense of history, especially of the accomplishments of elves in ages past. Magical instruction is easy to acquire in sun elf settlements, and many day-to-day tasks are solved or made easier through the use of routine magic. They are an intellectual people known for their mages, scholars, and seers.

Moon elves, in contrast, value wandering and the discoveries of the open road, meeting strangers with open arms. They are an easygoing, fluid people who value the ability to adapt to change. Many moon elves leave elven settlements for cosmopolitan cities inhabited by folk of all species.

WOOD ELVES

Wood elves, known also as copper elves, are a grounded, practical people. They value the forest and uncultivated nature over the glittering spires of elven cities, and are humble about elven accomplishments.

DROW

Faerûn's drow have a long history of association with Lolth, and their greatest city is infamous Menzoberranzan, in the Underdark. Drow not affiliated with Lolth can increasingly be found living peacefully among other folk in the North, the Dalelands, and other areas with ready access to the Underdark.

GNOMES

Gnomes are an optimistic and cheerful people with a reputation for being reclusive and not involving themselves in Faerûn's grand history. The truth is that if you want to find the influence of gnomes in the world, you just have to know where to look.

ROCK GNOMES

Rock gnomes are the gnomes most commonly encountered by citizens of Faerûn's cities and towns. They are curious, inventive, and outgoing folk eager to learn new things. They've famously transformed life in Lantan, Calimport, and Waterdeep by developing fantastic inventions that blend magic and mechanical skill.

Rock gnome villages dot the Heartlands region and the Shining Sea's shore. When rock gnomes live among other folk, they tend to form their own communities on the outskirts of town.



ARTIST: ZOLTAN BOROS

FOREST GNOMES

Forest gnomes are reclusive, typically living in all-gnome villages hidden in Faerûn's forests. Indeed, foresters and hunters live their entire lives completely unaware of a forest gnome village just a few miles away. The typical forest gnome dwelling shelters an extended gnome family and its many animal friends; the whole house is dug into a wooded hill and well appointed with the creations of generations of skilled woodworkers. And while forest gnomes can defend themselves if faced with violence, a village is far more likely to just disappear, its inhabitants departing under cover of illusion to rebuild elsewhere.

Forest gnomes who seek adventure or want to see the world join woodland communities, where they work alongside druids, elves, and other forest folk to tend sacred sites and preserve nature.

DEEP GNOMES

Deep gnomes (as seen in *Mordenkainen Presents: Monsters of the Multiverse*) live in the Underdark and other subterranean places, and they have been altered physically and culturally by warfare and long exposure to Underdark forces. Conflict with many enemies has made them a serious and suspicious folk. Their greatest city is Blingdenstone, which they have only recently liberated from Lolth-worshipping conquerors.

GOLIATHS

Goliaths trace their history back to empires built by giants in Faerûn's Dawn Age, and they participated in cataclysmic wars between giants and dragons that left Toril in ruins. When the empires of the giants fell, goliaths left to forge their own path.

GOLIATH ENCLAVES

Goliath enclaves can be found in Anauroch, in Chult, and in the North along the Spine of the World mountains. Life in these remote settlements is challenging, and the goliaths who live there learn to be cooperative when possible but self-reliant when necessary. These enclaves are usually home to goliaths of many different giant ancestries, sharing their magical gifts and natural talents with the community.

GIANT-KIN

Some goliath families live near or within giant communities. These groups of goliaths are more likely to all be of a single giant ancestry adapted to the environment the giants live in—for example, a community of goliaths descended from fire giants and living alongside them atop the volcanic Mount Neverwinter. Goliaths who live among giants are influenced by the beliefs and traditions of the giants they work alongside and are often in demand as ambassadors and emissaries between giants and smaller folk nearby.

GOLIATH EXPLORERS

In recent years, individual goliaths have left their homes to explore Faerûn. They've visited great cities like Calimport and Waterdeep and brought back knowledge and trade goods that have made life easier in their remote settlements. These explorers have, in turn, prompted other folk in Faerûn to seek out goliath communities to pursue alliances or regular trade.

For most of their history, goliaths have been peaceful folk. Few realms are willing to go to war over the lands where goliath settlements are typically built, and goliaths living among giants are protected from invasion by their giant neighbors.

HALFLINGS



ARTIST: DMITRY BURMAK

LIGHTFOOTS AND STRONGHEARTS

In the Forgotten Realms, halflings broadly divide themselves into the lightfoot or strongheart lifestyles. But these categories are permeable, and halflings might move from one group to the other many times in their life.

Lightfoot halflings (never call them lightfeet) live on the move. They seek out new experiences and new company, exploring and making new friends. Lightfoots travel light, and they need to be resourceful and quick to adapt to changing conditions. Halflings' legendary luck keeps many lightfoots alive. Halflings tend to become lightfoots as young adults when they leave home, when wanderlust strikes, or when other major changes to their lives occur.

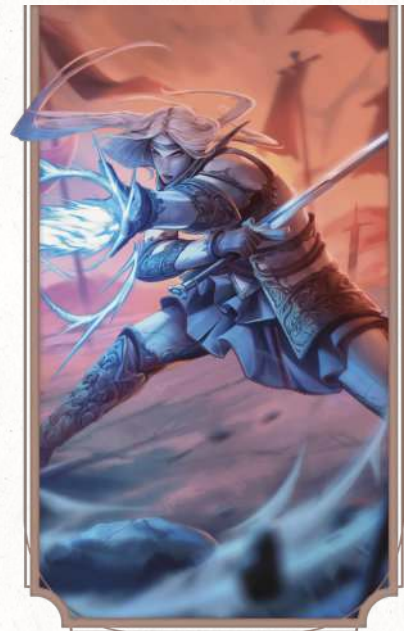
When a halfling settles down in a community, they become strongheart. Strongheart traditions emphasize permanence, comfort, family connection, growing things, the comforts of home, and getting along with neighbors. Some communities of stronghearts are so enduring that everyone in them has been strongheart all their lives.

HUMANS

The history of the Forgotten Realms has largely been written by humans. Because humans are so numerous, most settlements, factions, and institutions in Faerûn are made up mostly of humans, even if their leadership is another species. But the simple fact that humans are so numerous belies their countless cultural divisions. Human culture varies widely from one realm to another. They speak dozens of different languages and war on each other more than any other species.

ANCIENT ORIGINS

Humans are unusual in that they are among the most ancient species on Faerûn, but for much of that time they went largely unnoticed and had no great influence on world affairs. No one is quite certain where they came from; one theory, based on the Common language's origin in Sigil, is that humans came to Toril from the Outlands.



ARTIST: AGUSTÍN MARCELLAC

Regardless, more than thirty thousand years ago, humans inhabited the supercontinent of Merrouroboros and lived in the shadow of the creator races. They had no permanent settlements, no written language, and no tools more advanced than the club.

But slowly this changed as humans came into contact with dragons and giants and then with elves, dwarves, and other peoples. By the Founding Time, approximately nine thousand years ago, human cultures were building cities and empires. In the time since, humans have spread across Faerûn and played an outsize role in history.

DIVERSE ETHNICITIES

War and trade have spread humans across Faerûn. The cataclysmic war between the Narfell empire and the Raumathar people scattered refugees throughout the east. The Raumathar became the Rashemi, settling in the Arcane Empires, while survivors from Narfell settled around the Sea of Fallen Stars and became the Damarans.

In the west, Chondathan humans established trade routes and settlements, their culture changing rapidly from one region to the next. Humans along the Sword Coast formed the seafaring Illuskan culture while, to their south, humans escaping the tyranny of genie overlords became the Calishites. Some human ethnicities even originate from other worlds and were brought to Faerûn by magic.

ORCS

Orcs have a complicated history in Faerûn. Their myths tell of a primordial rivalry between Gruumsh, their patron deity, and Corellon, a god of the elves. Orc nations have long fought with dwarven strongholds over territory. And many orcs have been recruited or impressed into the armies of would-be conquerors. But for the most part, orcs coexist peacefully with all manner of folk, especially in difficult and dangerous environments where their natural gifts prove the difference between life and death.

A WANDERING PEOPLE

Orcs first came to Toril from other worlds. Legends tell that when Faerûn was divided among the various species, dwarves claimed the mountains, elves the forests, and so on, until no land was left for orcs when they arrived. Undeterred, Gruumsh simply declared his people would live everywhere, and they've been a wandering people ever since.

They founded settlements in lands too inhospitable for other folk, especially in mountainous regions such as the Spine of the World and the Sword Mountains, near Waterdeep. But over the centuries, orcs have departed these homelands, individually or in bands, to travel the world and seek out new places to live.

KINGDOM OF MANY-ARROWS

The greatest orc realm in Faerûn's recent history was established in 1371 DR by King Obould Many-Arrows, a Chosen servitor of Gruumsh. The Kingdom of Many-Arrows held the Spine of the World mountains, and Obould encouraged trade and diplomacy with his neighbors in the North.

A generation ago, a tyrant named Hartusk took control of Many-Arrows and invaded several neighboring realms. Hartusk was deposed, but despite the return of Obould's legitimate heir and a desire for peace among the orcs, vengeful dwarves from the strongholds Hartusk besieged leveled Dark Arrow Keep, the realm's capital.

But orcs are nothing if not resilient. A new King of Many-Arrows has arisen, unrelated to Obould's line. Orrusk Homebringer is calling orcs from the Spine of the World back to rebuild Dark Arrow Keep and restore the realm, making it greater than it was before.

TIEFLINGS

Fiends have influenced Faerûn since its earliest history, and where there have been fiends, there are tieflings.

Tieflings with an infernal legacy usually trace their history to the Spellplague. During that disaster, Asmodeus attempted to make every tiefling in Faerûn his servant by performing a ritual that cursed them with an infernal appearance called the Mark of Asmodeus. Asmodeus's gambit ultimately failed, but infernal tieflings remain the most common tiefling lineage in Faerûn.

LIFE AMONG OTHERS

Though far more common than aasimar, their cousins from the Upper Planes, tieflings remain relatively rare in Faerûn. Most towns are home to no more than a handful of tieflings, only some of whom reside there permanently. Even in cities, tiefling communities are small enough for everyone to know each other and share methods of coexisting within the larger non-tiefling population.

A few regions, however, have been home to significant populations of tieflings for centuries. Aglarond, a land associated with sorcerers and training in sorcery, has long been a haven for tieflings eager to control their fiendish powers. The presence of gods and demigods throughout the Old Empires region has made tieflings almost common there, and tieflings with an infernal legacy have adapted easily to the harsh environments of Calimshan and can often find a place in the court of efreet living in the Calim Desert. Places with devil-worshipping cults, such as Neverwinter and Baldur's Gate, also have longstanding tiefling populations.

ELTUREL AND BALDUR'S GATE

About a decade ago, the city of Elturel was briefly transported to the Nine Hells. Although it was eventually rescued by adventurers, Elturel's citizens were deeply affected by their time in the Lower Planes. There was already a small population of tieflings in the city, and more have been born ever since. But Elturel's rulers have rejected anything with a connection to the Lower Planes, including the city's tiefling residents, and tiefling families have fled to nearby Baldur's Gate.

This does little to help those tiefling children recently born in Elturel to parents of other species, however. Many of these children are hidden by their parents, lest their infernal legacy be discovered. Others have fled their homes, with their parents or without.

SUBCLASSES

This chapter presents eight new subclasses that are particularly appropriate for characters in the Forgotten Realms:

College of the Moon: A Bard trained by druids of the Moonshae Isles, with a special connection to local folktales and mysterious shrines called moonwells

Knowledge Domain: A Cleric of Gond, Mystra, Oghma, Selûne, or another deity who values knowledge, craft, or secrets

Banneret: A Fighter who leads others into battle

Oath of the Noble Genies: A Paladin empowered by the elemental magic of the genies of Calimshan

Winter Walker: A Ranger of the North, wielding magic of cold and ice

Scion of the Three: A Rogue who taps into the deadly power of three evil gods—Bane, Bhaal, and Myrkul

Spellfire Sorcery: A Sorcerer born with the ability to manipulate spellfire

Bladesinger: A Wizard who has mastered an ancient elven technique of magical combat

COLLEGE OF THE MOON (BARD)

Inspire Allies with Primal Tales

The College of the Moon traces its origins to the ancient druidic circles of the Moonshae Isles, who entrusted the first Bards of this tradition with chronicling the stories of the islands and their people. Bards of this college draw from the isles' fey magic and the primal power of the moonwells to bolster their allies, protect the natural world, and inspire their bardic works.

LEVEL 3: MOON'S INSPIRATION

The primal and ever-changing power of the moon flows through you, granting you the following benefits.

Inspired Eclipse. When you take a Bonus Action to give a creature a Bardic Inspiration die, you can have the **Invisible** condition and teleport up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space you can see as part of that Bonus Action. This invisibility lasts until the start of your next turn and ends early immediately after you make an attack roll, deal damage, or cast a spell.

Lunar Vitality. Once per turn when you restore Hit Points to a creature with a spell, you can expend a Bardic Inspiration die and increase the amount of Hit Points restored by a number equal to a roll of the Bardic Inspiration die. The creature's Speed also increases by 10 feet until the end of its next turn.

LEVEL 3: PRIMAL LORE

You learn Druidic and one cantrip from the Druid spell list. It counts as a Bard spell for you but doesn't count against the number of cantrips you know. Whenever you gain a Bard level, you can replace this cantrip with another cantrip of your choice from the Druid spell list.



COLLEGE OF THE MOON

SUBCLASS
ARTIST: MARCELA MEDEIROS

Additionally, choose one of the following skills: **Animal Handling**, **Insight**, **Medicine**, **Nature**, **Perception**, or **Survival**. You have proficiency in that skill.

LEVEL 6: BLESSING OF MOONLIGHT

You always have the **Moonbeam** spell prepared.

When you cast **Moonbeam**, you can modify the spell so that you glow faintly while the spell is active. While glowing, you shed **Dim Light** out to 5 feet, and whenever a creature fails its saving throw against the effects of this **Moonbeam**, another creature of your choice that you can see within 60 feet of yourself regains 2d4 Hit Points.

Once you use this feature to modify a casting of **Moonbeam**, you can't use it again until you finish a Long Rest.

LEVEL 14: EVENTIDE'S SPLENDOR

You become suffused with the might of the moon, improving your Moon's Inspiration in the following ways.

Shadow of the New Moon. When you use Inspired Eclipse, the creature who received the Bardic Inspiration die can also have the **Invisible** condition and immediately take a Reaction to teleport up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space it can see. The creature remains Invisible until the start of its next turn.

Vibrance of the Full Moon. When you use Lunar Vitality, you can roll 1d6 and use the number rolled in place of expending a Bardic Inspiration die.

KNOWLEDGE DOMAIN (CLERIC)

Unearth Secrets and Master the Mind



KNOWLEDGE DOMAIN

SUBCLASS

ARTIST: MARCELA MEDEIROS

The Knowledge Domain values learning and understanding above all. Clerics who tap into this domain study esoteric lore, collect old tomes, delve into secret places, and examine the processes of the mind. To them, knowledge is more valuable than material wealth, and learning is an act of worship. Libraries, universities, and other educational institutions also draw on the power of the Knowledge Domain.

Gods of knowledge vary from masters of arcane magic to patrons of craft and invention. In Faerûn, Clerics of the Knowledge Domain worship deities of learning and ingenuity such as Oghma and Gond, among many others.

LEVEL 3: BLESSINGS OF KNOWLEDGE

You gain proficiency with one type of Artisan's Tools of your choice and in two of the following skills of your choice: **Arcana**, **History**, **Nature**, or **Religion**. You have Expertise in those two skills.

LEVEL 3: KNOWLEDGE DOMAIN SPELLS

When you reach a Cleric level specified in the Knowledge Domain Spells table, you thereafter always have the listed spells prepared.

Knowledge Domain Spells

Cleric Level	Prepared Spells
3	<i>Command</i> , <i>Comprehend Languages</i> *, <i>Detect Magic</i> *, <i>Detect Thoughts</i> *, <i>Identify</i> *, <i>Mind Spike</i> *
5	<i>Dispel Magic</i> , <i>Nondetection</i> , <i>Tongues</i> *
7	<i>Arcane Eye</i> *, <i>Banishment</i> , <i>Confusion</i>
9	<i>Legend Lore</i> *, <i>Scrying</i> *, <i>Synaptic Static</i>
*Spell of the Divination school	

LEVEL 3: MIND MAGIC

As a **Magic** action, you can expend one use of your Channel Divinity to manifest your magical knowledge. Choose one spell from the Divination school on the Knowledge Domain Spells table that you have prepared. As part of that action, you cast that spell without expending a spell slot or needing Material components.

LEVEL 6: UNFETTERED MIND

You gain telepathy out to 60 feet. When you use this telepathy, you can simultaneously contact a number of creatures equal to your Wisdom modifier (minimum of one).

Additionally, you gain proficiency in Intelligence saving throws. If you already have this proficiency, you instead gain saving throw proficiency with one ability in which you lack it.

LEVEL 17: DIVINE FOREKNOWLEDGE

As a Bonus Action, you magically expand your mind to the future. For 1 hour, you have Advantage on **D20 Tests**. Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you finish a Long Rest. You can also restore your use of this feature by expending a level 6+ spell slot (no action required).

BANNERET (FIGHTER)

Rally Fellow Heroes with Inspiring Leadership

Bannerets are paragons of valor and leadership who protect the innocent and rally fellow adventurers to the causes of justice and freedom. Many are knights serving in Cormyr, the Silver Marches, Damara, Chessenta, or other lands across Faerûn. They wander the realms as knights errant, taking the fight against evil beyond their kingdom's borders.

A Banneret relies on judgment, bravery, and fidelity to the code of chivalry to guide them in defeating evildoers. A lone Banneret is a skilled warrior, but when leading a band of allies one of these warriors can transform even a poorly equipped militia into a ferocious war band.

LEVEL 3: KNIGHTLY ENVOY

You know how to conduct yourself with grace as a noble ambassador. You gain the following benefits.

Comprehension. You can cast the [Comprehend Languages](#) spell but only as a Ritual. Charisma is your spellcasting ability for it.

Polyglot. You learn one language from the language tables in the *Player's Handbook* or chapter 2 of this book. When you finish a Long Rest, you can replace a language learned from this benefit with another language you have heard, seen signed, or read in the past 24 hours.

Well Spoken. You gain proficiency in one of the following skills of your choice: [Insight](#), [Intimidation](#), [Persuasion](#), or [Performance](#).

LEVEL 3: GROUP RECOVERY



BANNERET

SUBCLASS

ARTIST: LEROY STEINMANN

When you use your Second Wind to regain Hit Points, you can choose a number of allies within a 30-foot [Emanation](#) originating from yourself, up to a number of allies equal to your Charisma modifier (minimum of one). Each of those allies regains Hit Points equal to 1d4 plus your Fighter level. Once you use this ability, you can't use it again until you finish a Short or Long Rest.

LEVEL 7: TEAM TACTICS

When you use Group Recovery, each chosen ally has Advantage on [D20 Tests](#) until the start of your next turn.

LEVEL 10: RALLYING SURGE

When you use your Action Surge, you can choose allies within a 30-foot [Emanation](#) originating from yourself, up to a number of allies equal to your Charisma modifier (minimum of one). Each of those allies can immediately take a Reaction to use one of the following options.

Attack. The ally makes one attack with a weapon or an Unarmed Strike.

Move. The ally moves up to half its Speed without provoking [Opportunity Attack](#) action.

LEVEL 15: SHARED RESILIENCE

When an ally you can see within 60 feet of yourself fails a saving throw, you can take a Reaction to expend a use of your Indomitable feature. The ally can immediately reroll the saving throw with a bonus equal to your Fighter level; the ally must use the new roll.

LEVEL 18: INSPIRING COMMANDER

You gain the following benefits.

Bolstered Rally. The area of effect for both Group Recovery and Rallying Surge is now a 60-foot [Emanation](#).

Unshakable Bravery. You have Immunity to the [Charmed](#) and [Frightened](#) conditions.

OATH OF THE NOBLE GENIES (PALADIN)

Brandish the Elemental Splendor of Genies



OATH OF THE NOBLE GENIES

SUBCLASS
ARTIST:

Paladins sworn to the Oath of the Noble Genies revere the forces of the Elemental Planes. Through taking this oath, Paladins draw power from the four different types of genies—dao, masters of earth; djinn, masters of air; efreet, masters of fire; and marids, masters of water. In Faerûn, many Paladins who swear this oath hail from Calimshan, a land teeming with genies.

Paladins who swear this oath often undertake quests that take them all over the Realms and across the multiverse—including the Elemental Planes. These paladins share the following tenets:

Sow the seeds of creation amid the ashes of destruction.
Lead with splendor and grace.
Respect the elements, and fear their wrath.

LEVEL 3: ELEMENTAL SMITE

Immediately after you cast *Divine Smite*, you can expend one use of your Channel Divinity and invoke one of the following effects.

Dao's Crush. Earth rises up around the target of your *Divine Smite*. The target has the **Grappled** condition (escape DC equal to your spell save DC). While Grappled, the target has the **Restrained** condition.

Djinni's Escape. You teleport to an unoccupied space you can see within 30 feet of yourself and take on a semi-incorporeal form, which lasts until the end of your next turn. While in this form, you have Resistance to Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing damage, and you have Immunity to the Grappled, **Prone**, and Restrained conditions.

Efreeti's Fury. The target of your *Divine Smite* takes an extra 2d4 Fire damage, and fire jumps from the target to another creature you can see within 30 feet of yourself. The second creature also takes 2d4 Fire damage.

Marid's Surge. The target of your *Divine Smite* and each creature of your choice in a 10-foot **Emanation** originating from you make a Strength saving throw against your spell save DC. On a failed save, a creature is pushed 15 feet straight away from you and has the **Prone** condition.

LEVEL 3: GENIE SPELLS

When you reach a Paladin level specified in the Genie Spells table, you thereafter always have the listed spells prepared.

Genie Spells

Paladin Level	Spells
3	<i>Chromatic Orb, Elementalism, Thunderous Smite</i>
5	<i>Mirror Image, Phantasmal Force</i>
9	<i>Fly, Gaseous Form</i>
13	<i>Conjure Minor Elementals, Summon Elemental</i>
17	<i>Banishing Smite, Contact Other Plane</i>

LEVEL 3: GENIE’S SPLENDOR

When you aren't wearing any armor, your base Armor Class equals 10 plus your Dexterity and Charisma modifiers. You can use a Shield and still gain this benefit.

You also gain proficiency in one of the following skills of your choice: **Acrobatics**, **Intimidation**, **Performance**, or **Persuasion**.

LEVEL 7: AURA OF ELEMENTAL SHIELDING

Choose one of the following damage types: Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder. You and your allies have Resistance to that damage type while in your Aura of Protection.

At the start of each of your turns, you can change the damage type affected by this feature to one of the other listed options (no action required).

LEVEL 15: ELEMENTAL REBUKE

When you are hit by an attack roll, you can take a Reaction to halve the attack's damage against yourself (round down) and force the attacker to make a Dexterity saving throw against your spell save DC. On a failed save, the attacker takes damage equal to 2d10 plus your Charisma modifier of one of the following types (your choice): Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder. On a successful save, the attacker takes half as much damage.

You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Charisma modifier (minimum of once), and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

LEVEL 20: NOBLE SCION

As a Bonus Action, you gain the benefits below for 10 minutes or until you end them (no action required). Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you finish a Long Rest. You can also restore your use of it by expending a level 5 spell slot (no action required).

Flight. You have a Fly Speed of 60 feet and can hover.

Minor Wish. When you or an ally in your Aura of Protection fails a **D20 Test**, you can take a Reaction to make you or that ally succeed instead.

WINTER WALKER (RANGER)

Withstand the Horrors of Frigid Wastelands



WINTER WALKER

SUBCLASS

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO

Winter Walkers hone their craft in the bleak and frozen wilds of places like Icewind Dale. These ruthless, rimed Rangers hunt monsters that haunt arctic wastelands, eventually becoming frigid terrors themselves. Winter Walkers are well versed in the phenomena of Icewind Dale, including the latent magic of fallen Netherese cities, endemic monsters like yetis and crag cats, and the rising threat of Underdark invaders. Due to their cold pragmatism, terrifying magic, and mastery of the region, Winter Walkers are regarded with equal parts respect and fear. Ten-Towns citizens say that Winter Walkers' frequent exposure to malignant entities gives them their fearsome powers. Many Reghed nomads, on the other hand, believe that nature spirits bestow on Winter Walkers a unique curse.

LEVEL 3: FRIGID EXPLORER

You gain the following benefits.

Biting Cold. Damage from your weapon attacks, Ranger spells, and Ranger features ignores Resistance to Cold damage.

Frost Resistance. You have Resistance to Cold damage.

Polar Strikes. When you hit a creature with an attack roll using a weapon, you can deal an extra 1d4 Cold damage to the target, which can take this extra damage only once per turn. When you reach Ranger level 11, this extra damage increases to 1d6.

LEVEL 3: HUNTER'S RIME

Ice rimes you and your prey, protecting you and hindering them. When you cast *Hunter's Mark*, you gain **Temporary Hit Points** equal to 1d10 plus your Ranger level.

Additionally, while a creature is marked by your *Hunter's Mark*, it can't take the **Disengage** action.

LEVEL 3: WINTER WALKER SPELLS

When you reach a Ranger level specified in the Winter Walker Spells table, you thereafter always have the listed spells prepared.

Winter Walker Spells

Ranger Level	Spell
3	<i>Ice Knife</i>
5	<i>Hold Person</i>
9	<i>Remove Curse</i>
13	<i>Ice Storm</i>
17	<i>Cone of Cold</i>

LEVEL 7: FORTIFYING SOUL

Your experience surviving harrowing environments allows you to bolster your allies in addition to yourself. As a **Magic** action, choose a number of creatures you can see equal to your Wisdom modifier (minimum of one). Each chosen creature regains Hit Points equal to 1d10 plus your Ranger level and has Advantage on saving throws to avoid or end the **Frightened** condition for 1 hour.

Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you finish a Long Rest.

LEVEL 11: CHILLING RETRIBUTION

When a creature hits you with an attack roll, you can take a Reaction to force the creature to make a Wisdom saving throw against your spell save DC. On a failed save, the target has the **Stunned** condition until the end of your next turn. While the target is Stunned, its Speed is reduced to 0 feet.

You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Wisdom modifier (minimum of once), and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

LEVEL 15: FROZEN HAUNT

When you cast *Hunter's Mark*, you can adopt a ghostly, snowy form. This form lasts until the spell ends, and while you are in this form, you gain the following benefits. Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you finish a Long Rest unless you expend a level 4+ spell slot (no action required).

Frozen Soul. You have Immunity to Cold damage. When you first adopt this form and at the start of each of your subsequent turns, each creature of your choice in a 15-foot **Emanation** originating from you takes 2d4 Cold damage.

Partially Incorporeal. You have Immunity to the **Grappled**, **Prone**, and **Restrained** conditions. You can move through creatures and objects as if they were **Difficult Terrain**, but you take 1d10 Force damage if you end your turn inside a creature or an object. If the form ends while you are inside a creature or an object, you are shunted to the nearest unoccupied space.

SCION OF THE THREE (ROGUE)

Become a Gruesome Agent of Malice

A Scion of the Three draws power from a group of malevolent gods known in Baldur's Gate as the Dead Three: Bane, a god of tyranny; Bhaal, a god of violence and murder; and Myrkul, a god of death. While some Rogues of this subclass pledge themselves ardently to those three macabre gods, others are thrust on this path by a curse. Either way, a scion's power manifests as various occult gifts, as well as an uncanny talent for striking and terrifying foes.

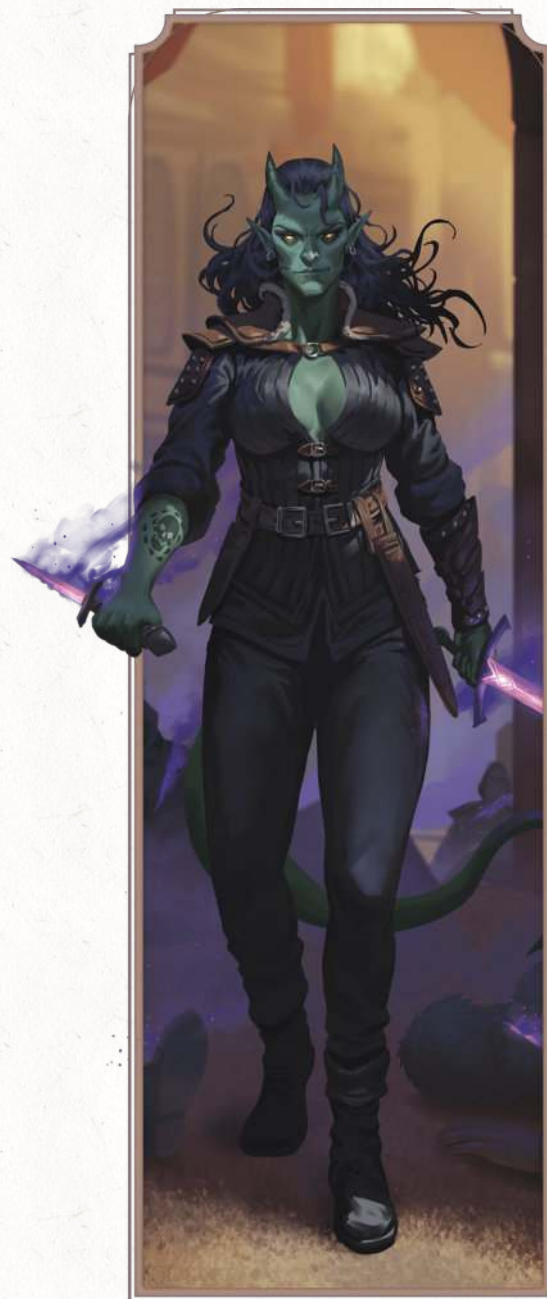
Scions of the Three are most common in Baldur's Gate, where the Dead Three lived as mortals before ascending to godhood. Underground cults to Bane, Bhaal, and Myrkul often count Scions of the Three among their most useful agents. Outside Baldur's Gate, secular thieves' guilds such as the Shadow Thieves of Amn or the Xanathar Guild in Waterdeep might call on a Scion of the Three to undertake an especially violent contract.

LEVEL 3: BLOODTHIRST

When an enemy you can see within 30 feet of yourself takes damage and is **Bloodied** after taking that damage but not killed outright, you can take a Reaction and teleport to an unoccupied space you can see within 5 feet of that enemy. You can then make one melee attack. You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Intelligence modifier (minimum of once), and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

LEVEL 3: DREAD ALLEGIANCE

Choose one of the Dead Three: Bane, Bhaal, or Myrkul. You gain Resistance to one type of damage and the ability to cast a cantrip, as detailed in the table below; Intelligence is your spellcasting ability for this cantrip. When you finish a Long Rest, you can change your choice.



SCION OF THE THREE

SUBCLASS
ARTIST: TNEH KEONG

God	Damage Resistance	Cantrip
Bane	Psychic	<i>Minor Illusion</i>
Bhaal	Poison	<i>Blade Ward</i>
Myrkul	Necrotic	<i>Chill Touch</i>

LEVEL 9: STRIKE FEAR
You gain the following Cunning Strike option.

Terrify (Cost: 1d6). The target must succeed on a Wisdom saving throw, or it has the **Frightened** condition for 1 minute. While the target is Frightened in this way, you have Advantage on attack rolls against the target.

The Frightened target repeats the save at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

LEVEL 13: AURA OF MALEVOLENCE
You radiate malignant power associated with one of the Dead Three. When you use Bloodthirst and teleport, each creature of your choice within 10 feet of either the space you left or your destination space (your choice) takes damage equal to your Intelligence modifier; the damage type is the same as the damage Resistance granted by your choice in the Dread Allegiance feature. Damage dealt by this feature ignores Resistance.

LEVEL 17: DREAD INCARNATE
You gain the following benefits.

Cutthroat. You regain one expended use of Bloodthirst when you finish a Short Rest.

Murderous Intent. When you roll for your Sneak Attack damage, you can treat a roll of a 1 or 2 on the die as a 3.

SPELLFIRE SORCERY (SORCERER)

Wield Raw Magic



SPELLFIRE SORCERY
SUBCLASS
ARTIST: IOANNIS FIORE

Your innate power stems from the source of magic itself: the Weave. This connection manifests as a rare ability known as spellfire, and you surge with radiant bursts of this raw magic. Your talent with spellfire allows you to heal allies, sear enemies, and absorb powerful spells.

Wielders of spellfire tend to have a penchant for wandering. Many travel between cosmopolitan settlements, such as those along the Sword Coast, and wield their magic in service of the common good. Others realize their own strange powers by roaming equally strange lands, from the magic-blasted wastes of the desert of Anauroch to the god-touched wilds of the Old Empires. Wherever they go in the Realms, spellfire Sorcerers are courted by factions with interests in the arcane arts, such as the Harpers, Cult of the Dragon, and Red Wizards.

LEVEL 3: SPELLFIRE BURST

When you spend at least 1 Sorcery Point as part of a **Magic** action or a Bonus Action on your turn, you can unleash one of the following magical effects of your choice. You can do so only once per turn.

Bolstering Flames. You or one creature you can see within 30 feet of yourself gains **Temporary Hit Points** equal to 1d4 plus your Charisma modifier.

Radiant Fire. One creature you can see within 30 feet of yourself takes 1d4 Fire or Radiant damage (your choice).

LEVEL 3: SPELLFIRE SPELLS

When you reach a Sorcerer level specified in the Spellfire Spells table, you thereafter always have the listed spells prepared.

Spellfire Spells

Sorcerer Level	Spells
3	<i>Cure Wounds, Guiding Bolt, Lesser Restoration, Scorching Ray</i>
5	<i>Aura of Vitality, Dispel Magic</i>
7	<i>Fire Shield, Wall of Fire</i>
9	<i>Greater Restoration, Flame Strike</i>

LEVEL 6: ABSORB SPELLS

You always have the **Counterspell** spell prepared.

Additionally, whenever a target fails the saving throw against a **Counterspell** you cast, you regain 1d4 Sorcery Points.

LEVEL 14: HONED SPELLFIRE

Your Spellfire Burst improves. You add your Sorcerer level to the **Temporary Hit Points** gained from Bolstering Flames, and the damage of your Radiant Fire increases to 1d8.

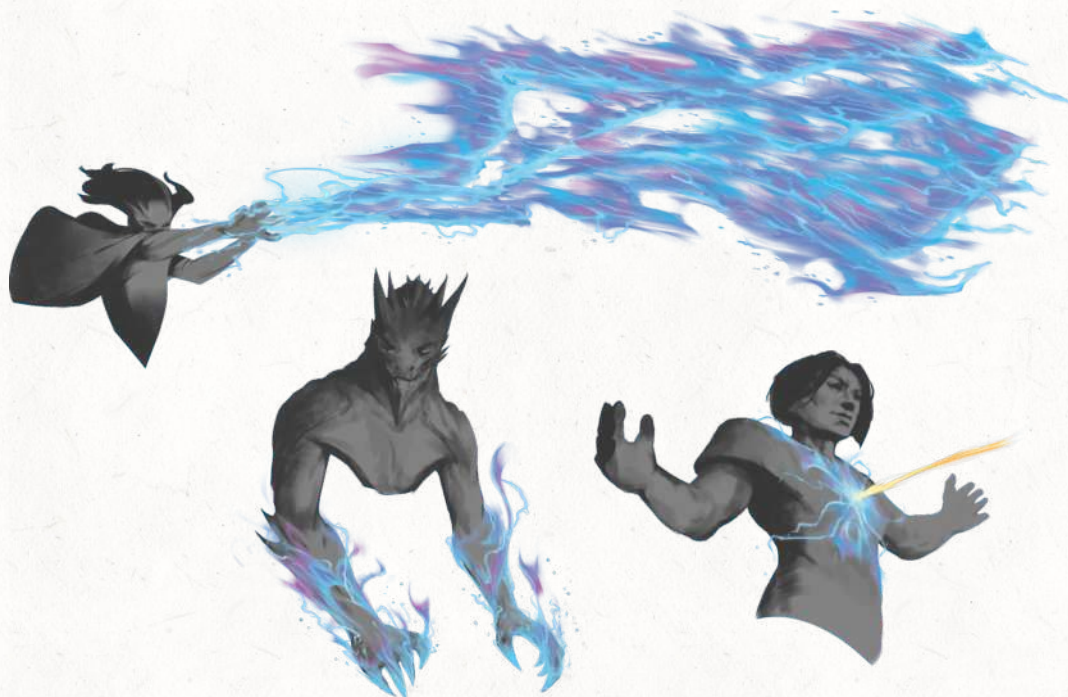
LEVEL 18: CROWN OF SPELLFIRE

When you use Innate Sorcery, you can alter it and infuse yourself with the essence of spellfire, gaining the following benefits while this use of Innate Sorcery is active. Once you use this feature to alter Innate Sorcery, you can't use it again until you finish a Long Rest unless you spend 5 Sorcery Points (no action required) to restore your use of it.

Burning Life Force. Once per turn when you are hit by an attack roll, you can expend a number of Hit Point Dice, up to a maximum equal to your Charisma modifier (minimum of one). Roll the expended dice, and reduce the amount of damage from that attack equal to the total rolled.

Flight. You gain a Fly Speed of 60 feet and can hover.

Spell Avoidance. When you're subjected to a spell or magical effect that allows you to make a saving throw to take only half damage, you instead take no damage if you succeed on the save and only half damage if you fail. You can't use this benefit if you have the **Incapacitated** condition.



SPELLFIRE TAKES MANY FORMS
ARTIST: TARAS SUSAK

BLADESINGER (WIZARD)

Wield Weapon and Wizardry in Elegant Tandem



BLADESINGER

SUBCLASS
ARTIST: ERION MAKUO

Bladesingers master a tradition of wizardry that incorporates swordplay and dance. In combat, a Bladesinger uses intricate, elegant maneuvers that fend off harm and allow the Bladesinger to channel magic into devastating attacks and a cunning defense. Many who have observed a Bladesinger at work remember the display as one of the more beautiful experiences in their life—a glorious dance accompanied by a singing blade.

Bladesinging is associated with the ancient elven societies that first mastered the art and coined the term. Even today, most Bladesingers still hail from old elven realms, such as Myth Drannor, or from non-elven societies that share land and history with elves, such as the Silver Marches. Wherever they hail from, Bladesingers take their talents all across the Realms to help common people and perform heroic deeds. Most communities greet the arrival of a Bladesinger as a good omen.

LEVEL 3: BLADESONG

As a Bonus Action, you invoke an elven magic called the Bladesong, provided you aren't wearing armor or using a Shield.

The Bladesong lasts for 1 minute and ends early if you have the **Incapacitated** condition, if you don armor or a Shield, or if you use two hands to make an attack with a weapon. You can dismiss the Bladesong at any time (no action required).

While the Bladesong is active, you gain the following benefits. You can invoke the Bladesong a number of times equal to your Intelligence modifier (minimum of once), and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest. You regain one expended use when you use Arcane Recovery.

Agility. You gain a bonus to your AC equal to your Intelligence modifier (minimum of +1), and your Speed increases by 10 feet. In addition, you have Advantage on Dexterity (**Acrobatics**) checks.

Bladework. Whenever you attack with a weapon with which you have proficiency, you can use your Intelligence modifier for the attack and damage rolls instead of using Strength or Dexterity.

Focus. When you make a Constitution saving throw to maintain **Concentration**, you can add your Intelligence modifier to the total.

LEVEL 3: TRAINING IN WAR AND SONG

You gain proficiency with all Melee Martial weapons that don't have the Two-Handed or Heavy property. You can use a Melee weapon with which you have proficiency as a Spellcasting Focus for your Wizard spells.

You also gain proficiency in one of the following skills of your choice: **Acrobatics**, **Athletics**, **Performance**, or **Persuasion**.

LEVEL 6: EXTRA ATTACK

You can attack twice, instead of once, whenever you take the **Attack** action on your turn. Moreover, you can cast one of your Wizard cantrips that has a casting time of an action in place of one of those attacks.

LEVEL 10: SONG OF DEFENSE

When you take damage while your Bladesong is active, you can take a Reaction to expend one spell slot and reduce the damage taken by an amount equal to five times the spell slot's level.

LEVEL 14: SONG OF VICTORY

After you cast a spell that has a casting time of an action, you can make one attack with a weapon as a Bonus Action.

BACKGROUNDS

This section presents eighteen new backgrounds for characters from Faerûn. These backgrounds are presented in alphabetical order.

Ten of these new backgrounds correspond to regions of the Forgotten Realms described in chapter 2; these backgrounds are listed in the Regional Backgrounds table. Not every character from a given region needs to take a given background. For example, not all residents of Mulhorand are tomb raiders. Conversely, you might find a given background a good fit for your character even if the character isn't from the designated region. For example, the Chondathan Freebooter background is a good fit for many pirate characters from any region.

Seven of these backgrounds are related to factions described in chapter 6; these backgrounds are listed in the Faction Backgrounds table. These backgrounds describe the training associated with a faction but aren't required for affiliation or membership with that faction.

Finally, the Spellfire Initiate background represents characters born with the ability to manipulate spellfire, which is described in chapter 5. This background, along with the related feats later in this chapter, can represent a character of any class with a talent for spellfire. Sorcerer characters with this background might also choose the Spellfire Sorcery subclass presented earlier in this chapter.

REGIONAL BACKGROUNDS

Background	Region
Chondathan Freebooter	Vilhon Reach
Dead Magic Dweller	Anauroch
Flaming Fist Mercenary	Sword Coast
Genie Touched	Lands of Intrigue
Ice Fisher	The North
Moonwell Pilgrim	Trackless Sea
Mulhorandi Tomb Raider	Old Empires
Mythalkeeper	Heartlands
Rashemi Wanderer	Arcane Empires
Shadowmasters Exile	Forgotten Lands

FACTION BACKGROUNDS

Background	Faction
Dragon Cultist	Cult of the Dragon
Emerald Enclave Caretaker	Emerald Enclave
Harper	Harpers
Knight of the Gauntlet	Knights of the Gauntlet
Lords' Alliance Vassal	Lords' Alliance
Purple Dragon Squire	Purple Dragon Knights
Zhentarim Mercenary	Zhentarim



ARTIST: OLIVIER BERNARD

CHONDATHAN FREEBOOTER



ARTIST: MIRO PETROV

Ability Scores: Strength, Dexterity, Wisdom

Feat: Skilled

Skill Proficiencies: Athletics and Sleight of Hand

Tool Proficiency: Weaver's Tools

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) Dagger, Weaver's Tools, Backpack, Ball Bearings, Basket, Bedroll, Bucket, Rations (3 days' worth), Rope, Signal Whistle, Traveler's Clothes, 38 GP; or (B) 50 GP

Though most youths in Chondath accept their four-year term of compulsory military service, you bristled at that authoritarian attempt to control your life. You forsook your nationhood, discarded your given name, and worked as a freebooter with the first ship that would have you. Since then, you've traveled the Vilhon Reach. Though you've never sailed more than a few dozen leagues from land, you make up for it with deep local connections and the breadth of your experiences.

DEAD MAGIC DWELLER



ARTIST: EREL MAATITA

Ability Scores: Strength, Constitution, Wisdom

Feat: Healer

Skill Proficiencies: [Medicine](#) and [Survival](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Leatherworker's Tools](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Greatclub](#), [Leatherworker's Tools](#), [Bedroll](#), [Blanket](#), [Healer's Kit](#), [Pole](#), [Rations](#) (3 days' worth), [Tent](#), [Tinderbox](#), 5 [Torches](#), [Traveler's Clothes](#), [Waterskin](#), 32 GP; or (B) 50 GP

The dead magic zones of the Anauroch desert are anathema to spellcasters and monsters that rely on magic—which is exactly why you made your life there. Perhaps you're on the run from Red Wizards, or you ran afoul of a powerful djinni in Calimshan. Whatever the case, you decided that living in Anauroch was your best option. After long months or years, you're stronger, wiser, and armed with hard-earned knowledge of desert medicine and wasteland survival.

DRAGON CULTIST



ARTIST: SWATCHES STUDIO, SAM WHITE

Ability Scores: Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence

Feat: Cult of the Dragon Initiate (see "Feats" later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: [Deception](#) and [Stealth](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Calligrapher's Supplies](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Calligrapher's Supplies](#), [Dagger](#), [Glass Bottle](#), [Lamp](#), [Manacles](#), [Oil](#) (5 flasks), 2 [Pouches](#), [Robe](#), [Rope](#), 30 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You are an initiate of the Cult of the Dragon. You discovered or were brought to a cell cult, where you exemplified the values honored by dragon cultists: duplicity, secrecy, and determination. In exchange for your oath to serve the cult, the cult offered you the company of fellow dragon worshipers, plus access to resources that might help further your studies in the realms of arcana and occultism.

EMERALD ENCLAVE CARETAKER



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

Ability Scores: Constitution, Intelligence, Wisdom

Feat: Emerald Enclave Fledgling (see “Feats” later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: [Nature](#) and [Survival](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Herbalism Kit](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Shortbow](#), 20 [Arrows](#), [Herbalism Kit](#), [Bedroll](#), [Blanket](#), [Pouch](#), [Tent](#), [Traveler's Clothes](#), 13 GP; or (B) 50 GP

As a Caretaker with the Emerald Enclave, you take care of those who care for the world. Either alongside your fellow Emerald Enclave members or by yourself, you've learned essential skills for living with the land: how to track game, where to forage for useful herbs, and even how to forecast the weather. You use these talents to maintain the balance between civilization and the wilds and to rid the world of unnatural creatures.

FLAMING FIST MERCENARY



ARTIST: LUCA BANCONI

Ability Scores: Strength, Constitution, Charisma

Feat: Tough

Skill Proficiencies: [Intimidation](#) and [Perception](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Smith's Tools](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Mace](#), [Smith's Tools](#), [Fine Clothes](#), [Manacles](#), [Portable Ram](#), 4 GP; or (B) 50 GP

The chief law enforcement branch of Baldur's Gate is the Flaming Fist, a brawny mercenary guild led by the city's grand duke. You once served as a Flaming Fist, where you learned how to preempt trouble with your intimidating stare and, when necessary, absorb deadly blows. Flaming Fist mercenaries, active or retired, are known as some of the toughest, most resilient warriors along the Sword Coast, and you seek to maintain that reputation.

GENIE TOUCHED



ARTIST: LUCA BANCONE

Ability Scores: Dexterity, Wisdom, Charisma

Feat: Magic Initiate (Wizard)

Skill Proficiencies: Perception and Persuasion

Tool Proficiency: Glassblower's Tools

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) Light Hammer, Glassblower's Tools, Fine Clothes, Lamp, Oil (3 flasks), Waterskin, 2 GP; or (B) 50 GP

Although genies no longer rule Calimshan, genie magic is still common in your homeland. Perhaps you inadvertently summoned a djinni from a magic lamp, or maybe you came upon an oasis guarded by a marid. A dao might have saved you from a landslide, or you bargained with an efreeti for fleeting wealth. However your fate intersected with that of a genie, the experience left you with a keen eye, a silver tongue, and more than a touch of magic.

HARPER



ARTIST: KATERINA LADON

Ability Scores: Dexterity, Intelligence, Charisma

Feat: Harper Agent (see “Feats” later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: Performance and Sleight of Hand

Tool Proficiency: Disguise Kit

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) Disguise Kit, Bedroll, Costume, Grappling Hook, Rope, Traveler's Clothes, 14 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You accepted an invitation to join the Harpers, pledging an oath to uphold the Harper code and act in service to the common good. Like all Harpers, you understand the value of teamwork as well as when it's best to go it alone. Harper veterans have taught you the order's secrets—magical melodies, special watchwords, and legerdemain—and have entrusted you to use such knowledge to surveil and undermine the forces of evil.

ICE FISHER



ARTIST: EREL MAATITA

Ability Scores: Strength, Dexterity, Constitution

Feat: Alert

Skill Proficiencies: [Animal Handling](#) and [Athletics](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Woodcarver's Tools](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Woodcarver's Tools](#), [Basket](#), [Block and Tackle](#), [Bucket](#), [Chain](#), [Hunting Trap](#), [Net](#), [Pole](#), [Rations](#) (3 days' worth), [Rope](#), [Traveler's Clothes](#), 32 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You come from a proud line of ice fishers out of Ten-Towns in Icewind Dale. Catching knucklehead trout isn't the most glorious trade in the North, but it's an honest living. You've trained your senses for the slightest tug on the line, wrestled big trout out of ice-covered lakes, and gutted enough knucklehead trout to feed your village many times over. These experiences have toughened your body and mind for a life of adventuring.

KNIGHT OF THE GAUNTLET



ARTIST: ERIC BELISLE

Ability Scores: Strength, Intelligence, Wisdom

Feat: Tyro of the Gauntlet (see "Feats" later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: [Athletics](#) and [Medicine](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Smith's Tools](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Spear](#), [Smith's Tools](#), [Bullseye Lantern](#), [Holy Symbol](#), [Manacles](#), [Oil](#) (5 flasks), [Tinderbox](#), [Traveler's Clothes](#), 9 GP; or (B) 50 GP

Not all who answer the call of a higher power are content to pore over scripture in a stuffy temple apse. You chose the path of the holy warrior by joining the Order of the Gauntlet. As a knight of the Gauntlet, you exercise righteous scorn for the forces of evil, unswerving camaraderie for your siblings in arms, and heartfelt compassion for the survivors of war. With weapon and holy symbol in hand, you've sworn not to rest until the light of justice has vanquished the shadow of chaos across Faerûn.

LORDS' ALLIANCE VASSAL



ARTIST: IGNATIUS BUDI

Ability Scores: Strength, Intelligence, Charisma

Feat: Lords' Alliance Agent (see "Feats" later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: **Insight** and **Persuasion**

Tool Proficiency: **Calligrapher's Supplies**

Equipment: *Choose A or B:* (A) 2 **Javelins**, **Calligrapher's Supplies**, **Fine Clothes**, **Ink**, 5 **Ink Pens**, **Parchment** (9 sheets), 13 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You've pledged your loyalty to a member-city of the Lords' Alliance. As an Alliance agent, you must uphold the tenets of the Alliance and seek to increase safety and prosperity along the Sword Coast. You're sworn to bring honor and glory to your lord's house, whether that means securing trade roads for a merchant-lord of Waterdeep or vanquishing monsters upriver of Daggerford. You've trained in the arts of swordplay and statecraft and are as deft with a blade as you are with a quill.

MOONWELL PILGRIM



ARTIST: LUCA BANCONE

Ability Scores: Constitution, Wisdom, Charisma

Feat: Magic Initiate (Druid)

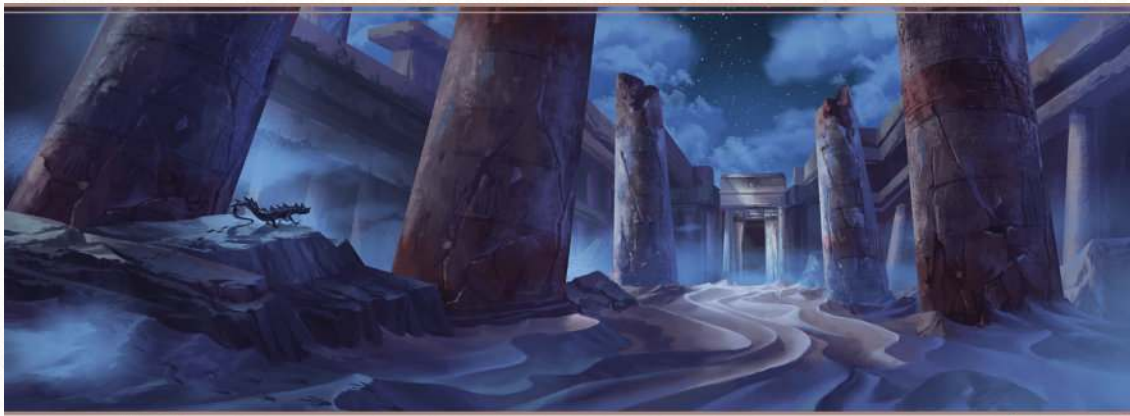
Skill Proficiencies: **Nature** and **Performance**

Tool Proficiency: **Painter's Supplies**

Equipment: *Choose A or B:* (A) **Quarterstaff**, **Painter's Supplies**, **Bedroll**, **Bell**, **Pouch**, **Robe**, **String**, **Traveler's Clothes**, **Waterskin**, 34 GP; or (B) 50 GP

Like many who hail from the Moonshae Isles, you grew up revering the blessed land, its unique gods, and the mysterious shrines called the moonwells. As a moonwell pilgrim, you undertook a quest to visit and commune with every moonwell on (or off) the map. Along your idyllic journeys, you collected a repertoire of Moonshavian folk songs, painted landscapes of enchanting vistas, and even learned how to wield a bit of primal magic.

MULHORANDI TOMB RAIDER



ARTIST: EREL MAATITA

Ability Scores: Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence

Feat: Lucky

Skill Proficiencies: Investigation and Religion

Tool Proficiency: Mason's Tools

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) Dagger, Light Hammer, Mason's Tools, Backpack, Bedroll, Crowbar, Ladder, Pole, 2 Pouches, Rope, String, Tinderbox, 5 Torches, Traveler's Clothes, Waterskin, 26 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You grew up in a land of living god-kings, and as a child you were told countless stories of ancient empires and buried cities. In these tales, Mulhorand was a land overflowing with forgotten riches—priceless treasures awaiting anyone cunning and brave enough to seek them out. You've taken it upon yourself to explore your homeland's crypts, tombs, and pyramids to reclaim your people's relics.

MYTHALKEEPER



ARTIST: PEDRO CARDOSO

Ability Scores: Intelligence, Wisdom, Charisma

Feat: Crafter

Skill Proficiencies: Arcana and History

Tool Proficiency: Jeweler's Tools

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) Quarterstaff, Jeweler's Tools, Perfume, Pouch, Robe, Shovel, String, Waterskin, 16 GP; or (B) 50 GP

Mythals are sources of great magical power that can alter the Weave or even the very nature of reality. Most were constructed in antiquity, and many have since been damaged or gone dormant. As a mythalkeeper from the Dalelands, your first experience with a mythal was likely in the ruins of Myth Drannor. You roam Faerûn in search of other ruined places of power, hoping to learn more about the history and powers of mythals—or even restore a malfunctioning one.

PURPLE DRAGON SQUIRE



ARTIST: IOANNIS FIORE

Ability Scores: Strength, Wisdom, Charisma

Feat: Purple Dragon Rook (see "Feats" later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: [Animal Handling](#) and [Insight](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Navigator's Tools](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Spear](#), [Navigator's Tools](#), [Fine Clothes](#), 9 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You've pledged your life to the safety of Cormyr and sought admission to that realm's order of elite warriors: the Purple Dragon Knights. But before you have the chance to join the ranks officially, you must first serve as a knight's squire. You've found a liege willing to take you on and teach you the order's ways. Will you uphold the Purple Dragon Knights' ideals of glory, honor, and strength and prove yourself worthy of knighthood?

RASHEMI WANDERER



ARTIST: BRUCE BRENNSEISE

Ability Scores: Strength, Constitution, Charisma

Feat: Tough

Skill Proficiencies: [Intimidation](#) and [Perception](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Cartographer's Tools](#)

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) [Cartographer's Tools](#), [Backpack](#), [Bedroll](#), [Hooded Lantern](#), [Oil](#) (3 flasks), [Rope](#), [Tinderbox](#), [Traveler's Clothes](#), Waterskin, 23 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You spent years wandering the highlands of Rashemen, a dangerous windswept heath that's dotted with ancient obelisks enchanted to imprison Fiends and home to dragons, gnolls, and other deadly creatures. Friendships are hard to find in such an isolated land, and you've learned to keep strangers at a distance.

SHADOWMASTERS EXILE



ARTIST: BRUCE BRENNEISE

Ability Score: Dexterity, Intelligence, Charisma

Feat: Savage Attacker

Skill Proficiencies: **Acrobatics** and **Stealth**

Tool Proficiency: **Thieves' Tools**

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) 2 **Daggers**, **Thieves' Tools**, **Caltrops**, **Costume**, **Grappling Hook**, **Iron Spikes**, **Mirror**, 2 **Pouches**, **Rope**, **Traveler's Clothes**, 3 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You trained your whole life to become a member of the Shadowmasters, the mysterious thieves' guild that controls the realm of Thesk from behind the scenes. **Stealth** and quick reflexes were just the start of your Shadowmaster education; you also needed to hone your ruthlessness to ensure the safety of the guild's secrets. But one wrong move led to your expulsion from the order. Now you must walk your own path.

SPELLFIRE INITIATE



ARTIST: TARAS SUSAK

Ability Scores: Constitution, Intelligence, Charisma

Feat: Spellfire Spark (see "Feats" later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: **Arcana** and **Perception**

Tool Proficiency: Choose one kind of Gaming Set

Equipment: Choose A or B: (A) Gaming Set (same as above), Arcane Focus (**Crystal** or **Wand**), 2 **Pouches**, **Traveler's Clothes**, 36 GP; or (B) 50 GP

You bear the gift of spellfire: a rare form of magic that channels the raw power of the Weave. Wielding spellfire takes a heavy toll on the body. You've trained both mind and body to efficiently wield this sacred power.

ZHENTARIM MERCENARY



ARTIST: IGNATIUS BUDI

Ability Scores: Strength, Dexterity, Charisma

Feat: Zhentarim Ruffian (see “Feats” later in this chapter)

Skill Proficiencies: [Intimidation](#) and [Perception](#)

Tool Proficiency: [Forgery Kit](#)

Equipment: *Choose A or B:* (A) [Club](#), [Dagger](#), [Forgery Kit](#), [Fine Clothes](#), [Hooded Lantern](#), [Oil](#) (3 flasks), 2 [Pouches](#), [String](#), [Tinderbox](#), 11 GP; or (B) 50 GP

Maybe you needed the money. Maybe you longed for a family, no matter how dubious. Or maybe you're just good at getting the job done by any means necessary. Whatever your reason, you enlisted with the Zhentarim, the most notorious mercenary guild in the Realms. Though the Zhentarim's leaders insist the organization is more like a family than a shadowy syndicate, few families exhibit as much dishonesty, nepotism, and corruption as this one. You've honed your cunning, reflexes, and blade to climb the guild's ranks.

FEATS

This section's feats are organized by category—Origin, General, or Epic Boon—and alphabetized in each category. All the feats are listed alphabetically in the Feat List table.

FEAT LIST

Feat	Category
Boon of Bloodshed	Epic Boon
Boon of Bountiful Health	Epic Boon
Boon of Communication	Epic Boon
Boon of Desperate Resilience	Epic Boon
Boon of Exquisite Radiance	Epic Boon
Boon of Fluid Forms	Epic Boon
Boon of Fortune's Favor	Epic Boon
Boon of Poison Mastery	Epic Boon
Boon of Revelry	Epic Boon
Boon of Terror	Epic Boon
Boon of the Bright Sun	Epic Boon
Boon of the Furious Storm	Epic Boon
Boon of the Soul Drinker	Epic Boon
Cold Caster	General
Cult of the Dragon Initiate	Origin
Dragonscarred	General
Emerald Enclave Fledgling	Origin
Enclave Magic	General
Fairy Trickster	General
Genie Magic	General
Harper Agent	Origin
Harper Teamwork	General
Lordly Resolve	General
Lords' Alliance Agent	Origin
Mythal Touched	General
Order's Resilience	General
Purple Dragon Commandant	General
Purple Dragon Rook	Origin
Spellfire Adept	General
Spellfire Spark	Origin
Street Justice	General
Tyro of the Gauntlet	Origin
Zhentarim Ruffian	Origin
Zhentarim Tactics	General

ORIGIN FEATS

These feats are in the Origin category.

CULT OF THE DRAGON INITIATE

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Dragon's Tongue. You know Draconic. If you already know Draconic when you select this feat, you instead learn one language of your choice from the language tables in the *Player's Handbook* or chapter 2 of this book.

Dragon's Terror. You can take a **Magic** action to instill terror in a creature you can see within 30 feet of yourself. The target must succeed on a Wisdom saving throw (DC 8 plus your Wisdom modifier and Proficiency Bonus) or have the **Frightened** condition until the end of your next turn. If the target succeeds on the save or when the effect ends for a target, the target is immune to this effect for 24 hours.

Inspired by Fear. When you cause a creature to have the Frightened condition and you are the source of its fear, you can gain **Heroic Inspiration** if you lack it. Once you use this benefit, you can't use it again until you finish a Short or Long Rest.

EMERALD ENCLAVE FLEDGLING

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Speak with Animals. You always have the **Speak with Animals** spell prepared and can cast it with any spell slots you have. Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma is your spellcasting ability for this spell (choose when you select this feat). When you cast this spell as a Ritual, its duration is 8 hours.

Tag Team. When you take the **Help** action, you can switch places with a willing ally within 5 feet of yourself as part of that same action. This movement doesn't provoke **Opportunity Attack** action. You can't use this benefit if the ally has the **Incapacitated** condition.

HARPER AGENT

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Thieves' Cant. You know Thieves' Cant.

Instrument Training. You gain proficiency with a Musical Instrument of your choice.

Distracting Melody. When you take the **Help** action to assist an ally's attack roll, the enemy you're distracting can be within 30 feet of you, rather than within 5 feet of you, provided the enemy can see or hear you.

LORDS' ALLIANCE AGENT

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Inspiring Strike. Once per turn when you score a Critical Hit against a creature, you can choose an ally within 30 feet of yourself who can see or hear you and who lacks **Heroic Inspiration**. That ally gains Heroic Inspiration.

Reassert Honor. When an enemy you can see deals damage to an ally of yours that is within 5 feet of you, you have Advantage on your next attack roll against that enemy before the end of your next turn.

PURPLE DRAGON ROOK

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Entreat. You gain proficiency in one of the following skills: **Insight**, **Performance**, or **Persuasion**.

Rallying Cry. When you roll Initiative and don't have the **Incapacitated** condition, you can choose a number of creatures equal to your Proficiency Bonus that you can see within 30 feet of yourself. Those creatures gain **Heroic Inspiration**.

Once you use this benefit, you can't do so again until you finish a Long Rest.

SPELLFIRE SPARK

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Magic Absorption. Once per turn, when you take damage from a spell or magical effect, you reduce the total damage taken by 1d4. You can't use this benefit if you have the **Incapacitated** condition.

Spellfire Flame. You learn the **Sacred Flame** cantrip. Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma is your spellcasting ability for this spell (choose when you select this feat). You can also cast this cantrip as a Bonus Action a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

TYRO OF THE GAUNTLET

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Stand as One. When an ally within 5 feet of you is subjected to an effect that would push or pull it, you can take a Reaction to prevent that ally from being pushed or pulled. To receive this benefit, the ally can't have the **Incapacitated** condition.

Vigilant. When you take the **Ready** action, the next attack roll made against you has Disadvantage before the start of your next turn.

ZHENTARIM RUFFIAN

Origin Feat

You gain the following benefits.

Exploit Opening. When you roll damage for an **Opportunity Attack** action, you can roll the damage dice twice and use either roll against the target.

Family First. If you have **Heroic Inspiration** when you roll Initiative, you can expend it to give yourself and your allies Advantage on that Initiative roll.



WITH HER SPELL SIMBUL'S SYNOSTODWEOMER, THE SIMBUL PROTECTS HER SISTER DOVE FALCONHAND IN BATTLE
ARTIST: IOANNIS FIORE

GENERAL FEATS

These feats are in the General category.

COLD CASTER

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Cantrip. You learn the [Ray of Frost](#) cantrip. If you already know it, you learn a different Wizard cantrip of your choice. The spell's spellcasting ability is the ability increased by this feat.

Frostbite. Once per turn when you hit a creature with an attack roll and deal Cold damage, you can temporarily negate the creature's defenses. The creature subtracts 1d4 from the next saving throw it makes before the end of your next turn.

DRAGONSCARRED

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Cult of the Dragon Initiate Feat)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Constitution or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Damage Resistance. When you gain this feat, choose Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Poison. You have Resistance to the chosen damage type.

Fearsome Power. When you deal damage to a creature as part of the Attack or [Magic](#) action on your turn, you can use the Dragon's Terror benefit of the Cult of the Dragon Initiate feat as a Bonus Action this turn.

ENCLAVE MAGIC

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Emerald Enclave Fledgling Feat)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Friend to Animals. You have Advantage on ability checks when taking the [Influence](#) action with Beasts.

Two Hearts, One Mind. You always have the [Beast Sense](#) spell prepared. You can cast it once without a spell slot, and you regain the ability to cast it in that way when you finish a Long Rest. When you cast it without a spell slot using this feature, it doesn't require [Concentration](#). You can also cast the spell using any spell slots you have of the appropriate level. The spell's spellcasting ability is the ability increased by this feat.

FAIRY TRICKSTER

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Dexterity or Charisma ability score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Faerie Trod Trotter. When you take the [Disengage](#) action on your turn, [Difficult Terrain](#) doesn't cost you extra movement for the rest of that turn.

Flustering Strike. When you hit a creature with an attack roll, you can attempt to fluster the target. The target must succeed on a Wisdom saving throw (DC 8 plus the ability modifier of the score increased by this feat and your Proficiency Bonus) or have Disadvantage on saving throws until the end of your next turn.

You can use this benefit a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

GENIE MAGIC

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Wish Magic. As a [Magic](#) action, you can cast a level 1 spell of your choice from the Sorcerer spell list that has a casting time of an action. Once you use this benefit, you can't do so again until you finish a Long Rest. The spell's spellcasting ability is the ability increased by this feat.

When you reach level 11, the spell you cast with this feat is cast as though using a level 2 spell slot. When you reach level 17, the spell is cast as though using a level 3 spell slot.

HARPER TEAMWORK

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Harper Agent Feat)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Dexterity or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Withering Wordplay. When you take the **Help** action to assist an ally’s attack roll against an enemy, that enemy also has Disadvantage on the first saving throw it makes before the start of your next turn.

Inspiring Willpower. If you succeed on a saving throw to end the **Frightened** or **Paralyzed** condition on yourself, you can choose one ally you can see within 30 feet of yourself that has the same condition. That condition immediately ends for that ally.

LORDLY RESOLVE

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Lords’ Alliance Agent Feat)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Strength or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Standard Bearer. As a Bonus Action, choose up to three creatures within 60 feet of yourself that can see you. Each target can immediately take a Reaction to right itself and end the **Prone** condition, provided its Speed isn’t 0.

Additionally, you bolster the targets’ resolve, which lasts for 1 minute or until you have the **Incapacitated** condition. While bolstered, a target can’t be possessed or gain the **Charmed** or **Frightened** condition; if a target is already possessed, **Charmed**, or **Frightened**, the target has Advantage on any new saving throw against the relevant effect.

Once you use this benefit, you can’t do so again until you finish a Long Rest.

MYTHAL TOUCHED

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Mythal Ward. If a spell attack hits you or you fail a saving throw against a spell, you can take a Reaction to roll on the Mythal-Touched Magic table to create a magical effect. If an effect requires a saving throw, the DC equals 8 plus the modifier of the ability increased by this feat and your Proficiency Bonus.

You can use this benefit a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

MYTHAL-TOUCHED MAGIC

1d20	Effect
1–2	You and each creature within 15 feet of you make a Dexterity saving throw, taking Force damage equal to 1d8 times the level of the triggering spell on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.
3–7	You and the triggering spell’s caster form a telepathic link for 1 hour.
8–10	Gravity is reversed in a 15-foot-radius, 60-foot-tall Cylinder centered on you for 1 minute, per the Reverse Gravity spell.
11–13	You and the triggering spell’s caster each make a Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature has the Stunned condition until the end of its next turn.
14–17	You gain a +2 bonus to AC for 1 minute, potentially turning the triggering spell into a miss if it was a spell attack.
18–19	Any flammable, nonmagical object within 10 feet of the triggering spell’s caster that isn’t being worn or carried by another creature bursts into flame, takes 1d4 Fire damage, and is burning.
20	The triggering spell dissipates with no effect, and the action, Bonus Action, or Reaction used to cast it is wasted. If that spell was cast with a spell slot, the slot isn’t expended.

ORDER’S RESILIENCE

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Tyro of the Gauntlet Feat)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Strength, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Resurge. When you have the **Prone** condition, you can right yourself with only 5 feet of movement.

Stronger Together. If you are within 5 feet of an ally that doesn't have the **Incapacitated** condition, you and that ally have Advantage on Strength saving throws. You can't use this benefit while you have the Incapacitated condition.

PURPLE DRAGON COMMANDANT

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Purple Dragon Rook Feat or Martial Weapon Proficiency)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Strength or Dexterity score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Encourage Ally. As a Bonus Action, you bolster one ally you can see within 30 feet. The ally gains **Temporary Hit Points** equal to 2d6 plus the modifier of the ability score increased by this feat. You can take this Bonus Action a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all uses when you finish a Long Rest.

Last Stand. You have Advantage on attack rolls while **Bloodied**.

SPELLFIRE ADEPT

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Spellfire Spark Feat or the Spellcasting or Pact Magic Feature)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Fueled Spellfire. Once per turn, when a spell you cast deals Radiant damage, you can expend up to two Hit Point Dice, roll them, and add the total rolled to one damage roll of the spell.

Searing Spellfire. When you make a damage roll that deals Radiant damage, it ignores Resistance to Radiant damage.

STREET JUSTICE

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Strength or Dexterity score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Headlock. Your allies have Advantage on attack rolls against a creature **Grappled** by you.

Sturdy Knot. When you use **Chain**, **Manacles**, or **Rope** to bind a creature, add your Proficiency Bonus to the DC to escape or burst the Chain, Manacles, or Rope.

Tough Talk. A creature's **Hostile** attitude doesn't impose Disadvantage on your Charisma (**Intimidation**) checks to influence that creature.

ZHENTARIM TACTICS

General Feat (Prerequisite: Level 4+, Zhentarim Ruffian Feat)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Dexterity or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 20.

Retaliate. Immediately after a creature within 5 feet of you hits you with a melee attack, you can make an **Opportunity Attack** action against that creature.

Versatile Merc. When you finish a Long Rest, choose a skill in which you have proficiency. You have Expertise in that skill until you finish your next Long Rest.



FAERÛN IS HOME TO ADVENTURERS

GREAT AND SMALL
ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

EPIC BOON FEATS

These are feats in the Epic Boon category.

BOON OF BLOODSHED

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase one ability score of your choice by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Killer's Fortune. When an enemy you can see is reduced to 0 Hit Points, you gain Advantage on the next attack roll you make before the end of your next turn.

Power from Pain. Once per turn, when you make an attack roll while **Bloodied**, you can deal extra damage to the target equal to your Proficiency Bonus. The extra damage's type is the same as the attack's type.

BOON OF BOUNTIFUL HEALTH

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase one ability score of your choice by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Augmented Health. When you gain **Temporary Hit Points**, increase the number of Temporary Hit Points you gain by 5.

Superior Recuperation. When you spend one or more Hit Point Dice to regain Hit Points, you can instead use the highest number possible for each die.

BOON OF COMMUNICATION

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Cunning Speaker. You don't have Disadvantage on ability checks to influence **Hostile** creatures.

Gifted Interpreter. You understand the literal meaning of any language you hear or see signed, and you can understand the literal meaning of any written language you see.

Mental Communication. You gain telepathy with a range of 120 feet.

BOON OF DESPERATE RESILIENCE

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Strength or Constitution score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Defense of Body and Mind. While you are **Bloodied**, you have Resistance to every damage type except Force.

BOON OF EXQUISITE RADIANCE

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase one ability score of your choice by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Eternal Rest. Creatures you reduce to 0 Hit Points can't become Undead.

Powerful Radiance. When you make a damage roll that deals Radiant damage, you can instead use the highest number possible for each damage die. Once you use this benefit, you can't do so again until you finish a Long Rest.

BOON OF FLUID FORMS

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Shapechanger. You can take a **Magic** action to shape-shift into a Beast, Humanoid, or Monstrosity with a Challenge Rating no higher than 10. When you shape-shift, you gain a number of **Temporary Hit Points** equal to the Hit Points of the form. The shape-shifting effect lasts for 1 hour, and it ends early if you have no Temporary Hit Points left or if you take a Magic action to return to your true form.

Your game statistics are replaced by the stat block of the chosen form, but you retain your creature type; alignment; personality; Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma scores; Hit Points; Hit Point Dice; proficiencies; and ability to communicate. If you have the Spellcasting or Pact Magic feature, you retain it too. Upon shape-shifting, you determine whether your equipment drops to the ground or changes in size and shape to fit the new form while you're in it.

Once you use this benefit, you can't do so again until you finish a Long Rest.

Hardy Transformation. When you gain Temporary Hit Points when you shape-shift, increase that number of Temporary Hit Points by 20.

BOON OF FORTUNE'S FAVOR

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase one ability score of your choice by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Saving Throw Reroll. When you fail a saving throw, you can reroll it and must use the new roll. Once you use this benefit, you can't do so again until the start of your next turn.

BOON OF POISON MASTERY

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase one ability score of your choice by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Antitoxic. You have Immunity to Poison damage and the **Poisoned** condition.

Perfect Poisoner. Once per turn, when you roll dice to determine Poison damage a creature takes from your attack, spell, or feature, you can instead use the highest number possible for each die.

BOON OF REVELRY

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Inspire Dance. You always have the **Otto's Irresistible Dance** spell prepared. You can cast it once without a spell slot, and you regain the ability to cast it that way when you finish a Long Rest. You can also cast the spell using any spell slots you have of the appropriate level.

When you cast the spell, it requires no spell components, and taking damage doesn't break your **Concentration** on it.

Sing Out. While a creature that failed its saving throw against your *Otto's Irresistible Dance* has the **Charmed** condition from that spell, it can't cast spells with Verbal components, and it sings delightful nonsense if it can sing.

BOON OF TERROR

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Fearless. You have Immunity to the **Frightened** condition.

Flee, Fools! When a creature with the Frightened condition starts its turn within 60 feet of you, you can take a Reaction to stoke its terror, provided you can see the creature and it isn't behind **Total Cover**. If you do so, the creature must succeed on a Wisdom saving throw (DC 8 plus your Charisma modifier and your Proficiency Bonus) or spend its turn moving away from you by the fastest available means. Once you use this benefit, you can't use it again until you finish a Short or Long Rest.

Intimidating. You gain Proficiency in the **Intimidation** skill if you don't already have it. You also gain Expertise in Intimidation.

BOON OF THE BRIGHT SUN

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Constitution, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Daylight Presence. As a Bonus Action, you radiate a 30-foot **Emanation** of **Bright Light** that is sunlight. If any of the Emanation's area overlaps with an area of Darkness created by a spell, that spell is dispelled. The Emanation lasts until you dismiss it (no action required), die, or have the **Incapacitated** condition.

Fortifying Light. When your Daylight Presence is active, at the start of each of your turns, you and allies you can see in your Daylight Presence gain 10 **Temporary Hit Points**.

BOON OF THE FURIOUS STORM

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+, Spellcasting or Pact Magic Feature)

You gain the following benefits.

Ability Score Increase. Increase your Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma score by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Eye of the Storm. You have Resistance to Lightning and Thunder damage. While you are **Bloodied**, you have Immunity to Lightning and Thunder damage.

Storm's Strength. Creatures have Disadvantage on saving throws against your spells that deal Lightning or Thunder damage.

BOON OF THE SOUL DRINKER

Epic Boon Feat (Prerequisite: Level 19+)

You gain the following benefits.

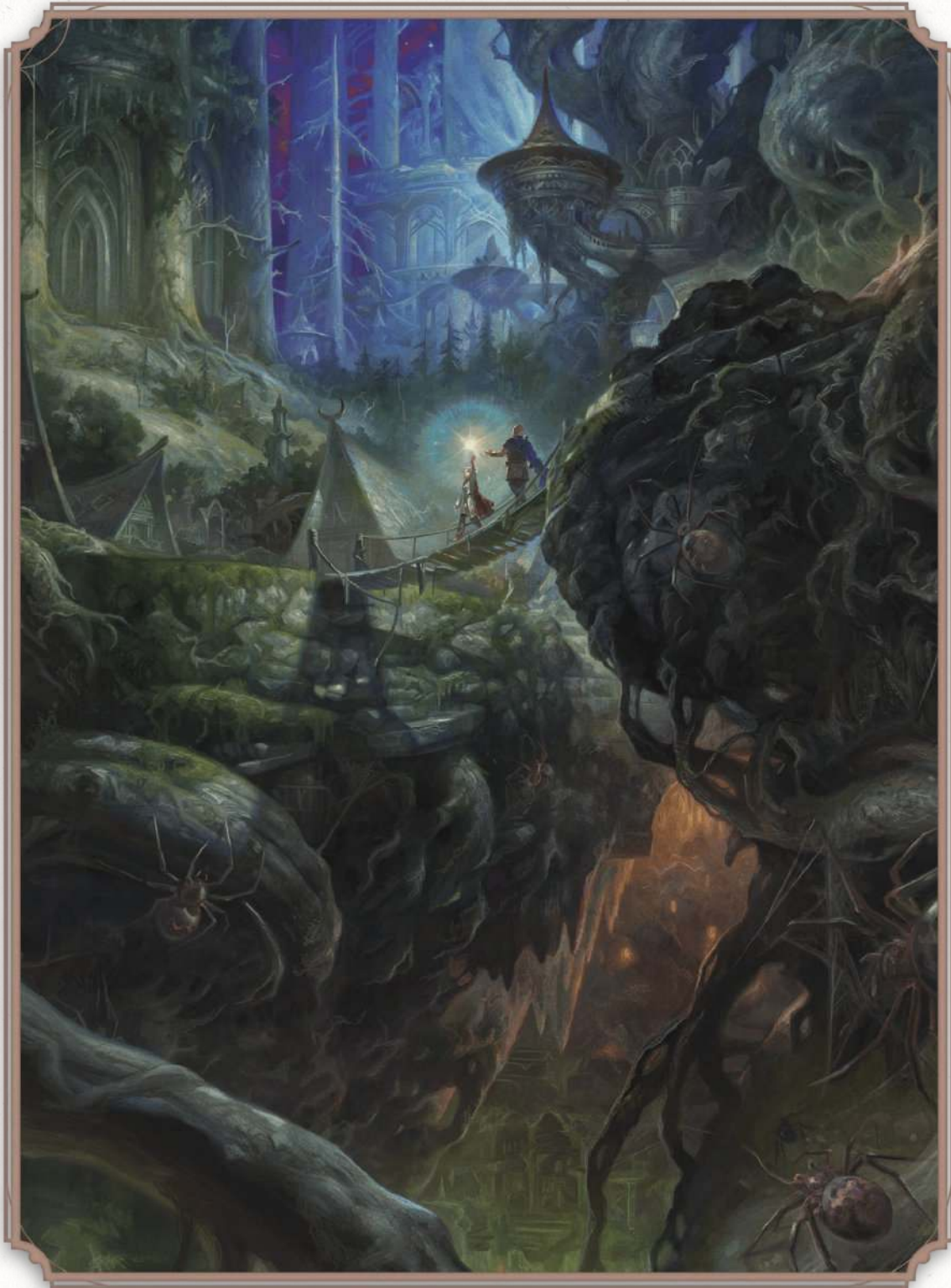
Ability Score Increase. Increase one ability score of your choice by 1, to a maximum of 30.

Grave Resistance. You have Resistance to Cold damage and Necrotic damage.

Siphon Life. When an enemy within 120 feet of you is reduced to 0 Hit Points, you can take a Reaction to regain 50 Hit Points. Once you use this benefit, you can't use it again until you finish a Short or Long Rest.

CHAPTER 2

A GUIDE TO THE REALMS



MINSC, BOO, AND DELINA EXPLORE THE RUINS OF MYTH DRANNOR.

ARTIST: QUINTIN GLEIM

THE CONTINENT OF FAERÛN STRETCHES BETWEEN THE TRACKLESS SEA TO THE WEST AND THE SUNRISE MOUNTAINS TO THE EAST ON A WORLD CALLED TORIL. A PLACE OF varied cultures and peoples, Faerûn contains diverse realms, including kingdoms, city-states, and carefully maintained alliances of rural communities. While many of these realms are ruled by humans, who are the most populous species in Faerûn today, people of all sorts—including dragonborn, goliaths, orcs, tieflings, and more—mingle in those realms, as well as mountainous dwarven kingdoms, hidden elven enclaves, and other communities. Except in the most remote or insular places, Faerûnians are accustomed to seeing people of different cultures, ethnicities, and species.

A great deal of adventure is to be had in the Realms. The routes between cities and nations often cross into the territory of brigands or marauding monsters. Every forest, swamp, and mountain range has its own perils, whether lurking bandits, malicious fey, or mighty creatures such as giants and dragons. Ruins of ancient, forgotten realms dot the landscape, and these ruins often conceal expansive subterranean dungeons that wind beneath the surface. In these places, long-lost treasures await intrepid adventurers.

Faerûn is filled with rich history and wondrous tales of adventure and magic, but day-to-day life in Faerûn is that of a medieval society. Rural farmers grow food and herd livestock that gets sent to market in towns and cities, where crafters and other tradesfolk gather. News and gossip are carried by caravans, ships, and traveling minstrels. Adventurers also spread news—when they're not creating it!

Most of the people who populate the continent have little or no knowledge of lands outside Faerûn. Only the more educated or well traveled among the populace are aware that Faerûn is but one continent and that Toril is the whole of the world. For most, "Faerûn" is quite large enough.

Time in the Realms

Although a number of means exist for marking the days and the passage of time during a year, nearly all folk in Faerûn have adopted the Calendar of Harptos.

In the Calendar of Harptos, a year on Toril consists of 365 days, divided into twelve months of thirty days, loosely following the cycle of Selûne, the moon. A month is made up of three tendays, also known as rides. Five annual holidays, falling between the months, complete the calendar. Once every four years, Shieldmeet occurs as a leap day following Midsummer.

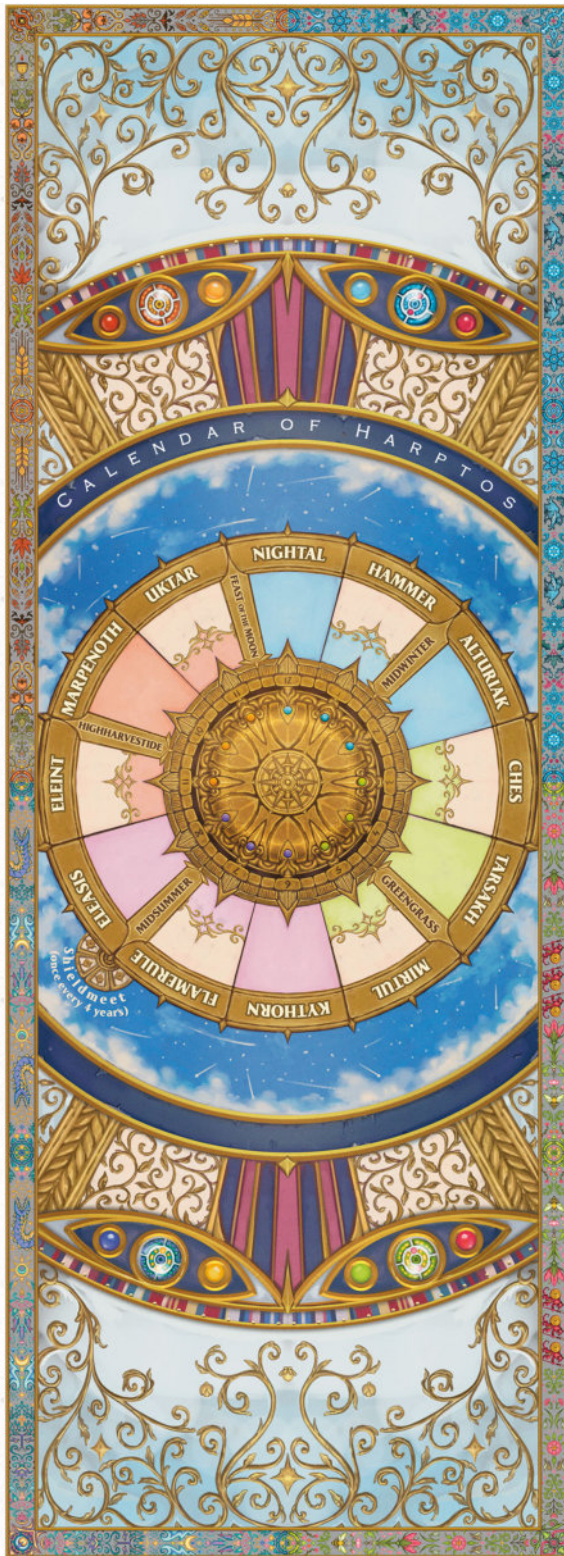
Individual days of a tenday have no special names. Instead, they are denoted by counting from the beginning of the period ("first day," "second day," and so on). Days of the month are designated by a number and the month name (for example, "1 Mirtul" or "27 Uktar"). People might also refer to a given day by its relationship to the current date ("two tendays from today") or the nearest holiday ("three days past Greengrass").

Calendar of Harptos

Month	Name	Common Name
1	Hammer	Deepwinter
Annual Holiday: Midwinter		
2	Alturiak	The Claw of Winter
3	Ches	The Claw of Sunsets
4	Tarsakh	The Claw of Storms
Annual Holiday: Greengrass		
5	Mirtul	The Melting
6	Kythorn	The Time of Flowers
7	Flamerule	Summertide
Annual Holiday: Midsummer		
Quadrennial Holiday: Shieldmeet		
8	Eleasis	Highsun
9	Eleint	The Fading
Annual Holiday: Highharvestide		
10	Marpenoth	Leaffall
11	Uktar	The Rotting
Annual Holiday: Feast of the Moon		
12	Nightal	The Drawing Down

Special Calendar Days

Every realm, faith, and culture across Faerûn has its own special festivals and holidays, the observances of which are governed by the cycles of the sun, the moon, the stars, or some other event. In addition, the Calendar of Harptos specifies five annual festivals keyed to the changing of the seasons and one quadrennial festival that are observed in almost every land, with particular celebrations varying based on local traditions and popular faiths.



ARTIST: RALUCA MARINESCU

FEAST OF THE MOON

As nights lengthen and winter winds approach, the Feast of the Moon is the time when people celebrate their ancestors and honored dead. During festivals on this day, people gather to share stories and legends, offer prayers for the fallen, and prepare for the coming cold.

KEEPING TIME FROM DAY TO DAY

Most people don't keep track of the time of day beyond notions such as "midmorning" or "near sunset." If people plan to meet at a particular time, they base their arrangements around such expressions.

The concept of hours and minutes exists mainly where wealthy people use clocks, but mechanical clocks are often unreliable and rarely set consistently. If a local temple or civic structure has a clock that tolls the passing of the hours, people refer to hours as "bells," as in "I'll meet you at seven bells."

MIDWINTER

The first festival day of the year is Midwinter, though some people name it differently. Nobles and monarchs of the Heartlands call it the High Festival of Winter, a day to commemorate or renew alliances. Commoners in the North, the Moonsea, and other colder climes celebrate it as Deadwinter Day, the midpoint of the cold season, with some of the worst days now past.

GREENGRASS

The traditional spring festival, Greengrass is celebrated with freshly cut flowers (grown in special hothouses where necessary) given as gifts to the gods or spread among the fields in hopes of a bountiful growing season.

MIDSUMMER

The midpoint of summer is a day of feasting, carousing, betrothals, and basking in the pleasant weather. Storms on Midsummer night are seen as bad omens and signs of ill fortune, and sometimes interpreted as divine disapproval of the romances begun or marriages promised that day.

SHIELDMEET

The great holiday of the Calendar of Harptos, Shieldmeet occurs once every four years immediately after Midsummer. It is a day for plain speaking and open council between rulers and their subjects, renewing pacts and contracts, and forging treaties. Many tournaments and contests of skill are held on Shieldmeet, and most faiths mark the holiday by emphasizing one of their key tenets. The next Shieldmeet will be in 1504 DR (see the "Realms Timeline" sidebar).

HIGHHARVESTIDE

A day of feasting and thanks, Highharvestide marks the fall harvest. Most people give thanks to Chauntea on this day for a plentiful bounty before winter approaches. Many who make their living by traveling long distances by road or sea set out immediately following the holiday, before winter blocks mountain passes and harbors.

REALMS TIMELINE

This timeline provides a summary of Faerûn's history. Dates are provided in Dalereckoning (DR). Beginning with the year –700 DR, years have a name found in the Roll of Years, prophetic writings by the Netherese mage Augathra and expanded by Alaundo of Candlekeep:

Days of Thunder (–35000 DR to –30000 DR). Water recedes to reveal the supercontinent of Merrouroboros, eventually inhabited by the so-called creator-races.

Dawn Age (–30000 DR to –24000 DR). The empires of the creator-races fade, replaced by realms of dragons and giants. These two great peoples wage mighty war for centuries.

First Flowering (–24000 DR to –12000 DR). Elven civilizations supplant those of the dragons and giants. In –17600, elven high magic creates Evermeet and brings a cataclysm to Toril known as the Sundering.

Crown Wars (–12000 DR to –9000 DR). Elves war with each other for generations.

Founding Time (–9000 DR to –3000 DR). As elven influence declines, other realms arise, including Imaskar, Netheril, Rashemen, and Unther. The genies Calim and Memnon are bound.

Age of Humanity (–3000 DR to 1000 DR). Realms ruled by humans—including the Mulhorand, Narfell, and Raumathar empires—spread across and dominate Faerûn.

Present Age Begins (1000 DR). The present age is one of conflict, adventure, and global crises.

Time of Troubles (1358 DR). Deities wander the land as mortals and war against each other.

Netheril Returns (1372 DR). The floating city of Thultanthar returns to Anauroch from the Shadowfell, and Shadovar begin rebuilding their empire.

Spellplague (1385 DR). Cyric and Shar murder Mystra, triggering a series of disasters. Toril is briefly merged with the world of Abeir.

Second Sundering (1482 DR to 1489 DR). Abeir and Toril separate again, and over several years, many of the effects of the Spellplague are reversed.

Present (1501 DR). The current year is the Year of the Shining Mythal.

CURRENCY

Nearly every major power of Faerûn has its own currency minted within its borders that represent both its influence and material wealth. Most coins of pure composition and standard weight are accepted across the continent, though not every city-state or nation bothers to mint every sort of coin. The standard used to set the weight and value of coins is Waukeen's *Golden Coin*, a relic that lies on sacred scales in the city of Schamedar in Calimshan.

Some of the most commonly found and widely accepted currencies in the Realms are summarized below. Each grouping is arranged in order of value: copper, silver, electrum, gold, and (when present) platinum. Most people refer to coins by whatever name the issuing government uses, regardless of origin, except for Zhentil Keep—for some reason, Zhentarim coins have unflattering epithets associated with them:

- Amn:** Fander, taran, centaur, danter, roldon
- Calimshan:** Unarche, decarche, centarche, bicenta, kilarche
- Cormyr:** Thumb, falcon, blue eye, golden lion, tricrown
- Sembia:** Steelpence (an iron coin), hawk, blue eye, noble
- Silverymoon:** Glint, shield, sword, dragon, unicorn
- Waterdeep:** Nib, shard, sambar, dragon, sun
- Zhentil Keep:** Fang ("dung-piece"), talon/naal ("flea-bit"), tarenth ("hardhammer"), glory ("weeping wolf"), platinum glory ("flat metal gem")

ADVENTURERS



DERYAN KAYA SUMONS A HORDE OF CONSTRUCTS TO FIGHT OFF A BLUE DRAGON.
ARTIST: KATERINA LADON

Adventurers have a long history in Faerûn. Children are told stories of great adventurers like Storm Silverhand, Drizzt Do'Urden, and Alias. While most people eventually put away their dreams of heroic adventure in favor of more practical matters, a few leave their homes to embark on a life of peril, hoping to become heroes who find great rewards. Individuals who suffer great tragedy in their lives might turn to adventuring out of desperation. Some adventurers are forced into the occupation when they or others are placed in sudden danger. A few individuals simply grow bored with their lives and dream of something more, becoming adventurers to reinvent themselves or find new meaning in their lives.

The common folk of Faerûn look on adventurers with a mixture of admiration, envy, and mistrust.

An adventurer willing to risk their life on behalf of a complete stranger deserves applause and a reward, and many are envious that adventurers live their lives on their own terms, untrammelled by custom or convention.

But adventurers are also dangerous, possessing skills and magic beyond the reach of Faerûn's common folk. Their lives are violent, and where they go, chaos follows. Many adventuring parties have descended into an ancient crypt only to unwittingly release a horrifying evil on an unsuspecting world. And a successful adventurer amasses wealth and power very quickly—perhaps too quickly for rulers to monitor or for the law to handle.

Regardless, authority figures often turn to adventurers to solve unusual problems. Towns and cities typically have a budget set aside for hiring adventurers.

REGIONS OF THE REALMS



MAP: FORGOTTEN REALMS (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



Faerûn is frequently divided into various regions that share common cultural characteristics. The ten regions of the Forgotten Realms setting are as follows:

Anauroch. The inhospitable desert of Anauroch and adjoining glacier is home to nomads and criss-crossed by trade caravans.

Arcane Empires. Three realms in east Faerûn are ruled by wielders of arcane magic: masked witches in Rashemen, sorcerers in Aglarond, and the infamous Red Wizards of Thay.

Forgotten Lands. The remote northeast of Faerûn is home to vast mineral wealth and long-lost magical secrets.

Heartlands. The rich, powerful realms of Cormyr and Sembia surround the frontier settlements of the Dalelands and a legendary elven ruin.

Lands of Intrigue. The realms of Amn, Calimshan, and Tethyr have not warred with each other for centuries, but this only hides a long history of political schemes.

The North. Harsh weather, Underdark menaces, and isolation threaten the people of Icewind Dale and other settlements in a dangerous and unforgiving land.

Old Empires. The ancient realms of Chessenta, Mulhorand, and Unther are ruled—for better or for worse—by living gods.

Sword Coast. Some of the largest and most well-known cities in Faerûn lie along its west coast, tied together by trade and shared history.

Trackless Sea. The island nations in the Trackless Sea are isolated from each other but united by their dependence on the sea.

Vilhon Reach. The Emerald Enclave's mystic island of Ilighôn lies at the entrance to the Vilhon Reach. Wielding arcane magic is a crime in most of the Vilhon Reach.

Each of these regions is described on the pages that follow and on the poster map in this book. Each region begins with a brief overview that summarizes key facts, as well as a map of the region. Subsequent sections detail the realms of each region, important cultural elements, and noteworthy places adventurers might visit.

REGIONS AND LANGUAGES

Many realms, ethnicities, and cultural groups in Faerûn have their own language they use in addition to Common. These languages are noted in the gazetteer sections that follow. You can choose any of these languages as one of the languages your character knows. These regional languages, along with the standard languages from the *Player's Handbook*, are listed on the Standard Languages of Faerûn table, which you can use to randomly determine the languages your character knows (in addition to Common).

STANDARD LANGUAGES OF FAERÛN

1d100	Language	Origin
—	Common	Sigil
01–03	Aglarondan	Aglarond
04–06	Alzhedo	Calimshan
07–09	Bothii	Uthgardt nomads
10–12	Chessentan	Chessenta
13–15	Chondathan	Chondath
16–18	Common Sign Language	Sigil
19–21	Damaran	Damara
22–26	Draconic	Dragons
27–33	Dwarvish	Dwarves
34–40	Elvish	Elves
41–45	Giant	Giants
46–50	Gnomish	Gnomes
51–55	Goblin	Goblinoids
56–62	Halfling	Halflings
63–65	Illuskan	The North
66–68	Lantanese	Lantan
69–71	Midani	Bedine nomads
72–74	Mulhorandi	Mulhorand
75–77	Netherese	Netheril
78–82	Orc	Orcs
83–85	Rashemi	Rashemen
86–88	Reghedjic	Reghed nomads
89–91	Sespech	Sespech
92–94	Thayan	Thay
95–97	Turmic	Turmish
98–00	Untheric	Unther

ANAUROCH

OVERVIEW

At a Glance: A wasteland, once the thriving heart of the Netherese empire, inexorably spreads into surrounding lands.

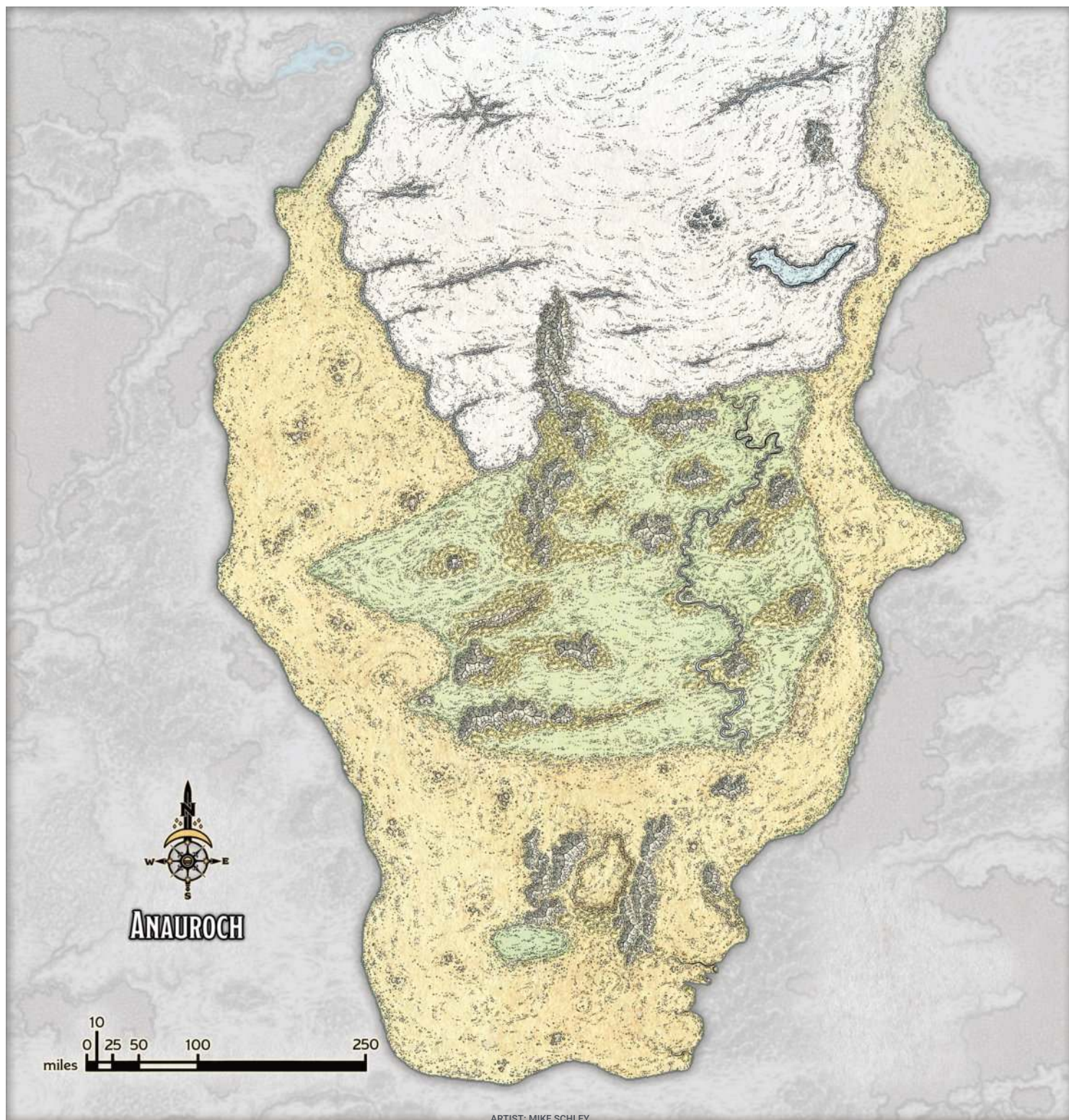
Realms: Bedine tribes, Empire of Shadows, Zhentarim caravans

Languages: Midani (Bedine), Netherese (Shade)

Landmarks: Azirrhath, Saiyaddar, Scimitar Spires, Shadow Sea, the Sword

Threats: Lamias threaten the north, Netherese plot to rebuild their empire, and raiders prey on travelers and settlements.





Despite the harsh conditions in Anauroch, people still eke out an existence there. Remnants of Netheril returned from a long retreat to the Shadowfell and resettled with designs on spreading their power and influence once again. Nomadic peoples adapted to the trials of the region travel and live comfortably within the wastes. Travelers and fortune seekers from afar also carve out a niche in the desert, seeking fortunes and relics of the past beneath the sands and ice.

Adventures in Anauroch include themes of survival, for the struggle against the brutal conditions never relaxes. In addition to the harsh climate, vicious creatures call the wastelands home, jealously guarding the lost magic and knowledge of the realms that rose and fell in the region's past.

BEDINE TRIBES

The alternately blistering hot and biting frigid Anauroch desert was once the lush, thriving seat of the empire of Netheril. In the wake of the empire's fall, and subsequent magical devastation by wicked aberrant monsters known as phaerimm, the desolate desert slowly spreads, threatening to devour the surrounding lands.

The nomadic Bedine people have lived in Anauroch for centuries, traveling from oasis to oasis, living in tents, and following small herds of desert-dwelling animals. Most tribes live in the region known as the Sword and number around a hundred people, encountering another tribe only once or twice a year. Their knowledge of the desert and hardy survival skills command respect.

EMPIRE OF SHADOWS

Anauroch is littered with the ruins of the ancient empire of Netheril, which fell in a magical cataclysm almost 3,000 years ago. Some of these ruins lie frozen in ice, their magical secrets preserved and waiting for Netherese survivors—or bold adventurers—to discover them. In the Year of Wild Magic (1372 DR), the Netherese flying city of Thultanthar, also called the City of Shade, emerged from the Shadowfell, where it had lain hidden for centuries. Its rulers, calling themselves Shadovar, began rebuilding their long-lost empire and even returning life and growth to the desert. Thultanthar fell in 1487 DR, crashing in Myth Drannor (see “Heartlands” in this chapter), and the Shadovar empire fell with it. But survivors of that catastrophe are working to re-create the fallen city near the Shoal of Thirst.

Shade. The former city of Thultanthar, capital of the Empire of Shade, was a magical flying marvel. After it crashed, survivors of the empire built a new settlement on the slopes of the Scimitar Spires, overlooking the Shoal of Thirst. Though this city, called Shade, can't yet fly, it is inspired by old Thultanthar, and it resembles a piece of the Shadowfell transplanted to Faerûn. Its lightless avenues and sunless courtyards are shrouded in impenetrable gloom despite the desert's glaring sun, providing a comfortable home for the city's Shadovar rulers. Most explorers and traders avoid the city, as the Shadovar attack intruders.

ZHENTARIM CARAVANS

The Zhentarim carved out a niche in Anauroch long ago by forging and securing caravan routes across the desert that bypass the High Ice to the north. Its guides and guards are experienced in navigating these paths and command steep prices to guide traders and travelers safely across with their wagon trains.

Black Road. The Black Road is the main trade route that crosses Anauroch. Zhentarim garrisons and patrols monitor the road and protect the life-giving oases that dot its length. They exert immense influence over this road. They provide protection, travel stations, and access to oases but expect their tolls to be paid promptly.

ANAUROCH FEATURES

Outsiders often imagine Anauroch to be a featureless expanse of desolate sand, but in fact it is defined by a glacier in the north and a central rocky plateau, both surrounded by the wind-blown sands.

At'ar's Looking Glass. A hazardous, sweltering stretch of desert in southeastern Anauroch is At'ar's Looking Glass, named for the merciless Bedine sun god, whose face is reflected by the sand back up and into the heavens.

High Ice. The desolate glacier called the High Ice crowns the northern reaches of Anauroch. Few people live here. Arctic monsters abound on the High Ice's frosty plains, including different kinds of dragons. In spite of the danger, expeditions strike out into the glacier hoping to plunder ancient cities that have been buried in and preserved by ice.

Plain of Standing Stones. The central region of Anauroch is the Plain of Standing Stones, a plateau that overlooks the sandy desert to the south. This area is mostly waterless, covered in gravel and jagged rock and ravaged by constant, howling winds. This is where the Shadovar first discovered chardalyn—a dark, icelike crystal that absorbs magic.

Saiyaddar. One place in southern Anauroch teems with lush greenery and abundant animal life: the Saiyaddar. This verdant valley within the Sword is lined with natural springs that keep it watered, and the Bedine people guard the area as a hunting ground and safe waypoint for travelers. None of the individual Bedine tribes lay claim to Saiyaddar, and they work together fiercely to ensure that no one else tries.

Scimitar Spires. The Scimitar Spires is a range of sharp mountain peaks that abut the Shoal of Thirst and the lush Saiyaddar valley. Nestled in the northern reach of the Spires is Elah'zad, an oasis sacred to the god Eldath. A temple at the oasis is made of translucent desert rock; it's said Eldath can speak through anyone who enters the temple.

Shoal of Thirst. Shadovar magic once created and preserved a body of water here called the Shadow Sea. With Thultanthar's destruction and the fall of the empire, the magical cloud cover that protected the sea blew away, and the desert swiftly reclaimed the land. Legends speak of valuable gems once buried beneath the sea that now lie exposed to treasure hunters, but the Shoal's proximity to Shade makes excavation of those gems a dangerous task.

The Sword. When most people think of Anauroch, they think of the southern region known as the Sword, named for the bandits and raiders who maraud the region. Vicious creatures such as wyverns and purple worms are abundant.

NOTEWORTHY SITES

Anauroch is littered with ancient ruins, particularly those of fallen Netherese cities. For those willing to sift through the expanses of weathered stones and sand, the desert holds many secrets buried in time, many of which are powerful, valuable, or both.

Araugul. The southern region of Anauroch was once home to a large, expansionist goblinoid realm known as Hlundadim. The fortress-city of Araugul, also known as Goblinmount, was its capital and the home of the mysterious wizard Hlundadim, founder and leader of the realm. As weather in Anauroch grew arid and the land turned to dust, the goblins fled and the wizard vanished as mysteriously as he appeared. That was over a thousand years ago. Goblinoids and their allies have since returned to the ruins, and some live there still, defending the city from intruders.

Ascore. The ruined northern city of Ascore was once a bustling port on the shore of a now-dried sea. Now its windswept streets are haunted by undead, and the ancient blue dragon Iymrith has claimed the ruins as part of her territory. Somewhere in its depths, Ascore holds a portal into the lost Netherese city of Hlaungadath. The portal is activated by reading the final line of a carving in a stone archway.

Azirrhat. A small cluster of peaks on the southeast edge of the Plain of Standing Stones is known as Azirrhat, a word meaning “slashed rocks.” The crags are dotted with veins of gold, and prospectors sometimes brave encounters with the asabi, a territorial, nocturnal group of lizardfolk that dwell in the peaks.

Heroes' Helm. The rocky pinnacle of Heroes' Helm in central Anauroch rises four hundred feet and is shaped like the helmet of a mighty warrior, complete with two caves where the warrior's eyes would be. The caves lead to an expansive central cavern, home to an ancient blue dragon named Ghondalaath.



NETHERESE RUINS IN ANAUROCH SHOW THE INFLUENCE OF THE SHADOWFELL.
ARTIST: ROBIN OLAUSSON

Hlaungadath. One of the ruined flying cities of Netheril in Anauroch, Hlaungadath landed near the High Ice and was abandoned. In the ages since, it has been claimed by a powerful family of lamias. The city is still largely intact, maintained by the lamias and their thralls. The lamias kill most intruders, but they occasionally pick a few to ensnare with their curses and enchantments, keeping them as pets and servants. Most peoples of Anauroch know the place's reputation and stay well away, but lost knowledge and potential wealth are powerful lures for adventurers.

Lashloc. The so-called Lake of Ice is the result of subterranean hot springs that melt a sliver of the High Ice into a long, twisting lake. For creatures that live on the High Ice, Lashloc is an oasis—a place to stay warm and find liquid water without needing a fire. High winds freeze some of the lake's surface water into ice floes. Predatory creatures lair within the lake, but three insidious aboleths dominate, using the lake's unusual nature to draw in victims.

Mines of Tethyamar. On the edge of Anauroch, southeast of Addas Babar, once lay the dwarven realm of Tethyamar. This vast city branched out underground as scattered and self-reliant neighborhoods that contributed to a large and thriving whole. Four centuries ago, Tethyamar was conquered by evil wizards commanding fiends and mercenaries. Repeated attempts to reclaim the city ended in failure. The survivors fled to Daggerdale in the Dalelands. The Zhentarim had a long trade rivalry with Tethyamar when the city was lost, and Zhents have plundered the upper levels of the lost city for magical secrets and treasure.

The Shattered Tower. Long ago, phaerimm magic brought down the cloud castle of a storm giant, which crashed in eastern Anauroch. Adventurers have found the skeletal remains of storm giants and looted many of its halls. The castle is vast and inhabited by elementals and a blue dragon that either survived the crash or moved in after.

The Smokeholes. Travelers in the High Ice see huge gouts of smoke and steam rising from the Smokeholes from many miles away. These vents were created by a massive network of underground lava tubes and lakes known as the Caverns of Burning Ice, inhabited by salamanders and dragons that would otherwise find the High Ice inhospitable, including blue, brass, and red dragons. The heat from the lava creates vents in the ice above and carves out steamy grottoes that capture warm, wet air.

Untrivvin. Yetis dwell on the slopes of a mountain in the High Ice called Untrivvin, but the mountain's interior is a catacomb of meticulously crafted tunnels and halls that echo and amplify any sound made within them. This is the source of the mountain's name, which means "singing rock." The honeycomb of passages within the mountain suggest that they were carved, perhaps by an ancient civilization predating even those of the giants and dragons.

LIFE IN ANAUROCH

Simply surviving in Anauroch is a challenge. The people that dwell here rely on traditions based on generations of experience.

Banditry. Brigands, raiders, and other bandits are an unfortunate constant in Anauroch. Victims of these bandits face a choice: fight to defend their property, or allow raiders to take what they please in the hope that enough is left behind for life to continue.

Dry Death. Finding water is a struggle for anything that lives in this region. Most places are bone dry sand and dusty stone. The High Ice is a frozen glacier with no fuel for fire in sight.

Gods and Names. Deities worshiped in Anauroch are often gods of the Faerûnian pantheon who go by other faces and names. At'ar, for example, is a pitiless sun god, but scholars of other lands consider her a form of Amaunator. Eldath, a god of peaceful waters, tenaciously maintains a presence in this harsh land, much like the springs and oases that offer life among the dust.

Travels and Trade. For many in Anauroch, life is spent on the move, as staying still often means death. Bedine tribes bring their food and livelihood with them, escorting herds between oases. Others, like the Zhentarim, move back and forth over the Black Road, a dangerous but profitable route across the desert.

ARCANE EMPIRES

OVERVIEW

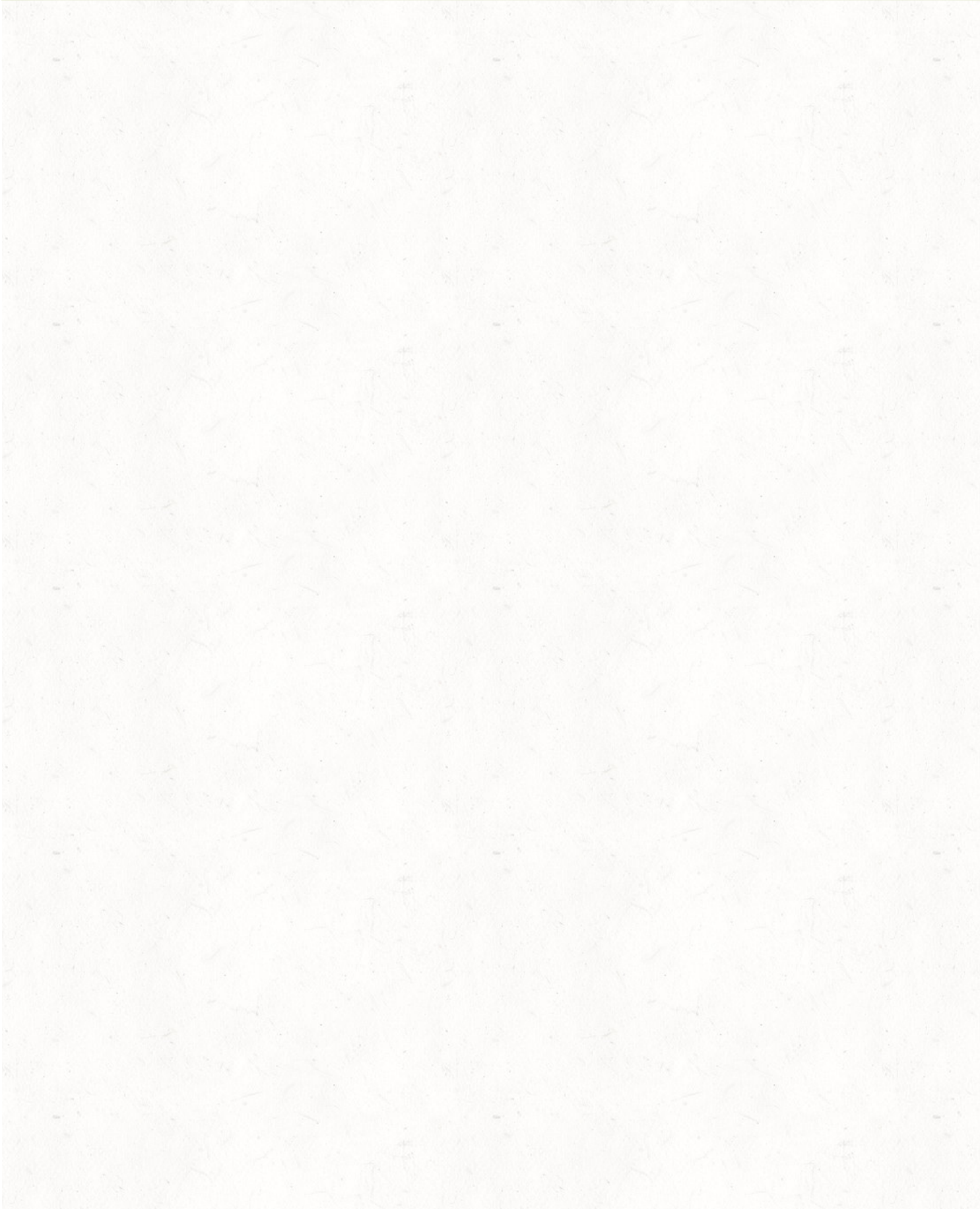
At a Glance: Arcane magic profoundly influences these cultures—sorcery in Aglarond, wizardry in Thay, and warlock pacts in Rashemen.

Realms: Aglarond, Rashemen, Thay

Languages: Aglarondan, Rashemi, Thayan

Landmarks: Immilmar, the Plateau of Thay and Thaymount, Sunrise Mountains, Velprintalar, Yuirwood

Threats: Thay and its ruler, the lich Szass Tam, have long threatened Thay's neighbors as a prelude to conquering all Faerûn.





For centuries, the Red Wizards of Thay have threatened Faerûn, but no one has felt that threat more acutely than the realms of Aglarond and Rashemen, who have fought off Thayan raids and invasions and kept Thay bottled up within its old borders. To do this, Aglarondans and Rashemi have had to learn arcane magic powerful enough to match that of the Red Wizards.

Aglarond, Rashemen, and Thay—collectively known as the Arcane Empires—are ruled by spellcasters. Although all kinds of arcane magic are practiced in these lands, each realm has its own preferred magical tradition. In Aglarond, where the legendary Simbul once ruled, sorcery reigns supreme. In Rashemen, warlocks called hathrans forge pacts with mighty spirits known as telthors. And, in Thay, the word of a Red Wizard is law. All the Arcane Empires maintain large fighting forces augmented by spellcasting leaders. The common folk of these lands, though, aren't spellcasters; magical training is a sign of status and power.

Adventures here spotlight the struggle against supernatural foes, with both heroes and villains wielding dazzling arcane magic. Sometimes this struggle takes place on the battlefield between armies. But often characters wage war in the shadows, infiltrating Thayan strongholds or sniffing out Red Wizard agents.

AGLAROND

The realm of Aglarond was founded five centuries ago, bringing together human settlers and elves of the Yuirwood in a treaty of mutual defense and friendship. For centuries, the Red Wizards of Thay have posed a constant threat, leaving Aglarondans distrusting of arcane magic. This changed under the leadership of the Simbul, a sorcerer of legendary power whose goodness—while capricious—was beyond question. Under the Simbul's leadership, individuals born with arcane magic were trained as sorcerers, and this tradition has continued after her death. Now the realm is ruled by the Simbarch Council, most of whom are arcane spellcasters.

Aglarond is famous as a place where elves and humans have come together to form a single realm. Marriage between elves and humans is common there.

Altumbel. The small human kingdom called Altumbel is often considered part of Aglarond, but its inhabitants assert its independence and distinct identity. People here make their living from the sea, and the capital, Spandeliyon, is called the City of Pirates.

Fang Light. The small peninsula that juts north of Velprintalar is known as South Fang. (Cape Dragonfang in Thesk, on the north side of the Sea of Dlurg, is called North Fang in Aglarond.) It's an isolated and parochial backwater whose inhabitants are derisively known as "Fangers" by other residents of the Arcane Empires. At the tip of South Fang stands Fang Light, a magical lighthouse maintained by a mage that guides ships in and out of the Sea of Dlurg. Pirates frequently target the lighthouse.

Sunglade. Just inside the southern edge of the Yuirwood stands the Sunglade, a double circle of standing stones decorated with elven runes. This ancient site was constructed by and sacred to inhabitants of the Yuirwood who left or died out long ago. The outer ring of larger stones bears dedications to deities of the elven pantheon, the Seldarine, while the inner stones represent the deities of long-gone human inhabitants of the Yuirwood. Though apparently abandoned, the stones remain in excellent repair, and a mystic presence lingers in the sunny glade, waiting for someone to speak to it.

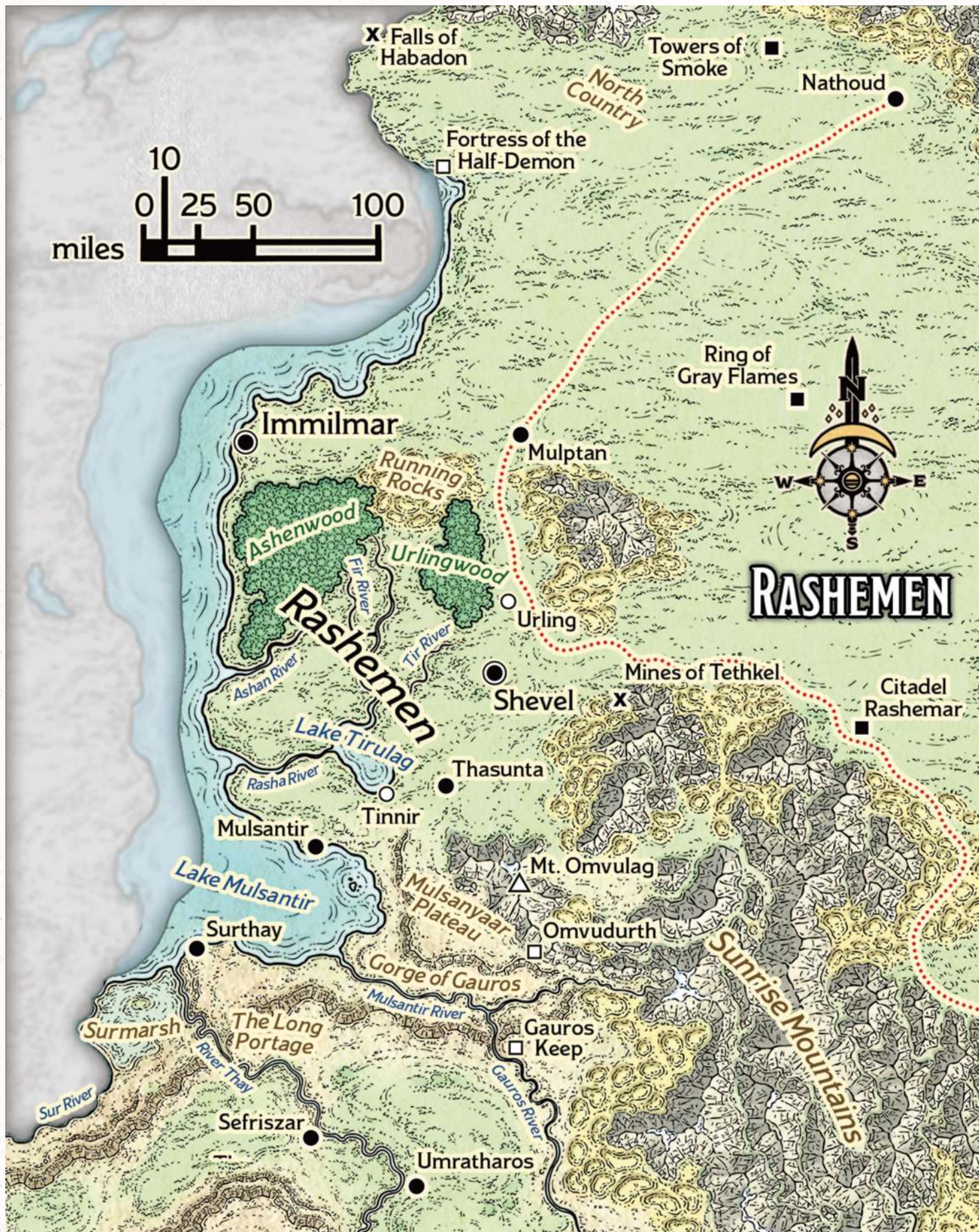
Umber Marshes. Named for the rusty water created by its iron deposits, the Umber Marshes is the border between Aglarond and Thay. Countless raids and invasions have criss-crossed this swamp, which is famous for intolerable bloodsucking insects and deadly monsters.

Velprintalar. The crown jewel of the Aglarond peninsula is Velprintalar, one of the most beautiful cities in Faerûn. The Simbarch Council, made up of sorcerers and other spellcasters, rules Aglarond from a magnificent palace of pale-green Mulhorandi stone. Sorcerers from across Faerûn come here for training.

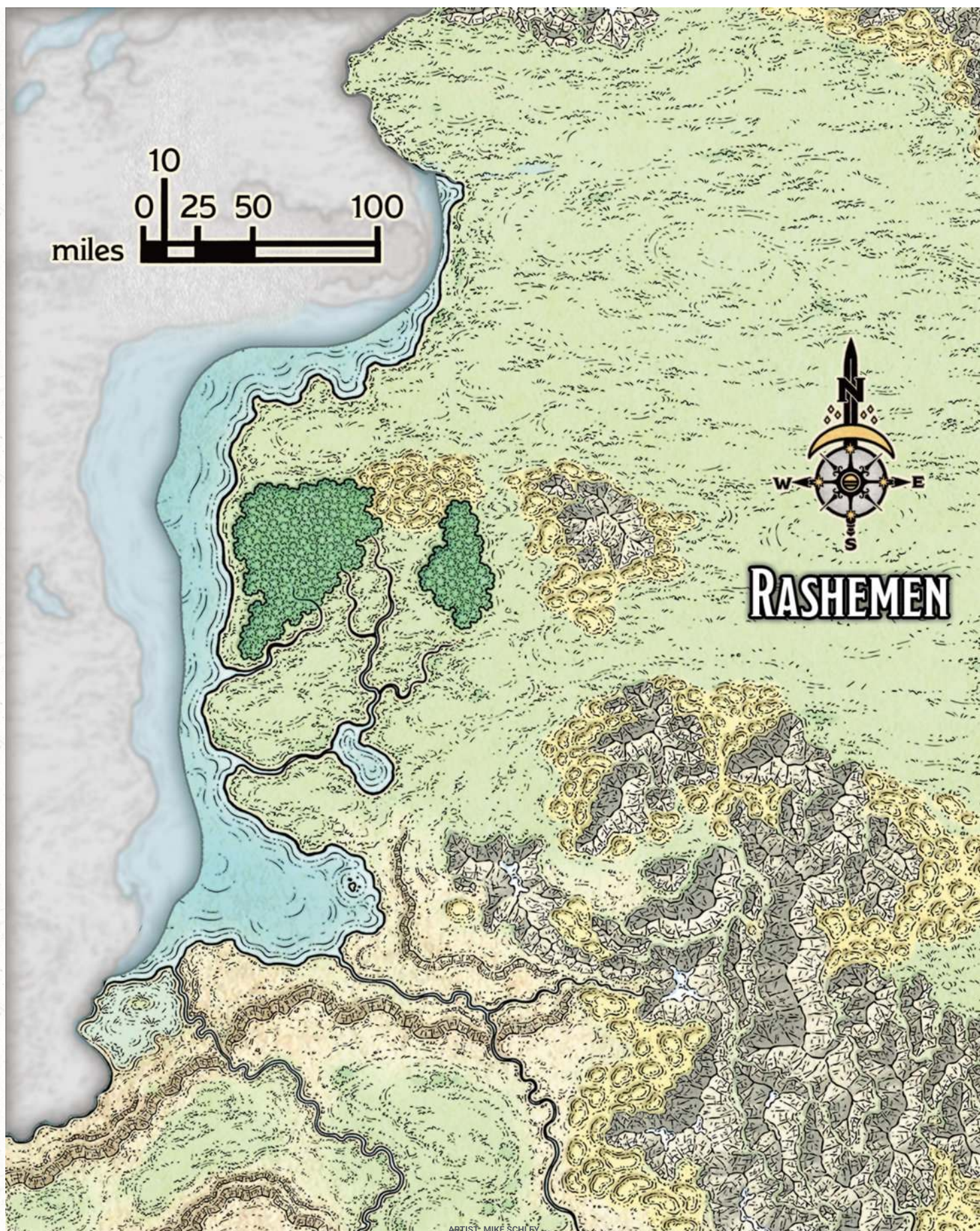
Watchwall. Between the fortress city of Glarondar and the slopes of the mountain Umbergoth stretches the fifteen-mile-long stone Watchwall built long ago by galeb duhr for the Aglarondan crown. The Watchers—guards assigned to the wall—keep a constant lookout for Thayan aggression.

Wizards' Reach. The cities along Aglarond's south coast are nominally ruled by Aglarond, but in practice the farther east one goes, the more the Red Wizards hold sway. Cross-country travel through the coastal marshes is difficult. Monsters leave the eaves of the Yuirwood and roam the coast of the Wizards' Reach.

Yuirwood. Elves who settled this forest millennia ago were called Yuir. Over centuries, humans joined them and adopted elven traditions, living among ancient Yuir ruins. These woods are protected by powerful magic that blocks scrying and detection spells. Fey crossings are plentiful, and many dangerous animals call the forest home.



MAP: RASHEMEN (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



An infamously insular realm of deep forests, high mountains, and wind-blasted heaths, Rashemen is home to magical practices considered strange by outsiders but also respected as frightfully potent. The warriors of Rashemen are berserkers known for their fierce frenzy in battle. The ruler of the realm, titled the Iron Lord, is chosen from among the berserkers by a council of mask-

wearing spellcasters called hathrans. The hathrans are leaders in many aspects of Rashemen's society, drawing their magic from pacts with powerful spirits that dwell in the realm's magical woodlands. The current Iron Lord is Mangan Uruk, who has held the position for a generation.

The people of Rashemen revere a trio of gods they call the Three: Bhalla (the Den Mother), Khelliara (the Forest Maiden), and the Hidden One. In addition to these gods, countless potent and dangerous spirits called telthor live in the forests and wild spaces of Rashemen. These gods and spirits make pacts with spellcasters, who don individualized masks representing their pacts. These spellcasters are called wychlaran ("wise ones"), in recognition of the wisdom bestowed on them in their pacts.

Traditionally, wychlaran women are called hathrans ("wise sisters") and form a governing council that selects the Iron Lord, while wychlaran men are called vremyonni ("old ones") and support the hathrans by crafting magic items and inventing new spells. These roles have relaxed as Rashemen has opened more to the outside world, and wychlaran outside of Rashemen aren't bound to these roles.

Ashenwood. By order of the hathrans, no one is permitted to live in this ancient forest, which is home to mighty spirits, intelligent animals, and fierce monsters. Rashemi enter Ashenwood to commune with or hunt these creatures, placating the spirits with gifts and offerings of food.

Citadel Rashemar. Once a mighty fortress, Citadel Rashemar was flattened over a century ago by invaders from the east who slaughtered the entire garrison of two thousand warriors. Now a coven of hags controls the ruins, served by a small army of goblins, giant animals, ogres, and other monsters.

High Country. The north end of the Sunrise Mountains is called the High Country. This perilous region is marked by wild magic, strange occurrences, and crumbling monoliths built by the ancient empire of Raumathar. These monoliths imprison demons summoned and once controlled by Narfell; now hathrans check them every year to ensure the wards don't fail. An ancient white dragon, Kissethkishan, commands these mountains, but the site of his lair is unknown.

Immilmar. Traders, diplomats, and tourists coming to Rashemen often first arrive in Immilmar, Rashemen's capital. The Iron Lord, the nominal leader of the nation, rules from a mighty castle raised centuries ago by hathran magic and warded with spells. Beyond the castle, citizens dwell in A-frame timber lodges. The city is insular, and visitors are encouraged to leave as quickly as possible.

Mines of Tethkel. The Rashemi folk who live and work in this iron mine are infamously fractious, violent, and unruly. Goblin bandits and worgs prowl the outskirts of the town looking for prey, while kobolds lair in the mines. The kobolds have spent decades building a lair fit for a dragon, and an egg in their hoard has recently hatched into a deep dragon wyrmling.

North Country. The North Country is the land between the Falls of Erech and the Towers of Smoke. While officially part of Rashemen, this land is sparsely populated and scattered with ruined settlements from the ancient realms of Narfell and Raumathar. Rashemi warriors venture into the North Country and plunder these ruins to prove their valor.

Ring of Gray Flames. Five ancient towers built by the Raumathari civilization stand in a circle known as the Ring of Gray Flames. Most are ruined, but two are intact, and mechanical sounds and grinding noises come from within. From atop all five, gray flames spout. Divine magic doesn't work within or near the towers, and the region is prowled by strange guardians—arcane spells brought to life.

Shevel. Tradespeople established the town of Shevel near the Golden Road trade route to craft and peddle their wares. Over time, the town grew into a thriving, walled city of immigrants within the otherwise-isolated realm of Rashemen. Since the fall of Citadel Rashemar, raids from the lands to the east have been a regular occurrence, and there's always mercenary work to be found in Shevel.

Sunrise Mountains. Most people consider the high-impassable Sunrise Mountains the eastern edge of Faerûn. The range towers fifteen thousand feet high and is littered with ruined towers from the ancient realm of Raumathar and mysterious wells that date to some other forgotten culture. The few passes over the mountains are exceedingly dangerous, and many lethal creatures lair in deep caves and subterranean passages.

Urlingwood. The mystical heart of Rashemen, Urlingwood is a dense, wild forest populated by telthors and supernatural beasts. Rashemen law dictates only hathrans are permitted here under penalty of death.

THAY

Thay has a reputation as a barren wasteland ruled by tyrannical wizards and populated by their undead minions. The truth is more complex.

While much of Thay remains barren, ancient weather-controlling spells bring enough rain for rivers and forests. The word of a Red Wizard is law, but most Red Wizards are more interested in self-advancement than conquest. And while undead walk openly in Thay, necromancy is just one of eight schools of magic, and Thay is home to many ordinary citizens just trying to live out their lives. All this combines to make Thay more than the caricature known throughout Faerûn, even if this exaggerated reputation is built on a foundation of truth.

Thay's infamous undead ruler, Szass Tam, rules Thay, assisted by seven other zulkirs, each a master of a different school of magic. Few dare to oppose Szass Tam, but the zulkirs and the rulers of Thay's various tharchs have considerable leeway to do as they please, so long as they don't attract Szass Tam's attention.

Aglarond and Rashemen pride themselves as realms that keep Thay in check, thwarting the Red Wizards' territorial and magical ambitions. Thayan rulers, called tharchions, try to invade Aglarond or Rashemen every decade or so, and border raids are constant.

The Citadel. A vast and ancient fortress that predates the Red Wizards of Thay, the Citadel was carved out of one of the highest mountains of Thaymount by a lizard-like people who left their images in statues and murals. The Citadel towers among lava, ash, and razor-sharp rocks and has extensive subterranean levels. For centuries, the Citadel has been Thay's greatest stronghold, and Szass Tam has claimed it for his own. In the Citadel, Szass Tam is unassailable. In the time since he moved into the Citadel, many magical atrocities have occurred there.

Delhumide. Thay began as a colony of the distant Mulhorandi empire, and Delhumide was Thay's capital. Now the old city is a dangerous ruin inhabited by fiends, evil fey, and desperate folk. These threats keep the region around the ruins sparsely populated, but adventurers brave the ruins in search of lost Thayan treasures.



SZASS TAM RULES THAY FROM THE CITADEL, HIS FORTRESS ON THAYMOUNT.
ARTIST: GAVIN O'DONNELL

Plateau of Thay and Thaymount. Central Thay stands on a vast, desolate plateau. Magic formalized by Red Wizards long ago brings rain here, which in turn allows towns, cities, and forests to survive. A second higher plateau rises from the first, culminating in the volcanic peaks of Thaymount. Only Red Wizards and their guests are allowed there.

Tax Stations. Small fortresses called tax stations dot Thay's border, roads, and internal boundaries. Soldiers at each station check identification papers and collect small but frequent tolls. A typical tax station has a garrison of thirty to fifty warriors, often including a pack of gnolls.

Tharchs. Thay is divided into districts called tharchs, many named after a prominent city in that region; every tharch is governed by a tharchion who answers to one of the eight zulkirs. The eleven tharchs are the Alaor (two islands that house Thay's fleet and shipyards), Delhumide, Eltabbar, Gauros (everything between the Gauros River and the Sunrise Mountains), High Thay (bounded by the Second Escarpment), Lapendrar (bordering Thesk and Aglarond), Priador, Pyarados, Surthay, Thazalhar, and Tyraturos.

FORGOTTEN LANDS

OVERVIEW

At a Glance: Booming trade cities dot rugged wilds in a diverse region that bursts with untapped wealth: gemstone-studded mountains, powerful primal magic, and relics of buried kingdoms.

Realms: Damara, Great Dale, Impiltur, Narfell, Thesk, the Vast

Languages: Damaran

Landmarks: Bildoobaris, the Dunwood, the Earthfast and Earthspur Mountains, the Easting Reach, the Great Glacier, Procampur, Telflamm

Threats: Teeming monsters, treacherous climes, and ancient evils repel all but the most die-hard explorers and adventurers.

Faerûn's northeast quadrant is a land of lost magical secrets, buried ancient empires, and literal mountains of unclaimed wealth. Between the Sea of Fallen Stars to the south and the Great Glacier to the north, merchant-princes and archdruids struggle for dominion over a harsh, beautiful wilderness and its bounteous resources. Even the land itself vies for supremacy; for every ruler who claims to control a realm, there lies a magical glacier, a shifting labyrinthine forest, or a monster-plagued mountain that proves nothing in these parts can truly be controlled.

The remote north—Damara, Narfell, and the Great Dale—has a well-earned reputation as a harsh land. The climate is dismal, the soil is rocky, and the food is bland. But beneath its crusty exterior, the land teems with river-size veins of gold, caverns lined with gemstones, and buried cities. Those who can endure toiling in the frozen northlands could strike it rich at any moment.

Conversely, creature comforts abound in the rich kingdoms of Impiltur and Thesk, to say nothing of the Vast's lush pastures and rolling hills of golden grain. Yet, though Impiltur and Thesk are lands of plenty, competition is fierce. Adventurers arrive in droves to cities like Procampur and Telflamm. Gold and jewels are readily abundant in the north, but those who hope to prosper in these realms should be prepared to work fast and face terrible danger.

DAMARA

In Damara, hardy folk from many backgrounds work together to turn rocky soil into tillable farmland or extract bloodstone from the mountains to the west. Currently, the usurper King Yarin Frostmantle sits smugly on the throne of the Dragonbane dynasty while his people complain about his tyranny and the growing threat from demons across the country. Despite—or perhaps because of—these facts, Damara is a thriving adventuring hub.

Bloodstone. Nowhere is the bloodstone trade stronger in the Forgotten Lands than in west Damara. Here, amid the East Galena Mountains that separate the lands of Damara from neighboring Vaasa, the ruins of a settlement called Bloodstone mark the infamous Bloodstone Pass. In its 150-year history, Bloodstone served as the battleground for monsters, assassins, warlocks, and countless others who wished to command the gem trade. Its most recent attackers razed Bloodstone to the ground. Little remains of the site except for an ancient, petrified tree that, if legends are to be believed, once bore golden leaves.

Glacier of the White Worm. Nestled near the heart of the Earthspur Mountains is the Glacier of the White Worm: a mass of ice populated by herds of titanic white remorhazes and—if rumors are to be believed—a “king worm” that rules over the others. Devotees of Ilmater from the nearby Monastery of the Yellow Rose practice their sacred remorhaz-taming rites here; a monk who entreats and rides a white remorhaz is said to bear the “gift of the worm” and is afforded great prestige. Yellow Rose sages speculate that the glacier must be magical, for it is too far south for a nonmagical glacier to exist. The source of this magic, however, remains unknown.

GREAT DALE

Between Narfell to the north and Thesk to the south are two imposing forests called the Dunwood and the Forest of Lethyr. These forests, in turn, surround a narrow strip of grassland called the Great Dale. Xenophobic druids, reclusive rangers, and enigmatic fey call this realm home and welcome few others into their domain. Those who brave the Great Dale's depths should keep their wits about them and their spellbooks close—traditional maps are all but useless in the mazelike woods, making divination magic essential for navigation.

Dunwood. Dunwood is a soupy morass of firs and oaks that thins to muskeg in the north. The peaty soil has preserved the ruins of elven and Nar cities. The Dunwood's countless secrets tempt treasure hunters bold enough to challenge the monsters rampant in the realm: zombies infused with demonic power, ancient living trees with inscrutable motives, and an extensive family of sadistic green dragons.

Dun-Tharos. This great ruin near the center of the Dunwood is the former capital of ancient Narfell. Great plazas and wrecked temples devoted to demonic powers lie half-buried in the mist-shrouded bog. Various fell powers have claimed to rule over these wretched ruins, which are practically unexplored by adventurers. That might change soon—rumors circulating in roadside inns speak of powerful Nar treasures buried in crumbling shrines and flooded conjuring chambers hidden beneath the old ruins of Dun-Tharos.

Forest of Lethyr. Mysteries abound in the gloomy Forest of Lethyr. The druids of Lethyr brook few trespassers in their sacred groves, and they resort to violence against anyone who means to exploit the land's abundant resources. Outsiders who persist in exploring Lethyr might discover Yeshelmaar, the center of civilization in the Great Dale and a testament to elven engineering. In Yeshelmaar, visitors can see architectural marvels: vast, floating herb gardens; tiered stone courts; and ornately carved grottoes with pools of crystalline spring water, to name just a few.

GREAT GLACIER

The Great Glacier originally formed from the ice necklace of the deity Ulutiu. The people who call this vast territory home are the Ulutians. Few southerners have ever interacted with them. Most outsiders who dare tread these arctic wastes instead encounter fierce monsters adapted to the glacier—white dragons, remorhazes, and even ice devils. The latter are said to be servants of an ancient and mighty priest of Auril who styles herself “the Ice Queen.”

IMPILTUR

In the past, Impiltur was among the wealthiest realms in Faerûn. Over the past century, though, the realm unsuccessfully grappled with magically altered geography and incursions from demons and demon worshipers. Now the waters of the Sea of Fallen Stars have risen again, and Impiltur's wealth and influence are returning. Hopeful commoners whisper that a lost monarch of the old ruling family will rise up to restore Impiltur to the great empire it once was.

Lyrabar. The capital city of Impiltur, Lyrabar, boasts numerous sailing academies. The academies are fierce rivals and host regattas and other contests of skill year-round. One of the academies, Waywater's Nautical University, specializes in teaching abjuration magic to seafaring mages. Lyrabar hosts the headquarters of the Warswords, chainmail-clad soldiers responsible for patrolling Impiltur's trade roads and keeping merchants safe from brigands and monsters. Warswords sometimes deputize adventurers as “swordpoints”—temporary agents of the law granted special privileges within Impiltur's borders.

NARFELL

The ruins of two ancient empires—Narfell, home to demon worshipers, and Raumathar, known for its battle mages—dot the plains where nomadic horse riders now roam, offering abundant opportunities for brave deeds and exploration. The Nars don't care about dynasties or family lines. Rather, they believe actions speak for themselves. This sensible attitude also explains most riders' preference to avoid the demon-cursed ruins of ancient Narfell. However, some now dwelling on the plains wish to reclaim ancient Narfell's powerful, sinister magic for a new generation of Nar demonologists.

Bildoobaris. In a vast, empty plain beneath the shadow of Mount Nar, tens of thousands of nomads gather for one tenday every summer for an annual trade meet, forming a vast tent city called Bildoobaris. Here, Nars barter in horses, furs, and jewelry; share news and oral histories; and celebrate the realm's all-too-brief time of plenty. In recent years, Nar demonologists have come to Bildoobaris bearing demonic relics and weapons from the buried cities of ancient Narfell in the hope of recruiting more followers.

THESK

Thesk is known to many as the Gateway to the East because it is the western terminus of the Golden Way, an ancient trade road that connected Faerûn to lands beyond the Sunrise Mountains. Although much of the Golden Way now lies in ruins, remnants of the old road still appear in the well-traveled hills between Thesk's largest cities—Telflamm, Phsant, and Tammar. Thesk's glory days as a trade metropolis are over, and Theskian wealth is now concentrated in the uppermost echelons of society, whose oligarchs exploit the working class via all manner of harebrained investment schemes.

Golden Way. Despite its history as the most famous trade route between Faerûn and lands to the east, the Golden Way is now a shadow of its former self. In Faerûn, the Golden Way begins at the western edge of Thesk, where well-maintained roads connect the cities of Telflamm, Phent, Phsant, and Tammar. Beyond Thesk's borders, the Golden Way becomes a path through the plains of Ashanath, connects to Rashemen via various ferries, and dissolves into little more than piles of stones—way markers—as it wraps around the Sunrise Mountains and continues eastward through the Hordelands and beyond. Interspersed here and there along the road are encampments and travel stations that provide shelter for those daring to make the months-long intercontinental journey.

Telflamm. The largest city in Thesk isn't controlled by that realm, but by the Shadowmasters, a religious thieves' guild that owns the city's inns and gambling halls and exercises considerable influence over Thesk's government. The Shadowmasters operate out of the House of the Master's Shadow, the largest temple to Mask in Faerûn.

THE VAST

The Vast isn't a unified realm, but a common term for the great swath of land bound by the Dragon Reach to the west, the Moonsea to the north, Impiltur to the east, and the Sea of Fallen Stars to the south. The region's name comes from Vastar, the orc kingdom that once ruled this place and warred with the surrounding dwarven and elven communities. The Vast of today is primarily peaceful farmland ringed by prosperous coastal cities. Countless treasures lie buried just beneath the land's surface, either in dwarven ruins, orc crypts, or forgotten battlegrounds.

As in other lands that touch the Earthspur Mountains, the gem trade is strong in the Vast, and many miners and adventurers alike come to the foothills seeking their fortune. The wisest are wary, for many of the tunnels that ribbon the Earthspurs connect to the Underdark, whose communities are far less welcoming of outsiders.

Procampur. One of the oldest extant settlements along the Sea of Fallen Stars, Procampur was built atop an underground dwarven town called Proeskampalar. Procampur is known for its walled city districts, with slate-roofed buildings. More than its handsome architecture, though, Procampur is reputedly the single richest independent city along the northern Inner Sea. Hundreds of gem cutters and goldsmiths call the place home, and it would be a popular target for pirates if not for its incomparable fortifications and vigilant local government.



THE WHITE WORM TAKES KARLACH, ASTARION, AND SHADOWHEART BY SURPRISE.
ARTIST: AUDY RAVINDRA

LIFE IN THE FORGOTTEN LANDS

Savage winters, perilous wilds, and fierce rivals mean that only the hardy survive long in the Forgotten Lands. Those who can meet the challenges of these realms are formidable indeed, contributing to this region's reputation as a land of grim settlers and cutthroat traders.

Adventurers' Hub. The Forgotten Lands are a popular destination for adventurers from all over Faerûn. These realms are rich with history and magic that can turn a peasant into a monarch. Not all who journey to this region yearn for fame, however; many come to remote realms like Damara to forget their old lives and forge new destinies. And the Forgotten Lands are filled with material wealth; those who seek fortune here can dredge it up from the seafloor, carve it out of a mountain, or retrieve it from a dungeon.

Bloodstone Economy. Realms in this corner of Faerûn benefit from abundant resources in nearby mountain ranges. The East Galenas, Earthspurs, and Earthfasts are rich in rare metals and gemstones, especially chalcedony, known locally as bloodstone. This gem is so plentiful—and so vital to the local economy—that these areas are sometimes referred to as the Bloodstone Lands.

Brutal Climes. Life is hard in most of the Forgotten Lands. Long, icy winters and fleeting, muddy summers make for difficult farming. Many find other ways to subsist—such as trapping, mining, or fishing—but these trades are only slightly less trying in the region's frigid climate. Fussy nobles and soft urbanites don't last long in these parts; the average denizen of the Forgotten Lands is one of the toughest, most down-to-earth people one will ever meet.

Living with the Elements. Regional natives must cope with the inhospitable climate. The nomads of Narfell, for example, migrate south during the dark months, avoiding the brunt of winter's chill. Elsewhere, such as the Monastery of the Yellow Rose in Damara, people overcome the elements by mastering magic and enlisting the aid of local fauna. (See "Glacier of the White Worm" above.)

Trade Prevails. For all their talk of autonomy and self-determination, the people of the Forgotten Lands also understand the importance of sharing goods and information. Trade in these realms begins in the mountains of Damara and plains of Narfell, from where it flows toward the Sea of Fallen Stars as a rushing river that empties into the rich ports of Impiltur and Thesk. Gold is everywhere in the Forgotten Lands, but unlike in other wealthy regions like Calimshan and the Sword Coast, folk here hold onto their wealth instead of flaunting it in the form of lavish palaces or gilded statues.

HEARTLANDS

OVERVIEW

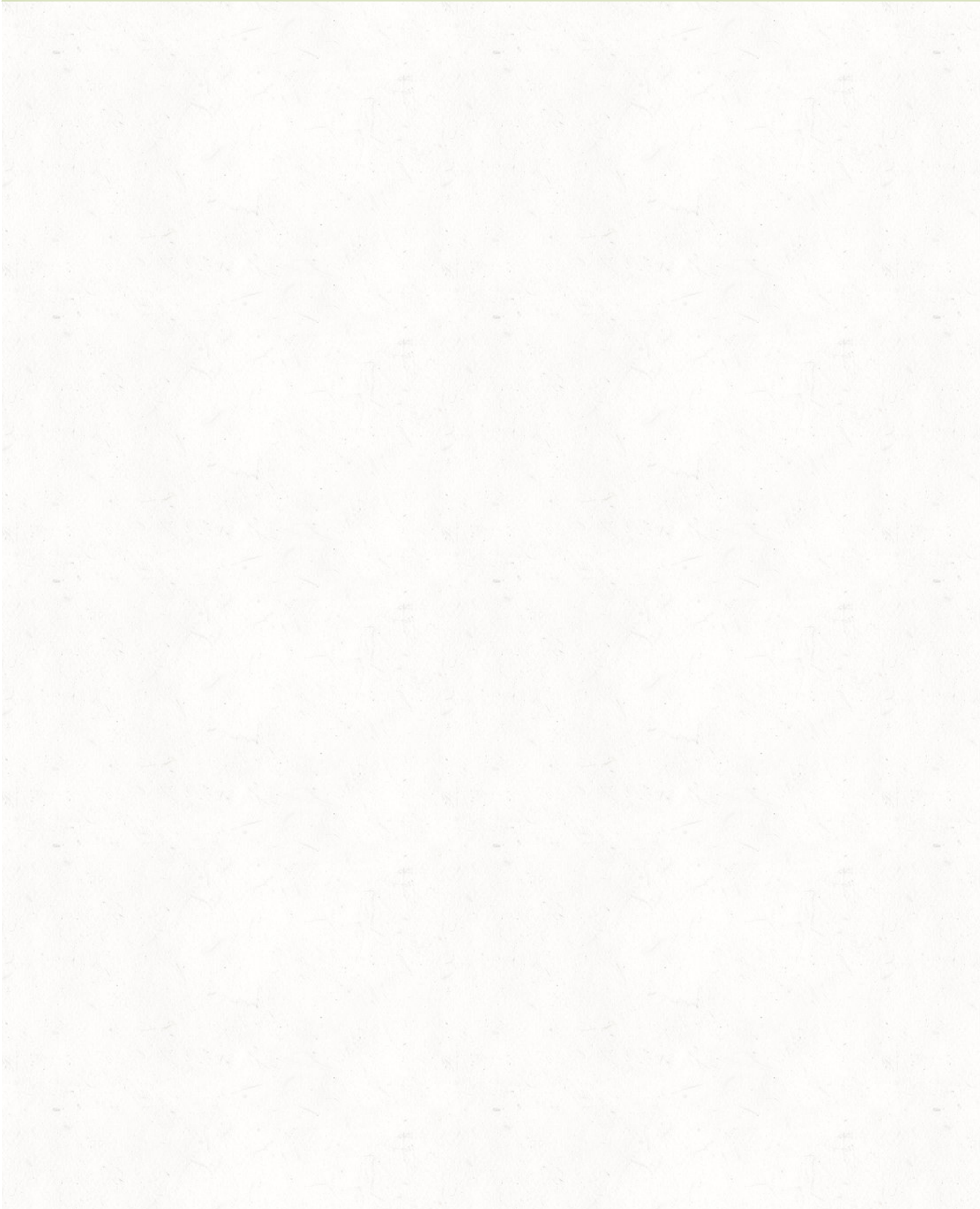
At a Glance: These are lands of chivalrous knights, dastardly despots, rich and scheming merchants, and backwoods farmers just trying to make a living.

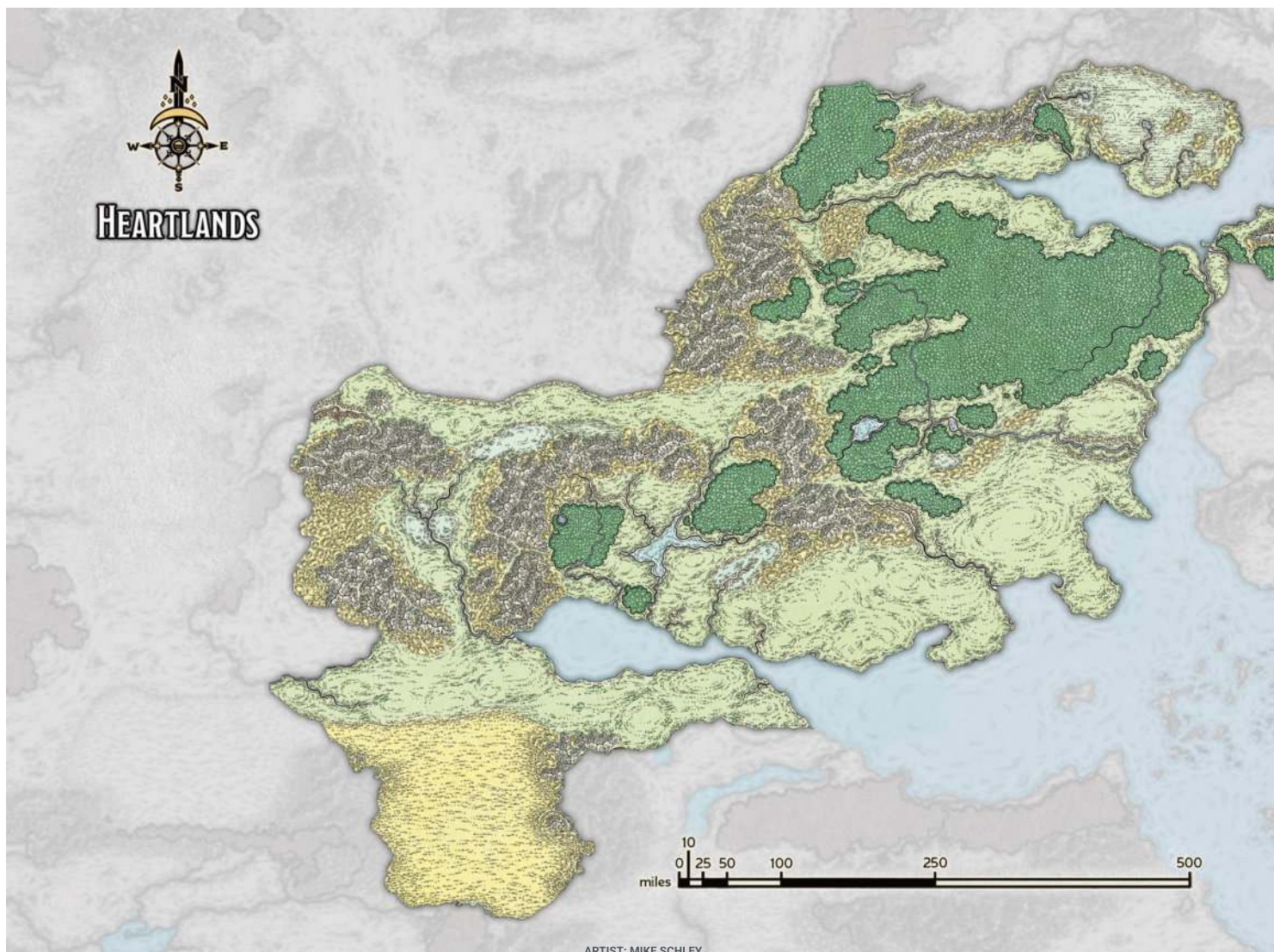
Realms: Cormyr, the Dalelands, the Moonsea, Sembia

Languages: Chondathan, Damaran

Landmarks: Cormanthor, Myth Drannor, Ordulin, Suzail

Threats: Neighbors clash over borders, and monsters creep out of the wilds.





The Heartlands comprises four realms, each with borders that have fluctuated over the centuries. Its folk have hardy frontier spirits, for their lands are ripe with crops, resources, and danger. Monsters lurk in every forest and mountain range. No matter the threat, the people of the Heartlands must be ready to defend their homes.

The Heartlands is rife with classic medieval fantasy adventure. The Dalelands lend themselves to small-scale storytelling with personal stakes, such as defending a village from vicious monsters. Cormyr and Sembia are well suited for tales of knightly warfare or noble intrigue. Adventures around the Moonsea might involve ending the reign of a cruel tyrant. For a classic D&D experience, adventurers can brave the megadungeon ruins of Myth Drannor. See chapter 2 of *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn* for more on the Dalelands and Myth Drannor.

The political landscape of the Heartlands is ever changing. Towns are absorbed into larger realms but might break out again when those realms are stretched too thin.

CORMYR

Cormyr has a legacy of chivalry and military might. Cormyr's army, the Purple Dragon Knights, is the largest of any kingdom in Faerûn. Led by the just Queen Raedra Obarskyr, the Purple Dragon Knights and their allied war wizards train to fight both on land and in the sky. As monstrous threats from the Storm Horns and the Hullack Forest increase, and as Sembia grows ever larger, Queen Raedra has paused Cormyr's expansion efforts to focus on defending and strengthening its borders. She also sends her Purple Dragon Knights across Faerûn on their amethyst dragon steeds to do good deeds, collect information, further her goals, and popularize Cormyr in the hearts and minds of common folk.

Farsea Marshes and Marshes of Tun. The ruins of two prehistoric civilizations, preceding even the elves' arrival in the Heartlands, lie in the pestilent marshes of Farsea and Tun in Cormyr's north. Explorers who have braved the marshes' monsters and magical sicknesses theorize that these societies released magical contagions on each other, resulting in their mutual destruction.

Huthduth. A monastery devoted to Chauntea, Huthduth lies in a wooded valley just south of the Farsea Marshes and is well protected with walls and militant priests. It is named after its founder, whose benevolent spirit still haunts the monastery and periodically manifests. Priests raise sheep and make wine from local berries, but the well-defended nature of the place has led many to believe Huthduth houses a secret inhabitant, a valuable treasure, or magic unknown to the rest of the world.

Shargrailer's Lair. The ancient red dragon Shargrailer was the first dracolich Sammaster, the lich leader of the Cult of the Dragon, created using the [Tome of the Dragon](#). The dracolich was destroyed more than a century ago with spellfire, but his lair, dug out of the Thunder Peaks near the headwaters of the Immerflow, remains a place of pilgrimage for the Cult of the Dragon and a nursery for red dragon wyrmlings.

Sunset Mountains. The towering Sunset Mountains are home to the Darkhold, a powerful Zhentarim stronghold. Dragons dying of natural causes often come to the Sunset Mountains to spend their last hours at an extinct volcanic caldera called the Well of Dragons. The Cult of the Dragon's base beneath the Well has been vanquished, but cult leaders have been spotted probing the ruins.

Suzail. Suzail is the capital of Cormyr. Its monarch, the skilled sword fighter Queen Raedra Obarskyr, rules from the Dragon Throne. Her royal authority is kept in check by the Suzail Writ, a fifty-year-old piece of legislation that holds Cormyr's monarch to the same laws as the rest of its citizens.

Thunder Peaks. The storm-battered Thunder Peaks were once home to Shargrailer, Faerûn's first dracolich. These days, a dracolich called Aurgloroasa, formerly a shadow dragon, lairs in an abandoned dwarven city within the mountain range. Also known as the Sibillant Shade, she commands the Cult of the Dragon's Sembian sect.

Tilverton. A rift to the Shadowfell wrought havoc on the Cormyrian town of Tilverton between the Desertsouth Mountains and the Thunder Peaks. Now, all that remains is a vast crater of writhing darkness, from which monsters of shadow stuff periodically emerge.

DALELANDS

The Dalelands is a loose collection of tiny vales called dales, each with its own territory, governance, and character. To the south, Archendale is well fortified, protecting tranquil Battledale, elven Deepingdale, and the rest of the dales from Sembian invasion, though Tasseldale still struggles from a history of Sembian influence. Distrustful Daggerdale, unassuming Shadowdale, and bountiful Mistledale sit to the west, where High Dale enjoys a defense treaty with Cormyr. Laissez-faire Featherdale, ambitious Scardale, and Harrowdale—the oldest dale—lie to the east. Every year at Midwinter, delegates from each dale convene for a Dales Council to discuss issues affecting the Dalelands at large. The location of the Dale Council changes from year to year.

Dales Compact. When human settlers first arrived in the area now known as the Dalelands, the forest of Cormanthor was already occupied by a thriving elven civilization. These wary elves proposed the Dales Compact: an agreement that allowed humans to settle on the edges of Cormanthor or in places that the great trees didn't grow, so long as they didn't cut deeper into the forest. Human mages erected a stone obelisk called the Standing Stone in Cormanthor as a symbol of unity between the two species. This date became the beginning of the Dalereckoning, or 1 DR, marking the first year of the modern Faerûnian calendar. Though Cormanthor's elven civilization fell long ago and few elves still live there, the people of the Dalelands still respect the Dales Compact.

Archenbridge. A history of Sembian invasions has led the trading hub of Archenbridge (the chief settlement of Archendale) to become the most fortified town in the Dalelands. Most goods from Cormyr and Sembia flow through this walled, trap-filled town to the rest of the dales.

Cormanthor. Cormanthor is a forest of towering trees. Most of the elves who once lived here left long ago, but some refugees of Myth Drannor's second fall remain. A swath of fungi, oozes, and rot called Moander's Road was carved through Cormanthor's northern reaches by the rampaging god of corruption and rot, Moander.

Myth Drannor. The elven metropolis of Myth Drannor fell hundreds of years ago to demonic forces. Elves briefly reclaimed it in the last century, but then the flying Shadovar city of Thultanthar crashed into it, doing extensive damage. Now demons and other monsters again infest Myth Drannor's remains. Its many ruins invite adventurers to seek the lost city's treasures or find a way to restore its mythal.

Scardale Town. The infamously lawless harbor of Scardale Town is home to several criminal syndicates and an enclave of Red Wizards. Its people still reel from the memory of the Shaking Plague, a magical contagion that decimated its population. The town is governed by Lord Kharu Aumersair, a tiefling sorcerer who claims descent from Elminster, through the infamous Zhentarim agent Scyllua Darkhope and her father, Lashan Aumersair. Scardale has a history of being ruled by invaders, and Lord Aumersair has used this resentment of outsiders to unite the town's criminal syndicates into an alliance that supports his rule.

Shadowdale Town. Though small and unassuming at first glance, many consider sleepy Shadowdale Town the Dalelands' cultural heart. It was once home to Elminster and Storm Silverhand, though neither has been seen in town for years. These days, a growing community of orcs from the River Ashaba have settled in Shadowdale. Lady Khara Sulwood rules from the twisted Tower of Ashaba, with the help of the elf warrior Tharinell, her reliable bodyguard and adviser.

MOONSEA

Named after its central body of water, the Moonsea is a region of disparate cities ruled by cruel despots. It is a land of people hardened long ago by the assaults and schemes of chromatic dragons. The people of the Moonsea view the rest of Faerûn and even other Moonsea cities with distrust. In turn, people elsewhere in Faerûn view these folk as unfriendly and dangerous.

Hillsfar. The independent walled city of Hillsfar, on the southern shore of the Moonsea, is busy, prosperous, and secured by a mercenary company called the Red Plumes. Until recently, Hillsfar's Great Law of Humanity barred non-humans from entering the city. After a revolution deposed First Lord Torin Nomerthal, his successor, Vuhm Yestral, revoked the law. Hillsfar still suffers from strained relations between humans and other species, and progress is slower than Vuhm would like. In the wake of Zhentil Keep's decline, Hillsfar's only rival for dominance of the Moonsea is the city of Mulmaster.

Melvaunt. A cloud of smog hangs over the austere and unwelcoming Moonsea city of Melvaunt courtesy of its hundreds of forges. This polluted merchant town is a smith's haven and a den of crime.

The Moonsea. Rumors persist of isles that rise from the cold, purplish depths of the eponymous Moonsea on certain nights of the year. An underwater tower called the Bell of the Depths is said to be guarded by the ghosts of the first humans who settled the Moonsea region. Its spire is visible from the water's surface, and it tolls on foggy nights with the sound of a ghostly bell heard as far as Hillsfar.

Mulmaster. Sixteen wealthy nobles called the Council of Blades rule the unabashedly imperialist Moonsea city of Mulmaster. At their disposal are the Hawks, a clandestine group of spies and assassins; the Cloaks, Mulmaster's official mage guild; and the Soldiery, the city's armed forces. The Church of Bane is Mulmaster's dominant faith.

Point Iron. The dwarven iron mine known as Point Iron was taken over by duergar more than a century ago. In their mining, the duergar found gold, which they craft into fabulous jewelry that fetches exorbitant prices throughout the Moonsea and Sembia. This trade has also given the psychic duergar access to powerful individuals they can bring under their mental control.

Quivering Forest. For a time, travelers who entered the Quivering Forest emerged in Barovia, a Domain of Dread within the Shadowfell (described in *Curse of Strahd* and *Van Richten's Guide to Ravenloft*). The mists of Barovia have since cleared, but terrifying werewolves, vampires, and other creatures from that realm still haunt these woods. Barovia's influence has even granted new powers to Jeny Greenteeth, a legendary hag of the forest.

Thar. Valiant orcs fight to defend their territory from ogres, manticores, and perytons in the rocky moorland known as the Thar. Eons ago, this land was a unified orc kingdom. Legend has it that Vorbyx's Hammer, a great weapon carried by the first king of Thar, lies hidden somewhere here. Thar's orcs believe that the next orc to wield it will restore the kingdom to its former glory.

Zhentil Keep. Once the seat of Zhentarim power across Faerûn, Zhentil Keep was razed over a hundred years ago by Shadovar forces. Eventually the Zhents returned and rebuilt it. Zhentil Keep is again a flourishing trade city, but Zhentarim leaders have been slow to return there. Zhentarim soldiers are sent to Zhentil Keep for training, and the governing council is conspiring to regain influence in the Moonsea from rivals Hillsfar and Mulmaster.

SEMBIA

The young realm of Sembia aggressively pursues both trade and territorial expansion. Merchant councils govern many of its cities, from gothic Saerlooon to lavish Selgaunt. Sembians relish the art of negotiation, and coins create friendships fast here. But the lack of coins makes those friends disappear just as quickly. Outside Sembia's cities, orchards, vineyards, and farms sprawl throughout the realm's countryside.

Ordulin. Half a century ago, a dale called Moondale enjoyed a prosperous trade relationship with neighboring Sembian cities before being peacefully annexed into Sembia. It was renamed Ordulin and now serves as Sembia's capital. Every seven years, the merchant councils of Sembia's other cities convene and appoint an Overmaster from their ranks to govern Sembia from Ordulin. They have gone to great lengths to foster Sembian pride in the city and erase its cultural roots as a former dale.



THE RUINS OF MYTH DRANNOR LIE AT THE HEART OF CORMANTHOR.
ARTIST: TITUS LUNTER

LIFE IN THE HEARTLANDS

Some of Faerûn's greatest threats and most inspiring alliances have sprung up in the Heartlands. These histories influence the region to this day.

Dragons. Dragons were the first occupants of the Heartlands, before even the elves of Cormanthor, and dozens of active dragon lairs litter the wilds, as do countless remnants of long-abandoned lairs. The Moonsea region sees much dragon activity; its sea was even once called the Sea of Dragons. Cormyr has seen a recent uptick in dragon attacks from the Storm Horns, and the Cult of the Dragon is steadily gaining influence in Sembia.

Expansionism. While cities of the Sword Coast and the North enjoy relative harmony among each other, the same can't be said for the realms of the Heartlands. Sembia and Cormyr have expanded relentlessly over the centuries and taken turns encroaching on each other's territories. The Moonsea's leaders ruthlessly control their individual cities and plot to overthrow each other to grab more power. The Dalelands sits in the middle of it all, trying to avoid the attention of realms and factions that would eagerly invade the dales if it wasn't so difficult to march an army through the forest of Cormanthor.

Pools of Radiance. Pools of radiance are open wounds in the Weave—powerful, naturally occurring fonts of raw magic. The water of these pools shimmers and shines with an unearthly glow. Nearly all of Faerûn's pools of radiance are in the Heartlands region. Several evil entities throughout Faerûn's history have found ways to channel the immense power of the pools—especially the pool of radiance beneath the Moonsea town of Phlan—to enact devastating rituals. A pool of radiance can be destroyed only with an artifact called the *Gauntlets of Moander*, but its whereabouts are unknown.

LANDS OF INTRIGUE

OVERVIEW

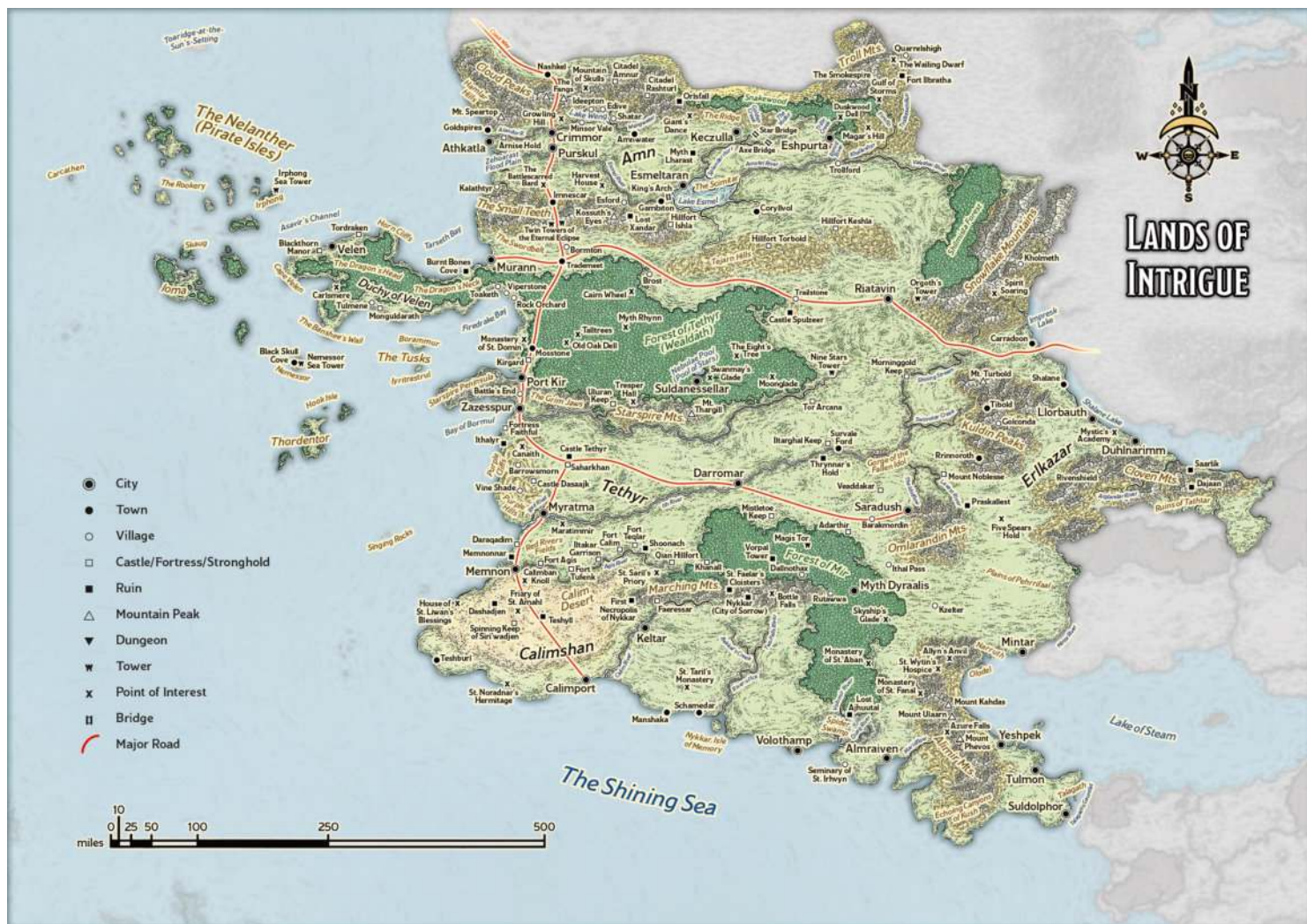
At a Glance: These wealthy mercantile realms each keep a close eye on each other while carefully tending to their own political turmoil.

Realms: Amn, Calimshan, Tethyr

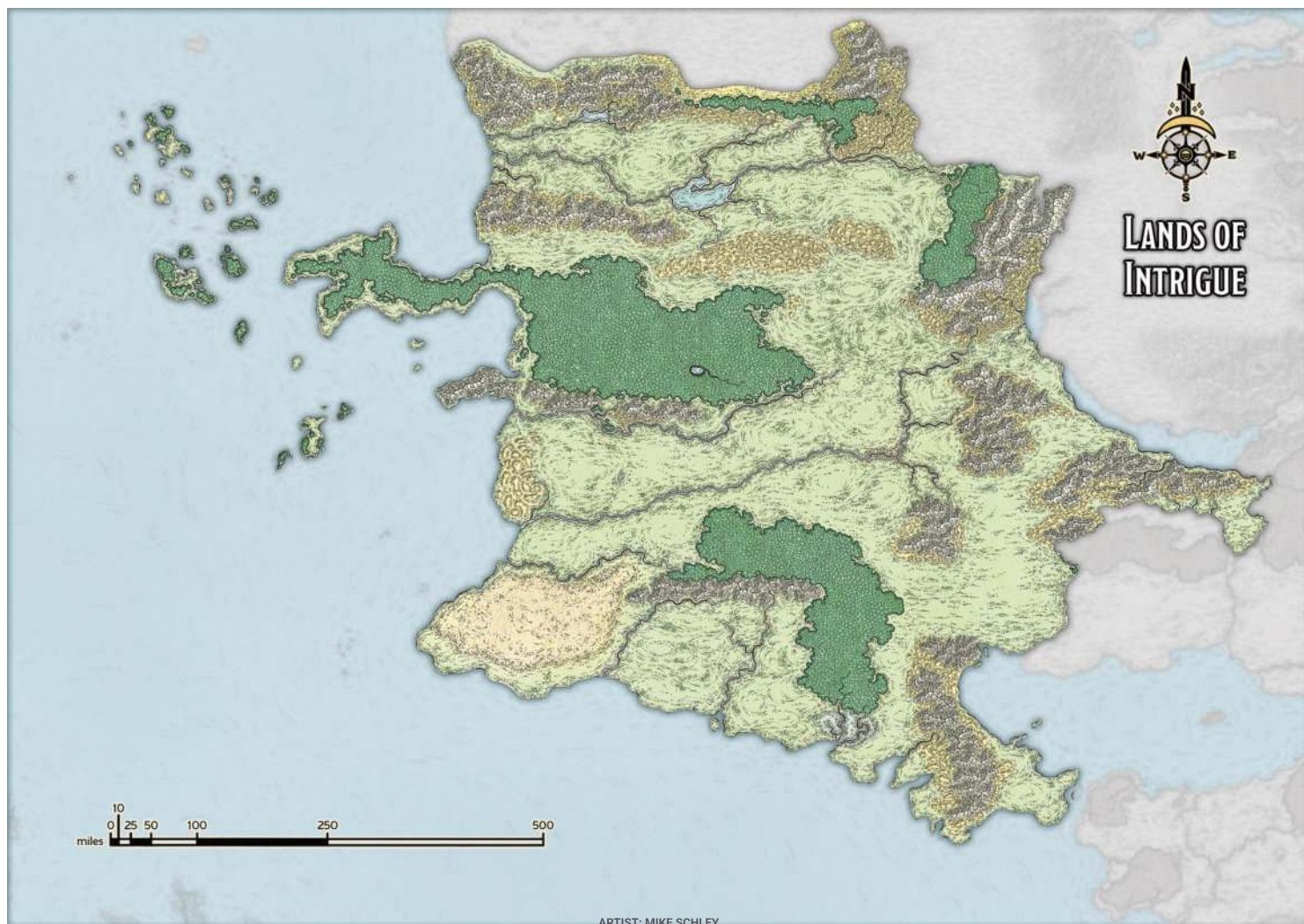
Languages: Alzhedo, Chondathan

Landmarks: Athkatla, the Calim Desert, Calimport, Darromar, the Forest of Tethyr (Wealdath)

Threats: Pirates and bandits harry these lands with raids while genies and beholders scheme from afar.



MAP: LANDS OF INTRIGUE (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



The Lands of Intrigue maintain civil relations with each other, even as they jostle for authority over Faerûn's commerce. Though Amn, Calimshan, and Tethyr might not have raised swords against each other in the last few hundred years, they've spied on each other, made aggressive trade deals, and exchanged land with each other in delicate dances of thinly veiled mistrust.

Each realm grapples with its own internal web of intrigue. Merchant houses ally with and pit

themselves against each other in dizzying configurations to assert their influence over Amn. Questions of bloodline and right to rule swirl around the queen of Tethyr. The four genie factions of Calimshan bristle at the increasing self-reliance of the realm's folk—especially Sultana Songal, Calimshan's ruler.

Adventures in these lands often play out against a backdrop of political machination. Characters might hobnob with influential nobles at galas, strike backdoor bargains in seedy undercities, or spy on one noble genie while working for another. Perhaps they'll infiltrate the Shadow Thieves, a network whose meddling is felt throughout the Lands of Intrigue.

Each of the three realms in the Lands of Intrigue has at least one active port city and trade routes to go along with it. News travels as swiftly as goods, but deserts, forests, and mountain ranges make it difficult for armies to cross from one realm to another.

AMN

No realm in Faerûn is wealthier than Amn. Unlike their neighbors—which pursue wealth for the comfort it brings—Amnians seek and spend wealth as a symbol of status. Amn's governing body is the anonymous Council of Five, said to consist of the heads of Amn's most influential merchant families. Open worship of Cyric is legal here, thanks to deep ties between the Church of Cyric and the council, and Amn has long had imperial ambitions. Spellcasting, on the other hand, is forbidden. The law permits only priests of Cyric and the Cowled Wizards—specialized mages in service to Amn's merchant houses—to use magic.

Athkatla. Athkatla, the City of Coin, is the capital city of Amn and a place of vast riches. Things illegal, immoral, and despicable pass without comment in this busy port city so long as the price is right. The Council of Five rules from a fortress here called the Council House.

Cloud Peaks. The Cloud Peaks teem with iron, precious metal, and gems—but also with remorhazes and white dragons. Frost giants sometimes scale the mountains' crags for ceremonies or games.

Esmeltaran. Amnian nobles and wealthy tourists flock to the beautiful city of Esmeltaran during the winter months to bask in the warmth of Lake Esmel's hot springs. A young copper dragon has begun pulling pranks on the lake's visitors, who mistake the dragon for a legendary monster of the lake named Esmelda.

Myth Lharast. The city of Myth Lharast was sacred to Selûne for three centuries, home to benevolent lycanthropes as well as elves and other folk. Protected by a powerful mythal, it nevertheless fell to internal dissent many centuries ago. As evil wizards and their undead and elemental minions conquered the city, Selûne removed Myth Lharast from the world, placing it in a demiplane. Now the city can be accessed only when the moon is full.

Orgoth's Tower. Hubris claimed Orgoth the Tainted, a prodigious wizard who summoned three unruly fiends and died at their hands. Rumor has it that his spellbook, the *Alcaith*, still lies in Orgoth's Tower. Elves of the Shilmista Forest warn against searching for it, since the three fiends are rumored to still haunt the tower's halls.

Small Teeth. To the south, temples of Cyric called the Twin Towers of the Eternal Eclipse sit high on each side of the Small Teeth mountains' central pass. The ancient blue dragon Iryklathagra, also called "Sharpfangs," sleeps deep within the Small Teeth, awakening once a century. Killing the dragon is a fool's errand; instead, adventurers try to loot the many hoards scattered throughout her sprawling lair.

Snakewood. Priests of Eldath inhabit Duskwood Dell in the serpent-infested Snakewood. Two years ago, a conniving beholder named Sersentrych slew the green dragon Ringreemeralxoth and moved into his lair. Sersentrych has since indoctrinated the dragon's hatchlings into loyal servitude.

Troll Mountains. Trolls aren't the only dangers in the Troll Mountains. Balagos "the Flying Flame," an ancient red dragon feared throughout the Lands of Intrigue, lairs in the extinct Smokespire volcano. The Gulf of Storms, a lightning-wracked canyon and pilgrimage site for worshipers of Talos, lies nearby. Wind whistles through the hollow eyes, ears, and mouth of the Wailing Dwarf, a mile-high mountainside carved to depict an enormous dwarf. An abandoned, ooze-infested dwarven city lies beneath this monument and is the setting for *Lancameth's Last Expedition*, a famous ballad detailing the death of Bryam Lancameth and his four companions, armed with potent magic items that have never been recovered.

CALIMSHAN

Tradition and innovation coexist in Calimshan under the reign of Sultana Songal. Calimshan's people have a fraught and complex relationship with the realm's four genie factions. The genies have both subjugated and fought alongside the people of Calimshan at various points in the realm's ten-thousand-year history. While Calishites of the desert and other wilderness areas rely on genie magic for survival, inhabitants of Calimport have instead embraced and improved on innovations from Lantan, resulting in a new wave of *Mechanical Wonders* that have transformed city life.

Calimshan has the largest population of genasi (described in *Mordenkainen Presents: Monsters of the Multiverse*) of any realm in Faerûn; some of these genasi live among the realm's people, while others reside with the four genie factions. See chapter 4 of *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn* for more on Calimshan.

Alimir Mountains. Calimshan fought back against beholders from the Alimir Mountains thousands of years ago in a series of conflicts called the Eye Tyrant Wars. Nearly fifty beholders live together in a massive hive in those mountains today, biding their time while rebuilding their numbers.

Calim Desert. Eons ago, when the immortal genies Calim and Memnon were imprisoned in the *Calimemnon Crystal*, the magical backlash transformed the surrounding environs into the inhospitable Calim Desert. Wild magic and sandstorms wreak havoc here.

Calimport. Calimshan's capital city Calimport is among the oldest cities in Faerûn. This famous trade hub teems with wonders magical and mechanical. Genies must swear a magically binding pact with Sultana Songal, called the Sultana's Oath, to enter the city. Cults, criminals, and illicit markets lurk in the Muzad, Calimport's undercity.

Forest of Mir. The Forest of Mir hides Myth Dyraalis, a thriving city with deep ties to both the Feywild and the plane of Arborea. A powerful mythal allows only those with fey ancestry to see this so-called Phantom City. Nearby lies Dallnothax: a mostly subterranean settlement devoted to Vhaeraun, a drow god of thievery.

Genie Strongholds. The four genie factions of Calimshan lair in fantastic strongholds scattered around the realm. The dao fortress of Olympus Dag stands in the Marching Mountains; the marid city of Maran Saya lies deep beneath the waves of the Shining Sea; the flying djinni city of Burin Bir and its trailing palaces drift above the Forest of Mir; and the efreeti fortress of Gozva Ka stands in the Calim Desert, hidden with shimmering illusions. These palaces are ruled by noble genies and are also home to a variety of aides and servitors who are adapted to the genies' preferred environments.

Marching Mountains. The Marching Mountains house the remains of the First Necropolis of Nykkar: an ancient site where early Calishites prepared their revered dead for burial.

Nykkar, Isle of Memory. In more modern times, Calishites have established many mausoleums and cemeteries in a necropolis on the so-called Isle of Memory, named Nykkar after the ancient necropolis in the mountains. Nykkar is maintained by priests of Kelemvor and serviced by ships known as the Death Fleet. A crew of engineers maintain a lighthouse on the island's northern tip.

Spider Swamp. Zanassu the Spider Demon was vanquished from Calimshan's Spider Swamp on the southern coast long ago, but quasits and other demons still infest this fetid area. The swamp is also home to reclusive spider-people known as araneas; so far, araneas have remained hidden, using magic to conceal their identity when they enter towns to trade. (Araneas are detailed in *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn*.)

TETHYR

Though not as much of a mercantile superpower as its neighbors, Tethyr enjoys a strong relationship with the elves of the Wealdath, who shun Amn and trade rare goods exclusively with Tethyr. Tethyr is a feudal realm of lords and vassals, and its royal line appeals to the divine patronage of Siamorphe, a demigod of nobility, to assert its right to rule. When Queen Anais Rhindaun died of old age, her half-niece and adopted daughter, Ysabel Linden, assumed the throne. Ysabel has guided Tethyr with a courageous heart and steady hand for three years, but she hasn't received the blessing of Siamorphe. Some of Tethyr's nobles whisper that Ysabel is too far removed from the Rhindaun bloodline—and Siamorphe's favor—to rule.

Castle Tethyr. Castle Tethyr was the historical home of Tethyr's royalty before it burned down some 150 years ago. Now, an elder beholder named Xithallowthlan schemes within the dungeons below the castle. Hundreds of eyes cover Xithallowthlan's body—a blessing from the Great Mother, a patron deity of beholders.

Darromar. Queen Ysabel Linden rules the realm of Tethyr from Faerntarn Palace in the capital city of Darromar. An aasimar named Saerwyn the Bright has recently arrived in Darromar to challenge Ysabel's right to the throne, claiming to be a child of the demigod Siamorphe. Whether Saerwyn is truthful or a pretender remains to be seen.

Forest of Tethyr. Many call the Forest of Tethyr "Wealdath," an Elvish phrase meaning "unspoiled woods." This vast forest is home to monsters, fey, the peaceful gold dragon Garlokantha, and two wood elf tribes: the Suldusk and Elmanesse. The Suldusk have their own treetop city, Suldanessellar. The Elmanesse seek to restore the mythal around the will-o-wisp-infested elven tomb city of Myth Rhynn.

Omlarandin Mountains. Omlar gems can be found only in the Omlarandin Mountains. These rare turquoise gems hold magic like a sponge, making them exceptional components for crafting magic items. The demand for omlars among Calimshan's genie lords has run most of the mountain's existing mines dry, prompting miners and adventurers to delve ever deeper into the mountain range.

Purple Hills. No one in the Lands of Intrigue makes finer wine than the halflings of the Purple Hills, on Tethyr's southwest coast. These halflings also recently reopened Canaith, a legendary bard academy. Bards travel from far and wide to study their craft there.

Starspire Mountains. Balagos, a red dragon of the Troll Mountains, keeps some of his hoard at a secondary lair called Mount Thargill in the Starspire Mountains. Five years ago, Balagos captured a young bronze dragon named Ixolothingeir, tore off his wings, and commanded him to guard this lair or die.

Velen. Velen is haunted, but its citizens don't mind. Many of the city's dead remain there as ghosts for unknown reasons, coexisting with the living. The autonomous Duchy of Velen gained its independence from Tethyr in 1424 DR. It maintains a friendly relationship with its western neighbor, using its impressive naval fleet to defend itself and Tethyr from Nelanther pirates.



KAYA EDUCATES
ARTIST: EKATERINA BURMAK

LIFE IN THE LANDS OF INTRIGUE

Folk in the Lands of Intrigue are more interested in politics than the mysteries of the lands themselves.

Nelanther Pirates. Hordes of lizardfolk, ogre, and minotaur pirates surge forth from the Nelanther Isles (detailed further in the “Trackless Sea” section of this chapter) to raid shipping from the Lands of Intrigue. Merchants from all three realms commission adventurers to sail forth into those islands and recover stolen goods.

Night Bandits of Erkkazar. The Lands of Intrigue’s eastern reaches suffer raids from the neighboring realm of Erkkazar. Armies of vampiric bandits slip into merchant camps and leap over city walls in the dead of night. Those who journey to Erkkazar find no trace of these bandits or the pilfered goods. The vampiric nature of the Night Bandits remains a secret outside Erkkazar, for the locals are too frightened of their vampire masters to betray them to outsiders.

Rise and Fall of Murannndin. In the late fourteenth century, an oni couple conquered the city of Murann in southwest Amn and founded Murannndin, a short-lived empire of marauding orcs and ogres who sought living sacrifices for their gods Gruumsh and Vaprak. Amn and Tethyr’s forces slew the founders and reclaimed nearly all of the land by the late fifteenth century DR. However, the couple’s son—a brooding oni named Avasskyth—still rules over the villainous city of Murann. The city is surrounded by a formidable wall made of thick, sharpened tree trunks.

Shadow Thieves of Amn. The ruthless Shadow Thieves began as an ordinary thieves’ guild in Waterdeep. When the Lords of Waterdeep assassinated many of the Shadow Thieves’ founding members and drove the rest out, the organization reestablished itself in Amn. It thrived in Athkatla, where they became a household name and forged covert connections with Amn’s ruling Council of Five. Now, the Shadow Thieves pulls strings everywhere in the Lands of Intrigue and plot vengeance on the Lords of Waterdeep. See chapter 6 for more information on the Shadow Thieves.

Shanatar. Before the Lands of Intrigue existed, there was Shanatar. This ancient shield dwarf kingdom sprawled across the region’s Underdark and contained eight subkingdoms, each dedicated to one of Moradin’s divine children. Duergar and other Underdark invaders brought ruin to Shanatar long ago. The only kingdom still standing is Iltkazar, situated beneath the Omlarandin Mountains. The god Clangeddin Silverbeard watches over Iltkazar, and a wise ancient silver dragon called King Mith Barak rules over the kingdom. Mith Barak seeks the return of the [Wyrmskull Throne](#), a powerful Shanatar artifact that went missing eons ago.

THE NORTH

OVERVIEW

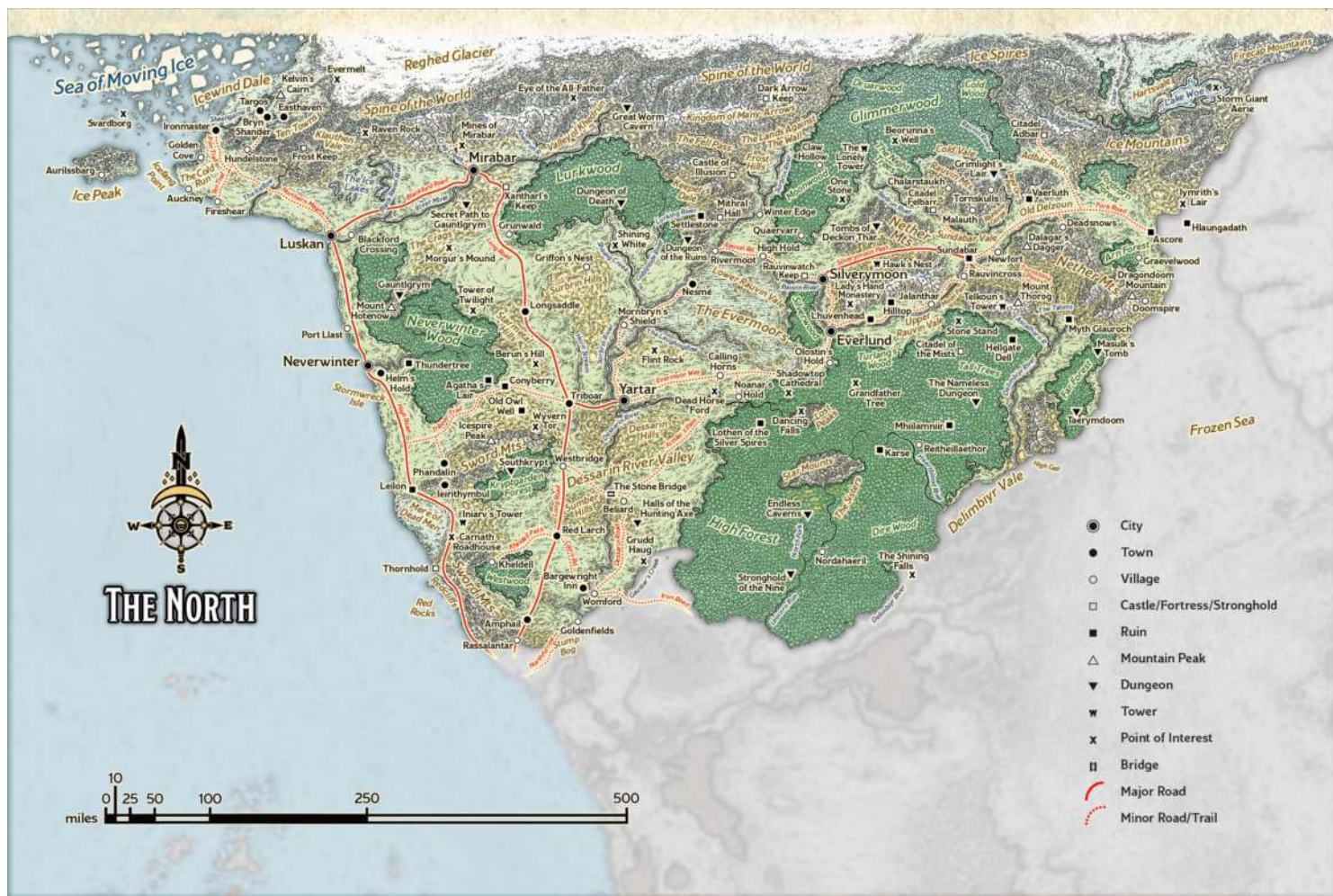
At a Glance: In this harsh and beautiful wilderness, nothing lasts and survival is a day-to-day concern.

Realms: Icewind Dale, Kingdom of Many-Arrows, Lords’ Alliance, Luskan, Menzoberranzan, northern dwarfholds, Savage Frontier

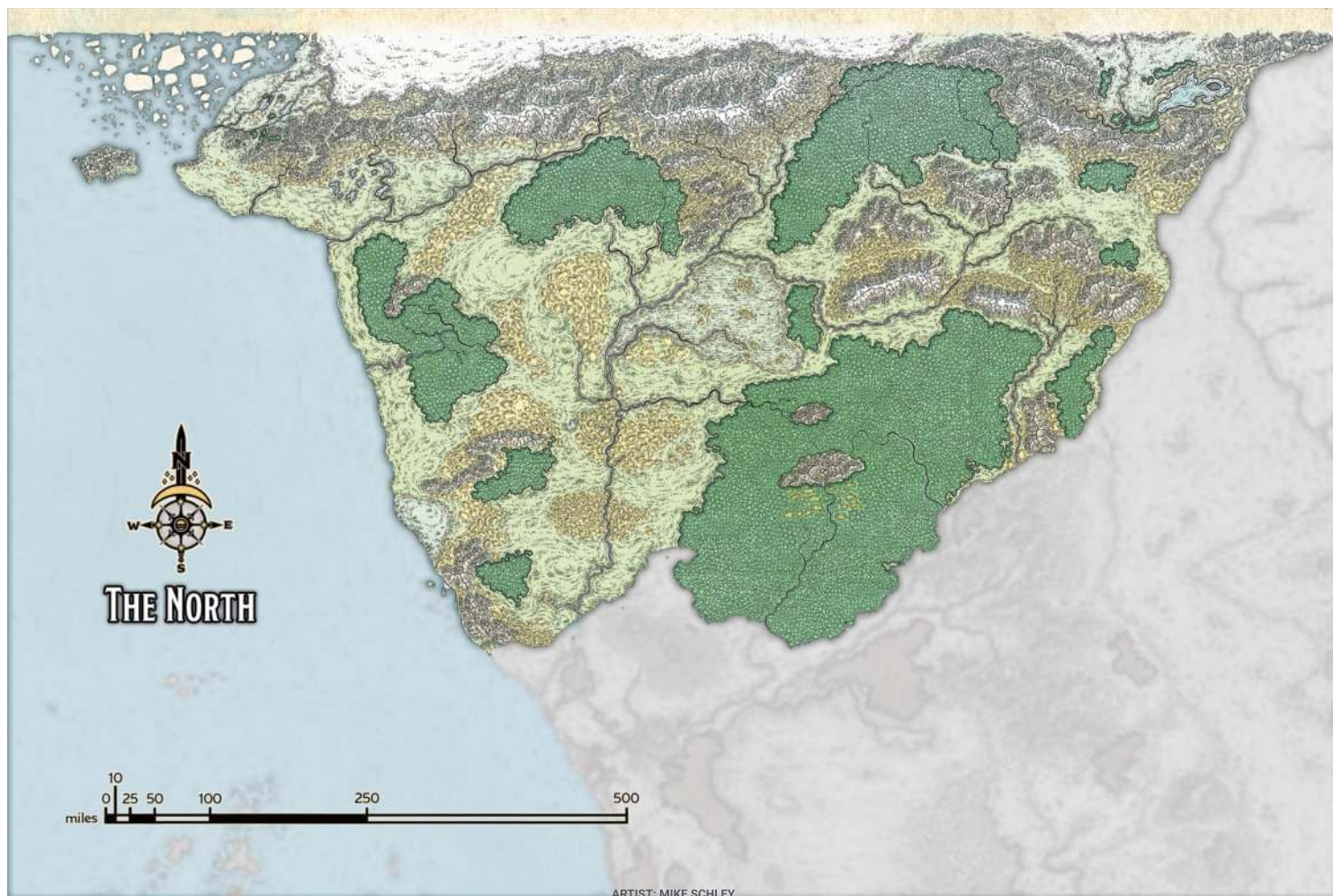
Languages: Bothii, Chondathan, Illuskan, Reghedjic

Landmarks: The Evermoors, Gimmerwood, Nether Mountains, Reghed Glacier, Sea of Moving Ice, Spine of the World Mountains

Threats: [Nature](#)’s wrath, giants, dragons, roving marauders, and the menace of the Underdark.



MAP: THE NORTH (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



Nothing lasts forever in the North. Frost giants, white dragons, and marauders threaten the land, and winter is always near, ready to destroy whatever remains. The region was ravaged by the War of the Silver Marches—a sweeping conflict between Many-Arrows, Menzoberranzan, and the cities of the Lords' Alliance—and again more recently by violence between giants. And yet, the North abounds with fertile river valleys, mineral deposits, deep forests, and startling natural beauty. It is a wilderness of violent extremes, hidden wonders, and isolated strongholds struggling to survive against all odds.

The land is vast, cold, and lawless, and civilization survives only through fear, toil, and blood. Independent strongholds act as city-states in loose alliances. Outside fortress walls, farmers, prospectors, and settlers eke out hardscrabble lives, while roving nomads do what they must to survive while honoring their traditions. Ancient dwarfholds and forest ruins echo with memories of vanished realms. People in the North worship fierce gods and fear the freezing dark.

Adventures here focus on survival above all, both individual and communal. Here, adventurers must fight off invaders and face natural disasters as they carve out a foothold in an inhospitable land. They broker tenuous peace between hostile fortresses, uncover frozen secrets, battle dragons and giants, and defy fate to build something that can survive the cold.

The North is criss-crossed by fragile alliances between independent cities and strongholds in loose confederations for mutual aid, defense, and trade. These independent city-states look to their own interests first, defending and developing their own resources. They cooperate with allies not from fealty or honor, but from shared self-interest and to increase their own chances of survival.

ICEWIND DALE

At the far northern end of the Sword Coast, beyond the Spine of the World, lies Icewind Dale. Bounded by the Reghed Glacier to the east and the gnashing maw of the Sea of Moving Ice to the north and west, Icewind Dale is a wind-scoured waste marked by the solitary peak of Kelvin's Cairn. The rough-hewn Ten-Towns band together to harvest hidden abundance: gems, timber, and the valuable bones of knucklehead trout. Would-be heroes and villains alike come to Icewind Dale seeking frost giant artifacts, Underdark wonders, and Netherese secrets, but most run afoul of fierce monsters, locals, and priests of Auril—to say nothing of chardalyn, a blighted material capable of twisting minds and spirits in pursuit of power. See *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn* for more on Icewind Dale.

Bryn Shander. Foremost among the Ten-Towns—Icewind Dale's cluster of small settlements—Bryn Shander is the local center of trade and government. It serves as a walled refuge for those fleeing nearby towns in times of crisis.

KINGDOM OF MANY-ARROWS

Self-crowned King Orrusk Homebringer is working to restore an orc domain in the far north, beginning with the shattered fortress of Dark Arrow Keep. The Kingdom of Many-Arrows united the disparate orc tribes of the Spine of the World for over a hundred years until it was razed in the War of the Silver Marches. Orrusk would see it come into being again, and more orcs arrive every day, drawn by his vision of a new, independent orc realm.

LORDS' ALLIANCE

The Lords' Alliance isn't a realm, but rather a tenuous but powerful coalition between contentious settlements of the North and elsewhere, established to promote peace, prosperity, and security among its members. It includes Neverwinter, Silvermoon, Mithral Hall, and others, including powerful Waterdeep to the south (see "Sword Coast" in this chapter). Each settlement in the alliance looks first to its own interests, then to the needs of its allies. The Alliance hires adventurers to investigate and eradicate threats to the region and isn't above using violence and deception in pursuit of its goals. See chapter 6 for more information on the Lords' Alliance.

High Road. A vital lifeline linking settlements along the Sword Coast and one of the North's foremost trade routes, the High Road begins in Luskan, runs south through Neverwinter, and then continues along the coast to Waterdeep (where it continues as the Trade Way). After decades of neglect and disrepair, the road is again safe to travel thanks to the efforts of Dagult Neverember and the High Road Charter Company.

Mirabar. The richest city in the North sits on the Mirar River, enclosed by sloped outer walls. Above ground, a largely human population is ruled by their hereditary marchion, but Mirabar is deeply dwarven. Tunnels, forges, and foundries in the massive undercity lead to the great mines of the Sword Coast. Dwarven elders on the Council of Sparkling Stones rule underground, and the Axe of Mirabar, a well-armed company of dwarf soldiers, defends the city against threats, above or below.

Neverwinter. The City of Skilled Hands was once known for its master crafters, fine goods, and lavish gardens heated year-round by the Neverwinter River, flowing from Mount Hotenow. When the volcano erupted and a great chasm to the Underdark opened, Neverwinter was nearly destroyed. Now, with the volcano's wrath spent and the chasm sealed, the city is rebuilding itself under the rule of Lord Dagult Neverember.

Silvermoon. Rightly called the Gem of the North, this quiet, cosmopolitan city is a powerful member of the Lords' Alliance and a haven of learning, music, and culture. The Knights in Silver and magical defenses protect the city's ivy-covered walls and towers, where gardens and trees cast dappled light on peaceful streets. For a time, Silvermoon was the capital of a tight-knit alliance across the Silver Marches—the region between the Glimmerwood and the High Forest. The War of the Silver Marches brought an end to that alliance and tarnished Silvermoon's reputation, but it is still respected and beloved across the region.

LUSKAN

Luskan, the City of Sails, was once a grand port, but years of crime and ill fortune have reduced it to a dirty dive with filthy streets, ramshackle docks, and pirates thinly disguised as traders. Rising above its stinking fog like a clawed hand is the Hosttower of the Arcane, home of the Arcane Brotherhood (described in chapter 6). Five pirate lords called High Captains rule the city and are charged with the city's defense and legitimate trade, as well as plundering the Northlander islands to the west.

MENZOBERRANZAN

Menzoberranzan is a drow city carved from the pillars of a great cavern in the Underdark between Silvermoon and Mithral Hall. It is the center of Lolth's worship in Faerûn. Also known as the City of Spiders, it's known for its culture of deception, manipulation, and the capture and trade of enslaved surface dwellers. Although officially governed by a council of matrons from the eight greatest houses, the city is under the heel of House Baenre and the Matron Mother, who rules in Lolth's name. On a high plateau stands the Academy, Tier Breche, where priestesses, mages, and noble warriors are trained. Over a hundred tunnels link the city to other parts of the Underdark, and drow traders sell poisons, strange mushrooms, beasts of burden, scrolls, wine, and secrets with merchants of the deep.

NORTHERN DWARFHOLDS

Throughout the North, many dwarves dwell in independent fortresses called dwarfholds. Though many such dwarfholds are lost, abandoned, or infested by monsters, some still stand firm. Dwarves in Mithral Hall, Citadel Adbar, Citadel Felbarr, Gauntlgrym, Stoneshaft Hold, and Ironmaster trace their ancestry back to Delzoun, the ancient dwarf kingdom of the North. Mirabar and Sundabar are also dwarfholds, though Mirabar has welcomed human immigrants and Sundabar was razed by the Kingdom of Many-Arrows in the War of the Silver Marches. Before then, most dwarfholds had joined the Lords' Alliance, but when Silvermoon failed to save Sundabar, the dwarfhold leaders declared their intention to rely only on one another.

Citadel Adbar. Citadel Adbar is a fortress in the Ice Mountains built by the dwarves of ancient Delzoun that has defied invaders for eighteen centuries. The War of the Silver Marches reduced the city's once-great Knights of the Mithral Shield to a handful of members, but its defending army—the Iron Guard—remains strong.

Gauntlgrym. Once a bastion of Delzoun, Gauntlgrym lay abandoned under the mountains for centuries until King Bruenor Battlehammer reclaimed it from Lolth's followers with an army of shield dwarves. The heart of Gauntlgrym is its legendary forge, within which is trapped a fire elemental known as Maegera the Dawn Titan.

Mithral Hall. The ancestral home of the Battlehammer clan is a nigh-impregnable vault beneath the Frost Hills. Despite its almost mythic reputation, Mithral Hall is more of a stronghold than a city, with tunnels to other dwarfholds deep below its mines. Queen Dagnabbet Waybeard rules Mithral Hall, firmly in support of the Lords' Alliance.

Sundabar. Like its sibling-city, Mirabar, Sundabar was both an underground dwarfhold and a thriving surface city until it was razed by Many-Arrows orcs in the War of the Silver Marches. Refugees from the surface city fled west to Silvermoon and other nearby settlements, while the dwarves of the lower holds withdrew from the Lords' Alliance and banned outsiders from the city. While the walls and buildings of the city above crumble into ruins stalked by roving monsters, black smoke rises from tunnels and hidden chambers, where underground forges still operate.

SAVAGE FRONTIER

The Savage Frontier is a vast swath of ungoverned land inhabited by dangerous monsters. Visitors can trudge for days through its peaks and snowfields without seeing so much as a trapper's cabin.

Evermoors. An unsettled region of fog-shrouded hills, cold bogs, rocky ridges, small peaks, and crumbling ruins, this vast waste is inhabited by hill giants, ettins, ogres, countless trolls, and warring bands of orcs. A mile above the Evermoors floats the cloud giant castle of Lyn Armaal, only fleetingly glimpsed through overcast skies.

Glimmerwood. This wide forest combines the dense, lycanthrope-prowled Moonwood, the Druarwood (claimed by Uthgardt tribes), and the Cold Wood, which is covered by ice and snow even during the height of summer, except where blackened by traveling fire giants.

High Forest. The greatest existing forest in Faerûn is vast and mysterious, a remnant from ages past, when elven realms like Illefarn and Eerlann ruled a continent covered in green. The High Forest is as large as a realm, covering mountains and countless secrets. Here dwell treants of enormous size, stags with antlers wide as a wagon, gigantic bears, owlbears, wolves, centaurs, unicorns, and other creatures stranger still, some of which have no name remembered by mortals. The forest's outermost fringes are inhabited by woodcutters and outlaws, but deeper in, wood elves and Uthgardt warriors of the Ghost Tree tribe guard the forest's secrets.

Icespire Peak. Icespire Peak is the tallest of the Sword Mountains, visible from far away as Phandalin. The mountain conceals mithral mines dug by dwarves long ago, and in winter its waterfalls freeze, forming amazing curtains of ice. But Icespire Peak is now home to goblins, frost giants, trolls, the white dragon Cryovain, and agents of the Cult of the Dragon, ensuring all but brave adventurers avoid its perilous slopes.

Mere of Dead Men. Thousands of dwarf, elf, human, and orc corpses lie beneath this saltwater swamp, which was created many centuries ago through fell magic. The swamp is home to two ancient black dragons: Voaraghamanthar the Black Death and his twin brother Waervaerendor the Rapacious Raider. The two dragons share a psychic link and are indistinguishable, so they're often mistaken for a single dragon. Efforts to drain the swamp or redirect the High Road away from its borders have been fruitless; the swamp merely expands to fill any abandoned space.



ICE CAVES LEADING TO THE UNDERDARK HAVE TEMPTED MANY ADVENTURERS INTO DANGER.

ARTIST: EREL MAATITA

Phandalin. The frontier settlement of Phandalin has a long history of association with mages and artificers working in the nearby complex of Wave Echo Cave, home to the legendary Forge of Spells. Fragments of Netherese civilization also dot this region, including pieces of psychic crystal. Mind flayers lairing in the Underdark beneath Phandalin collect these crystals and use them to mutate innocent victims in an elaborate scheme to create a new empire in Faerûn.

LIFE IN THE NORTH

To live in the North requires strength—strength of body to withstand the harsh elements, strength of will to withstand fear and isolation, and strength of heart to stand side by side with strangers.

Giants and Dragons. In other parts of Faerûn, people tell stories about the conflicts between giants and dragons. In the North, these are lived realities. Many giants and dragons dwell here at the edge of the world, and their ancient enmity threatens those who dwell peacefully in the shadow of the mountains.

Nomads. The Reghed nomads of Icewind Dale and the Uthgardt of the Savage Frontier survive through hardiness and mobility, proving that it's possible to flourish even in the deadliest of lands. Some, however, depend on raiding and violence to survive.

Spine of the World. This impossibly high mountain range spans the entire north, shaping and threatening the entire region. Towering black rock peaks are gripped by snow and ice, scoured by raging winds, and filled with yetis, white dragons, and frost giants, while tunnels, caves, and abandoned dwarfholds below are home to goblinoids, remorhazes, duergar, and drow. In the jaws of these mountains lie the crumbling ruins and secrets of too many half-forgotten realms and lost souls to count.

Underdark Menace. Threats from deep below the earth's surface are never far from the minds of folk in the North. Drow worshipers of Lolth dwell in great numbers in the Underdark, aberrations lurk in caverns deeper still, and buried secrets have a way of turning up in frightening ways. Worse still, in Icewind Dale, mysterious forces have begun to thaw the frozen deep, freeing horrors deep beneath subterranean ice that should never be released.

Winter's Reign. However dragons and giants might rage, there is no power greater than the winter in the far North. Life here is geared toward withstanding hardship. Traders throughout the region supply winter gear and spirits strong enough to warm bones and numb wounds. Builders create thick-walled shelters that stand against the strongest winds. Priests placate gods of cold, such as Auril, and pray to deities willing to grant one more breath, one more glimpse of the sun, to the faithful.

OLD EMPIRES

OVERVIEW

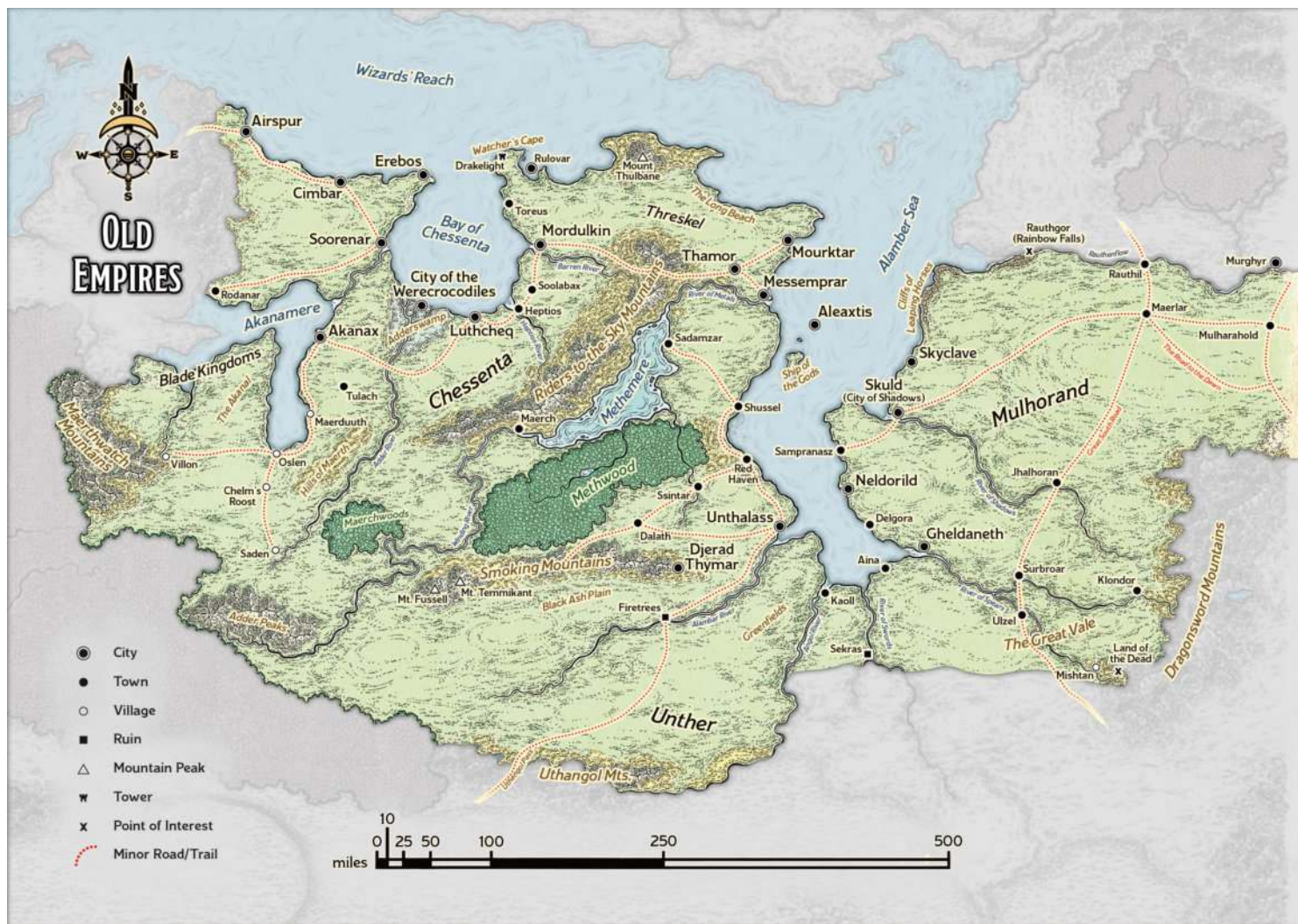
At a Glance: Living deities walk among mortals, leading their followers into cycles of terrible wars followed by golden ages.

Realms: Chessenta, Mulhorand, Unther

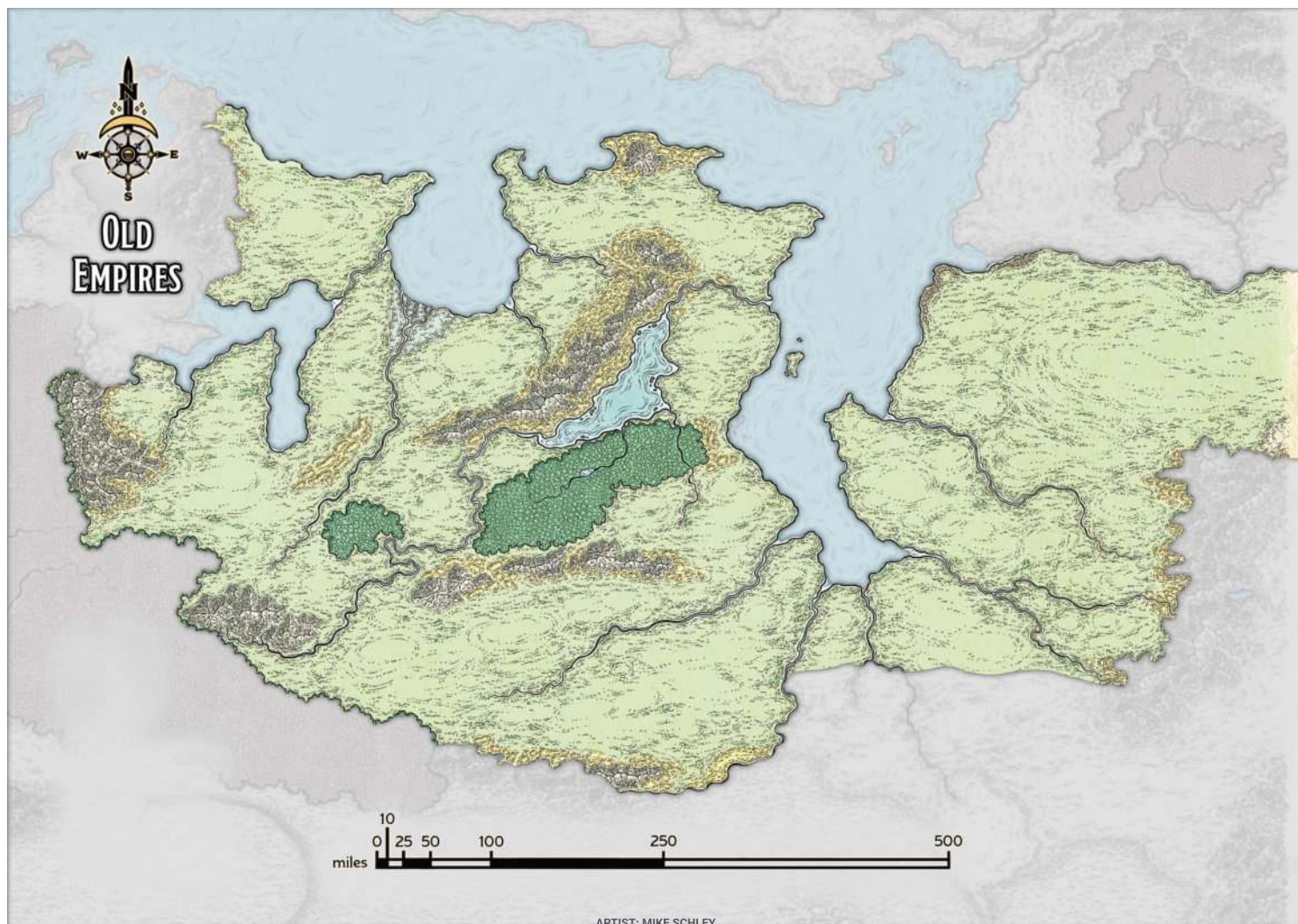
Languages: Chessentan, Mulhorandi, Untheric

Landmarks: Alamber Sea, Black Ash Plain, Dragonsword Mountains, the Great Vale, Land of the Dead, Mount Thulbane, River of Swords

Threats: Visitors and locals alike must contend with the will of merciless god-kings, vast stretches of inhospitable desert, and ancient blood feuds that divide these realms.



MAP: OLD EMPIRES (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



The realms of the Old Empires are the most ancient extant civilizations in Faerûn. For over three thousand years the people of Mulhorand, Chessenta, and Unther have alternately flourished and floundered, rising to unparalleled heights and surviving unprecedented disasters. The result is three realms that share wide swaths of history and aspects of culture peculiar to outsiders: strict theocratic governments,

enormous military-bureaucracy complexes, and unique advances in art, science, and magic.

Those who make the perilous voyage across the Sea of Fallen Stars and into Old Empires ports find desert coasts dusted with glittering purple sand; beachside bazaars overflowing with turquoise, lapis lazuli, and bronze metalcraft; and terraced temple gardens bursting with grapes, dates, and figs. Further inland, limestone monoliths loom over oceans of ripe grain next to unspeakably impoverished slum-cities; flooded riverside ruins and parched savanna fortresses teem with desert monsters; and battlegrounds lay haunted by restless dead—including previous incarnations of the gods themselves.

With their alien deities, inscrutable technology, and ancient grudges, the Old Empires are unlike any other region of the Forgotten Realms. To explorers and mercenaries from foreign soil, Mulhorand, Unther, and Chessenta are realms teeming with mysteries. For locals of these lands, opportunities abound to become heroes either by confronting the desert's dangers or shedding light on corrupt powers. No matter who answers the call, the Old Empires promise priceless rewards for the brave, beneficial secrets for the cunning, and exciting adventures for all.

The story of the Old Empires begins with an empire called Imaskar, whose high artificers and overlords facilitated their kingdom's ascension by subjugating tens of thousands of people from a distant world. The abused subjects beseeched their patron deities for freedom, and their prayers were answered. The Imaskar underclass liberated itself, and in place of overthrown Imaskar the people founded two new empires: Mulhorand and Unther.

Though they share similar origins, Mulhorand and Unther have harbored mutual animosity toward one another since their founding. Their constant territorial disputes eventually birthed the independent realm of Chessenta to the northwest.

CHESSENTA

Chessenta is an unusual empire, where a chaotic array of city-states are in perpetual conflict with one another. But where constant strife might weaken lesser realms, Chessenta's endless saber rattling and infighting only tempers an already resilient people.

Chessentans revel in war the way other cultures delight in sports or feasting. In Chessenta, a youth's first brush with death is a rite of passage, and a life without battle is no life at all. Chessentans who don't take part in their city's bloody military campaigns toil at home to supply the army, growing drought-resistant crops in the thin and stony soil, forging sturdy but lightweight weapons and shields suitable for the hot summer wars, and producing thousands of barrels of the region's famous ruby wine to keep soldiers' spirits high.

Religion is important in Chessenta, and Chessentans have an array of gods and demigods utterly alien to outsiders. But perhaps no deity in Chessenta is so noteworthy as Tchazzar, a legendary god-king who in antiquity united the city-states of Chessenta and spearheaded the realm's only golden age. Tchazzar's death four hundred years ago heralded a great schism between the Chessentan cities. Only recently has the violent deity returned to Faerûnian soil in his true form as the Great Red Dragon. After reclaiming and subjugating the city of Cimbar, Tchazzar now aims to reunite the fractious powers of Chessenta into his idealized warrior realm.

Airspur. The city of Airspur drifts above the shores of Wizards' Reach on an island of floating stone. Its populace includes a higher-than-average percentage of orcs and genasi (described in *Mordenkainen Presents: Monsters of the Multiverse*). Its theocratic rulers—the Church of Bhaelros—demand monthly sacrifices to appease their bloody god. The flying city uses its aerial

advantage to harry its longstanding political rival, Cimbar, to the east. If not for Cimbar's divine ruler, Tchazzar, Airspur likely would've already destroyed its age-old foe.

Cimbar. The former capital of united Chessenta, Cimbar remains one of the fragmented empire's largest metropolises. The city is Tchazzar's seat of power. Naturally, given Tchazzar's draconic nature, the Cult of the Dragon has a strong foothold here. Though it is a blood-soaked and perilous port of call, Cimbar boasts one of the largest navies in the whole Inner Sea region. It also hosts famous non-military institutions such as the University, the greatest center of higher learning in the Old Empires.

Luthcheq. Military zeal combines with religious fervor in Luthcheq, whose ruling Karanok family persecutes practitioners of arcane magic in the name of Entropy, a strange god of alien intellect that resides somewhere in the vast underground chasms beneath Luthcheq's undercity. Dozens, if not hundreds, of magically gifted refugees flee Luthcheq each year to escape this destructive cult.

Threskel. South of the dormant volcano known as Mount Thulbane and north of the Riders to the Sky lies the sparsely populated land of Threskel. Chessenta and Unther both claim Threskel, but this remote land is famously lorded over by evil dragons. The few people who live in Threskel eke out pitiful existences on barren farms nestled between rocky shores and windswept cliffs. The desperation of this land has given rise to many heroic adventurers whom the dragons eagerly squash.

MULHORAND

Mulhorand is the oldest of the Old Empires and was literally shaped by gods. Deities from a distant world—gods with names like Anhur, Horus-Re, and Set—took on physical form, leading their people to settle in rich, densely populated metropolises and build massive stone pyramids. To this day, these incarnated deities continue to walk the land and directly influence the realm.

While pharaohs with divine lineage ultimately rule the realm, Mulhorand is governed by a class of powerful theocrats: high priests, sages, and holy warriors who serve the incarnated gods. All Mulhorandi, from blue-blooded nobles to common street peddlers, heed their god-kings' wishes in every aspect of daily life. When a merchant's latest shipment arrives safely at port, it is thanks to the will of Nephthys; a new mother's safe delivery might personally be overseen by Hathor; and Mulhorandi commanders pray to Anhur, General of the Gods, for victory against Untherites who threaten their borders.

The Great Vale. The breadbasket of Mulhorand produces enough barley, lentils, and onions to feed millions of the empire's citizens; it is also the realm's primary source of papyrus. Large bronze pumps—just one of Mulhorand's advanced technologies—move water from the River of Spears to irrigate the valley's vast farms. To the east, the Dragonsword Mountains cast their shadows over the Great Vale; the empire's pharaohs and greatest high priests are buried among the foothills of these mountains. Marking these crypts are dozens of monuments and elaborate tombs—ancient step pyramids and towering obelisks—collectively known as the Land of the Dead.

River of Swords. This long river is the current border between Mulhorand and Unther. A perennial battleground, the River of Swords sustains few settlements along its bloodstained banks. Most of the river's water is too salty to drink or water crops. In the small city of Sekras there is a machine that pumps water from the river and filters out the salt; only a handful of priests of Thoth know how to operate the pump. Occupation of Sekras has traded hands so many times that even its few permanent residents scarcely know which empire—if any—they currently serve.

Skuld. Anyone wishing to experience Mulhorandi culture in its most realized form visits the metropolis of Skuld. The so-called City of Shadows has the noteworthy distinction of being the oldest continually inhabited city in Faerûn. Its central district is called the City of the Gods; here, incarnations of Mulhorand's god-kings live in grand temples that overlook lush gardens that produce delicious fruit and courtyards of gilded statues.

UNTHER

Though they share a common origin story, Mulhorand and Unther are vastly different realms. Whereas some might call Mulhorand paradise, most of Unther is nothing less than a hellscape. As one sage wrote, "the society of Unther is one of the most miserable tyrannies that the Realms have ever known." It is a land defined by violence—an ever-shifting territory of fiery war camps, poisoned rivers, and salted battlefields where soldiers commit unspeakable atrocities in the name of their realm. Mercenaries might find their fortune serving in the armies of Unther, but the cost is no less than one's own soul.

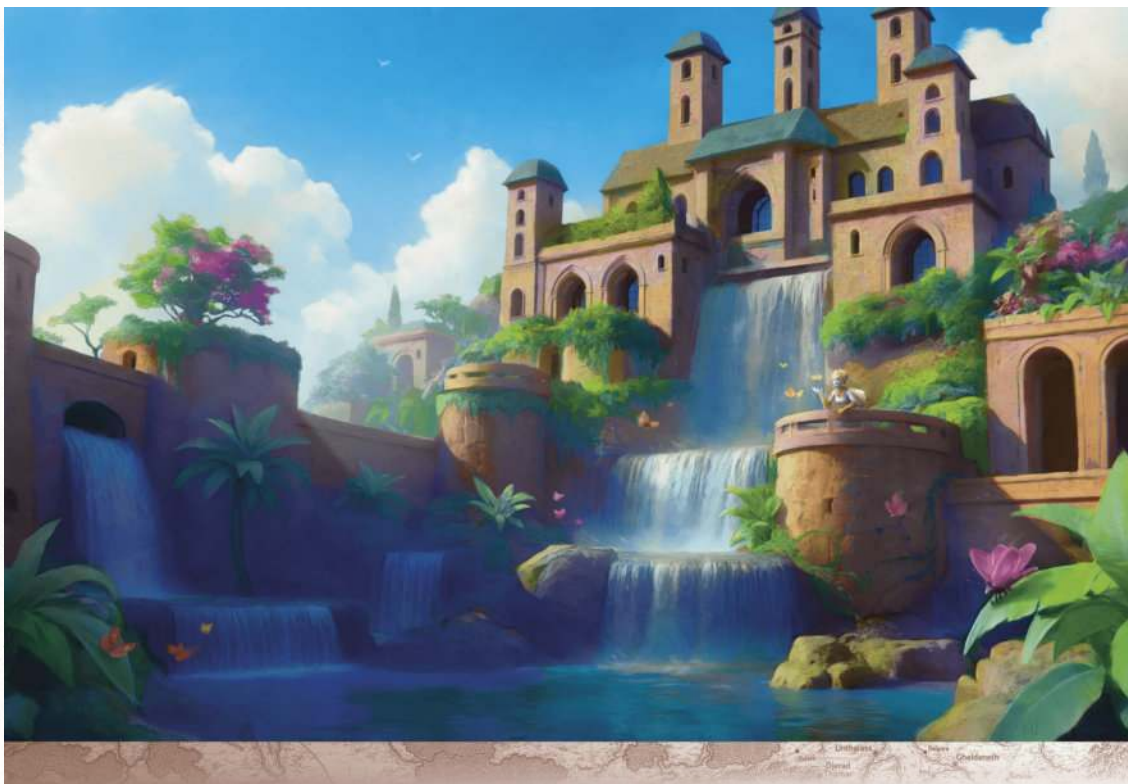
The patron god-king of Unther, Gilgeam, is largely to blame for the realm's state. Whereas the god-kings of Mulhorand treat their realm with benign neglect, Gilgeam is neither benign nor neglectful. Cruel and vindictive, he forbids the worship of any other deity. He justifies his violence by attributing it to fate, a force he insists even he, a god, is beholden to. It was Gilgeam who led Unther to its present state of corruption and chaos. There was a short era of relative peace without the dread god, but that time has ended, and Gilgeam now leads a new generation of lambs to the slaughter. Already Unther is once more a realm of violent dysfunction, maintained by the brute force of Gilgeam and the raw willpower of his most devoted followers, a class of violent hoplites, holy warriors, and warlocks called the Children of Gilgeam.

Black Ash Plain. This wasteland of infertile soil takes its name from the embers and ash that perpetually rain down from the volcanoes of the nearby Smoking Mountains. From the blighted earth jut brutalist ruins—vestiges of Ancient Mulhorand and even earlier empires. The ruins magically shift across the desert of their own accord. Those who brave the ruins' subterranean depths find themselves in an ever-transforming maze of basalt corridors and granite columns engraved with eerie glyphs that resemble no known language.

Djerad Thymar. The fortress-city called Djerad Thymar was the capital of Tymanchebar, an empire of dragonborn that was transported from its home world of Abeir to Toril during the Spellplague and fused with Unther to form the new realm of Tymanther. With Unther's return in the Second Sundering, the armies of Unther have shattered the power of Tymanther, but Djerad Thymar still stands. With its awe-inspiring stone architecture (the city is carved into the face of a mountain) and its vast arts districts, Djerad Thymar is a bastion for draconic culture and a mark of great pride for dragonborn.

Messemprar. The large city of Messemprrar is by far the finest and most hospitable settlement in Unther. Not coincidentally, it is also the only city not presently under the thumb of Gilgeam. Instead, a coalition of anti-Gilgeam mages called the North Wizards controls the settlement. The North Wizards foster a brand of democracy otherwise unknown in the Old Empires. A prime port, Messemprrar is beset on all sides by would-be conquerors: war ships from Chessenta, the armies of Mulhorand, and freebooting Inner Sea pirates from lands abroad. Sturdy adventurers are in constant demand to protect the city's independence.

Unthalass. Supposedly, Unthalass was once the greatest city in the Realms: a paradise of flowering gardens, alabaster statues, and palatial limestone manors. Anyone who visits the city as it is now would scarcely believe such legends. Everything here has been sacrificed in the name of the god-king Gilgeam's hunger for conquest. The mud-brick streets overflow with filth and even blood, for Gilgeam brooks no dissent within his capital. The tyrant himself rules all of Unther from an imposing granite fortress in Unthalass called the Citadel of Black Ash.



NINGAL, CHOSEN OF SELÛNE, TAKES HER EASE IN MESSEMPRAR'S TERRACED GARDENS.

ARTIST: MIRO PETROV

LIFE IN THE OLD EMPIRES

Those visiting the Old Empires are often surprised by the realms' different cultural values, their unique architecture and customs, and the unforgiving southern climate. For natives of the Old Empires, these are simply facts of life.

Ancient History. Mulhorand, Chessenta, and Unther are unfathomably old—and they are built atop the ruins of realms even older still. Most notably, Mulhorand and Unther are inheritors of the Imaskar Empire. To this day, countless ruins of Imaskar are strewn across the region, awaiting discovery by brave adventurers.

Insular Realms. The people of the Old Empires care little for the concerns of greater Faerûn. Rulers and commoners alike consider themselves and their kingdoms far above the juvenile concerns of younger realms. The denizens of Mulhorand and Unther justify this point of view by citing the gods and godly descendants that have shaped their empires to an extent virtually unknown in other parts of the Realms. (Chessentans, for their part, simply view other cultures as weak and cowardly.) Further, rulers in the Old Empires are too concerned with their own internal power struggles to consider much beyond the horizon.

Living Gods. Unlike most Faerûnian deities, the deities of the Old Empires regularly assume tangible, readily perceivable forms. This allows the god-kings of these realms to take an active role in their followers' affairs. These deities deliver divine mandates personally and issue decrees that offer little room for doubt about the gods' motives or intentions. Because of this, priests in the Old Empires tend to function more like bureaucrats or law enforcers than spiritual guides.

Technology and Magic. The people of the Old Empires are masters of unusual technology and forms of magic seen nowhere else in Faerûn. Some of these secrets they inherited from Imaskari mages called artificers. Others are simply a result of unique Mulhorandi or Untherite genius. Examples include bronze water pumps and mass water purification spells that enable the transfer and filtration of precious water, and sail-powered sand sleds and easy-to-learn flotation spells allowing travelers to glide on desert winds over vast distances.

SWORD COAST

OVERVIEW

At a Glance: This cosmopolitan region is famous for its large cities and the Realms-shattering menaces that threaten them.

Realms: Elturgard, the Lords' Alliance, Najara

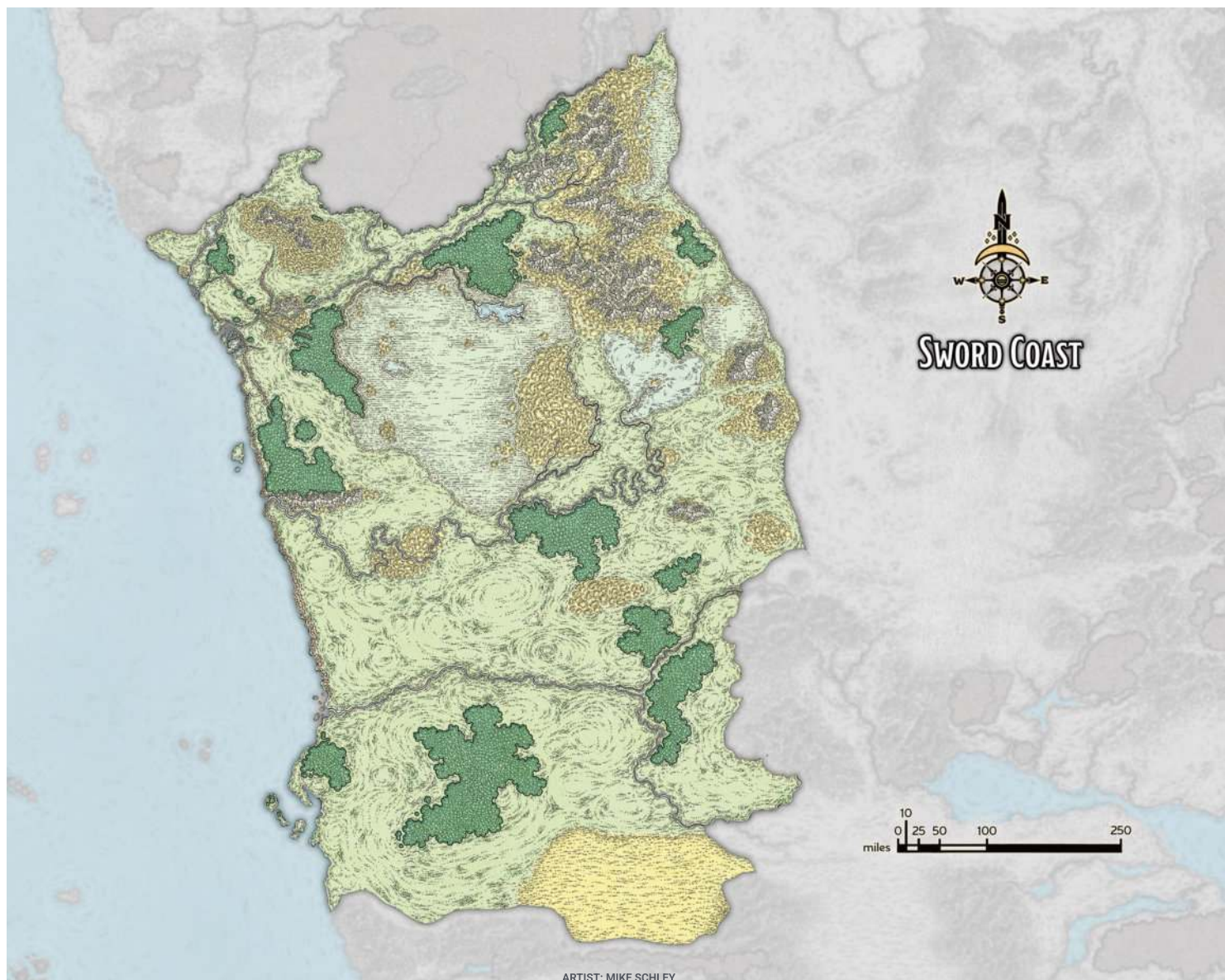
Languages: Chondathan

Landmarks: Baldur's Gate, Candlekeep, Elturel, the High Moor, Ss'thar'tiss'ssun, Undermountain, Waterdeep

Threats: Urban crime syndicates, the Dead Three, Halaster Blackcloak



MAP: SWORD COAST (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



The lands around and between the two coastal cities of Waterdeep and Baldur's Gate have been tested relentlessly over the past century, enduring the rise and fall of draconic and elemental cults, the scheming of illithids and dead gods, and even being dragged into the Nine Hells.

Unlike most of Faerûn's territorial governments, the Sword Coast's city-states have no interest whatsoever in quarreling over land disputes. The Lords' Alliance ensures that both the Sword Coast's and the North's major settlements keep their attention squarely directed at mutual threats.

The Sword Coast boasts some of the most cosmopolitan cities in Faerûn. In a city like Waterdeep or Baldur's Gate, a visitor might pass a dragonborn ombudsman, an aasimar merchant, and a goliath lutist all in the span of a city block. Even in smaller villages, people hold few prejudices and tend to be more receptive to new ideas than in places like the stubborn Heartlands or the more isolationist isles of the Trackless Sea.

This is a region of adventure, where daring souls delve into the wreckage of ancient strongholds and explore long-lost ruins. The Sword Coast's enormous cities also serve as useful sites for urban-based adventures, where characters unearth the machinations of scheming nobles or shady factions.

LORDS' ALLIANCE

The Lords' Alliance isn't a true realm, but rather a loose coalition of cities, including Waterdeep, Baldur's Gate, Daggerford, and Amphail in the Sword Coast. It also includes several cities in Faerûn's North, such as Neverwinter (see "The North" in this chapter). Each member of the Lords' Alliance keeps its own interests in mind first and foremost. But these cities also agree to maintain trade ties with each other, uphold a mutual peace, and band together against common threats. Without the Lords' Alliance, many of western Faerûn's great cities would have long ago fallen to outside threats.

BALDUR'S GATE

The grim, crowded city of Baldur's Gate sits alongside the River Chionthar. Its nobles, called patriars, reside in the Upper City while most of the rest of the populace lives in the Lower City. Refugees and the destitute make what homes they can in the Outer City. A short way to the east sits the walled district of Little Calimshan, a thriving neighborhood of immigrants from that southern realm. The Council of Four governs Baldur's Gate, led by Grand Duke Ulder Ravengard. See chapter 6 of *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn* for more on Baldur's Gate.

Criminal Underworld. Baldur's Gate has a shady underworld organization known as the Guild. It operates throughout the city under the discreet leadership of a crime boss named Nine-Fingers Keene. She has agents throughout Baldur's Gate, including in the city's banking network.

The Dead Three. The gods Bane, Bhaal, and Myrkul share a common history linked to the city of Baldur's Gate, where they are known as the Dead Three. All three gods began as mortals, claimed a share of the power of the death god Jergal, and died during the Time of Troubles. All three have returned, and their worshipers have made a resurgence in Baldur's Gate and the surrounding area, hiding away in the shadows of society. Cultists of the Dead Three plot endlessly to secure the ascendancy of their deities at the expense of innocent folk. (The three gods are described in more detail in chapter 5.)

ELTURGARD

The realm of Elturgard encompasses Elturel, Triel, Scornubel, Soubar, and Berdusk. It also includes much of the surrounding land, including the Fields of the Dead. Once a shining kingdom, Elturgard fell into disarray when its capital Elturel was dragged into the Nine Hells and back again. Even after the capital's return, Elturgard struggles to pick up the pieces. Some of Elturgard's outer cities have attempted to secede from the increasingly theocratic realm. Elturel keeps them close by threatening to withdraw the protection of the Hellriders, a cavalry force that keeps Elturgard's loyal cities safe from danger.

The Fall of Elturel and Its Aftermath. A radiant sphere called the Companion appeared over Elturel in 1444 DR, blazing like a second sun. Elturel's people praised the god Torm for this fortuitous blessing, and Elturel expanded to become the holy nation of Elturgard. In truth, the Companion was summoned up by the archdevil Zariel to enact a decades-long grudge against the city. In 1492, it became a crackling orb of darkness, dragging Elturel and its inhabitants into Avernus, first layer of the Nine Hells.

While all reasonable folk know and fear the Nine Hells, this fear is largely abstract. Very few have ever had to see such a place with their own eyes or feel its heat on their skin. But that's precisely what the citizens of Elturel had to do, as their friends and family were slain by marauding devils. After brave heroes eliminated the Companion and returned Elturel to the Material Plane, Elturgard's theocratic government doubled down on the mandatory worship of Torm, Tyr, and Ilmater—three benevolent gods collectively called the Triad.

Elturel. Elturel's people have become more pious after returning from the Nine Hells, desperate to ensure their afterlives send them to the Upper Planes. But this has created new problems, as the paranoid populace now distrusts and harasses tieflings, blaming them for the city's fall. Fearing for their safety, Elturel's tieflings have fled in droves for Baldur's Gate.

NAJARA

The ancient realm of Najara stretches across the Serpent Hills, the Marsh of Chelimber, and the Forest of Wyrms. It is a land of yuan-ti, nagas, and lizardfolk. Najaran society is unfeeling and ever-calculating. The Sword Coast remained oblivious to Najara for over a millennia until Najara's current ruler, the spirit naga Jarant, decided to make the realm's presence known to its neighbors. For now, Najara's nefarious motives remain unexplored. The Lords' Alliance and Elturgard alike have been too busy with other threats to investigate the serpent realm. Najara grows in power right under their noses, like a coiled snake waiting for the perfect moment to strike.

Ss'thar'tiss'ssun. Ancient and evil, the spirit naga Jarant rules the realm of Najara from its capital city Ss'thar'tiss'ssun with the aid of a silver circlet called the *Marlspire of Najara*. This artifact grants Jarant powerful abjuration magic and control over reptilian creatures—including the first ruler of the kingdom, Terpenzi, now a powerful bone naga called the Guardian of Najara.

WATERDEEP

Also known as the City of Splendors, the bustling city of Waterdeep is ruled by a lordly council. The current Open Lord, Laeral Silverhand, keeps her identity known to the public. The Masked Lords rule alongside her anonymously, thus preventing any of them from being bribed or threatened. Waterdeep boasts a prodigious magical academy at Blackstaff Tower, which is run by a wizard holding the office of the Blackstaff—currently Vajra Safahr.

City Wards. Waterdeep is divided into several wards. Wards aren't separated by walls or gates, and crossing between wards is easy. City wards include the Sea Ward, marked by the palatial fortress-estates of the city's rich and powerful; the peacefully elegant North Ward; and the busy marketplaces of the Trade Ward. The Southern Ward is home to many immigrants, while the city's poorest live and work in the Dock Ward. Waterdeep's dead are entombed in the City of the Dead, a massive park and open air mausoleum within the city. Outside Waterdeep, a large collection of shelters that were once temporary housing for refugees has become a neighborhood of its own: the Field Ward. The Field Ward isn't patrolled by the city guards and has no sanitation or other city services; it is home to Waterdeep's most desperate citizens.

Defenses. While Waterdeep has a militia and city guard, its most famous defenders are magical walking statues and the griffon cavalry. The walking statues are eight enormous statues that sit dormant among the city's buildings. The Blackstaff can activate them to defend the city in times of dire need, animating each statue into an unstoppable stone colossus. The griffon cavalry is made up of well-trained riders and their griffon mounts. Each rider wears a *Ring of Feather Falling*, allowing them to safely leap from their mounts in daring assaults on any enemy.

Undermountain. The twenty-three-floor megadungeon of Undermountain stretches deep beneath the city of Waterdeep. Adventurers descend into it from a well in the Yawning Portal tavern to search for treasure. At the dungeon's bottommost level lairs Halaster Blackcloak. Halaster's motives are unknown and perhaps unknowable. He built this behemoth of a dungeon complex long before Waterdeep was founded, and he's been stocking it with perils ever since. Many creatures have also found their way into Undermountain of their own accord, creating civilizations in its halls, including the bustling, crime-ridden city of Skullport.

Xanathar Guild. The Xanathar Guild is a criminal organization operating out of Skullport, a subterranean city beneath Waterdeep. Its gang activity frequently spills up into Waterdeep proper. Very few people know who or what Xanathar actually is: a paranoid, megalomaniacal beholder who fawns over his pet goldfish, Sylgar. Xanathar has eyes all over the bustling city of Waterdeep and despises his rival, the Zhentarim. For more on the Xanathar Guild, see chapter 6.

OTHER SITES

Though Waterdeep and Baldur's Gate have great influence in this region, their official territories don't extend far beyond their city walls. Most of the land in this region doesn't fall under any realm's jurisdiction.

Ardeer Forest. Once the heart of an elf kingdom, Ardeer Forest has shrunk over the years, its trees cut and sent to Waterdeep to build ships and homes. About a decade ago, elves from Evermeet returned to the forest to defend it against further intrusion and exploitation. They aggressively drive out all who enter the forest. But Ardeer Forest remains a draw for adventurers of all stripes, as it houses many interesting ruins and magical sites.

Candlekeep. Candlekeep holds the largest repository of written lore in Faerûn. It is a towering, walled library standing proudly atop a seaside cliff. In order to enter Candlekeep, an individual must submit a work of writing not yet found within its halls. Its librarian-priests, the Avowed, retrieve tomes from the library for visitors. Candlekeep's defenses include a mythal and a ghostly dragon called Miirym, the Sentinel Wyrn.

Dragonspear Castle. An infernal portal hides in the catacombs beneath the dwarven ruins known as Dragonspear Castle, on the edge of High Moor. It connects to Avernus, first layer of the Nine Hells, but is currently sealed shut. These days, a thick cloud of mist shrouds Dragonspear Castle from harsh sunlight. A mysterious group of vampires known as the Szarl'naxi coven lurks within.

Evereska. The elven city of Evereska is often called "a pocket of Evermeet," and it shares that fabled land's elusive mystique. Evereska is rumored to exist in a great valley in the mountains near Anauroch, protected by a mythal and defended by elf warriors who ride giant eagles.



ADVENTURERS FACE TOO MANY TROLLS IN THE TROLLCLAWS.
ARTIST: GAVIN O'DONNELL

Fields of the Dead. Myriad wars and skirmishes have taken place on the Fields of the Dead over the centuries. It is a vast, rolling plain of windswept grasses. On rare occasions, it belches forth hostile undead, the buried remnants of wars long forgotten.

Graypeak Mountains. Stone giants and stone goliaths call the Graypeak Mountains home. The range is riddled with abandoned mines of both dwarven and Netherese origin.

High Moor. Trolls and cruel goblinoids prowl the rocky wilderness of the High Moor, as do nomadic orcs and human berserkers. An evil dracolich called the Old One lairs in Orogoth, a ruined villa on the moor, still guarding the ancient wealth of a long-lost Netherese noble family.

Orlumbor. There's no better place to purchase or repair a ship in the Sword Coast than Orlumbor. This rocky, cavernous island hides a great harbor full of skilled shipwrights and dockworkers who make some of sturdiest vessels around at a record pace. At the moment, Orlumbor has an exclusive business relationship with Waterdeep.

Trielta Hills. Halflings live out idyllic, pastoral lives in the quaint Trielta Hills. Its humble people have little in the way of valuables to covet, which has allowed Trieltans to exist undisturbed by Najara to the north. Short-lived gold rushes bring outsiders to Trielta every now and then.

The Trollclaws. The rough Trollclaw Hills teem with ravenous trolls. Caravans journeying south to Baldur's Gate or north out of the Fields of Dead cross the river at the Trollclaw Ford and hire adventurers to battle off the regenerating monsters.

Warlock's Crypt. A Netherese enclave crashed to the ground in the Troll Hills over a thousand years ago, becoming a set of ruins now called Warlock's Crypt. Hundreds of undead dwell among the site's shattered rubble and twisted towers. Liches, including the great lich Larloch, perform bizarre experiments on the creatures of the surrounding region and release them back into the wild as terrifying horrors.

Wood of Sharp Teeth. Hundreds of years ago, these woods were the site of a werewolf city called Vehlarr. Rumor has it that wicked lycanthropes are congregating in these woods once again to recreate that society.

TRACKLESS SEA

OVERVIEW

At a Glance: Each island realm is its own small, self-contained pocket of culture, from the ancient traditions of the Moonshaes to innovative Lantan.

Realms: Lantan, Mintarn, the Moonshae Isles

Languages: Lantanese, Illuskan, Chondathan

Landmarks: Gundarlun, Mother-of-Mists, the Nelander, Northlander Isles, Purple Rocks, Tuern, Whalebones

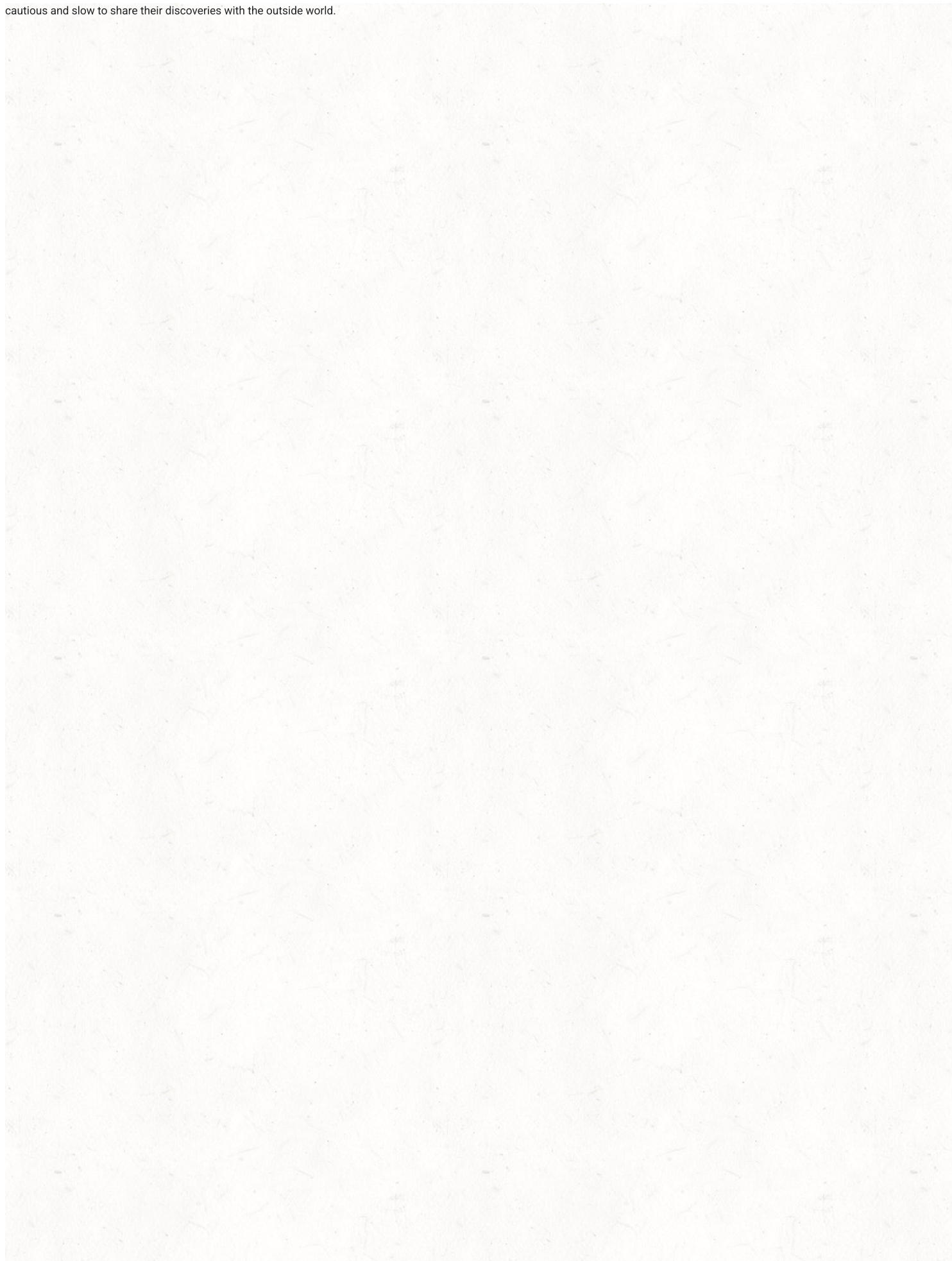
Threats: Pirates and sea monsters plague the tides, the Rusting spreads through the Moonshaes, and the dragon Hoondarrh hungers for power.

There's a reason most sea routes in Faerûn stick close to the coast: navigating the cold, choppy waters of the Trackless Sea is no easy feat. If the waves themselves weren't threats enough, the creatures that prowl them certainly are. Vicious pirates from the Nelander isles delight in pillaging ships and slaughtering their crews. Devotees of Umberlee summon tsunamis and whirlpools to drag folk to the ocean floor as offerings to their god. Bloodthirsty sahuagin and merrow surface from the depths to rip and tear at prey, and the enigmatic kingdoms of the storm giants lie deeper still.

Low-level adventures in the Trackless Sea might focus on the happenings of a single isle. Once characters begin to outgrow that island, their adventures might require sailing to neighboring locales and discovering the distinct cultures therein. Seasoned heroes might explore what lurks on the seafloor or voyage west to discover what lies beyond the map.

Several thriving and unique island realms call the Trackless Sea home, but cultural exchange among these realms is inhibited by the ocean's dangers. The folk dwelling under the shadow of the cruel dragon Hoondarrh in Mintarn lead very different lives than their neighbors in the magical Moonshaes. Lantan's denizens enjoy the conveniences conferred by their many inventions but are

cautious and slow to share their discoveries with the outside world.



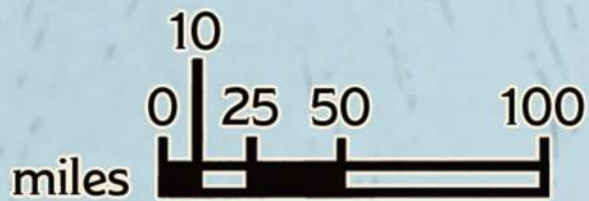


LANTAN

- City
- Town
- Village

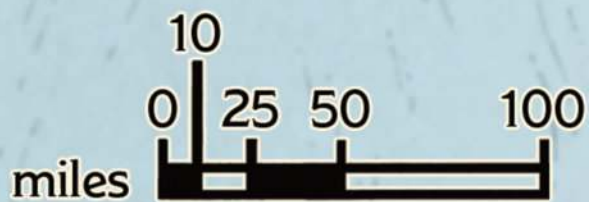


Mother of Mists
The Ssan
(The Daughters)





LANTAN



Folk on the mainland know little of the reclusive realm of Lantan apart from its people's devotion to Gond, the god of invention. Complex locks, oil lamps, tripwires, and light-beam intruder alarms have origins on the island. If a trap in a Faerûnian dungeon has a complex mechanism involved, odds are the technology originated in Lantan. The archipelago is governed by a theocratic twelve-person council called the Ayrorch, high-ranking members of the Church of Gond. Gnomes make up much of the island's population and most of the council.

Lantanese Inventions. The last hundred years have seen the secluded island realm of Lantan grow even more secretive. Its recent innovations include packets of explosive smokepowder, parachutes, firearms, and even submarines. Lantan's people worry that the rest of Faerûn might learn how to replicate these inventions, potentially diminishing the island realm's trading power. Lantan exports inventions in small shipments to mainland port cities like Baldur's Gate and Waterdeep in exchange for precious metals and critical resources that are hard to find on Lantan's islands.

Northern Lantan. The large northern island of Lantan is home to the capital city of Sambar, which houses the realm's ruling council. The city of Illul lies not far away, housing the High Holy Crafhhouse of Inspiration. Led by a high artificer, this wondrous temple is the center of Gond worship in Faerûn.

Orlil. The seemingly barren isle of Orlil boasts a self-contained network of Underdark tunnels that house thriving communes of Lantanese deep gnomes, or svirfneblin. Unlike the svirfneblin of Faerûn's mainland, Orlil's deep gnomes have never known drow subjugation.

Southern Lantan. Outsiders who wish to trade and parley with Lantan must do so on Lantan's southern island, at a port city called Anchoril. Southern Lantan's people are just as industrious and inventive as those to the north, but the citizens of Anchoril feign a lesser degree of technological advancement to keep Lantan's secrets safe.

MINTARN

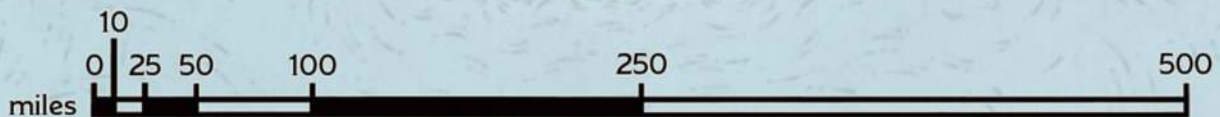
The island of Mintarn, between the Moonsea Isles and Waterdeep, is best known for its mercenaries. Mintarn is known as neutral ground, where enemies meet to negotiate and bargain with each other. Fledgling heroes often travel to Mintarn to make names for themselves. The island's taverns bustle with quest-givers and quest-seekers from across the Trackless Sea and the mainland alike. Mintarn has always been governed by a single ruler self-styled as a tyrant—though these tyrants generally rule with a light hand. But even the current tyrant trembles before the ancient red dragon Hoondarrh, who lairs on a small volcanic island northwest of Mintarn and demands annual tribute from Mintarn's people.

Hoondarrh. Up until recently, Mintarn enjoyed unprecedented prosperity by offering its mercenary services to the wealthy cities of Neverwinter and Waterdeep. As Mintarn's wealth grew, the ancient red dragon Hoondarrh demanded increasingly exorbitant tributes from the island's inhabitants. Today, Hoondarrh's influence keeps Neverwinter and Waterdeep from doing any business with Mintarn. This has left the island's ruler—Her Tyrancy Bloeth Embuirhan—with few ways to pay an increasingly greedy red dragon. Mintarn is poised to undergo a violent change of rulership as its people clamor for a new approach in dealing with Hoondarrh.



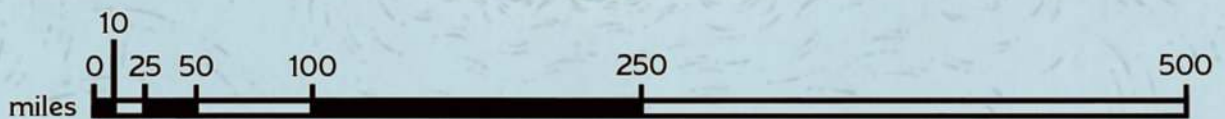
MOONSHAE ISLES

- City
- Town
- Village
- Castle/Fortress/Stronghold
- Ruin
- △ Mountain Peak
- ▼ Dungeon
- W Tower
- x Site
- || Bridge
- Major Road
- - - Minor Road/Trail





MOONSHAE ISLES



Fey abound and giants lurk in the misty Moonshae Isles, an archipelago steeped in fey magic. These wondrous isles are home to two cultures: the rugged, seafaring Norlanders and the practical, hard-working Ffolk. These cultures once warred with each other but have come together under the ruling Kendrick dynasty. Ffolk worship the Earthmother, a divine embodiment of the Moonshae Isles. Springs of natural magic called moonwells are her windows into the world. Druids and rangers tend the moonwells and protect them from a new, insidious curse called the Rusting. This curse threatens to transform moonwells into pools of stinking oil and living things into rusted iron. See chapter 5 of *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn* for more on the Moonshae Isles.

Rusting and the Rusted. A century ago, Amn invaded the Moonshae isle of Snowdown. Led by the vampire Erliza Darissa, Amn's soldiers stripped the island's mines bare, chopped down its forests, and polluted its ponds. Moonshavians banded together to slay Erliza and drive out the Amnians, but the vampire laid a curse on the Moonshaes with her dying words. This curse became the Rusting. Animals and plants affected by the Rusting warp into twisted iron before eventually crumbling to dust. Moonwells become pits of slick, black oil. People who dwell in an area gripped by the Rusting for too long become Rusted constructs who abhor the living. Some Rusted Norlanders even terrorize the Moonshae's coasts in giant warships plated with rusted iron.

Alaron. The Moonshavian island of Alaron is home to a large Ffolk population. Caer Calidyrr—a fortress that overlooks the city of Calidyrr—houses Derid Kendrick, high king of the Moonshaes. Norlanders live in the northern half of the island, herding sheep and working mines in the Farheight range.

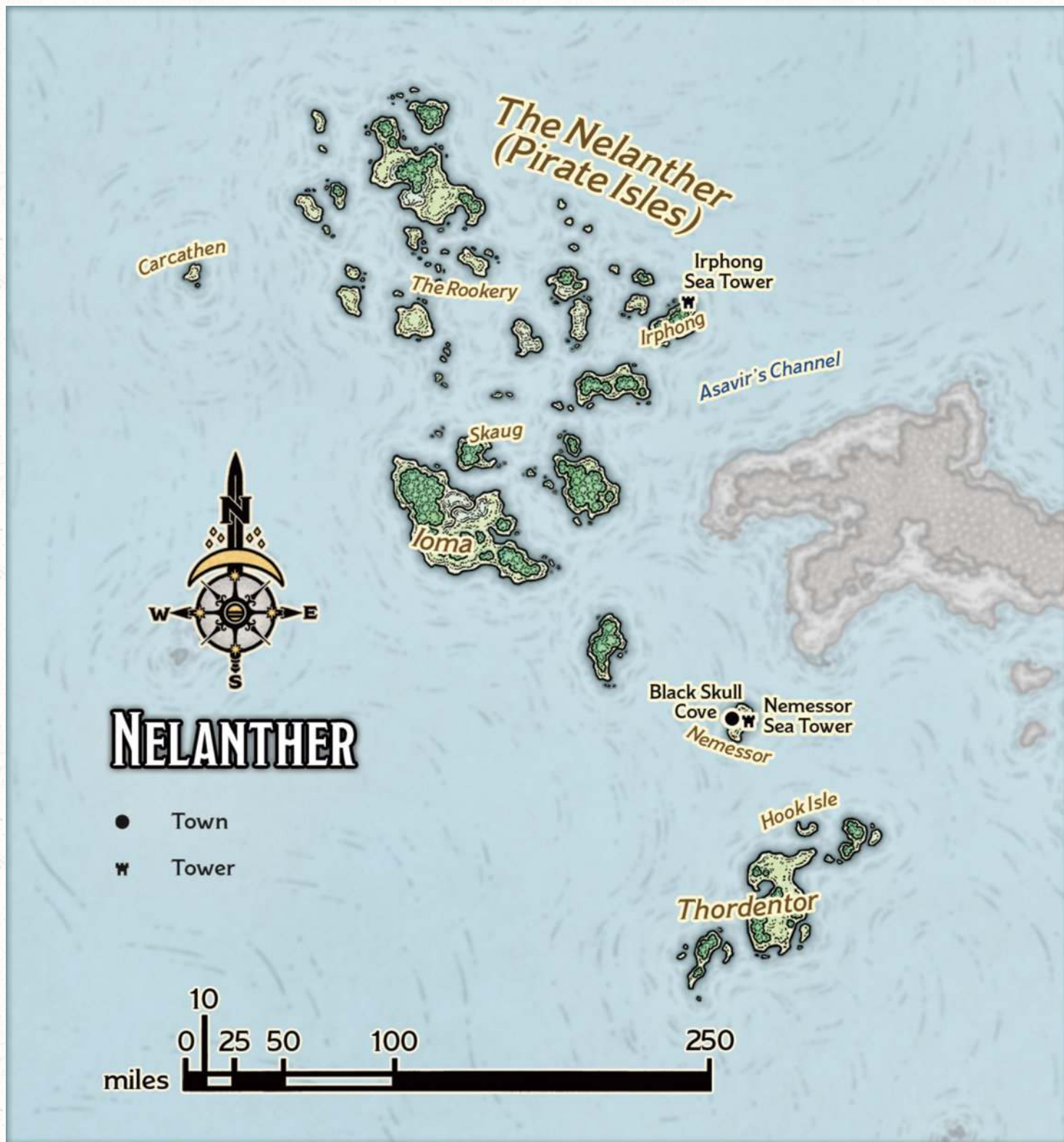
Gwynneth. Gwynneth is the most magical of the Moonshae Isles and the center of the Earthmother's power. As of yet, it is the only Moonshae Isle totally untouched by the Rusting. Its landmarks include the rebuilt castle of Caer Corwell and Myrloch Vale, a forested valley teeming with fey. In the north of the island, the fey kingdom of Sarifal endures, ruled by High Lady Ordalf.

Moray. The Moonshavian isle of Moray is home to monsters and the Red Shadow: packs of werewolves who worship a violent beast-god called Kazgaroth. The Red Shadow regularly abducts innocents for sacrifice in violent rituals.

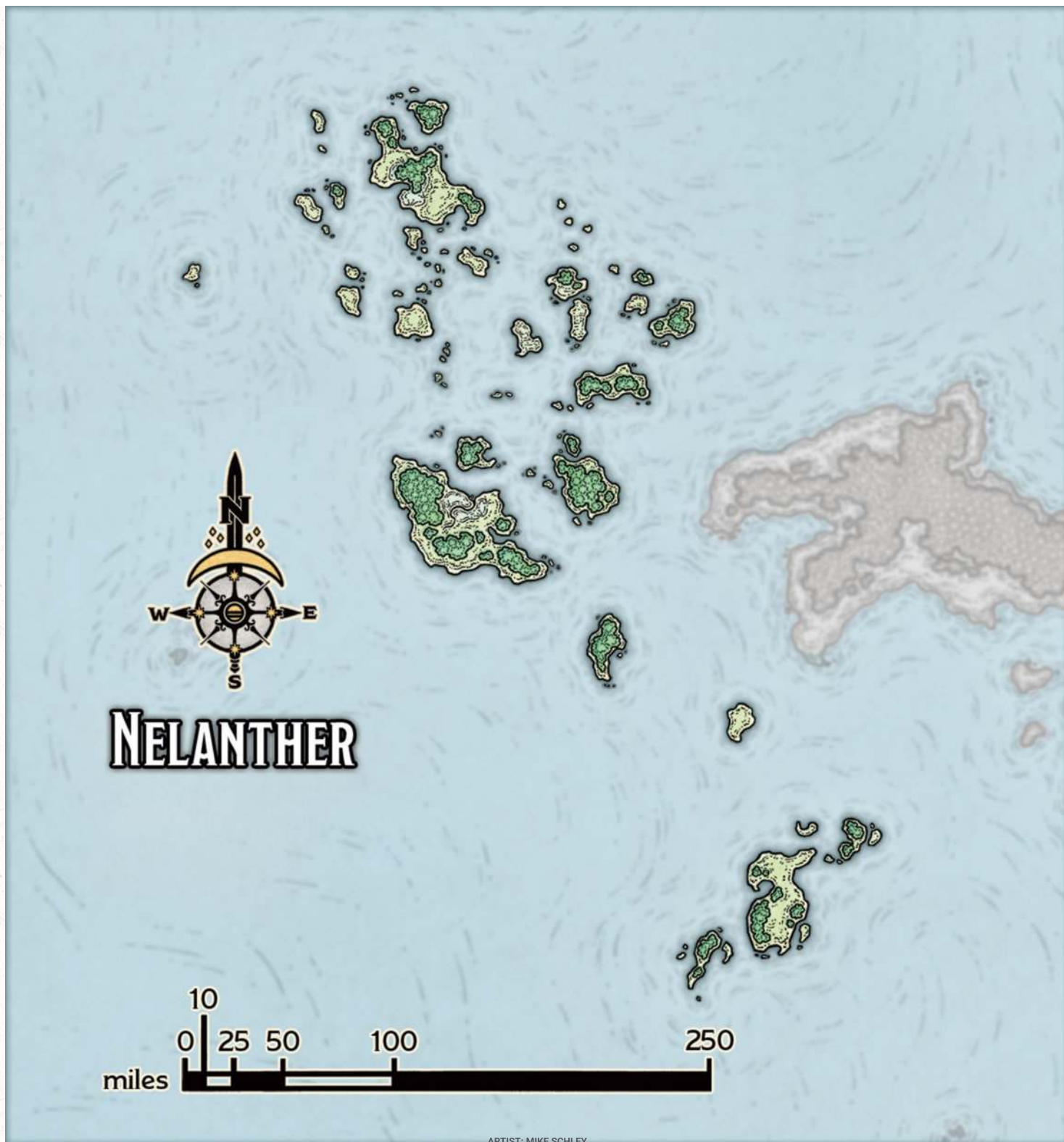
Norland. When Norlanders first sailed to the Moonshaes, they landed on the cold island now known as Norland. It remains the seat of Norlander culture in the Moonshaes. Jarl Olfsvenn is loyal to High King Kendrick, but he's torn by the fact his sister has fallen victim to the Rusting curse and taken on a new identity as Queen Forfallen. Overfishing in the Sea of Moonshae has brought the Rusting to Rogarsheim, and dockworkers show the signs of exposure to the curse: rust-colored marks around the eyes and a hacking cough.

Oman's Isle. Giants and their goliath kin live in well-established steadings and ancient Ostorian ruins all over Oman's Isle. Visitors can safely land at Trondheim, which is overseen by goliaths working for the giants.

Snowdown. The island of Snowdown is a blight on the Moonshaes. The Rusting first manifested at its only moonwell, located near the center of the island. Attempts to rein in environmental destruction caused by Amn have proved futile, and the island's population shrinks each year.



MAP: NELANTHER (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



ARTIST: MIKE SCHLEY

Beyond the major islands and archipelagos, unaffiliated islands dot the sea—and some mysterious sites lie hidden under the waves.

Gundarlun. Gundarlun, west of Neverwinter, experiences wintry weather most of the year, and its Northlander population is regularly terrorized by Arveiatrace, a white dragon from the North. Off the island's southwest coast lies the wreck of the *Golden Crown*, a Calishite merchant vessel that was carrying a vast cargo of gold, silver, electrum, and gemstones when it sank in a storm. A wizard named Hoch Miraz also went down with the ship. Its treasure has never been recovered.

Maelstrom. The storm giant stronghold of Maelstrom sits on the seafloor somewhere between Ruathym, the Whalebones, and the Moonshaes. Serissa, the titular queen of all giantkind, resides here. A natural whirlpool occasionally manifests far above the palace, wrecking ships and dragging them down to the seafloor.

Mother-of-Mists. Adventurers from Chult and Lantan alike have journeyed to Mother-of-Mists in search of treasure, finding nothing but danger. Poisonous vapors and smoke mix with cold sea winds to create the ever-present mists for which this volcanic island is known.

The Nelanther. Riddled with communities of monstrous pirates, the Nelanther islands have few resources and are plagued with infighting. Ancient towers guarded by monsters and magic wards jut from several of the isles and even from the sea itself. The Nelanther's pirates avoid these towers out of a mix of fear and superstition.

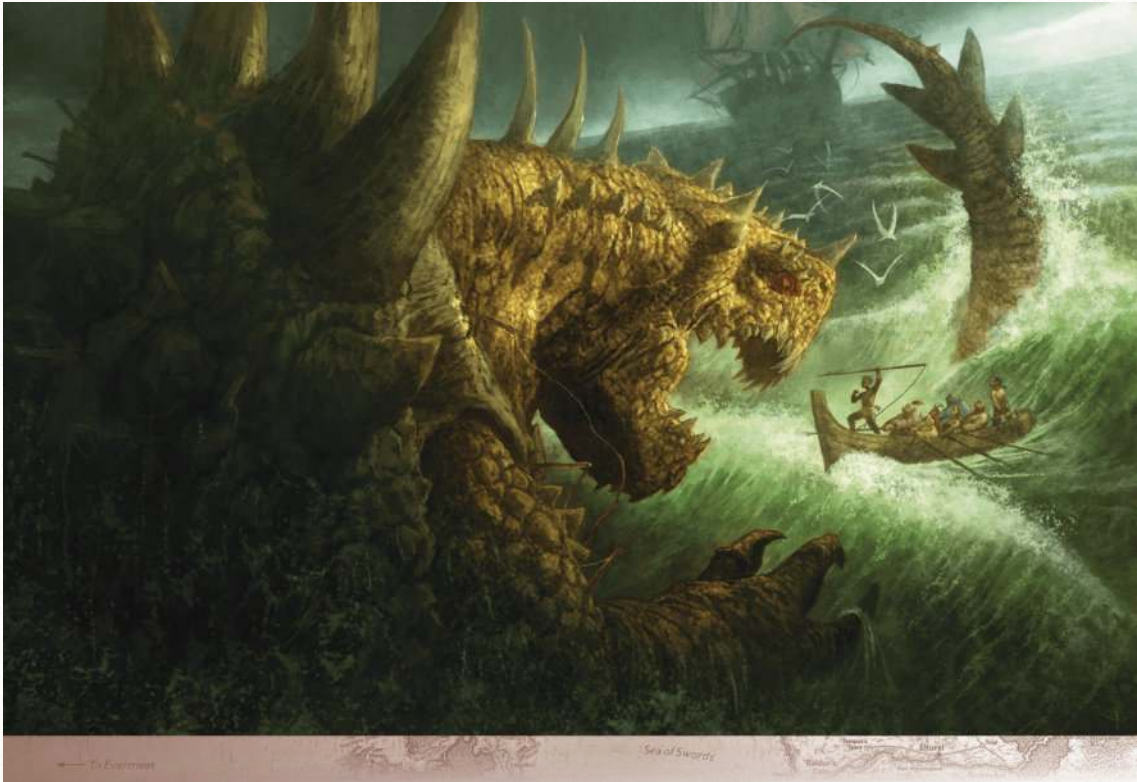
Northlander Isles. Norlander culture originated long ago on the bleak, mountainous island of Ruathym in the Northlander Isles, north of the Moonsea Isles. Most Norlanders left these isles long ago in favor of more hospitable climates, but a few scattered steadings remain. Queen Forfallen, a Rusted pirate queen and Norlander, uses Ruathym as a safe port.

Purple Rocks. Few have visited the distant Purple Rocks archipelago, far to the west of Neverwinter and so named because it appears dark purple under stormy skies. Those who return report its friendly inhabitants sport odd piscine features and also note an odd lack of children and elders.

Sea of Swords. The Sea of Swords is a cold and storm-wracked gulf. Most of the Sword Coast's trade routes hug close to the shore.

Tuern. Red dragons and fire giants war constantly on the volcanic island of Tuern, far to the north and west. For decades, they demanded tribute from Tuern's Humanoid population. When the people finally refused, the dragons and giants began conscripting them as disposable infantry in their brutal wars. People in Mintarn who have heard of Tuern see it as a cautionary tale.

Whalebones. Whales come to die for reasons unknown at a set of islands called the Whalebones. The shores are littered with their bleached-white bones. Rocs perch on the mountaintops while petty self-proclaimed "kings" of the tiny islets squabble among each other for power.



WHALERS IN THE TRACKLESS SEA SOMETIMES FIND MORE THAN THEY BARGAINED FOR.
ARTIST: HELGE C. BALZER

LIFE IN THE TRACKLESS SEA

No matter what island they dock on, outsiders quickly discover that life in the Trackless Sea can be quite different than life on the mainland.

Denizens of the Deep. Entire realms lie hidden beneath Faerûn's waves. Storm giants live in great palaces on the seafloor. Merfolk live in sunlit shallows, while monstrous merrow and sahuagin lair in dark grottoes but surface to feast on innocents. Sea elves are much rarer in the Trackless Sea than they are in the inland Sea of Fallen Stars, as they're hunted relentlessly in these waters by sahuagin and their malenti spies—a breed of sahuagin with the appearance of sea elves.

Piracy. Pirates abound in the Trackless Sea. Norlander culture has a long history of piracy and raiding, sometimes harrying the mainland's merchant vessels along the Sea of Swords. Mercenaries from Mintarn sell their services to privateering crews. But the most fearsome pirates hail from the monstrous Nelanther Isles. These ogre, lizardfolk, and minotaur buccaneers aren't bound by codes of honor; they torture their victims and leave them to hideous deaths. They prey on the shipping routes of Amn, Calimshan, the Sword Coast, and the Moonshaes, and they war on each other as often as they war on outsiders.

Ships. The lightly built galleys favored in more sheltered waters don't fare well in the winds and storms of the Trackless Sea. Savvy seafarers opt for bigger, more durable sailing ships instead. The Norlanders of Ruathym and the Moonshaes build swift yet sturdy longships, equipped with smaller, specialized boats called whaleboats for whaling. They are among the most recognizable ships on the seas, but a trained eye can recognize any vessel's land of origin by its size, shape, and build, even if the ship isn't flying any flags.

Umberlee Worship. Inhabitants of the Trackless Sea are ever-wary of Umberlee, the Wavemother. Cultists strike fear into the hearts of sailors, warning of Umberlee's ire and demanding passage on ships. Each coastal city maintains shrines to the cruel sea god, and sailors leave flowers or small candies in hopes Umberlee will show mercy on a ship's next voyage. Savvy pirate crews have been known to recruit priests of Umberlee to trap unsuspecting merchant ships in whirlpools or devastate towns with tsunamis before a pillage.

VILHON REACH

OVERVIEW

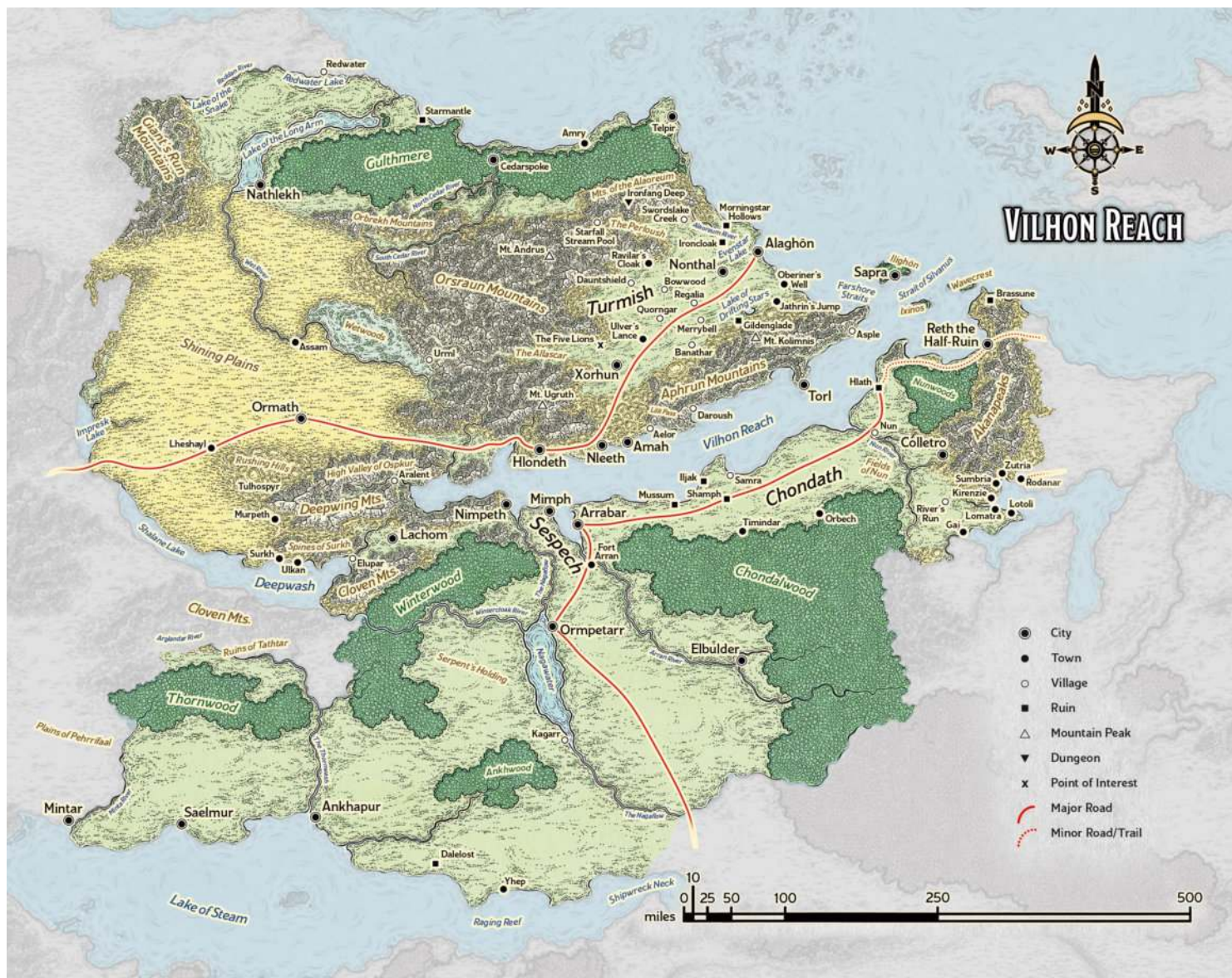
At a Glance: The Emerald Enclave helps to maintain balance between people and nature in this region.

Realms: Chondath, Sespech, Shining Plains, Turmish, independent city-states

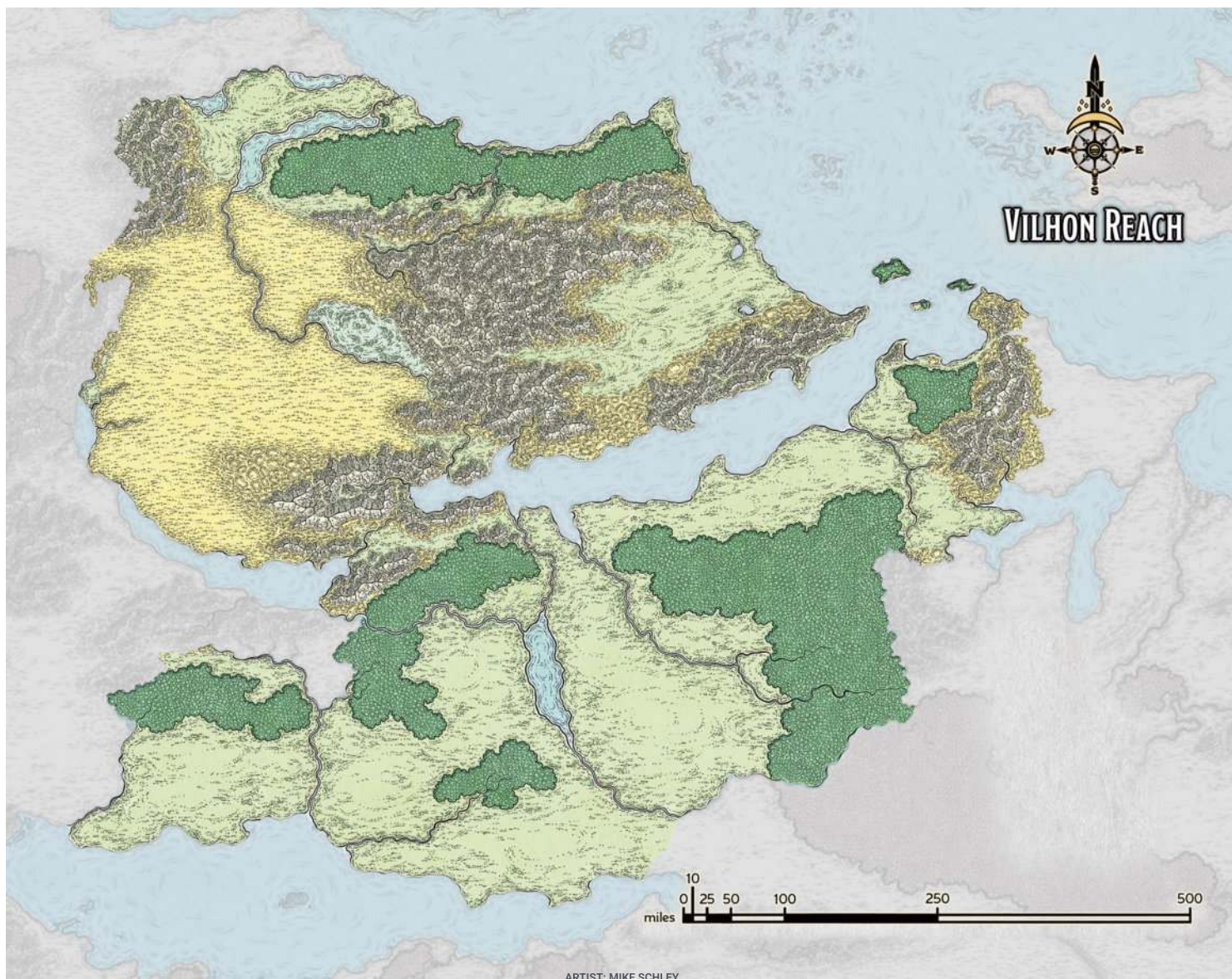
Languages: Chondathan, Shaaran, Turmic

Landmarks: Alaghôn, Arrabar, Chondalwood, Gultmere, Ilighôn, Ormpetarr, Orsraun Mountains, Shining Plains

Threats: Plagues, volcanic activity



MAP 02.014: VILHON REACH (DM-VERSION ABOVE, PLAYER-VERSION BELOW)



The subtropical Vilhon Reach lies southwest of the Sea of Fallen Stars, situated along its eponymous gulf. **Nature** is more respected here than in other areas of Faerûn, a result of both the Emerald Enclave's enormous influence on the region and the region's history of natural disasters.

People wary of magic often settle in the Vilhon, since some of its cities have laws that curtail or even ban spellcasting. Some Thayan commoners desperate to escape the rule of Red Wizards speak in whispers of Ilighôn, an island in the Vilhon Reach where no divination magic can find them.

Adventures in this region might explore philosophical themes about the role of magic in society or people's struggle to coexist with nature. They might be wizards on the run, druids and rangers in search of training, or mercenaries hired to capture fugitive spellcasters. The realm of Chondath also provides the opportunity for heroes to help small towns and villages extricate themselves from the grasp of a greedy nation, whether by diplomacy or force.

CHONDATH

Chondath was once a large and powerful realm comprising all of the southern Vilhon Reach, with distant colonies in the land now known as Sembia. Military defeats and numerous plagues led Chondath to shrink in on itself over a millennium. Then the Spellplague decimated nearly all of Chondath's coastal settlements, sealing the dying realm's fate.

Today, Chondath is but a shell of its former glory. Its capital city Arrabar still stands, desperately demanding increasingly exorbitant taxes from the tiny towns of Samra, Timindar, and Orbech—all three of which are considering secession. Adventurers flock to Chondath to see what abandoned treasures lie amid the ruined cities of Mussum, Iljak, Shamph, and Hlath.

Arrabar. Arrabar, capital of Chondath, is a city determined to hold on to the last vestiges of its realm's old splendor. Lady Udriana Wianar rules Arrabar and the realm from a grand palace called the Generon. Her family, along with Arrabar's many nobles, lead decadent lifestyles funded by the rest of Chondath.

Chondalwood. Rumor has it that a city-state of reclusive wood elves called Rucien-Xan lies hidden somewhere in the Chondalwood forest. Those who've searched the woods have found only monsters, raucous satyrs, territorial druids, and Ghostwise halflings—a distrustful and uncharacteristically ferocious clan of halflings with telepathic gifts.

SESPECH

Once a barony of Chondath, Sespech gained its independence centuries ago after a civil war called the Rotting War. It has defended itself fiercely ever since. With its neighbor Chondath in decline, Sespech now has little use for its military. Many of Sespech's former soldiers have turned to lives of adventure, roaming the Vilhon Reach and beyond. They're often surprised and disturbed by the magic they find, for magic is more deeply suspect in Sespech than anywhere else in the Vilhon. In Sespech, the use of magic to charm or injure another person is a crime punishable by death.

Mimph. A prosperous Sespech trade city, Mimph relies almost entirely on its port—famously, no roads lead to Mimph. A strong navy is based here. Rivalry with nearby Arrabar is so intense that merchants prefer to do business with only one city or the other, so as to avoid inciting violence. Helm is Mimph's patron deity; Helm's large temple is protected by a chapter of the Order of the

Gauntlet (described in chapter 6).

Nagawater. A bobbing line of buoys lit by *Continual Flame* spells divides the freshwater lake of Nagawater. The northern half belongs to the realm of Sespech, and fishers from Ormpetarr fish there often. The southern half is inhabited by a peaceful guardian naga. Those who assume the naga is guarding some treasure and attempt to retrieve it generally end up drowned in the lake's still waters.

Ormpetarr. Ormpetarr, capital city of Sespech, rests along the Nagawater. Baron Yorik Maplefoot rules Sespech from a modest manor here. He is a curt halfling man of few words, well-respected by his people for his daily public court sessions in which he rules on issues brought to him by citizens.

Winterwood. Dim light filters through the dense canopy of the Winterwood's tall oaks and pines. A cool mist coats the ground like snow, giving the forest its name. Several orc communities call the Winterwood home; they defend their villages against hordes of berserk plant monsters.

TURMISH

The mercantile realm of Turmish, often called the heartland of the Vilhon Reach, is expertly managed and mostly peaceful. Most Turmishan folk are humans, but the realm is also home to many dwarves whose families emigrated from the nearby mountains, as well as other more recent immigrants. Turmishan merchants have a reputation as honest and fair traders.

This democratic republic's tall mountain ranges shield it from outside aggression. Turmish also intentionally stays out of its neighbors' conflicts, refusing to provide aid of any kind. It's a stance that has often drawn the temporary ire of nearby realms, but it's served Turmish well in the long term.

Alaghôn. A great fire blazed through Turmish's capital city Alaghôn a millennium ago, and Alaghôn's buildings have been constructed of stone ever since. Turmish children play hide-and-seek in this stone city's hundreds of cubbyholes and hiding places, sometimes discovering secret passages to long-forgotten dungeon complexes.

The citizens of Alaghôn hold free elections to appoint the Assembly of Stars, Turmish's ruling council. These elected officials then select one of their rank to be Lord of Turmish.

Aphrun Mountains. A handful of cloistered stone and fire goliath families live in the otherwise unsettled Aphrun Mountains, retreating to hidden caverns whenever Mount Kolimnis spouts ash or red dragons circle overhead.

The Five Lions. An infamous and remote inn, the Five Lions was the site of a massacre—nobles fleeing revolution in far-off Tethyr took refuge here, but rebels caught up with them and all were killed. Now the inn is a haven for mages hiding from legal persecution. They have perpetuated a rumor that the inn is haunted by the restless spirits of Tethyrian dead, and this provides cover for their activities, including magical instruction and experimentation.

Gildenglade. Gildenglade was once a thriving Turmish city populated by elves and dwarves. Then Mount Kolimnis erupted in 1423 DR, burying Gildenglade in volcanic mud and ash. Years later, after the lava had cooled, caves opened into the buried city. Dungeon delvers who explore these ruins find them eerily preserved—and teeming with monsters from the Underdark.

Gulthmere. Nobanion, a benevolent god worshiped as a divine protector of the region, is said to live in the Gulthmere forest. Folk say they've seen the regal lion-god prowl through the foliage or even leap to their defense. Some faithful worshipers of Nobanion pilgrimage from the Shining Plains to Gulthmere in hope of catching a glimpse of Nobanion.

Mount Andrus. A semi-active volcano, Mount Andrus famously destroyed the home of the Candlekairn orc clan a thousand years ago. The volcano is sacred to Talos, whose worshipers maintain a temple and shrines in the mountain's heart, where they ally with evil elementals and other monsters capable of surviving the blistering heat. But Mount Andrus also hides a *Time Gate*, a portal that sends all who use it backward in time. The gate is protected by Mystra, who forbids anyone except her handpicked champions from using it.

Orsraun Mountains. Kobolds and red dragons lurk in the uncharted Orsraun Mountains, and the dwarven city-kingdom of Ironfang Deep lies beneath the ranges' northwest mountains. Some dwarves have migrated from Ironfang to Turmish, but many Ironfang dwarves loathe that upper realm. Centuries ago, a warlord led Turmish into battle against Ironfang, and Ironfang's dwarves are slow to forget the lives lost.

Starfall Stream Pool. A popular vacation destination, this picturesque town in the foothills of the Orsraun Mountains is particularly famous as a place to celebrate the Festival of the Moon. But the cult of Malar preys on tourists during this time, and the town desperately hires mercenaries and adventurers to keep visitors safe.

Xorhun. Xorhun's population consists mostly of elves and gnomes. This Turmish city is built in the fashion of the great elven cities of old, with elegant towers and abundant trees. Twin and triplet births are unusually common here; the elves and gnomes consider this a blessing from their gods.

SHINING PLAINS

Shimmering heat waves rise from the vast, dry grassland of the Shining Plains most of the year, giving rise to its name. Centaurs and thri-kreen call these plains home. They maintain civil, if distant, relationships with the handful of towns within the plains. No unifying force controls the Shining Plains and the nearby hills, mountains, and swampy forest, but influences from across the Vilhon Reach extend here.

Deepwing Mountains. The Deepwing Mountains are named for the many winged monsters that call its heights home: manticores, griffons, hippogriffs, dragons, wyverns, and more.

Nathlekh. Cats abound in the independent city-state of Nathlekh, resting on rooftops and sipping milk from public troughs. Nearly everyone in this so-called City of Cats worships Nobanion, the lion-god rumored to roam in the nearby Gulthmere forest.

Wetwoods. Lizardfolk, bullywugs, and other bog-dwelling creatures call the misty Wetwoods home. Apart from some tiny halfling hamlets, the most notable settlement here is Urml, a village of reclusive bullywugs.

INDEPENDENT CITY-STATES

The Vilhon Reach is dotted with independent city-states. There was once a time when these city-states feared reannexation into the Chondathan empire, but that time has long since passed.

Hlondeth. Turmish carefully maintains a friendly relationship with this City of Serpents, which controls the only trade road out of Turmish. House Extaminos, a line of guileful yuan-ti, has ruled Hlondeth for centuries. Snakelike architecture and green marble buildings decorate its streets.

Ilighôn. The Emerald Enclave's leaders, an Elder Circle of druids, reside in the faction's headquarters on the verdant island of Ilighôn. Arcane magic doesn't function on the island; magic from primal or divine sources is unaffected. As such, Ilighôn's port city Sapra has become a haven for those seeking refuge from mages. The island is protected by the Seven Sentinels of Silvanus, colossal elementals that deter visitors and answer to the Emerald Enclave.

Locals of the Vilhon Reach call the islands of Wavecrest and Ilighôn the Eyes of Silvanus. Unlike its peaceful sister island, Wavecrest is an uninhabited and dangerous jungle teeming with ferocious beasts and monsters.

Ixinos. Very little is known about Ixinos, a small forested island at the entrance to the Vilhon Reach, as the people there repel all visitors and refuse to engage in diplomacy even with their neighbors on the Emerald Enclave isle of Ilighôn. The only known settlement is the port town Tazixor, where the mysterious queen of Ixinos keeps court. The isle is defended by a mercenary company called the She-Wolves, and most of what is known about Ixinos comes from these mercenaries, who travel the Reach in small groups selling their services.

Reth the Half-Ruin. Half of the independent city of Reth crumbled into the sea during the catastrophic events of the Spellplague. Some adventurers take the plunge, battling kuo-toa in those underwater ruins to find the lost treasures therein.



THE SEVEN SENTINELS OF SILVANUS PROTECT ILIGHÔN, HOME OF THE EMERALD ENCLAVE.
ARTIST: CHRIS RALLIS

LIFE IN THE VILHON REACH

In the wake of the Second Sundering, the Vilhon Reach has enjoyed a period of relative calm.

Emerald Enclave's Influence. The Emerald Enclave (described in chapter 6) was founded on the island of Ilighôn in the 4th century DR by a coalition of priests from Turmish and Chondath who were devoted to nature deities. Its influence remains greater in the Vilhon Reach than anywhere else in Faerûn. Thanks to this faction, folk across the Reach share an immense respect for nature. The few callous folk throughout history who have polluted the waters of the Reach or tried logging in protected forests have been met with the Emerald Enclave's unbridled wrath.

The Rotting War and Distrust of Magic. The Vilhon Reach's subtropical climate has, unfortunately, made it a perfect incubator for plagues throughout the region's history. None haunt its people's collective consciousness more than the magical contagion that ended the Rotting War. This Chondathan civil war began in 900 DR and gained its name when archmages from Arrabar and Hlath unleashed a necromantic plague. The rotting contagion decimated all sides of the conflict and spread beyond anyone's expectations. This plague has long since subsided, but Chondath, Sespech, and the independent city-states near them remain distrustful of magic as a result.

Spellmarks. A few villages and hamlets in the southern Vilhon Reach ask spellcasters to identify themselves by drawing a distinctive rune on their forehead with ink or chalk. This "spellmark" tradition derives from an old practice in the Vilhon wherein people would paint several circles on their forehead to indicate they could read or write—a tradition that became defunct as literacy rates rose.

Volcanic Activity. The volcanoes around Turmish are both a blessing and a curse: their ash creates the fertile soil for which Turmish is well known, but it has also laid waste to more than one Turmishan settlement. Mount Ugruth is long dormant, while Mount Kolimnis and Mount Andrus are still active. Turmishan spellcasters do their best to predict eruptions and keep their cities safe. Troublesome red dragons flock to the volcanoes' smoky heights to make their lairs.

BEYOND

Toril is a vast world with continents so far unexplored. And beyond Toril lie the worlds of Realmspace, visited by spelljammers and other travelers of the Astral Sea. Some locations that lie beyond the map are detailed below, but you can create additional realms as you like, making the Forgotten Realms even more your own.

CHULT

Chult is a land of tropical wilderness: dense jungles and snaky rivers ringed by mountains, volcanoes, and sheer escarpments. Walls of mountains to the west, south, and east shield the interior from the sea and from the view of sailors. The rivers are so sluggish that it can be difficult determining which direction is upstream and which is down. The rivers pick up speed only where they thunder down through steep-sided gorges.

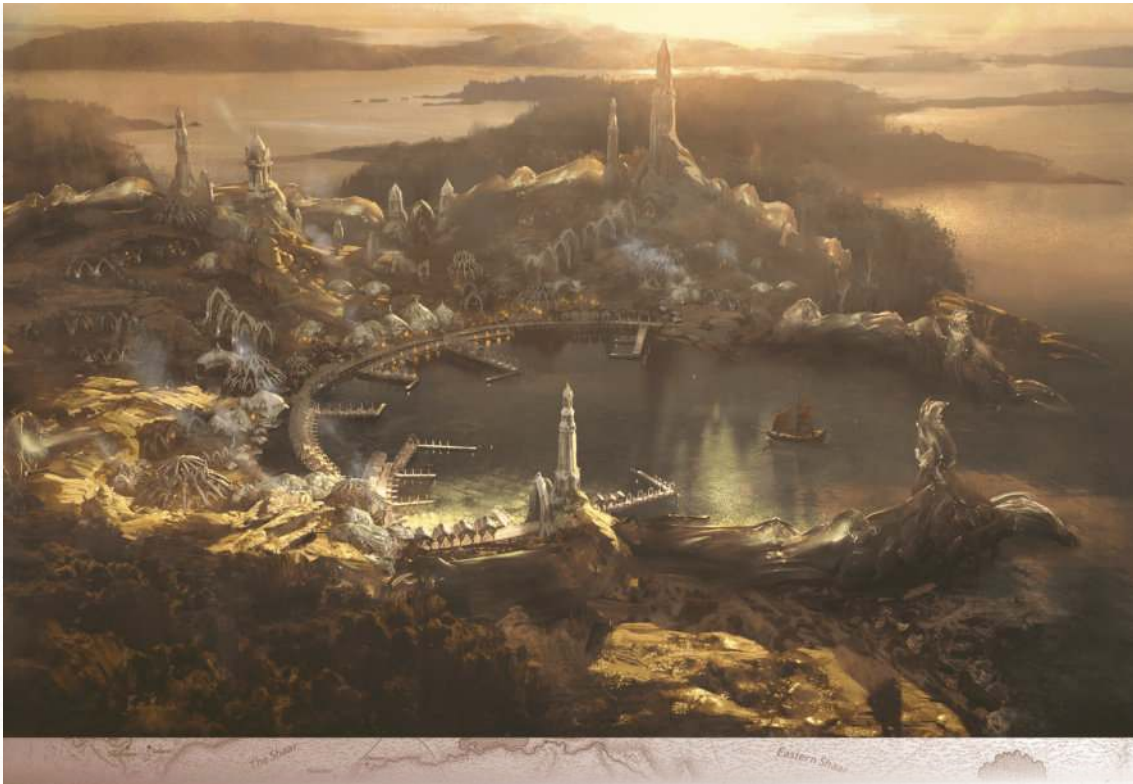
Chult has long been inhabited by bullywugs, dwarves, humans, goblins, and lizardfolk, as well as dinosaurs, hydras, wyverns, and other monsters. The people of Chult revere a deity named Ubtao, whose divine rival, Dendar the Night Serpent, is said to be imprisoned beneath volcanoes called the Peaks of Flame.

Chult's coast from the Bay of Chult to Refuge Bay offers beaches from which explorers embark into the jungle, but the Bay of Chult is the only spot that welcome travelers from afar. The rest of the peninsula is a breeding ground for bloodsucking, disease-bearing insects; monstrous reptiles; carnivorous birds and beasts of every variety; and murderous undead.

Two locations in Chult are described below; see *Tomb of Annihilation* for much more detail.

Mezro. The city of Mezro is widely thought to have been destroyed in the Spellplague. In fact, its inhabitants saved it through powerful magic, whisking it away into a demiplane and leaving only ruins behind. Some hints suggest the city will return when it is no longer in danger. The Flaming Fist, a mercenary company out of Baldur's Gate, has searched the ruins of Mezro extensively and still sends patrols there.

Port Nyanzaru. Port Nyanzaru hugs the coastline at the south end of the Bay of Chult. It's a colorful, musical, aroma-filled, vibrant city—the only city in Chult that isn't in ruins or overrun by monstrous creatures. The city is run by seven influential merchant princes. Other than trade, the biggest attractions are the weekly dinosaur races through the streets. Locals and visitors alike wager princely sums on the races' outcomes. The city also boasts grand bazaars, glorious mansions and temples, circuses, and gladiatorial contests.



THE ISLAND OF EVERMEET WAS CREATED IN THE SUNDERING.
ARTIST: PEDRO CARDOSO

EVERMEET

Almost twenty thousand years ago, elves used high magic to create a homeland for themselves. In the process, they devastated Toril in a cataclysmic disaster eventually known as the Sundering. But the island they created, Evermeet, remains. Elves from across Faerûn eventually travel to the island.

Evermeet is protected by many layers of defenses. First, it is magically warded to prevent navigators from finding the island. Winds and subtle currents turn ships aside, stars move in the sky, and powerful illusions hide the island itself. Only navigators entrusted with secret knowledge can find the way.

Second, a great navy shields Evermeet from enemies and allows the island nation to project its power into Faerûn when necessary. Elf merchants bring goods from Evermeet to markets in Faerûn and import anything the elves can't make themselves.

Finally, the capital city of Leuthilspar is protected by magically constructed walls of glass. Evermeet's Royal Council meets here.

Evermeet lies at a conjunction of three planes of existence: the Material Plane, the Feywild, and Arvandor. Non-elves aren't permitted to visit, but on very rare occasions, exceptions have been made, and at least one gnome has managed to reach the island by stowing away with an elf traveler.

LAKE OF STEAM

With independent city-states on the north shore and a succession of small countries founded or conquered by people of many different agendas to the south, the Lake of Steam is a hodgepodge of varying interests, bustling trade, and frequently changing boundaries. Most of the cities on the north shore were part of Calimshan in the past and retain Calimshan's desire for wealth, comfort, and influence, as well as a strong desire to remain independent. The intrigues brewing around these cities led observers to dub the northern shore the Moonsea of the South.

The Border Kingdoms on the southern shore are the homes of powerful adventurers of many types, each seeking to carve out a piece of land and rule it in the manner they prefer ... at least until the next would-be ruler decides to take over. Wizard towers, monasteries, fortresses, and temples dot the Border Kingdoms, only to have their owners replaced time and again.

Ankhapus. The city of Ankhapus boasts a thriving industry centered on pearls retrieved from the stinking yellow water of the Lake of Steam. The magnificent pearls prized from oysters that grow to enormous size fetch high prices in the markets of Calimshan and Amn.

THE SHAAR

The Shaar is a vast, rolling grassland running from the Shining Sea to the distant lands of the east. Nomadic humans (the dozen or so tribes of the Shaaryan), centaurs, and gnolls populate the Shaar, hunting and herding various animals, and occasionally raiding each other. The land supports its native grasses splendidly but is ill suited for agriculture—it's not a desert, but the land bakes by day and freezes by night.

The dozen or so nomad tribes known collectively as the Shaaryan have never been unified, though they share a common culture and way of life. Shaaryan humans seldom stray in large numbers from their ancestral plains, largely because their horses don't do well outside the Shaar.

Lhesper. This ruined city is home to a powerful clan of yuan-ti. Human travelers along the shores of Lake Lhespen often fall prey to bandits under yuan-ti domination and are carried back to a terrible fate in Lhesper—usually sacrifice to the yuan-ti's evil god, but sometimes transformation into monstrous servitors to the serpent race. The Shaaryan give it a wide berth.

Shaarmid. A free trading city populated mostly by human folk who claim no kinship with the Shaaryan nomads, Shaarmid is accepted by the tribes as a longtime ally because the city's people have a history of brokering excellent deals for the nomads with the traders from the rest of Faerûn. Merchants flock to Shaarmid for safety from Shaaryan bandits and other raiders.

SOSSAL

The remote realm of Sossal, far to the north of Narfell, has little contact with the rest of Faerûn. Once or twice a year (generally in the summer), visitors from Sossal arrive in Damara, bringing furs, seal meat from the Great Glacier, beautiful items of shaped wood, and gold. They leave with dwarven weapons, silver, and various kinds of meat to trade with the people of the glacier. Some Sossrim wield druidic magic to bend plants to their will, pass through undergrowth impenetrable to others, or even transport themselves from one tree to another. In fact, the ornate and smoothly shaped Sossar furniture sold so steeply in Sembia isn't carved at all, but sculpted by the minds of Sossrim "carvers."

CHAPTER 3

GODS OF FAERÛN



ARTIST: CHRIS RAHN



SELÛNE THE MOONMAIDEN, AND SHAR, MISTRESS OF THE NIGHT, ARE SISTERS AND DIVINE RIVALS.

WHEN THE PEOPLE OF FAERÛN FIND THEMSELVES IN NEED, THEY TURN TO THEIR GODS. THE GODS PLAY A ROLE IN THE LIVES OF NEARLY EVERYONE, FROM THE MIGHTIEST lord to the most unfortunate urchin.

FORMS OF WORSHIP

The average person worships different gods in different contexts. Most vocations have a patron deity: farmers make offerings to Chauntea for the prosperity of their crops, clerks sharpen their quills with a prayer to Deneir, and pious merchants set coins aside for Waukeen at the end of the day. Most people worship a deity associated with their livelihood, family, or home, while others feel called to a particular god for other reasons. Individuals might carry or wear a small token of their favored deity: a pendant or a pin in the image of the god's holy symbol or another personal keepsake.

In addition, people venerate gods based on their needs and circumstances. A farmer who favors Chauntea might pray to Amaunator for a few clear, sunny days, and a Waterdeep noble who worships Deneir might give thanks to Sune after a wedding celebration for her son. Even zealous priests of specific gods acknowledge the roles that other deities play in the world and in their lives.

Worshippers view their relationships with the gods as practical and reciprocal. They pray and make offerings because those rituals invite the blessings of the gods and turn away divine wrath. They quietly perform acts of devotion at shrines in their households or neighborhoods, or they visit temples dedicated to a god when they feel the need to demand the god's attention.

Forms of worship include verbal prayer—giving thanks for favor shown, acknowledging the god's dominion and influence, and offering praise for the deity's interventions, large and small. These prayers are typically accompanied by postures of supplication or praise, and sometimes by offerings of incense, burning herbs, small animals, or monetary gifts. Because most people don't want to attract the ire of cruel or wicked gods, beseeching those gods to keep the peace is also an act of worship. A student, farmer, or gambler might pray to

Beshaba to avert bad luck, and a sailor might make sacrifices to Umberlee to avert her wrath for the length of a voyage.

NEW AND FOREIGN GODS

The Faerûnian pantheon isn't the only one on Toril. Elves, dwarves, and other Humanoid species honor their own gods, for example, and people in faraway lands might worship different gods entirely. Occasionally, foreigners bring the worship of these gods to Faerûn. On rare occasions, a new god comes into being, perhaps a mortal elevated to godhood or a deity whose arrival was foretold by prophets and leaders of new religions. In cosmopolitan places such as Waterdeep and Calimport, small shrines and temples to strange gods spring up from time to time.

Over generations, a new god might join the pantheon. Scholars posit that Faerûn has many such gods who joined the pantheon's ranks so long ago that their origins are lost to antiquity.

DEAD AND RESURRECTED GODS

Over and over, mourning bells have tolled for deities of the Realms. Gods were struck down when ancient Netheril fell during the Time of Troubles and more recently when the Spellplague wrought its destruction. Some deities have even been slain by mortals wielding impossibly powerful magic.

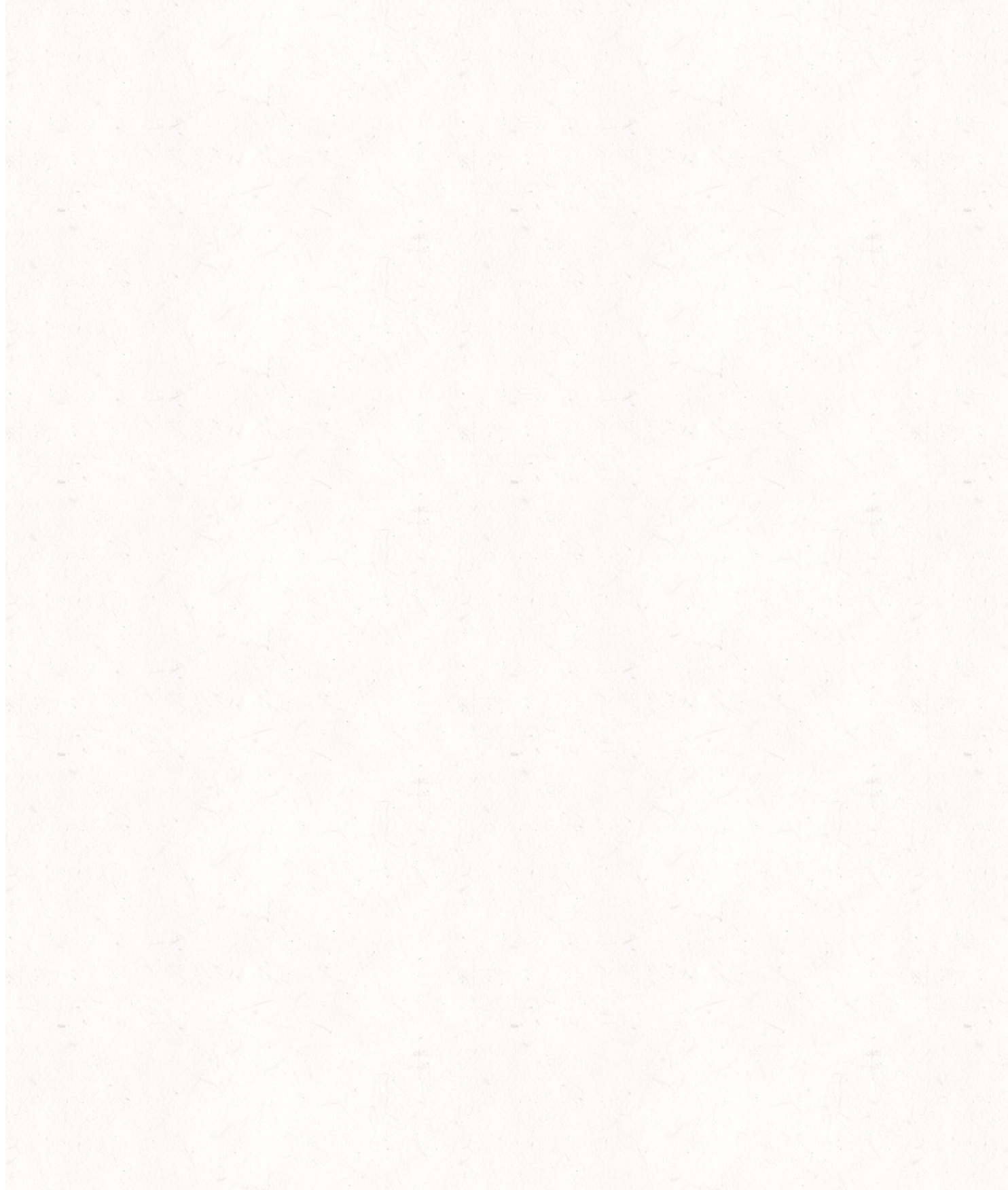
When a god withdraws from a pantheon, miracles and omens associated with that god cease, the deity's priesthood loses faith, and holy sites are abandoned or taken over by other faiths. Clerics devoted to a dead deity don't lose their ability to access divine power and cast spells; once that power has been unlocked, it can't be taken away by the mere death of a deity.

To a deity's worshipers, it is immaterial whether the god is truly dead or merely dormant—the consequences for them are the same either way. Yet, as recent events have borne out, a god who has vanished might not remain absent forever. Supposedly dead gods have returned and amassed a new body of worshipers, most notably in the Second Sundering, when several gods long presumed dead reappeared or returned to life.

THE AFTERLIFE

The souls of the recently deceased travel to the Fugue Plane, a demiplane within the Astral Sea. There, they wander the great City of Judgment, often unaware they are dead. Servants of the gods come to collect such souls and, if the souls are worthy, take them to their awaited afterlife in the deity's domain. Occasionally, the faithful are sent back to be reborn into the world to finish work they'd left undone.

Souls unclaimed by the servants of the gods are judged by Kelemvor, who decides the fate of each one. Some become guides for lost souls, while others are transformed into squirming larvae and cast into the dust.



RELIGIOUS INSTITUTIONS

The priests of the gods serve their deities and their deity's faithful through commonplace tasks that don't necessarily require magic. The majority of priests aren't Clerics. Indeed, the gods invest power in Clerics and other divine spellcasters (see "Divine Magic" below) in accordance with their own whims and needs.

The kind of person attracted to a deity's priesthood depends on the tenets of that god: the cunning scoundrels who venerate Mask have little in common with the upright law keepers of Tyr, and neither understand the delightful revelers who revere Lliira.

TEMPLES AND SHRINES

The core religious institutions of Faerûn are temples and shrines. Whether a small, out-of-the-way building or a complex of multiple structures built on many acres of land, each temple operates according to the traditions of its faith. Occasionally, powerful or charismatic figures who rise to prominence within the temple hierarchy motivate or inspire changes to those traditions.

Temples in Faerûn don't usually conduct regular public services. Group observances in a temple occur only at specific festival times, and priests go out into the community to perform rites such as marriages and funerals. Worshipers visit temples to spend personal or family time in a space consecrated to a deity or to seek the aid of the priests for personal reasons.

Small shrines and private chapels are common throughout Faerûn, particularly in areas that lack an official temple. Shrines tend to be unstaffed, kept up by the locals and visitors who use the place for prayer. A shrine might be as modest as a roadside well where traveling merchants can drop a coin to request good fortune from Waukeen, or as grand as a statue of Amaunator surrounded by braziers in a pavilion in the middle of a village.

Traveling priests visit these sites, which serve as meeting places for the faithful. For example, when word gets around that a traveling priest of Eldath has come into town, the faithful seek them out at the holy spring at the edge of town dedicated to the god.

Personal shrines abound: A family or business maintains a shrine or a chapel to its favored deity. A fighting school sets a room aside for a lanceboard set dedicated to the Red Knight, or a local mage displays a wooden symbol shaped like the hand of Azuth on a prominent wall, with a space nearby to burn a candle or incense.

COMMUNING WITH THE GODS

Though tales speak of times past when the gods appeared in physical form and walked the land, deities rarely appear in Faerûn. Instead, the gods communicate with their faithful through signs and omens. Of course, some signs are subtler—and thus more open to interpretation—than others.

Priests and worshipers commune with their deities through prayer, song, and meditation. Such experiences are intensely personal, and few worshipers care to relate details of such profound vulnerability. Each worshiper communes with their deity in their own way.

Divine magic provides a direct means of communing with the gods and calling on their guidance. Divine pronouncements of this sort are often brief and personal, and edicts that concern broader matters tend to be open to interpretation or debate.

GODS AND GENDER

Like all gods (as described in chapter 3 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*), the gods of the Faerûnian pantheon are beyond mortal understanding and have no fixed appearance or gender. However, during the Time of Troubles, all the gods of Faerûn manifested in mortal form on the world, making them extremely concrete in their worshipers' eyes. For that reason, many people in Faerûn think of their gods as having a fixed gender and even a certain physical appearance, remembered from that cosmic event. But in truth, the gods of Faerûn—even the ones that were mortal and ascended to godhood—are no more bound to those limited conceptions of bodily form than any other deities.



A PRIEST OF LATHANDER LEADS FOLLOWERS IN A RELIGIOUS CEREMONY.

Priesthood is a vocation, where those who undertake the profession hone their abilities through a system of apprenticeship. At a small temple, a novice or an acolyte studies under the single priest available. Larger temples accommodate groups of acolytes, each learning under the direction of one or more mentors responsible for training them in performing the gods' rites and tending their followers.

Once an acolyte completes their education, they are ordained in a ritual that invests a successful candidate with the responsibilities of the priesthood.

RELIGION AND THE LAW

The moral and ethical values of the deities in Faerûn express a range of predilections and are embraced by mortals who share those ideals, from principled agents of good to vicious proponents of evil. As a result, worship of certain deities might be frowned on in some places.

It's impossible to prevent individuals from innocuously or secretly worshiping whichever deities they choose, so restrictions on the worship of specific deities focus on formal temples, priesthoods, and organized festivals. For instance, worship of Talona is forbidden in Waterdeep, like that of many evil gods. This prohibition extends only to the creation of a temple and the presence of her priesthood within the city. Individual citizens or families who revere Talona might be viewed as misguided, but they aren't taken into custody or punished as long as they obey the laws of the city.

Some places take these restrictions a step further. A tyrant might outlaw worship of Torm lest it inspire rebellion, and an otherwise fair-minded mayor of a river-mill community could demand that worshipers of Silvanus find elsewhere to live because the timber cutters have had run-ins with the local druids.

DIVINE MAGIC

The gods show their favor toward mortals in myriad ways. A fortunate few have their minds and souls opened to the power of magic. There is no formula for who receives this divine insight, as the gods keep their own counsel concerning their selections. Some of the favored ignore or deny their gift, while others embrace it wholeheartedly.

ARTIST: PATRIK HELL



**ENVER GORTASH, CHOSEN OF BANE, PLANS
HIS TAKEOVER OF THE CITY OF BALDUR'S GATE.**

Some who display the potential for divine magic develop and practice their abilities in a temple, a sacred grove, or another spiritual place, perhaps in the company of fellow students. Other practitioners of divine magic discover and nurture their gods-given power on their own.

CHOSEN

When a deity wants to take direct action, they turn to their Chosen, powerful mortal agents of a deity. Some deities rely more heavily on Chosen than others, but it's unusual for a deity to go without a Chosen, and most deities imbue several Chosen at the same time.

How a deity selects their Chosen, and the unique magic they grant to those Chosen, varies by deity. In rare cases, an individual might not realize they're Chosen.

DEITIES OF FAERÛN

The gods that make up the pantheon of Faerûn are an eclectic blend of deities. The makeup of the pantheon has shifted over the ages as a result of changes in the Realms and its people.

The following pages describe the most prominent members of the pantheon and their followers, priests, and holy sites; these deities are summarized in the Faerûnian Pantheon table. Each entry details how followers of the deity are expected to act and what they're expected to do, and includes suggestions on how the deity might communicate with their followers. Finally, each entry notes how the deity selects their Chosen and what, if any, special powers and responsibilities those Chosen might have.

The deities of the Faerûnian pantheon are by no means the only powers worshiped in the Realms. Scattered cults and local divinities thrive across Faerûn.

Throughout this section, if a creature's name appears in **bold** type, you'll find that creature's stat block in the *Monster Manual*.

Faerûnian Pantheon

Deity	Home Plane	Typical Worshipers
Amaunator, god of the sun	Mechanus	Farmers, lawmakers, travelers
Asmodeus, god of indulgence	The Nine Hells (Nessus)	Corrupt politicians, desperate folk
Auril, god of winter	Pandemonium (Pandesmos)	Druids, inhabitants of cold climates
Azuth, god of wizardry	Arcadia (Buxenus)	Arcane spellcasters
Bane, god of tyranny	Acheron (Avalas)	Conquerors, Fighters, Monks, tyrants
Beshaba, god of misfortune	The Abyss	Gamblers, Red Wizards, Rogues
Bhaal, god of murder	Gehenna (Khalas)	Assassins, murderers
Chauntea, god of agriculture	Elysium (Eronia)	Farmers, gardeners, homesteaders
Cyric, god of lies	Pandemonium (Cocytus)	Liars, manipulators, power-hungry folk
Deneir, god of writing	Elysium (Amoria)	Sages, scribes, students, teachers
Eilistraee, god of song and moonlight	Arborea (Arvador)	Bladesingers, elves, performing artists
Eldath, god of peace	Elysium (Eronia)	Druids, pacifists, the dying
Gond, god of craft	The Outlands	Artificers, crafters, engineers, inventors
Helm, god of watchfulness	Mechanus	Explorers, Fighters, guards, Paladins
Ilmater, god of endurance	Bytopia (Shurrock)	Monks, the oppressed, the poor
Kelemvor, god of the dead	Astral Plane (Fugue Plane)	Funeral workers, the dying
Lathander, god of dawn and renewal	Elysium (Eronia)	Aristocrats, athletes, merchants, youths
Leira, god of illusion	Limbo	Actors, con artists, Illusionists, Rogues
Lliira, god of joy	Arborea (Arvador)	Bards, dancers, poets, revelers, singers
Lolth, god of spiders	The Abyss (Demonweb Pits)	Evil drow, folk who travel the Underdark
Loviatar, god of pain	Gehenna (Mungoth)	Those suffering from pain or betrayal
Malar, god of the hunt	Carceri (Colothys)	Barbarians, hunters, lycanthropes
Mask, god of thieves	Hades (Niflheim)	Assassins, Rogues, thieves, tricksters
Mielikki, god of forests	The Beastlands (Krigala)	Fey, foresters, Rangers
Milil, god of poetry and song	Elysium (Amoria)	Bards, orators, poets, singers
Myrkul, god of death	Hades (Oinos)	Necromancers, undead
Mystra, god of magic	Elysium (Eronia)	Anyone who uses magic
Oghma, god of knowledge	The Outlands	Archivists, cartographers, sages
Red Knight, god of strategy	Arcadia (Buxenus)	Fighters, game players, strategists
Selûne, god of the moon	Ysgard (Ysgard)	Lycanthropes, sailors, spellcasters
Shar, god of darkness and loss	Hades (Niflheim)	Anyone suffering pain or loss
Shaundakul, god of travel	Ysgard (Ysgard)	Guides, explorers, Rangers, travelers
Silvanus, god of wild nature	The Outlands	Barbarians, Druids, Rangers, wood elves
Sune, god of love and beauty	Arborea (Arvador)	Artists, hedonists, lovers
Talona, god of poison and disease	Carceri (Cathrys)	Those suffering from plague
Talos, god of storms	Pandemonium (Pandesmos)	Barbarians, Druids, raiders
Tempus, god of war	Limbo	Fighters, mercenaries, warriors
Torm, god of courage and self-sacrifice	Mount Celestia (Mercuria)	Guardians, knights, Paladins
Tymora, god of good fortune	Arborea (Arvador)	Gamblers, Harpers, merchants, Rogues
Tyr, god of justice	Mount Celestia (Lunia)	Judges, law enforcers, lawyers, Paladins
Umberlee, god of the sea	The Abyss	Coastal dwellers, sailors
Waukeen, god of trade	The Outlands	Merchants, the rich, traders

AMAUNATOR

The Keeper of the Eternal Sun, the Light of Law, the Yellow God

ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA



The rule of law and the glory of the sun both fall in Amaunator's dominion. He is a stern and unforgiving god, concerned with keeping promises and maintaining order.

Amaunator's followers believe he has died and been reborn time and again. They quarrel with followers of Lathander over whether Lathander is an aspect of Amaunator or is a separate deity. Either way, Lathander represents the optimistic light of dawn, while Amaunator represents the sun in all aspects. At times, the sun is warm and encouraging; at others, harsh and unforgiving. What matters most is that it reliably rises each day and sets each night.

When Amaunator sends a messenger, its presence is unmistakable: a **Couatl** or a seemingly ordinary bird with gleaming eyes like miniature suns descends from the heavens in a shaft of bright light. Amaunator also communicates with his followers via dreams in which the darkness of night is suddenly vanquished by the broad daylight.

The folk of Faerûn invoke Amaunator's name when praying for sunny weather, swearing oaths, signing contracts, and declaring laws. The connection between a solemn oath and the light of the sun is ingrained in the people of Faerûn; those closing deals or issuing edicts often pause and wait for a passing cloud to clear the sun before completing the transaction or pronouncement.

Amaunator's priests help establish bureaucracies and order in communities. They witness contracts and signed agreements, signifying these documents' validity by stamping them with the god's sun symbol. Temples to Amaunator feature courtyards and skylights to invite the god's bright gaze. In underground settlements or places plagued by cloud cover, his temples mount a torch with a **Continual Flame** spell cast on it over their doorway to symbolize the sun. Amaunator's temples keep extensive records of their surrounding community's laws and legal proceedings. Most temples make these records available to the public for transparency. In places where corruption has spread even to Amaunator's temples, access to these records cost a hefty sum.

The Chosen of Amaunator master magic that dispels darkness and unveils hidden truths. Some work to enforce the law across the land; others become magistrates in Faerûn's highest courts.

ASMODEUS

The Cloven, the Lord of the Ninth, Old Hoof and Horn

ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA



Both a god of indulgence and an archdevil, Asmodeus rules over his devilish kin from the bottommost layer of the Nine Hells. Asmodeus promises his followers pleasures and powers beyond their wildest dreams—for a price.

Asmodeus's reputation for uneven bargains precedes him. Even so, folk of all moral leanings strike deals with the archdevil when they have nowhere else to turn. For instance, when followers of other deities transgress against their patrons, these folk might bargain with Asmodeus to hide their sins from the other gods. Asmodeus is charismatic and seemingly generous when he needs to be, and his messengers are as silver-tongued as he is. When attempting to manipulate a mortal into entering a pact with him, he sends a snake or an unassuming **Imp**. He also enjoys using **Erinyes** as messengers, since unwitting mortals might mistake them for angels. The birth of an animal with nine legs or nine eyes is considered an omen of Asmodeus's influence.

Most cities don't explicitly outlaw the worship of Asmodeus. However, individuals who openly follow him earn the distrust of society, and temples to this archdevil are almost unheard of. Instead, many of Asmodeus's followers keep hidden shrines to the god in their homes.

Priests who serve Asmodeus exploit individuals who succumb to greed and impatience. If a priest of Asmodeus fails to sway a potential worshiper with rewards in this life, the priest tempts them with promises about the afterlife instead. Many individuals fear their souls will languish for centuries in the Fugue Plane after death, awaiting Kelemvor's judgment. Asmodeus's priests promise such individuals that a devil will comfort their waiting soul or whisk them off to the Nine Hells, where they can assume a rank in the infernal host.

Asmodeus's priests obey the commands of his Chosen, feigning humility just as lesser devils do with greater devils. Chosen of Asmodeus can gaze into people's souls, judging their character at a glance. This ability allows the Chosen to discern whether someone's soul has been claimed by a particular deity or whether their fate is still undetermined.

AURIL

The Cold Crone, the Frostmaiden, Icedawn

ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA



Auril, the merciless god of cold indifference, embodies winter's cruelty. Auril's beloved ice grips all things in her clutches, preserving them against the ravages of time. She hoards beauty in all forms, from art objects and flowers to skilled artisans and their wondrous works, freezing them in magical ice for her pleasure alone. If she deigns to speak to a mortal, her voice whispers like icy needles on the cold wind, or she sends a **Yeti** or an **Air Elemental** to speak on her behalf.

Auril is worshiped in regions affected by deep winters, notably Icewind Dale during the supernaturally long night known as the Everlasting Rime. Individuals propitiate Auril with offerings and prayers for mercy. Few favor Auril, except those who make their livelihood from winter or those who truly love the season. Worshipers stock food, fuel, and other sources of comfort and warmth,

which they sacrifice to Auril for deliverance from harsh winters. In times of deep desperation, however, sapient beings might be left in the deadly cold as a sacrifice to the Frostmaiden.

Auril's priests tend to be people who would, but for their status, be outcasts from their communities. They avoid personal relationships, remaining aloof when not serving in their official capacity. Her priests warn local residents to prepare for winter and stock extra provisions so they have offerings for Auril.

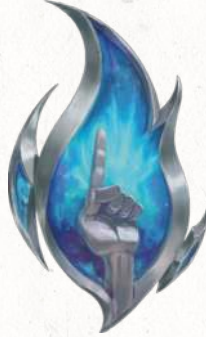
The rituals of Auril's worship seem cruel to outsiders. In Luskan, Auril's temple is the Winter Palace, a roofless array of pillars and arches carved of white stone. Visitors gather here to watch a ritual in which supplicants don garments packed with ice. These supplicants then journey between six white pillars known as the Kisses of Auril, dispersed throughout the city. The worshipers move from pillar to pillar, chanting prayers to the god. On reaching a pillar, a supplicant must climb it and touch the rusty iron plate at the top. In winter, these events resemble frantic footraces, with the added risk of frostbite and injuries caused by falling from the slippery pillars.

Auril's Chosen are spies or assassins who root out the agents of her enemies. She has invested few known Chosen, the most prominent being the Harper agent Artus Cimber.

AZUTH

The High One, Lord of Spells, the Shining Hand of Sorcery

ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA



Renowned as the right hand of Mystra and the First Magister, Azuth is a god of spells and spellcraft. Where Mystra is a god of magic in all its forms and manifestations, Azuth is the lord of spellcasting, the Art of giving shape to the raw power of the Weave. As the Aphorism of the High One says, "Where Mystra is force, Azuth grants form." His priests claim that spellcasters who meditate on the Aphorism reach new understanding of the Art.

The myths of Azuth portray the First Magister as being deeply in love with Mystra, which his priests say isn't idle gossip but the proper approach of any magic-user to magic itself: the Art must be wooed and treated with equal parts adoration and reverence, cultivated like a lifelong love. But Azuth is less concerned with good and evil than Mystra, and he tolerates evil spellcasters as long as they don't deceive or spread chaos. Azuth is friendly with Oghma, who shares his neutral outlook. Azuth wields the *Old Staff*, an Artifact of incalculable arcane power marked with sigils and topped by a shape-changing crystal. He communicates with his worshipers through a manifestation of the *Magic Mouth* spell with a gray beard and mustache, by sending a gray animal such as a cat or owl, or—in extreme cases—a sphinx.

Azuth has few dedicated temples, but every temple to Mystra contains at least one shrine to Azuth within it or a chapel dedicated to him. His priests, the magistrati, host magic fairs and collect rare and unusual *Spell Scrolls* so the death of a spell's inventor doesn't leave their creation lost to time. Magistrati give away spellbooks to people with the potential to become spellcasters but who can't afford to pursue their study. Some magistrati teach at schools of magic. Azuth's priests spread and enforce the magebond, a social covenant among Faerûn's spellcasters. The magebond stipulates that personal disputes between spellcasters shouldn't attract the attention of or disturb mundane society. It encourages spellcasters to handle such issues among themselves, preferably in a peaceful way.

Azuth's Chosen are called his Favored; they push the limits of magical research and arcane innovation, creating new ways to interact with and strengthen the Weave.

BANE

The Black Hand, the Lord of Darkness

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Bane, a god of tyrants and ambition, has a simple ethos: the strong have the duty to rule over the weak. A tyrant who can seize power must do so; not only does the tyrant benefit, but so do those under the tyrant's rule. When a ruler succumbs to decadence, corruption, or decrepitude, a stronger and more suitable ruler will rise. Bane is one of the Dead Three, a trio of gods including Bhaal and Myrkul who attained divinity when they absorbed the divine station of a former death god, Jergal, and were then slain during the Time of Troubles. Bane was the first of the three to return and has risen to a more prominent position than he ever held before his death.

Although Bane's worshipers have committed dark deeds in his name, most of them don't do so out of malice. Bane represents ambition and control, and those who have the former but lack the latter pray to him to give them strength. Bane favors those with drive and courage, and he aids those who seek to become conquerors, carve kingdoms from the wilderness, and bring order to the lawless.

Whatever form Bane takes, he is marked by his jet-black right hand. If he wishes to conceal his identity, he wears a gauntlet or glove over this hand. He appears to mortals in dreams as a powerful, shadowy figure in armor wearing a black, jeweled gauntlet. When he sends an emissary, it is usually a *Horned Devil*, or it could be a possessed *Knight* with pitch-black eyes who remembers nothing of the encounter later.

At many times and in many places in Faerûn, the faithful of Bane have been heralded as saviors for slaughtering raiders, throwing down corrupt rulers, or saving armies on the brink of defeat. But just as often, the worship of Bane has created or supported cruel dictatorships, aided mercantile monopolies, or subjugated entire populations. Priests of Bane wear a black-enameled gauntlet on one fist. Cults of Bane are particularly active in Baldur's Gate, where noble patriarch families are easily enraptured by Bane's promises of power.

The power-hungry Chosen of Bane become warlords or otherwise amass followers to help them seize and consolidate power. Bane's Chosen also act as whispering advisers, tempting and driving rulers to greater acts of cruelty and domination.

KNIGHTS OF THE BLACK GAUNTLET

The Knights of the Black Gauntlet is a military order of crusaders dedicated to Bane. Based in the city of Mintar on the shores of the Lake of Steam, this organization is ruled with an iron fist by the Lord Knight Imperceptor of Bane. The Black Gauntlet's roster boasts warriors and militant priests who are experienced in commanding troops and who are, in turn, prepared to execute orders without question.

Hopefuls join the order as soldiers (regardless of their class or background) and can expect to be treated as such. The rigid hierarchy of the Black Gauntlet ensures that only those who thrive in and master its unyielding structure can rise in rank. Soldiers follow their commanders on expeditions to secure borders, quell uprisings, and stamp out lawlessness that threatens stability.

Soldiers who show obedience to their superiors, demonstrate leadership, and inspire loyalty or fear might receive knighthood. Candidates for knighthood must demonstrate their leadership on a successful expedition without undermining the Black Gauntlet's hierarchy. Those who are found worthy are promoted and given a contingent of soldiers to oversee. Many don a black gauntlet on one hand. (If your campaign uses renown, your character must also have a Renown Score of 3+ with the Knights of the Black Gauntlet to be knighted.)

Knights of the Black Gauntlet learn tactics and leadership. If your character is a member of the Knights of the Black Gauntlet, you receive a free Comfortable lifestyle at any temple of Bane or outpost of the order. Additionally, if you have a Renown Score of 10+ and are leading an expedition in service to the order can request the temporary service of a **Helmed Horror**. Once you've used this benefit, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases.

Knights of the Black Gauntlet find allies in the cults of Bhaal and Myrkul, befitting their god's relationship among the Dead Three, as well as the worshipers of Loviatar. Their primary enemies include those who pose threats to the lands they govern, whether rivals from without or destabilizing elements and dissidents within their borders.

BESHABA

Lady Doom, the Maiden of Misfortune



ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD

Beshaba is a god of misfortune, the counterpoint to her benevolent sister, Tymora, and as frequently acknowledged in daily life. Lady Doom is a cruel and capricious god who must be placated to avoid attracting her ruinous attention and interest.

The ancient empire of Netheril revered a single god of luck, Tyche, whose influence extended over both good luck and bad. According to myth, Tyche became corrupted and died, but her essence then manifested in Beshaba and Tymora, two sisters who share influence over Tyche's divine portfolio. Beshaba is petty and spiteful, and her actions and whims seem perplexing even to her followers. When Beshaba speaks directly to a mortal, her voice whispers from broken mirrors. Otherwise, she sends a **Quasit** disguised as a black cat, or a great stag (**Deer**, **Elk**, or **Giant Elk**) with black antlers dripping blood.

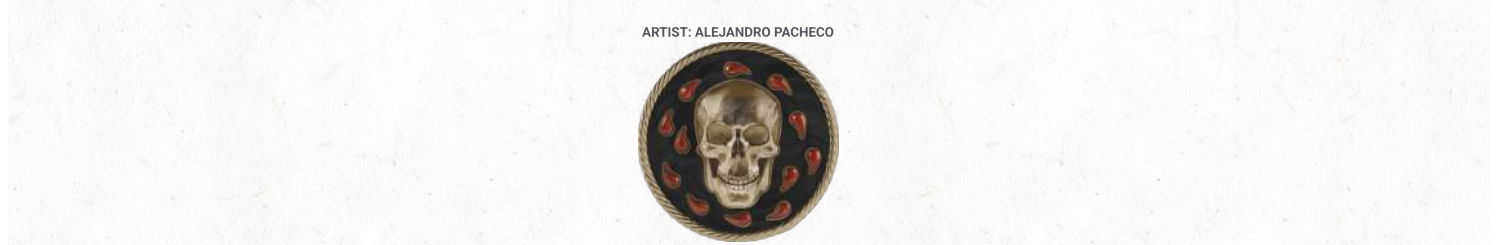
Mortals invoke Beshaba's name when beset by bad luck—anything as minor as stubbing a toe or as catastrophic as falling off a cliff. She is also petitioned to ward off her attentions when sudden bad luck could spell disaster, such as when crossing a rickety bridge. Although people tremble in fear at the prospect of Beshaba's presence at any event (even in spirit), those performing opening speeches or ceremonies at formal functions welcome and propitiate her—after all, if she isn't invited to an event, she might take offense and wreak misfortune on those involved.

Temples to Beshaba are virtually unknown. It's common, however, for rural folk to erect a post and mount antlers on it at the site of a roadside accident or murder. In cities, where antlers are hard to come by, the pious draw the black antlers of Beshaba with charcoal on a nearby wall, leaving the symbol on display until weather scours it away. These makeshift shrines warn others about places of ill fortune.

Beshaba's Chosen are conduits of misfortune. They move throughout the world manipulating people and events to drive disasters, unleash plagues, and let demons slip into the world.

BHAAL

The Lord of Murder



ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO

Bhaal is a god of murder who revels in violence and ritualistic killing. He lends power to those whose slaughters invoke fear and dread. The act of murder is only half the equation. The second half is the suspicion, paranoia, and fear that a seemingly unstoppable killer can evoke. Bhaal inspires fear by slaying those seemingly beyond the reach of death. He is a member of a trio of deities known as the Dead Three alongside Bane and Myrkul.

Bhaal always carries a red handkerchief somewhere on his manifested form. He can take on an alternate appearance regardless of his current form: a hulking figure armed with a long, curved dagger that drips blood. In this hairless form, he wears only a tattered loincloth and is covered with bleeding wounds caused by a blade. His face is a skull flayed of its flesh and surrounded by a halo of blood. When he sends emissaries to carry his word, he usually tasks a **Doppelganger** in the guise of someone the recipient later learns was dead during the conversation, or he sends a vicious **Mezzoloth**.

While the folk of Faerûn don't normally pray to Bhaal, some propitiate him when they want to commit murder. A person might have an understandable reason to resort to murder, such as when they're unable to redress an injustice through lawful means, but it's far more common for prayers to Bhaal to be uttered by murderers motivated by jealousy, greed, or wrath. It's rare for anyone but assassins or compulsive killers to take Bhaal as a patron.

Murder cults of Bhaal have arisen in the past, each led by a charismatic, self-styled priest of Bhaal, but organized worship of the Lord of Murder is extremely uncommon. Temples and shrines are similarly rare. Those who erect a shrine to Bhaal usually do so to thank him for a successful murder. Such shrines feature a skull or a severed head surrounded by drops of blood (both from the murdered victim). As with the other members of the Dead Three, Bhaal's cult has infiltrated Baldur's Gate on the Sword Coast, where a vast temple to the Lord of Murder is said to brood in the tunnels beneath the city.

Chosen of Bhaal are blood-soaked terrors with little or no capacity for empathy. Their divine gifts hone their killing skills to a razor's edge.

CHAUNTEA

The Grain Goddess, the Great Mother

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



Chauntea is the most widely worshiped god among Faerûn's common folk. As a god of agriculture, she is especially popular among farmers and rural communities. The hearth and home also fall under her purview, and as such, people in cities pray to her at mealtimes or before the birth of a child. Some say Chauntea blessed the world with life when it was first formed.

Grand spectacles and displays of power hold no interest to Chauntea. She prefers quiet and small acts of devotion. The Grain Goddess seldom appears directly to mortals, nor does she send divine messengers. On the rare occasions when she communicates with her followers, she does so through words scrawled on freshly tilled soil or the rustling sound of wind through crops, sounding faintly like whispered speech.

Some worshipers of Chauntea celebrate fertility festivals each Greengrass, wherein they arrange freshly cut flowers in beautiful arrangements as offerings for the god in exchange for a speedy growing season. Later in the year, folk across Faerûn express gratitude to Chauntea on the holiday of Highharvestide, thanking her at sunset for the past year's plentiful bounty as winter approaches.

Chauntea's teachings are full of agricultural aphorisms and farming parables. Her faith teaches folk to nurture, tend, and plant wherever possible; anything torn down must have something new planted in its place. Temples of Chauntea are repositories of practical lore concerning farming and cultivation. Chauntea's priests work closely with rural communities to ensure plentiful harvests and are happy to roll up their sleeves and dig their hands into the dirt. They dress humbly, wearing shades of beige and muted green.

It's rare for Chauntea to select a Chosen, and it's even rarer to spot one. They usually dress and comport themselves no differently than any other member of her following.

SEEDS OF CULTIVATION

The Seeds of Cultivation is a nomadic order of Chauntea dedicated to easing the pain of communities experiencing blight or famine. These worshipers travel wherever they are needed. Many know crop-yielding spells such as [Plant Growth](#), but the cause of a blight or famine is often more complicated than a simple lack of fertile soil. The origin might be a mysterious curse on the land, or the dastardly work of cultists of Talona—in which case, swords or skulduggery often prove more useful than spells. For this reason, the Seeds welcome folk with all manner of abilities in their ranks.

The group typically recruits from farming communities. If a city dweller or other aspiring recruit unfamiliar with pastoral life seeks to join the order, the prospective member must first spend at least one year tending to crops in a rural community. At the end of the year, a representative from the Seeds visits the community to survey its people. If the folk vouch for the aspiring recruit's work ethic and character, the Seeds of Cultivation welcomes the recruit into their ranks with open arms. (If your campaign uses renown, the Seeds of Cultivation might waive this requirement for characters who have a Renown Score of 5+ with the order.)

Like Chauntea herself, the Seeds of Cultivation cares little for pomp and circumstance. When initiating a new member, a group of Seeds makes a humble home-cooked meal and enjoys it with the recruit. At the end of the meal, the Seeds bestow on the recruit a wooden brooch depicting the symbol of Chauntea: a blooming rose over a sheaf of grain. Members of the Seeds of Cultivation wear these brooches prominently over their otherwise unassuming attire.

Anyone who grows crops recognizes the Seeds of Cultivation, and members of the order can lodge at any temple of Chauntea for as long as they wish.

Pestilence-bringing disciples of Talona rank among the Seeds' foremost enemies, along with followers of Talos who bring about destruction for destruction's sake. The Seeds typically count worshipers of nature deities among its allies, but the organization occasionally clashes with extremist druids of Silvanus who aim to turn cultivated farmland back into untamed wilds.

CYRIC

The Dark Sun, the Prince of Lies

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Cyric is the powerhungry god of strife, chaos, and malicious deception. He revels in misleading unwitting individuals to perform acts that ruin their lives, and he will stop at nothing until all peoples are afraid, uneasy, and mired in constant discord.

A relatively recent arrival to the Faerûnian pantheon, Cyric ascended from mortal life to godhood during the Time of Troubles by killing Bhaal. He went on to slay several other gods, stealing their portfolios. Aided by Shar, Cyric killed Mystra and caused the Spellplague. Today, many of the deities slain by Cyric have returned and wrenched back their portfolios. Ever petty and megalomaniacal, Cyric still believes himself the most powerful being in the universe. He whispers to his followers in haze-filled dreams and sends Undead riding **Nightmares** as his messengers.

Cyric's faith is strong in any area where evil plots flourish. Individuals who seek to gain control over others flock to his worship. Cyric's faithful believe he won't hear their prayers unless they first make a blood sacrifice. Good folk don't invoke his name, even when trying to deceive others; they call on Leira instead. "The Dark Sun" has become a colloquialism for strife in the Realms.

Temples to Cyric are forbidden in most nations, although they thrive in Amn. Cyric's faith fits in well with the nation's culture of ambition, self-reliance, and deception. Priests of Cyric dress in black or dark purple robes trimmed with silver and wear belts or jewelry adorned with the stamped skull-and-starburst symbol of their god. They spend much of their time scheming against each other, with each priest striving to strengthen their personal power.

The lies of Cyric's Chosen go undetected even by powerful magic, as if the Chosen had cast the [Glibness](#) spell. Spells that would otherwise compel the Chosen to tell the truth, such as [Zone of Truth](#), have no effect. At any given time, one Chosen of Cyric is tasked with guarding the *Cyrinishad*, a magical tome that turns its readers into fanatical devotees of the Prince of Lies.

DENEIR

The First Scribe, the Lord of All Glyphs and Images, the Scribe of Oghma

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Folk across Faerûn enjoy high rates of literacy, thanks primarily to the work of Deneir and his disciples. Deneir is a god of reading and writing. Any visual rendering that attempts to convey information or the truth falls under his domain, whether written or illustrated.

Deneir is Oghma's scribe and is sometimes thought of as Oghma's right hand. In legends, Deneir is typically portrayed as scatterbrained and out-of-touch with mortal affairs. When Deneir must communicate with mortals, he does so through books. Words on a page rearrange themselves into messages, a quill writes on a blank page of its own accord, or the crease between an open book's pages splits into a papery, whispering mouth.

It's common practice for someone who writes a letter or records information to pray to Deneir to avoid mistakes. While many artists worship gods of creativity like Lathander or Milil, illustrators who strive to convey concrete information or realism in their work favor Deneir. They acknowledge Deneir before beginning and on completing paintings, particularly illuminated manuscripts, tapestries that relate stories, and any attempt to use visual art to capture the truth.

Followers of Deneir consider literacy one of the god's most important gifts. His priests teach people how to read and write, free of charge. Deneir's priests tend to be individualists, united by their shared faith but unconcerned with religious hierarchy and protocol. They seldom establish temples of their own, instead operating out of temples of Oghma, schoolhouses, and libraries, or visiting folks in their homes.

The *Tome of Universal Harmony* is the seminal text of Deneir's faith. Deneir's followers have read this thick, two-thousand-page holy book at least once. Many carry it with them wherever they go. Although copies of the tome are nonmagical, Deneir's Chosen can use them to channel powerful magic straight from Deneir himself.

EILISTRAEE

The Dark Maiden, Lady of the Dance, Lady Silverhair

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



In realms such as the Underdark where worship of Lolth is prevalent, drow and other folk who oppose the Spider Queen turn to Eilistraee as a beacon of hope and freedom. She is the drow god of dance, song, beauty, moonlight, swordplay, and hunting.

Eilistraee was born to the gods Lolth and Corellon Larethian. Melancholy yet defiant, she resents the iron grip her mother has over drow cities such as Menzoberranzan. In response, Eilistraee encourages her followers to pursue their own destinies, which might mean fleeing the Underdark and living on the surface. She communicates with her worshipers through dance-like dreams awash in gentle moonlight. In recent years, Eilistraee's message of freedom and harmony has begun to echo beyond drow society. Folk in regions plagued by conflict or oppression might enter Eilistraee's worship after being inspired by a story of a hopeful future that Eilistraee can provide.

Followers of Eilistraee show their gratitude to the god by dancing beneath every full moon. Her priests are passionate advocates of the arts, especially song and dance. Temples to Eilistraee are some of the few places willing to teach the elven technique of bladesinging, and travelers visit from afar to learn this ancient skill. Her priests practice a variant known as sword dancing, which blends bladesinging with bardic arts from the College of Dance. Eilistraee's temples in the Underdark are refuges from the region's subterranean perils, concealed with powerful magic and requiring a sword-shaped key to enter.

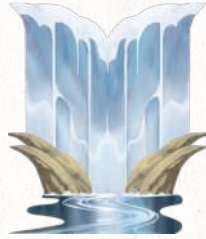
Eilistraee inspires two main adventuring orders: the Silverhair Knights and the Darksong Knights. The Silverhair Knights demonstrates the strength that lies in mercy and compassion. The order engages in combat only when absolutely necessary, even then strictly adhering to nonlethal techniques. The Darksong Knights is a smaller order, dedicated to hunting and destroying yochlols and Lolth's other demonic agents.

Eilistraee's Chosen are diplomats, traversing the surface and the Underdark alike. They put their lives on the line to broker mutual understanding in even the most unlikely places.

ELDATH

The Guardian of Groves, the Quiet One, the Mother of the Waters

ARTIST: EREL MATITA



Eldath is a god of comfort, healing, stillness, and peaceful waters. She is thought to be present at waterfalls, springs, pools, and glades, particularly those visited by druids. Her blessed waters heal the sick, ease troubled minds, and comfort the dying. When she speaks to her followers, Eldath appears as a serene humanlike face formed from flowing water in a pool or waterfall, or she sends a **Centaur Warden** or a **Merfolk Wavebender** to deliver her instructions.

Most rural settlements have a pond or a glade that locals ascribe to Eldath. Tradition dictates that the site remain a place of quiet reflection. The body of water serves as a repository of offerings. Within a glade, people tie offerings to a bush or tree. Offerings are broken weapons or items associated with arguments, which the faithful discard while praying for peace. Many who favor Eldath are pacifists or people troubled by violence they have witnessed or experienced.

Eldath's priests don't organize into large sects. Instead they wander between holy sites and shrines, ensuring locations are cared for and that they remain places of sweet serenity. The faithful of Eldath are close to nature and allied to druids. It is taboo to strike a priest of Eldath, and killing one is said to bring great misfortune. Despite this protection, some priests of Eldath avoid conflict entirely, while others quickly step in to soothe strife and disharmony. Those who serve Eldath preside over peaceful negotiations and certify treaties. Eldath is served by the Yielding Way, an order of monks devoted to peace and protection, and by the Tall Trees, a circle of druids operating in the High Forest.

Eldath's Chosen are known as Lotuses and wear a lotus blossom blessed never to wilt as long as they have Eldath's favor. Lotuses serve as ambassadors and mediators whose mere presence can extinguish violence and rage.

GOND

The Holy Maker of All Things, the Inspiration Divine, Wonderbringer

ARTIST: EREL MATITA



Whether forging a sword or tinkering with a clockwork contraption, makers of all sorts pray to Gond to guide their work. He is a god of invention and craft, and his followers are responsible for much of Faerûn's industrial and magical innovation.

Gond is a driven and energetic god. He is the foremost god worshiped on Lantan; over a century ago, he appeared on that archipelago in the form of a gnome and granted its islands the secrets of smokepowder. Since then, Gond communicates more subtly with mortals. He appears in dreams, providing inventors with the hint of inspiration they need to get their next big idea off the ground. On dire occasions, the flames of a forge twist into a semblance of his face and speak in his voice.

Temples of Gond double as workshops and laboratories. Blacksmiths, woodworkers, engineers, and other crafters count themselves among Gond's followers, but inventors carry Gond's spirit of innovation and are most likely to become his priests. Priests of Gond practice experimentation and innovation and encourage these virtues in others. These priests rarely stay in one place for long, believing that to stagnate physically is to stagnate mentally. They wander the land in saffron vestments; belts of large, linked metal medallions; and enormous sunhats. A traveling priest of Gond offers services to distant villages as a tinker and civil engineer. When priests of Gond invent something, they make two copies: one to be stored in a temple and one to be smashed or burned as an offering to Gond.

Gond's faith has its own units of currency, called Gond bells. These small brass bells are equal in value to 10 GP and vary slightly depending on which temple of Gond constructed them. Priests of Gond delight in discovering Gond bells from faraway temples, understanding them as symbols of the speed at which ideas travel.

Chosen of Gond are gifted with a knack toward problem-solving and innovation. They can discern how an object works with a mere glance or design never-before-seen clockwork trinkets. It is said that they channel the inspiration of Gond himself.

GATHERERS OF GOND

The Gatherers of Gond is a clandestine order that secures materials and intelligence required for new inventions. Gatherers spy on builders or inventors unaffiliated with the faith—not to sabotage them, but to bring back trade secrets they can iterate and improve on.

The Gatherers of Gond partners with dwarf miners to find valuable metals such as adamantine, and they scour the Underdark alongside svirfneblin guides in search of sturdy zurkhwood bark. Gatherers explore ruins of ancient cities and draw schematics to record architectural techniques from bygone civilizations. Experienced Gatherers seek out magic items so the faith can study how they work.

To join the Gatherers, an individual must present the order with an original invention. A sword made of a unique metal, an innovative clockwork contraption, a new weaving technique—all are viable submissions. Initiates are welcomed in a "forging" ceremony where they step into the heatless fire of a **Continual Flame** spell and emerge as official members. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must also have a Renown Score of 5+ with the Gatherers of Gond to join the organization.)

The Gatherers' ranks include the Lockkeepers, members skilled in tracking and coercion. Gond's priests keep a few ideas proprietary: most notably, the secrets of making smokepowder. Whenever Gond's priests becomes aware of a breach in confidentiality, the Lockkeepers hunt down the suspect and make sure the secret doesn't spread, defusing the situation amicably. When targets are less cooperative, Lockkeepers steer clear of outright assassination, resorting to blackmail or spells such as **Modify Memory**.

The Gatherers of Gond partners with followers of Lathander, Oghma, Tempus, and Waukeen, since the inventions Gond's priests create often relate to creativity, knowledge, profit, or war. The Gatherers of Gond opposes Talos, whose unhindered destruction threatens not only Gond's inventions but also Gond's dominion over devices of destruction.

HELM

He of the Unsleeping Eyes, the Vigilant, the Watcher

ARTIST: EREL MATITA



Helm is a god of vigilance and protection—the ultimate guardian, watcher, and sentinel. He is venerated by those who must remain watchful for enemies or danger. Helm is a favorite deity of those who make a living by protecting someone or something, such as bodyguards, members of the city watch, and the guards of a treasury vault.

Helm embodies the spirit of watchfulness without regard for good or evil. In legends, he is honorable and keeps his word to a fault. During the Time of Troubles, he guarded the celestial stairways, preventing the gods from ascending them and ensuring they continued to walk Faerûn. Helm appears as a towering figure in full plate armor with a concealing visor. When he speaks to mortals, he materializes in as a massive armored figure or sends a **Planetar** to deliver his word.

Helm's faith has known dark days. He was slain in a duel with Tyr—a tragic injustice some say was arranged by Cyric. But worship of Helm never faded. Most of his followers believe the Watcher can't be vanquished, and his return after the Second Sundering verified that belief.

Helm's priests teach followers to be vigilant, aware, and prepared for one's enemies. Patience, clear thought, and careful planning will always defeat rushed actions. Those who favor Helm strive to be alert, clearheaded, and true to their word. These traits don't necessarily make them nice people, however, and many consider the faithful of Helm to be inflexible and merciless.

Chosen of Helm—called Sentinels—arise from any walk of life, as the Watcher chooses those who stand against overwhelming peril for the sake of others. Occasionally, Helm looks into the heart of a mortal in the path of a great calamity and—if he judges them worthy—invests them with his power.

EVERWATCH KNIGHTS

The Everwatch Knights is a mercenary knighthood formed by Helm's faithful. The Everwatch makes Helm's vigilance readily available and generates income for the greater faith. While battle-savvy characters such as Clerics, Fighters, and Paladins fit among the Everwatch, these knights also prize the cunning of Bards, Rangers, and Rogues.

Recruits to the Everwatch Knights are called seekers. They train through partnerships with established knights. Contrary to much of Helm's priesthood, the Everwatch Knights keeps a loose rank structure. While traditional knights begin as squires, learning from a single knight for years, Everwatch Knights have no squires, and seekers learn from many knights in succession. Experienced knights support this system by passing on their skills and wisdom.

For a seeker to be chosen for knighthood, they must establish a reputation for upholding contracts and defend themselves in an armed encounter with enemies of Helm. A seeker tapped to ascend to knighthood must hold vigil at a post for a day, taking no food or rest with only water to drink. Once a seeker completes the vigil, they are knighted and join the ranks of the Everwatch. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must also have a Renown Score of 3+ with the Everwatch Knights to be knighted.)

Everwatch Knights train their martial skills and hone their alertness by studying stealth and infiltration techniques. Knights receive a free Comfortable lifestyle when guarding caravans or ships in service of the Everwatch. They can arrange for the services of a **Knight** or **Spy** to assist in defending a charge or to gather information.

The Everwatch Knights opposes destabilizing deities such as Mask, Shar, and Bane. Despite ideological differences between the followers of Torm and Helm, the Everwatch maintains a close alliance with several Torm-worshipping organizations.

ILMATER

The Crying God, He Who Endures, the Rack-Broken Lord

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



Ilmater is a god of suffering, martyrdom, and perseverance, renowned for his compassion and endurance. He offers succor to those who are in pain, victimized, or in great need. He is the willing sufferer who takes the place of another to heft their burden or take their pain. He is a god of the oppressed and the unjustly treated.

If he had his way, Ilmater would take all the suffering in the world onto himself to spare others. Since he can't, he blesses those who endure on others' behalf, and he alleviates suffering when he can. Martyrs are blessed by Ilmater with a final rest and reward in the god's afterlife. Ilmater speaks to mortals in moments of despair and agony, where his voice soothes their hurt and fear. He sometimes sends a **Shield Guardian** to protect a mortal in need and shows favor by growing daisies and white roses or sending peaceful animals.

Ilmater's priests take in the sick, the starving, and the injured, and his temples give away most of what they receive to offset the suffering of the world. His followers provide succor when they can, using force to end torture and the suffering inflicted on others. Ilmater's priests travel to unfortunate places, ministering to the needs of the oppressed, the forgotten, and the poor. They put others ahead of themselves, share all they have, and emphasize the spiritual nature of life over the welfare of the material body.

Priests of Ilmater wear hair shirts, vests of coarse fur. It is taboo to harm such priests as they go about their duties, including when they administer to the wounded on a battlefield. Even warlike groups avoid attacking a peaceful priest of Ilmater, as long as the priest administers to their fallen warriors.

Chosen of Ilmater become martyrs eventually, as they're driven to step between victims and the source of their suffering. The divine power coursing through them allows the Chosen to intervene in brutally perilous situations, pushing them closer to the embrace of the Crying God.

BROKEN ONES

The Broken Ones is a monastic order of temple and caravan guards dedicated to Ilmater. Monks are foremost members of the order, but others join to save others from suffering. Fighters, particularly Eldritch Knights, join the Broken Ones, as do Paladins who swear the Oath of Devotion. Other members are ascetics who distance themselves from worldly affairs, but some understand they must be active in the world to protect it.

Those seeking to join the Broken Ones begin as supplicants tasked to defend a temple. Once they understand the basics of Ilmater's faith, they're assigned tasks in the wider world. During this time, they focus on protecting Ilmater's followers; the most trusted track down, punish, or retrieve targets who inflict suffering on others.

To be inducted into the Broken Ones, a supplicant must endure great personal suffering on behalf of others and in the course of their duties. Superiors evaluate the supplicant for endurance and compassion. A supplicant who passes these trials must then endure a period of fasting and carefully inflicted pain before being welcomed as a full member of the Broken Ones. Many inductees have scars, previously broken bones, and other lingering signs of the suffering they endured during their supplication. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must have Renown Score of 3+ with the Broken Ones to join the order.)

Broken Ones train their bodies and minds to withstand pain and deprivation and learn techniques to make them better protectors of those who can't escape their suffering alone. Broken Ones receive a free Comfortable lifestyle at temples or monasteries of Ilmater. They can secure *Potions of Healing* and other items that soothe and salve.

The Broken Ones opposes anyone who oppresses and harms the weak and innocent, especially followers of Loviatar who delight in inflicting suffering. The order finds lasting allies in the faithful of Lathander.

KELEMVOR

The Judge of the Damned, the Lord of the Dead



Kelemvor is the just, fair, and comforting god of death. When death occurs, Kelemvor takes a soul by the hand and leads it to the proper afterlife. Death isn't a thing to be feared in Kelemvor's eyes, but a natural part of life that must be accepted in its time. When Kelemvor speaks to his worshipers, he does so in dreams appearing as a silver-haired man wearing black, hooded robes and a silver funeral mask, or he speaks through the body of a person who recently died.

Priests of Kelemvor—the most elite of whom are known as doomguides—provide people with peaceful transitions into death. Priests sort the dying's affairs, counsel bereaved mourners, and officiate funeral rites. The tenets of Kelemvor's faith compel his followers to forestall or prevent untimely deaths whenever possible, and to eliminate the scourge of the undead. Several organizations outside the formal priesthood focus on these tenets in different ways. The Vital Breath concentrates on stopping the spread of plagues and magical contagions, the Judge's Vigil focuses on the prevention of murder, and the Knights of the Eternal Order search for and destroy powerful undead.

Their vehement opposition to undead puts Kelemvor's followers at odds with necromancers, priests of Myrkul, and others who create undead, but it also causes conflict in unexpected ways. For instance, priests of Kelemvor routinely destroy writings about the creation of undead—an act that offends those who value knowledge for its own sake, such as the faithful of Oghma and Deneir. Undead of good alignment exist, but Kelemvor's devotees seek even their destruction.

Chosen of Kelemvor embody the natural course of death and are optimistic and jubilant. They rejoice in the thriving of life in its time and can resurrect the victims of improper deaths.

KNIGHTS OF THE ETERNAL ORDER

The Knights of the Eternal Order hunts undead in the name of Kelemvor and in defense of the natural order of life and death. While most members of the Eternal Order are battle-skilled warriors or priests, anyone with the courage to oppose undead is welcome.

Prospective knights join the order as aspirants and serve an established knight as a squire or warrior at arms. The knight oversees the aspirant's training and measures their suitability over time, leading them on quests in Kelemvor's name or sending the aspirant forth to serve. Adventurers might prove their worth on such endeavors.

To be knighted, the aspirant must show courage by destroying a dangerous undead. Those who are found worthy swear an oath to the order and receive a suit of black armor (as Kelemvor wore in his mortal days) or a silver-trimmed black tabard or robe marked with Kelemvor's holy symbol. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must also have a Renown Score of 3+ with the Knights of the Eternal Order to be knighted.)

Knights of the Eternal Order learn to identify and destroy Undead creatures, and they study divine magic and fighting prowess. Knights receive a free Comfortable lifestyle at any temple of Kelemvor. Knights can call on the aid of a **Priest** of Kelemvor during a quest in service to the order.

The Knights of the Eternal Order allies with followers of Helm, Lathander, and Mystra to oppose undead. Its chief foe is Cyric and his followers, although the Knights of the Undying Dragon (an order of **Death Knights**) draws the Eternal Order's ire and attention.

LATHANDER

Inspiration's Dawn, the Morninglord, the Rose-and-Gold God



When the folk of Faerûn gaze at the pastel hues of the morning sky, they thank Lathander. He is a god of dawn and the potential that comes with new beginnings. Spring, birth, youth, creativity, and renewal fall under his domain.

Although occasionally given to excess, abundant enthusiasm, and vanity, Lathander is above all an optimistic deity. An early morning visit from an exuberant songbird might be a good omen from the god. He also sends pixies with iridescent wings the colors of sunrise.

Since Lathander is a god of beginnings, people pray to him before undertaking journeys or endeavors. His priests officiate weddings and births, and his name is invoked to seal alliances and launch new ventures or companies. As a result, Lathander is popular among merchants, and his faith has benefited accordingly. Temples to Lathander are wealthy and unafraid to show it—sometimes to the point of gaudiness. Some feature elaborate stained-glass windows on every wall, while others have parapets designed to look like the spread wings of a rising phoenix. Lathander's temples pay Faerûn's best artists handsome amounts to create colorful statues and murals within their walls. Temples of Lathander hold a special ceremony called the Song of Dawn on Midsummer morning and at the equinoxes. During this event, priests and the faithful sing praises to the Morninglord.

Lathander's followers include athletes, nobles, artists, and the young, all of whom often dress in flamboyant fashions. The Morninglord's priests wear shades of rose pink, orange, and gold—the colors of the dawn. They teach others not to wallow in negativity, that life comes from death and every morning offers a chance to turn a setback into a success. Priests and followers of Lathander despise undead, seeing them as both a corruption of the natural order and a disavowal of new beginnings because undead cling to their old existence rather than move on.

Chosen of Lathander wield powerful magic of light and life and spend their time lending these services to other good deities on Lathander's behalf. Some theorize that these acts of benevolence are Lathander's way of apologizing to the gods for the Dawn Cataclysm—an eons-old incident in which

Lathander foolishly attempted to remake all deities in his image, leading to the deaths of several gods whose names have been nearly forgotten.

DAWNBRINGERS

When the destructive forces of Faerûn bring a town or village to its knees, Dawnbringers help the survivors rise from the ashes. This order of Lathander dedicates itself to helping people start anew. That often means finding refugees new homes and teaching them the skills they'll need to thrive.

Dawnbringers find folk who need their help through word of mouth, divination magic, or omens from Lathander. When necessary, Dawnbringers recruit adventurers or mercenaries to help them reach people in need.

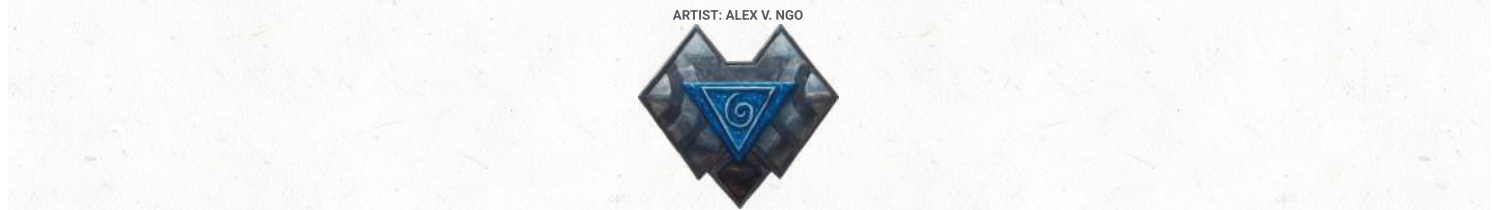
Dawnbringers wear distinctive tabards. The back of each tabard is dark gray, and the front is dyed any combination of sunrise-hued colors, as a symbolic reassurance that people's worst days are behind them. To become a Dawnbringer, one must be trusted by Lathander's followers. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must have a Renown Score of 5+ with the Dawnbringers to join the organization.) The typical Dawnbringer is gentle yet courageous, grounded yet optimistic. People who demonstrate these qualities are welcomed into the order. Many initiates undergo a renewal of their own by shedding their old name and picking a new one.

When they aren't helping displaced people, Dawnbringers connect with town leaders. By strengthening these connections, finding out which leaders are receptive to outsiders, and gently encouraging those that aren't amenable to change, they lay the groundwork for future refugees to find homes. High-ranking Dawnbringers attend dinners and meetings with town mayors and city councils, although this glamorous perk can distract members from their order's goals. In realms such as Thay where Dawnbringers don't have a foothold, they usher folk across long distances to safer lands.

Dawnbringers count Selûne's followers among their staunchest allies, which pits them against the forces of Shar. Dawnbringers despise Bane and Talos for the destruction those gods' faithful wreak on innocent folk.

LEIRA

The Lady of Deception, the Lady of the Mists, Mistshadow



Rogues, con artists, illusionist mages, and actors hold Leira in high regard, though none can identify specifics about the god or her intentions. She is an enigmatic deity of illusions, disguises, and deception.

Shortly after the Time of Troubles, Cyric slew Leira and became the god of lies in her stead. On her return, Leira reclaimed most of her portfolio, but not all of it. The folk of Faerûn now attribute everyday dishonesty to Leira, categorizing particularly heinous deception as the work of Cyric—though the boundary between such types of falsehood is rarely clear cut. Leira isn't viewed as malicious or a trickster, but instead as a mysterious recluse. She seldom communicates with her followers or manifests on the Material Plane. Nevertheless, **Displacer Beasts** are sometimes seen as omens of her will, especially when encountered in places beyond the ordinary reach of fey influence.

Some folk perform a swirling motion with a finger behind their backs when telling a lie as a way of beseeching Leira for aid. Her faithful keep their secrets close and refrain from telling the truth when falsehoods or half-truths would serve them better. Only among fellow worshipers of Leira do they feel comfortable enough to speak plainly.

No images or statues of Leira grace her temples, since her priests know it is useless to presume the true appearance of a god of illusion. Her temples are disguised as other sites, marked with signs that only the faithful recognize. Leira's temples are filled with a white mist that normally remains low but can rise to fill the room and thicken to obscure vision if the temple's high priest desires. Her priests wear vestments of white and mist gray, and their faces are covered by smooth, featureless masks. They are loath to reveal their faces to the unfaithful and sometimes wield sleep-inducing poisons.

Leira's Chosen can alter their appearance at will. Little else is known about them, which is how they like it.

LLIIRA

Mistress of Revels, Our Lady of Joy



Lliira is ever-changing, constantly moving, vibrantly alive. She embodies joy, contentment, dance, and freedom, and is beloved by many. As the patron of festivals, she is honored at celebrations and primarily worshiped in dance.

Artists depict Lliira as a woman soaring through the sky in elated dance. She manifests on the Material Plane as a cluster of brightly whirling lights, a single light that leaves a glittering trail, or peals of joyous laughter. **Will-o'-Wisps** and the **Dancing Lights** spell are easily mistaken as signs of her presence to the untrained eye, and necromancers and charlatans take advantage of these

similarities to fool unwitting victims. Joyful **Empyrean Iotas** or dancing pixies are Lliira's messengers of choice. Lliira is especially popular with satyrs. Several of the songs, dances, and prayers associated with her can be traced back to communities of these fun-loving fey.

Dancers and hedonists are among the Lliira's most devoted worshipers. Some of her followers train in bardic techniques of the College of Dance to better express their devotion. Her followers wear at least one item of clothing in a bright, cheerful color. They aren't frivolous, however. To them, divine joy is a greatly needed gift to the world of mortals.

Lliira's priests, known as joybringers, spread joy wherever possible. They throw excellent parties and are among the most beloved clergy in Faerûn. Joybringers' vestments more resemble festival attire than somber ecclesiastical garments. Joybringers are folk of whimsy and light spirits, prone to jokes but never pranks. Fighting or drawing weapons (except in ceremony) is strictly forbidden at joybringer celebrations.

Lliira's Chosen fight those who bring misery to others. These Chosen master mirthful spells such as *Tasha's Hideous Laughter* and *Otto's Irresistible Dance*, wielding them against evil forces like sharpened weapons. They battle fiercely against their foes and joyously revel when their work is done.

LOLTH

Queen of Spiders, Queen of the Demonweb Pits

ARTIST: RAFAEL ZANCHETIN



Much of the Underdark is ensnared in the figurative web of Lolth, god of spiders. Lolth considers herself the true god of drow, though other members of the drow pantheon disagree. Lolth is a cruel god who encourages her followers to backstab and betray each other, reveling in their treachery.

Lolth was once known as Araushnee, spouse of the elven deity Corellon Larethian. After attempting to overthrow Corellon with an army of spirits, Araushnee was banished to the Abyss. There, she fashioned an arachnid form for herself and took her current name. Spiders of all kinds are seen as omens of Lolth, especially in the Underdark. Lolth often sends **Yochlols**, her signature demons, as messengers or spies.

Lolth's worship has an iron grip on the social structure of many drow cities in the Underdark. Recently folk unassociated with the Underdark have heard the spider god's call, guided by trails of spiders to join aboveground cults dedicated to Lolth. Disciples of Lolth proudly wear web-patterned clothing and practice blood sacrifice, preferring unwilling creatures. Their doctrine teaches them to find and kill nonworshippers. Lolth's followers aren't permitted to pray to other gods apart from Kiaransalee and Selvetarm, Lolth's two allies in the drow pantheon.

The stone walls of Lolth's grandest temples are adorned with floor-to-ceiling bas-reliefs of webbing. As a reflection of the matriarchy of spiders, Lolth's faith permits only women to rise to the priesthood. In the Underdark, drow priests of Lolth rule the noble houses of drow cities like Menzoberranzan, where they wield absolute power. Some of these cities' residents despise the tyranny of Lolth's organization, fleeing to the surface or to drow communities that serve more lenient gods of the drow pantheon.

When one of Lolth's worshipers shows great promise, Lolth summons them to the Demonweb Pits for a test of faith and strength. Those who fail the test are transformed into **Driders**, but those who succeed become Yor'thae, Chosen of Lolth. Yor'thae exercise divine mastery over spiders and carry out Lolth's machinations.

SILKEN STEWARDS

Certain disciples of Lolth don't always kill their victims, instead putting them to sleep with Lolth's Sting (see chapter 3 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*). The victim awakes cocooned in sticky webs, suspended from the ceiling of a dark temple or underground room. In a matter of hours, a swarm of tiny creatures begins to wriggle in the victim's chest. The last feeling the victim experiences is a hair-raising, tickling sensation that quickly turns to agony as baby spiders chew their way out of the ribcage, killing the host.

Lolth's worshipers who practice this method of spider-egg incubation call themselves the Silken Stewards. The practice was pioneered by House Auvryndar, one of Menzoberranzan's ruling noble houses. The drow of this house found that implanting spider eggs into Humanoid hosts and performing a ritual to Lolth over the body caused the eggs to hatch in mere hours, rather than weeks. A *Lesser Restoration* spell cast on the host kills the spider eggs, ending the threat.

Silken Stewards provide other disciples of Lolth with a steady supply of spiders used as mounts, trackers, sentries, and front-line forces in service to the Spider Queen. The Stewards raise all sorts of arachnids: **Spiders**, **Giant Spiders**, and even **Phase Spiders**. Silken Stewards wear gloves made of the finest spider silk, and their clothes bear brooches depicting the stylized image of a curled-up spider inside a white spider egg. High-ranking members oversee the implantation of eggs and the accompanying rituals. Middle-ranking members capture Humanoids to use as hosts. Lesser-ranking members rear the hatched spiders and train them.

Followers of Eilistraee are among the Stewards' greatest foes, particularly Eilistraee's militant orders. They lead raids into the Stewards' hatcheries, killing spiders, freeing captives, and curing infested hosts. Silken Stewards are ever vigilant for Eilistraee's adherents infiltrating their ranks. Underdark-dwelling followers of Silvanus also oppose the Stewards, viewing the Stewards' methods of spider incubation and domestication as a blasphemous affront to the creatures' natural life cycles.

LOVIATAR

The Maiden of Pain, the Scourge Mistress, the Willing Whip

ARTIST: LUCA BANCONE



Loviatar is a god of agony, the mistress of physical and psychological suffering. Coldhearted and calculatingly cruel, Loviatar is an aggressive and domineering despot, and she deeply enjoys her divine remit. Pain isn't a means to an end for Loviatar, but an end unto itself. That quality endears her to the tyrant god Bane.

Loviatar takes the form of a slender woman, like a whip in her movement and aspect. She speaks to her followers during extended sessions of enduring or inflicting pain, intruding on their perceptions in the delirium of agony or ecstasy. When she dispatches an emissary, she usually sends a **Chain Devil**, an **Incubus**, or a **Succubus**.

To the followers of Loviatar, nothing is as transcendent as suffering. All pain is holy, from the crudest brutality to the emotional suffering of the heartbroken or the betrayed, and is proof of Loviatar's attention. Pain—the ability both to inflict it and to endure it—is a path to power. Loviatar's followers consider a cold, cruel demeanor ideal because that best emulates Loviatar herself, and for the same reason her faithful appreciate beauty, cultural refinement, and skill at manipulation.

Though temples to Loviatar are rare, her faithful are numerous. Loviatar is a preferred deity of those who inflict pain as a matter of course, including torturers and others who need to break the will of their victims. Her followers form cells of secret adherents led by someone who takes pleasure in administering pain and dominating others, supported and bolstered by submissive sycophants.

Worshippers of Loviatar rarely gather in numbers except in populous cities, and never openly. When small cadres of the faithful operate quietly, few citizens take notice or raise a fuss when they witness cult activity. Loviatar's cults sometimes kidnap and keep prisoners, which can draw the attention of the authorities.

The Chosen of Loviatar are paragons of inflicting and receiving pain. They delight in insinuating themselves into the fabric of society and then tearing through it like a barbed whip.

MALAR

The Beastlord, the Bloodgod, the Wild Hunter

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Malar inspires the thrill of adrenaline experienced by a predator chasing its next meal. He epitomizes the bloody, sadistic side of nature, the world that is red in tooth and claw. He is the god of those who delight in the hunt, don't shy from bloodshed, and savor the fear of their prey.

Malar is a bestial deity, depicted in paintings and murals as a feline monster. When he needs to make his will known on the Material Plane, he sends a ferocious predator drenched in blood, such as a **Displacer Beast**, an **Owlbear**, or a **Peryton**. Malar's intentions rumble and snarl in the minds of those experiencing the delights of savage violence, urging them on and basking in their bloodlust.

Foolish mortals attempt to propitiate Malar with offerings or prayers, hoping to avoid attacks by wild animals. These efforts are in vain, for Malar shows no mercy. Those who worship him instead attempt to embody his peerless hunting skill. Berserkers scream prayers to Malar as they rage, and hunters whisper a prayer before closing in for the kill. Lycanthropes see themselves in Malar's uncontrollable savagery. Malar's followers wear or carry trinkets from the fearsome creatures they've slain. Teeth, pelts, wings, claws—the more ferocious, the better.

Priests of Malar believe in the survival of the fittest, and none are allowed to enter the priesthood without first demonstrating prowess in hunting and combat. Malar has no temples in Faerûn's major cities, but villages on the edges of the wilderness might house a temple. During the tenday leading up to Highharvestide, priests of Malar hunt tirelessly for as much game as they can find. They then invite members of the community to join them at a great feast on Highharvestide called the Feast of the Stags. They keep quiet the dreaded High Hunt ritual, in which priests of Malar choose someone to become their prey for a day and a night. If the prey survives, they gain a favor from the priests of Malar, but death is a far more likely outcome.

Malar's Chosen are gifted trackers, sometimes blessed with lycanthropy. It is said that the Chosen of Malar can smell their quarry from miles away.

MASK

The Lord of Shadows, the Master of All Thieves

ARTIST: CONCEPTOLIS



Mask is a trickster god, the patron of ne'er-do-wells, spies, and thieves. All that occurs within shadow is in the purview of Mask. People whisper a prayer to Mask whenever stealth is required or intrigue is afoot. Courtiers and diplomats invoke Mask's name in hope of a smooth negotiation.

Mask takes the form of a quick masculine being wielding two shadowy blades, his identity hidden by a mask. Sometimes he takes the form of masks that others might wear. When he speaks to his followers, he does so by claiming a mask as his temporary face, or he sends a living shadow (Neutral Evil **Shadow Demon**).

Those who favor Mask practice thievery and try to acquire what belongs to others, engaging in pickpocketing, burglary, mugging, and con games. Ordinary folk pray to him so he'll avert his eyes from their valuables, but cautious individuals employ "Mask's purse," a small, cheap cloth pouch worn in plain sight containing a small offering of coin. By convention, a pickpocket pilfers Mask's purse when encountering another person wearing one and considers it a gift from the god, while the one who lost the purse is grateful to Mask for accepting this respectful sacrifice. Of course, nothing prevents another pickpocket from targeting someone who has lost Mask's purse, and anyone with the ill luck to attract multiple pickpockets in a single outing has probably earned Mask's ire anyway.

Priests of Mask are thieves by profession and serve as higher-ups in the local underworld or a criminal syndicate. They go by the title of demarche and wear veil-masks when acting in their priestly capacity.

The foremost organization serving Mask is the Shadowmasters of Telflamm, a criminal syndicate in the land of Thesk. The Shadowmasters are based at Mask's largest temple, the House of Shadow, in Telflamm, but they also maintain safe houses throughout Thesk.

Chosen of Mask are master thieves, manipulative spies, and assassins who rarely walk in the light.

MIELIKKI

Our Lady of the Forest, the Forest Queen

ARTIST: RAFAEL ZANCHETIN



Good natured, confident, and fiercely loyal to her allies, Mielikki is a god of the woods and the creatures who live within them. She is also a god of Rangers. When she makes her will known on the Material Plane, Mielikki manifests as a confident voice in a forest glade. Alternatively, she sends a **Dryad**, **Hawk**, or **Unicorn** as a messenger.

Mielikki's followers don't organize into official temples. Instead, they assemble in peaceful wooded glades to worship her or create shrines in her honor. A typical shrine to Mielikki is a dead tree trunk into which has been carved the likeness of her holy symbol: a unicorn or unicorn's head. Such a shrine marks a point in the forest beyond which locals know not to cut timber or hunt; in this way, followers thank Mielikki for the forest's bounty.

Priests of Mielikki protect the forests of Faerûn, using magic to communicate with and protect the animals and plants within. Mielikki's priests wear capes of leaves to match the seasons: verdant green in the summer, burnt orange in autumn, and dotted with flowers in the spring. In winter, they forgo the capes and wear crowns of twigs. Whatever the garb, they wear Mielikki's holy symbol over the heart, carved of ivory or bone or stitched in silver thread.

Mielikki is allied with Silvanus but she takes pity on hurt creatures Silvanus ignores. Mielikki has a close bond with Lurue, god of unicorns, and Lurue serves as her mount when Mielikki goes hunting in the Beastlands. Rangers of Mielikki serve as a line of defense against marauders and followers of the god Malar.

On Greengrass and Midsummer, Mielikki blesses her followers with an event called the Wild Ride. She causes unicorns to gather in herds and gallop through the woods. Mielikki's followers ride the unicorns through the night, covering astonishing distances and enjoying nature's beauty.

Mielikki gifts her Chosen with an undying unicorn that serves them as a mount and companion. Some Chosen transcend their physical forms to become disembodied manifestations of natural spaces—such as Jeryth Phaulkon, a woman from Cormyr who now inhabits an expansive garden estate in Waterdeep as a disembodied spirit.

MILIL

The Lord of All Songs, the First Poet, the Bard of Oghma

ARTIST: CONCEPTOPOLIS



Milil is a god of poetry, eloquence, and song. He is also a god of creativity and inspiration, of the essence of song beyond the lyrics or the music.

Like Deneir, Milil defers to Oghma's will, and he is sometimes thought of as Oghma's left hand. Milil is the ideal to which performers aspire: poised and confident, winningly charismatic, and a source of inspiration. Songbirds are heralds of Milil. He manifests to mortals as a beautiful, haunting voice echoing through open spaces or through visions that appear to entertainers during performances.

Milil is venerated by bards, troubadours, and other entertainers, but anyone preparing to entertain or speak before a crowd might pray to Milil for a successful performance. Milil's followers need not be entertainers themselves, but simply appreciate good music. His followers tend to be hedonistic in comparison to those of other gods. Milil's most daring followers become tuneservants, traveling with adventuring parties and composing ballads detailing the group's heroics. Fanciful gold netting is a hallmark of tuneservant attire; tuneservants drape this netting around their shoulders or use it to hold up their hair.

Worshippers dedicate holy sites to Milil in performance venues and music schools. Whether the site is a vast concert hall or a small choral chamber, it must have excellent acoustic qualities. Milil's priests are patrons of the arts, performers, and tutors. Each year on Midsummer, priests of Milil hold a holiday called the Grand Revel. In this ceremony, clergy and other followers of Milil dance, feast, act out parodies, and join in wickedly satirical song. Though it isn't an expressly political event, those in power are the revel's biggest targets. For this reason, tyrannical rulers outlaw the Grand Revel—though priests of Milil still conduct it in small, private ceremonies.

Milil's Chosen have angelic voices that resonate far beyond those of most mortals. Their passionate words can crack the hardest of hearts, whether through song or oration.

MYRKUL

The Lord of Bones, Old Lord Skull, the Reaper

ARTIST: CONCEPTOPOLIS



Myrkul is a god of death, decay, old age, exhaustion, dusk, and autumn. He claims power over corpses and souls and cares only for the acquisition of knowledge. Myrkul's faithful call him the Reaper. He is one of the Dead Three with Bane and Bhaal, former mortals who took the divine portfolio of the death god Jergal and were slain during the Time of Troubles.

Myrkul can call forth the soul of any slain creature and bind it into a wax skull. To exercise this power, he grinds up a piece of the creature's body, working the powder into the wax skull. As long as the soul remains inside the skull, the eye sockets burn with cold blue flames, and Myrkul can compel the trapped soul to answer his questions and share its knowledge. The skull melts a little with each service the soul renders until it collapses and the soul is freed. When he speaks to his followers, Myrkul sends a **Wraith** or the **Ghost** of someone known to the mortal.

Mortals fear Myrkul as the ending of things and as a symbol of hopelessness. Individuals don't pray to him but rather dread him and blame him for aching bones and fading vision. Myrkul is passionless and uncaring even to his most devout worshipers. Those who venerate Myrkul tend to be morose, taciturn, and obsessed with death and the undead. Wizards and other spellcasters who wish to master the necromantic arts follow Myrkul's teachings, as do undertakers and morticians.

Shrines to Myrkul or engravings of his holy symbol appear where people bury their dead, but full-fledged temples are rare. The few that exist are hallowed places where the dead from hundreds of miles around are brought for interment, even if they were not of Myrkul's faith. There is little space set aside for the living in such a location, usually only a single modest shrine, but the surrounding catacombs and ossuaries might be vast. Wicked cults of Myrkul haunt Baldur's Gate, plaguing the city alongside other followers of the Dead Three.

Myrkul's Chosen are imbued with terrifying necromantic might. He teaches them the secret of binding souls, as well as ways to siphon life from others to render themselves immortal.

MYSTRA

The Lady of Mysteries, the Mother of All Magic, Our Lady of Spells

ARTIST: CONCEPTOPOLIS



The Lady of Mysteries is a god of tremendous power, even among other deities. Her dominion is the Weave, the sum total of magic, from which spells are drawn. Like magic itself, Mystra has undergone many changes over the millennia, including two known passings of her mantle.

The faith of Mystra is pervasive throughout Faerûn, which is unsurprising in a land so touched by magic. Her worshipers include those who use magic or work closely with it, such as alchemists and sages. The goals of her faithful are simple: to preserve and promulgate magic throughout the Realms. Mystra's faithful watch for those who demonstrate magical potential, and they help such people find tutelage with a suitable mentor. She communicates through her Chosen, by sending a **Beast Lord** or pixie, or through animals that are blue, white, or multicolored.

The blue-clad priests of Mystran temples, called dweomerkeepers, wield both arcane and divine magic. Mystra inspires magic-centric organizations such as the Knights of the Mystic Fire, her foremost martial champions. In cities and towns, the Children of the Starry Quill serves as an information and spy network, while the Order of the Shooting Star pursues her interests in the wilderness. The secretive Sisterhood of the Silver Fire opposes the Cult of the Dragon, tracking down and destroying copies of the ***Tome of the Dragon***, the book that details how to turn a dragon into a dracolich.

Mystra relies on Chosen more than most deities, and the ranks of her Chosen include the Seven Sisters (the daughters of Mystra, including Alustriel Silverhand, Laeral Silverhand, and the Simbul), Elminster Aumar, and other legendary spellcasters. She gives her Chosen the ability to call on silver fire, a destructive manifestation of pure magic that can also restore magic to places that have been cut off from the Weave.

KNIGHTS OF THE MYSTIC FIRE

Elite warriors in service to Mystra can join the Knights of the Mystic Fire. These knights lead Mystra's martial efforts and command lesser soldiers. With sword and spell, they protect her temples, defend sacred sites, and attack her enemies. Eldritch Knights, Bladesingers, Paladins, Rangers, and other characters who combine fighting skill with magic make excellent Knights of the Mystic Fire.

Individuals who seek to become a Knight of the Mystic Fire must prove themselves in service to Mystra. This service lasts several years and includes garrison duty guarding Mystra's temples, or it might involve membership in one of Mystra's lesser orders (such as the Order of the Shooting Star). Adventurers might prove themselves by questing on Mystra's behalf or defending the faithful from violent assaults.

To be made a knight, a candidate must display three qualities: they must be trusted by Mystra's priests, they must be an exemplary warrior, and they must display leadership. The candidate must hold an all-night vigil under the stars and swear an oath of loyalty to Mystra before being invested with the order's distinctive blue tabard marked with a fiery silver star. They often use a knightly honorific before their name, such as "Sir," "Lady," "Dame," and the like.

Knights of the Mystic Fire receive training in arcane and divine magic as well as fighting techniques. Knights are supported with a free Comfortable lifestyle at any temple of Mystra. With sufficient notice and cause, they can call on a task force of lesser warriors such as **Guards, Knights, Scouts, or Warrior Infantry**.

In addition to serving Mystra's priests, Knights of the Mystic Fire work alongside followers of Azuth, Kelemvor, and Selûne, traditional allies of Mystra. Their foremost enemy is Cyric and his followers; they defend against Cyric's plots and aggressively seek out his temples and shrines to destroy them.

OGHMA

The Binder of What Is Known, the Lord of Knowledge

ARTIST: CONCEPTOPOLIS



Oghma is a god of knowledge, thought, and ideas. His holy symbol, a blank scroll, is ubiquitous in places of learning. Oghma has an unbridled enthusiasm for knowledge, and he shares it with the people of Faerûn.

Oghma carries a great deal of wisdom behind his carefree demeanor. Should an existential threat to knowledge arise, he doesn't intervene immediately. Instead, he mulls and puzzles over complex plots before taking action, consulting his associated deities—Deneir, Milil, and Gond. If Oghma needs to interact with mortals, he sends an **Owl**. On rare occasions, he speaks directly into a mortal's mind while they're deep in thought.

Oghma's followers include sages and academics. Students pray for him to fill their minds, and teachers pray that he might guide their instruction. People in Faerûn casually invoke Oghma's name while trying to remember something, and they curse him when something in their memory is just out of reach. Oghma's passionate followers believe he vets every new idea that enters someone's mind. Since criminals use this as an excuse for their actions, this way of thinking has fallen out of favor.

Oghma's temples accumulate and distribute books, scrolls, knowledge, and lore. His clergy includes cloistered sages and archivists who analyze, file, and copy the temple's archives, as well as traveling scholars who seek out new learnings. Oghma's priests believe knowledge is the greatest tool of the mortal mind, and they oppose those who try to keep people ignorant.

Most temples of Oghma double as public libraries. These temples hold a daily evening service called the Covenant, during which clergy and laypeople read works of wisdom, songs, and new knowledge aloud for the sake of Oghma and all others present. Temples financially support themselves by selling maps, ***Spell Scrolls***, and other works of scribes. They partner with priests of Deneir to provide these services, since Deneir has few temples of his own.

Chosen of Oghma have supernatural memories that allow them to memorize vast quantities of lore. In communities with oral histories or in places where libraries have burned down, Oghma's Chosen serve as living fonts of knowledge.

THE RED KNIGHT

The Crimson General, the Grandmaster of the Lanceboard, the Lady of Strategy

ARTIST: SWATCHES STUDIO



Where other war gods focus on the bravery, duty, or pain of battle, the Red Knight is concerned solely with the art of tactics. She is a god of planning and strategy. Her military genius allows her and her followers to see the greater picture in any war, rather than a series of battles won and lost.

In spite of her calm and logical demeanor, the Lady of Strategy isn't without compassion. Faerûn's myths and legends depict her as a wise, daughter-like figure to the god Tempus, advising him in times of need. She aids mortal tacticians by fashioning boulders into red-veined **Stone Golems** shaped like lanceboard pieces, sending crimson **Pegasi** from the heavens above, or animating lanceboard pieces to demonstrate tactical maneuvers.

Devotees of the Red Knight are rare in the general population. Her name is seldom invoked outside of battle, except perhaps in games of strategy such as lanceboard. High-ranking commanders of armies, instructors in colleges of war, quartermasters, and authors of tomes of tactics revere her.

Worship of the Red Knight arose among a hero-venerating monastic order of Tempus in Tethyr shortly after the Time of Troubles. The Lady of Strategy visited these monks in a dream and delivered to them the Great Stratagem: an imperative to travel to places of warfare to educate generals and monarchs in the arts of strategy and battlefield tactics. Known as the Red Fellowship, her priests traveled throughout southwestern Faerûn sharing their wisdom. Many leaders they approached turned them away at first, but it soon became apparent that those who accepted the counsel of the Lady of Strategy gained a distinct tactical edge. Grateful victors built temples to the Red Knight, and gradually her faith spread. Today, her followers appear in nearly any land that has seen warfare in the past century. The Red Knight's greatest temples include an enchanted war table that visiting generals can rent out to visualize their tactics.

The Red Knight's Chosen ride the god's crimson pegasi into combat. However, their most crucial work takes place in war rooms far from the front lines. These Chosen act as trusted advisers to powerful military forces in Faerûn, predicting their foes' next moves with eerie accuracy.

SELÛNE

The Moonmaiden, the Night White Lady, Our Lady of Silver

ARTIST: SWATCHES STUDIO



Selûne is a god of the moon, and she is among the most ancient of Faerûn's deities. People in Faerûn consider the moon to literally be the god gazing down on the world, and the trailing motes of light behind it her tears. She is also a god of stars, navigation, and motherhood.

Selûne appears as a woman of varying ages. She sometimes changes slowly before an onlooker's gaze, passing through the phases of aging as the moon transitions through its cycle. In any form, she emits the silvery-blue glow of the brightest full moon. When she sends an emissary to mortals, she sends an **Owl** or other night bird, a moonlight-hued **Planetar**, or a benevolent lycanthrope, commonly a **Werebear**. Lycanthropes are said to be blessed by Selûne.

The principal legend about Selûne recounts the battle at the beginning of time between Selûne and her sister, Shar. The Tears of Selûne, the cluster of starry lights that follow the moon around the sky, are said to be the result of her joy, sorrow, or both.

Selûne is venerated by navigators, sailors, those who work at night, those seeking protection in the dark, the lost, and the questing. Temples to the Moonmaiden include a series of windows that reveal the moon in the night sky at various positions and in different phases throughout the year.

Selûne's rites include trances and meditation. Those who favor her set a bowl of milk outside on each night of the full moon.

Chosen of Selûne step into danger to light the way through darkness. A select few of her Chosen can create moonfire, a mysterious substance that grants magical power to objects or people.

SWORDS OF THE LADY

The Swords of the Lady is an order of knights devoted to Selûne. Swords are known for an incongruously jovial, even joking, nature, as well as for their unpredictable tactics in battle. The order welcomes those who contemplate the moon and her lessons. The Swords of the Lady eagerly seeks out and recruit arcane spellcasters who were born under a full moon.

Individuals seeking to join the Swords of the Lady are welcomed as Slivers, referring to the first glint of light following the dark of a new moon. Slivers learn the unorthodox manner in which Swords carry out their duty and are encouraged to improvise, use their surroundings, and otherwise employ change and surprise when facing enemies of the Lady.

Once a Sliver has proven worthy in the eyes of their comrades and superiors, the initiate undergoes a vigil held under a waxing half-moon, symbolizing the way in which the new knight's commitment and responsibility has grown. The knight receives their vestments: a tabard, cloak, and cloth mask of gleaming white fabric stitched with silver. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must also have a Renown Score of 3+ with the Swords of the Lady to be knighted.)

Thereafter, the new Sword trains in battle skills, learning a smattering of divine or arcane magic. Swords of the Lady wield both magic and steel to confound their enemies and glorify the Moonmaiden. Swords receive a free Comfortable lifestyle at the organization's holdings. If they demonstrate legitimate need, Swords can secure silvered weaponry on loan or buy these weapons for half their normal price. In times of crisis, a knight can call on a friendly lycanthrope to aid the fight against Selûne's enemies.

The Swords of the Lady sets itself against the children of Shar. The order also finds bitter enemies in the followers of Mask, god of thieves, as well as Umberlee for her callous endangerment of sailors on night seas. They find allies in the followers of Lathander, Mystra, and Sune.

SHAR

The Mistress of the Night, the Dark Lady, Our Lady of Loss

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



The dark twin of Selûne, Shar is a god of darkness, both in its physical form and as it exists in the minds and souls of mortals. People worship Shar as the god of night, secrets, loss, and forgetfulness. She represents hidden pain and vengeance hidden from the light. She has the power to make individuals forget their pain or become inured to a loss, and people in distress pray to Shar for this blessing.

Shar appears as a lithe dancer with skin like a black night set with glittering stars, or as a mysterious woman clad in swirling, black robes. In her guise as the dancer, she is charismatic and magnetic, and in her dark-robed form foreboding and haunting. Rarely, she appears as a black sphere limned in swaying, purple flames, like a strange solar eclipse. She appears to mortals in dreams, or she sends a **Death Tyrant** or **Shadow** as an emissary.

Shar is revered by those who venture into dark places, such as miners, as well as by those who fall into melancholy and despair, who wish to forget something, or who wish to recover something lost. Priests who serve Shar nurture their own deep wounds or dark secrets, which in their minds makes them best suited to console those who suffer from a similar ill. Followers of Shar have carried out many dark deeds in her name, and the Shadovar of Anauroch is an entire society dedicated to her. The tragedies and losses brought about by her followers have caused realms to outlaw her worship, driving her priests into secrecy. Such prohibitions only heighten the priests' umbrage toward authorities and make the faithful a focal point for rebellion and revenge against whoever rules.

Chosen of Shar forget who they once were and know only who Shar has made them into. She delights in taking followers from her rivals or from otherwise happy lives and breaking them down until they forget their past, remembering only devotion to the Mistress of the Night.

ORDER OF THE DARK MOON

Shar's Order of the Dark Moon studies darkness, deception, stealth, assassination, and espionage. Monks, Rogues, Sorcerers, grim Rangers, and other characters who seek to cast away their grief into Shar's blissful forgetfulness are welcomed into the order.

Prospective members don't approach the Dark Moon; instead, the order notes a candidate's reputations and deeds, then approaches the potential initiate, offering them succor for their anguish or a way to indulge their darker impulses. Once inducted, the initiate is called a Wanderer—one who searches the darkness. Wanderers are subjected to lessons woven with enchantment magic designed to mold them into spies and weapons. These enchantments cause a Wanderer to doubt their memories and their identity, replacing the candidate's fractured bits of self with a new personality befitting Shar's service.

Once a Wanderer has proved their loyalty and devotion to the cause, they undergo a midnight ceremony and are anointed a Dark Sibling. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must also have a Renown Score of 3+ with the Order of the Dark Moon to be inducted.)

The Dark Sibling learns the crafts of subtle strikes, deception, and ambush through skill and magic. Dark Siblings receive a free Comfortable lifestyle at any holding of Shar's faith. Those ordained into the Dark Moon secure assistance hiding their identity, such as disguises, magical assistance, or forged or stolen credentials useful for travels and on missions.

Despite the enveloping nature of the Order of the Dark Moon, a Wanderer can reclaim bits of who they once were. Such a soul is faced with a difficult path to rebuild their true self or forge a new identity of their own devising while struggling to avoid Shar's clutches.

Selûne is the bitter rival of Shar, and the Order of the Dark Moon frequently works against Selûne's militant orders and priests. The order finds allies in the cult of the death god Myrkul.

SHAUNDAKUL

The Rider of the Winds, the Helping Hand

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



Shaundakul is a god of journeys and travelers. Both mundane and magical means of travel fall under his sphere of influence. Though the heyday of his worship has long since passed, the Rider of the Winds still leaves his mark on Faerûn via rare portal-shrines dotted across the continent.

Shaundakul is an ancient deity, but his worship dwindled in the aftermath of the fall of Myth Drannor, where his chief temple was located. A small but dedicated contingent of scattered priests carries on his faith. Shaundakul communicates with these remaining followers by manifesting as an elderly voice carried on a crisp zephyr.

Travelers pray to Shaundakul before embarking on long treks. Spellcasters invoke his name while casting the *Teleport* spell in the hope that he will take them safely to their desired destination. Apart from such brief invocations, lay worship of Shaundakul is rare in the Realms.

Shaundakul's priests wear garb appropriate for arduous treks. Each wears a gauntlet or glove on their left hand: silken lace, gauze, or other diaphanous material trails at the wrist. His only remaining temple is Shaundakul's Throne in the ruins of Myth Drannor. The ruins are famously perilous, so priests seldom congregate there. Instead, they aim to unearth and protect other shrines to Shaundakul left from long-gone eras. These stone shrines bear the chiseled holy symbol of Shaundakul: a humanlike figure walking on the wind. Each shrine of Shaundakul is linked to another somewhere in Faerûn. When a hopeful traveler stands before the shrine and uses the appropriate command word, a two-way portal of swirling air materializes to connect the two locations. Unless these command words are displayed at the shrine, Shaundakul's priests must sift through ancient dungeons to find them or beseech adventurers to do so.

Chosen of Shaundakul take to the skies through spells like *Fly* and *Wind Walk*. These Chosen help Shaundakul's lesser priests make the dangerous pilgrimage through Myth Drannor to Shaundakul's Throne. Some take vows to cleanse the ruins of Myth Drannor of the monsters that lurk therein.

SILVANUS

Oak Father, the Old Oak, Old Father Tree

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



Silvanus, god of wild nature, is closely associated with forests, mountains, and plains. In truth, Silvanus represents the entirety of nature: deserts as well as forests, sharks as much as deer. In legends he commands other nature deities, dealing out rewards and punishments to them as he sees fit.

Interpretations of Silvanus's personality vary wildly. Many see him as a vengeful god, looking with aloof disgust on the inhabitants of Faerûn as a shopkeeper regards an infestation of rats. However, worshipers of Silvanus believe that Silvanus doesn't hold people in disdain but rather wishes to maintain the balance of nature. Wilderness is brutally fair when it comes to matters of life and death, and so is the Oak Father.

Whenever he wishes, Silvanus can bring the natural world to sentient life, with streams finding their own courses and trees uprooting to walk around. When he needs to communicate directly with his followers, he sends a *Dryad*, *Treant*, or *Twig Blight* as a divine messenger.

Druids make up most of Silvanus's following. His creed dictates that nature's glory must be preserved not merely because nature is beautiful, but because wild nature is the true state of the world. *Nature* refreshes and revitalizes the mortal soul, giving breath to the world. His faithful oppose the expansion of settlements into wild places and consider the excessive consumption of natural resources to be not only wasteful but blasphemous.

The oak leaf is Silvanus's symbol, and villagers might dedicate a grove of oaks nearby as a shrine to him. In places where oak trees don't grow, an oak leaf etched into the bark of another kind of tree signifies a sacred site. Official temples to Silvanus are few and far between and likely to be hidden away in the depths of a forest rather than in a bustling urban center.

Silvanus tasks his Chosen with presiding over a forest, a desert, a lake, or another natural region. Some develop spiritual relationships with their assigned domain, not unlike a dryad's link to its sanctuary. When their domain flourishes, these Chosen become invigorated; when it suffers or comes under attack, they feel the pain.

SUNE

Lady Firehair, the Lady of Love, the Princess of Passion

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Sune Firehair is a deity of passion and the delights of the senses. She is the god of beauty in all its forms—not just pleasing sights, but also enchanting sounds, luxurious tastes and scents, and exquisite sensual pleasures, from a lover's caress to the whispering brush of silk on the skin. Her worshipers seek out these pleasures in life, not out of mere decadence, but because the experience of pleasure is an act of worship.

Sune appears as a woman of unearthly beauty. Regardless of what features she takes on, her hair is always impossibly long and fiery red. When she doesn't speak in dreams or visions, she sends a **Couatl** or **Deva** to act as muse on her behalf.

The followers of Sune have a reputation as hedonists. Her priests foster beauty in the world by creating art or acting as patrons for promising talents. Her priests consider loveliness to be one of their greatest callings and train in comportment, fashion, and cosmetics.

But beauty is more than skin deep, say Sune's followers; it issues from the core of one's being and shows one's true face to the world. The followers of Sune believe in romance, true love winning over all, and following the heart to its true destination. Fated matches, impossible loves, and embracing beauty beyond the physical are the purview of Sune.

Temples dedicated to Sune serve as public baths and places of relaxation. A temple features a mirrored and well-lit salon where individuals can enhance their appearance, as well as see others and be seen. In remote locales or in parts of sprawling cities far from a temple, small, roofed shrines to Sune provide her followers convenient access to beautification resources. Each shrine bears a mirror and is stocked with free perfumes and cosmetics.

Sune's Chosen exemplify some aspect of beauty. For some, this is physical loveliness, but others create beauty through art, music, writing, or other creative endeavors. They inspire through expression and show that beauty exists in all facets of the world.

SODALITY OF THE RUBY ROSE

The Sodality of the Ruby Rose is a knightly order dedicated to Lady Firehair and tasked with guarding Sune's temples and holy sites. The Sodality also accompanies Sune's priests and those questing on the Lady's behalf. Anyone with a drive to protect beauty and oppose those who seek to tear it down find acceptance in the Ruby Rose.

Prospective members are called Hopefuls. A Hopeful who demonstrates adherence to Sune's ideals accompanies knights on simple assignments. When the Hopeful wishes to pursue initiation, they keep vigil in a temple of Sune for one night. If the god shows her favor by granting a vision or other boon, the Hopeful is accepted as a Sodalite, also known as a Companion.

To win Sune's acceptance, a Hopeful must have protected a meaningful aspect of beauty from something that would destroy it, whether through ignorance or malice. Once inducted, the Companion is granted an enameled red rose brooch and joins the order. Members of special distinction bear brooches with ruby petals. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must have a Renown Score of 3+ with the Sodality of the Ruby Rose to join the organization.)

Companions of the Ruby Rose are trained in battle, presentation, and poise. Companions receive a free Comfortable lifestyle when staying at holdings of Sune's faithful. When need arises, Companions can requisition the aid of a **Mage** or **Priest** of Sune.

The Sodality of the Ruby Rose strives against creatures that are corrupt and eager to destroy beauty. Sune's nature ensures that most people, even followers of other gods, are unlikely to remain in conflict with her for long, though the Ruby Rose occasionally clashes with the faithful of Talona, Talos, Tempus, and Umberlee.

TALONA

Lady of Poison, Mistress of Disease, the Plague Crone

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



One of Faerûn's most feared deities, Talona is a god of plague and poison, blamed for everything from common illnesses to crop failure, from brackish wells to plague. She craves propitiation from mortals and pursues it by any means necessary.

Talona is a fickle god. She is more petulant than conniving, more reactive than active. Though she receives many prayers, Talona has almost no temples or cults dedicated to her, and she resents the neglect. When she lashes out with plagues, blights, and magical contagions, victims desperately pray to her for respite, placating her for a time. But once the contagion ends, prayers dwindle, and it isn't long before the neglected god lashes out again.

When Talona communicates with mortals—usually to demand some sort of propitiation—she sends a **Vulture**, a **Giant Rat**, or the corpse of a creature infested by insects. Whatever method she chooses, her messenger is shrouded in a sickly yellow-brown glow.

Rituals to placate Talona involve three drops of blood or three tears dropped into a well that has gone bad, dripped into the handkerchief of someone beset by coughing, dropped into a fire made by burning a withered crop, dripped into the mouth of a plague sufferer, and so on. It's common practice to mark a container of poison with her holy symbol, three droplets in a triangle. During epidemics, this image is painted on the homes of the infected.

Talona's priests rarely enter into her service willingly. Some are forced into the role by their communities, while other individuals simply have nothing else to live for. This latter category includes the sole survivors of harrowing magical contagions, or people who have lost loved ones to Talona's whims. They dedicate their lives to the priesthood to make sure the same fate doesn't befall others. A priest of Talona maintains a small shrine instead of a temple. Despite the priest's best efforts, people often lavish these shrines with offerings during tough times while neglecting them in times of health and abundance.

Devoted followers of Talona brew poisons in her name and summon magical contagions to unleash on the people of Faerûn as punishments for neglecting the Mistress of Disease. Among these fanatics, her Chosen are gifted with immunity to poisons and magical maladies.

TALOS

The Destroyer, Storm Lord, the Raging One

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Talos personifies the destructive aspects of nature. He is best known as a god of storms, but he is also associated with forest fires, earthquakes, tornadoes, and general destruction. Raiders, looters, and brigands flock to his worship.

The Storm Lord's actions seem petty and vengeful, motivated by rage, anger, and the need to posture among other gods. Talos is an ancient god who sprang up from the wreckage of the first battle between Selûne and Shar. Religious art often depicts him as a broad-shouldered, bearded man with an eye patch, but the folk of Calimshan know him by the name Bhaelos and depict him with a genie-like appearance. Talos rules over the gods of fury—Auril, Malar, and Umberlee—though it's said Malar would kill him if he could. The Raging One manifests to mortals as bellowing laughter in the heart of strong winds or as red lightning strikes in a storm.

Day-to-day worship of the Storm Lord is outlawed in most of Faerûn, though folk make desperate offerings to save themselves from natural disasters. Talos's faithful love destruction, and they call storms on towns and cities in the name of their deity. Many become brigands, wandering from place to place demanding loot and threatening destruction. Sometimes Talos's faithful forgo any ultimatum, causing wanton destruction for destruction's sake. They are taught that life is chaos and that each person should seize what they can when they can—after all, who can say when Talos will strike and bring them to the afterlife?

Priests of Talos have few temples, instead traveling like a wayward storm. They wear ragged robes and cloaks shot through with jagged lines of gold and silver. Many wear an eye patch in deference to their god. Priests and other devout worshipers of Talos make pilgrimages to a canyon called the Gulf of Storms in eastern Amn. The peculiar iron ore in the canyon's walls attracts electrical charges, making the chasm prone to spectacular, deadly arrays of crisscrossing, leaping lightning bolts. This energy develops into storms that race down the valley to lash across Amn and Tethyr.

Talos's Chosen bring terror to Faerûn. They wield incredibly powerful destructive spells such as [Storm of Vengeance](#), [Earthquake](#), and [Meteor Swarm](#), unleashing annihilation on cities and villages that don't bend to the Storm Lord's will.

TEMPUS

The Foehammer, the Lord of Battles

ARTIST: RAFAEL ZANCHETIN



Tempus is a war god concerned with brave conduct, using force to settle disputes, and encouraging bloodshed. The Foehammer is friendly with Gond for his war machines and was once Beshaba's lover. Tempus sponsored the Red Knight's ascension to divinity.

This god of war is random in his favors, meaning his chaotic nature favors all sides equally. Tempus might be an army's ally one day and its enemy the next. When he manifests before a battle, he can appear to either side in the conflict. If he rides Veiros, his white mare, the army will succeed. If he rides Deiros, his black stallion, defeat is certain. Most often, he rides with one foot in each mount's stirrup, signifying the unpredictable nature of battle.

In such visions, Tempus is a powerfully built warrior dressed for battle in the style of those who see him. When he speaks to mortals directly, his voice reverberates in a clash of weapons, or he sends a Celestial **Berserker** to carry his will.

Over the centuries, Tempus's priests have spread and enforced a common code that encourages rules of war, respect for reputation, and professional behavior on the battlefield. This code, called Tempus's Honor, encourages conflicts to be brief, decisive, and as safe as possible for bystanders. The rules in the code include the following: arm anyone who has need of a weapon,

disparage no foe, acquit yourself with bravery, train all for battle, and don't engage in feuds. Those who poison wells, taint fields, kill noncombatants, or engage in torture in the name of war are considered enemies.

Worshippers of Tempus are a legion, and soldiers carry his name in their hearts. His priests are tacticians skilled in the art of war. Many of his priests serve as battlefield chaplains with armies and mercenary companies, encouraging fellow soldiers with word and blade. Priests of Tempus teach that war conducted properly is fair because it impacts all sides equally, with each soldier poised for both death and glory. Mortals shouldn't fear war but should see it as a natural force—the storm that civilization brings about by its existence.

The Chosen of Tempus are masterful tacticians, fearsome warriors, and powerful leaders. They find their way to battlefields with such certainty that many suspect the Chosen's presence causes battles to break out.

STORMKNIVES

Mercenaries loyal to Tempus have long identified themselves through the symbol of a rusty dagger dripping four drops of blood. In recent years, these mercenaries have organized around a common code of conduct beyond Tempus's Honor. These individuals call themselves Stormknives.

A warrior who wishes to become a Stormknife simply declares himself to be one. They carry a dagger at all times—even while sleeping or bathing—and wear a patch bearing four drops of blood. When these individuals sign a mercenary contract, or any other binding agreement related to war or conflict, they add four red marks to their signature, signifying the commitments of a Stormknife.

Each of the four drops of blood in the Stormknives' symbol represents a commitment, ranked in ascending order of importance. The first of these represents loyalty to the sword and signifies the Stormknife's obligation to seek out battle at every opportunity. Whenever a Stormknife is given a choice between violent and nonviolent methods to solve a problem, they should choose violence.

The second drop represents loyalty to the client. A Stormknife respects the wishes of the individual they're working for, obeying them whenever possible. A client, for example, might order a Stormknife to put away their weapons and retreat from battle, and the Stormknife is obliged to obey.

The third drop represents loyalty to the contract, emphasizing the letter of the contract over the client's wishes. If, for example, a client instructs a Stormknife not to loot a body, but the contract includes such plunder as the Stormknife's right, the mercenary can disobey the client in favor of the contract.

And finally, the fourth drop represents loyalty to Tempus. The wishes and whims of the Lord of Battles supersede other rules, even a written contract. But it's up to individual Stormknives to determine what Tempus's will might be, leading to corruption and abuse. Some Stormknives use this part of their code as an excuse to break a contract or disobey a client's wishes, claiming such deeds are the will of Tempus and thus unavoidable.

TORM

The Hand of Righteousness, the Loyal Fury, Torm the True

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



Those who favor Torm believe salvation is found through service. He is a god of courage and self-sacrifice, an unyielding deity who dutifully puts himself on the front line of the fight against evil and injustice. He is a patron god of many Paladins, embodying the tenets of the Oath of Devotion.

Torm's name carries gravitas and strikes fear into treacherous hearts, but his heart is filled with goodness. In legends, he is kind and gentle when dealing with faithful friends, the weak, and the defenseless. But he is stern and righteous against the forces of evil and injustice. When Torm appears in dreams, he takes the form of an enormous, flying metal gauntlet surrounded by arcs of lightning. He might send a golden **Lion** or, in extreme cases, a **Deva** clad in gleaming armor to make his will known.

Torm's faithful believe that brave acts of service please their god. They strive to maintain peace and order while opposing unjust laws and standing alert against corruption. Though many of Torm's followers are warriors, skill in combat isn't required to uphold Torm's ideals. For instance, a council member who worships Torm advocates for what is just, even if this puts their position at risk. Torm's followers believe every failure of duty diminishes Torm and every success adds to his luster. The faithful know everyone stumbles from time to time, but they never cease aspiring to Torm's standards.

Followers construct fortress-temples dedicated to Torm on defensible heights. These structures offer drilling grounds, stables, and austere quarters for residents and visiting knights. Lion statues and armored figures feature in these temples' decor, with the coats of arms of fallen heroes decorating the white-granite walls. The priesthood of Torm is friendly with the priesthoods of Tyr and Ilmater: together with Torm, these gods make up a trio of deities called the Triad. Torm's priests are also allied with the Red Knight and Lathander.

Chosen of Torm dedicate themselves to the fight against evil, especially against the forces of Bane. Torm and Bane battled each other to their mutual destruction during the Time of Troubles—both gods have since returned, and the animosity between them still seethes.

ORDER OF THE GOLDEN LION

East of the Dalelands, the city of Tantras is home to the greatest concentration of Torm worshipers in Faerûn. There, Torm manifested and slew Bane during the Time of Troubles. While this era was a time of great pride for Torm's followers, it also became one of great shame. After returning to his godly state, Torm was disgusted to find that Tantras's priests had been persecuting believers of other gods, and that this practice had spread throughout the Dalelands and along the Sea of Fallen Stars. As punishment, Torm dictated a series of responsibilities and obligations—the Penance of Duty—for his followers to perform as atonement. Over a century has passed since this decree, and Torm's followers have regained trust in the regions around Tantras. Still, a select group of Torm's faithful vowed to continue the atonement of the Penance of Duty, and those people are known as the Order of the Golden Lion.

The Order of the Golden Lion involves righting three Debts: Persecution, Dereliction, and Destruction. Typically knights of the Golden Lion devote themselves to righting a single debt. Those who choose the Debt of Persecution aid good religions wherever possible. Followers of the Debt of Dereliction atone for abdications of duty by seeking out and eliminating cults of Bane, as well as routing the Zhentarim. Adherents to the Debt of Destruction are obliged to report and repair areas of dead magic and wild magic throughout Faerûn as penance for the destruction to the Weave caused by Torm's battle against Bane.

The Order of the Golden Lion is most active in the Dalelands and the region around Tantras, but faithful as far as the Sword Coast have picked up the mantle. The order is largely composed of warriors, and members wear the order's signature article of clothing: a pair of golden pauldrons, each carved in the shape of a lion's head. To become a member of the Order of the Golden Lion, an individual must prove their dedication by completing a holy quest for a temple of Torm. (If your campaign uses renown, a character must also have a Renown Score of 5+ with the Order of the Golden Lion to join the organization.)

TYMORA

Lady Luck, Our Smiling Lady

ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA



Tymora is a bright-faced god of fortune, the patron deity of game players and gamblers. Our Smiling Lady loves those who gamble with skill and daring. She watches over all who take risks to better their fortunes. Tymora takes the form of a tall, graceful young woman with flowing platinum-blond or silver hair. She might send a faerie dragon as an emissary.

Tymora is Beshaba's sister. Long ago, the Netherese revered Tyche, the god of luck, whose influence extended over both good luck and bad. Tyche perished, but Beshaba and Tymora manifested soon after, each commanding half of Tyche's portfolio.

The battle cry of Tymora is "Fortune favors the bold." Folk pray to Tymora before any endeavor in which a little good luck would help. One common method of divining the future is to toss a coin to a stranger and ask if it's heads. If it is, the coin is left with the stranger as payment for Tymora's favor. If it's not, the stranger can keep it (and the bad luck that comes with it) or return it.

Those who favor Tymora—as distinct from those who merely invoke her name whenever they roll dice—are daring sorts. Many of her followers are adventurers and gamblers. They believe that the good in their lives results from having both good luck and the bravery to seek it out. Tymora draws all sorts of worshipers: the dashing noble, the risk-taking merchant, the daydreaming field hand, and the scheming ne'er-do-well.

Priests of Tymora and temples devoted to Lady Luck are scarce, since her faith doesn't stress a need for intermediaries: "Let the lucky man and the Smiling Lady suss it out," as the old saying goes. Shrines to Tymora at gambling parlors aren't unusual, however, and such establishments might attract a priest and effectively become temples.

Tymora's Chosen become infused with her extraordinary luck. Some never realize they are Chosen, ascribing their luck to mere chance. The Smiling Lady chooses individuals who embrace her tenets and dive boldly into action and risk, rolling the dice and betting big.

TYR

The Evenhanded, Grimjaws, the Maimed God

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Tyr Grimjaws, Tyr the Evenhanded, Wounded Tyr, the Maimed God, the Lord of Justice—all these names speak to the nature of the god of justice.

Tyr appears as a noble warrior without his right hand, which he lost to Kezef the Chaos Hound in an act of bravery and sacrifice. His eyes are wrapped in cloth, his blindness signifying that justice applies evenly to all. Weary of the foolishness of mortals, Tyr seldom appears or speaks directly to mortals, instead sending an awakened **Mastiff** as an emissary or sending the sound of a war gong or a choir.

Tyr's followers devote themselves to achieving justice, righting wrongs, and delivering vengeance. This devotion isn't concerned with equality or fairness, but rather discovering the truth and punishing the guilty. Those who favor Tyr are stiff-necked about theology and laws, evaluating actions according to a rigid moral code.

Tyr's credo of lawfulness and honesty is demanding, and his priests remind the faithful not to judge too harshly those who fail to live up to Tyr's standards. If Tyr's commands were easily followed, they wouldn't be worth obeying.

Many orders of knighthood devote their lives to Tyr, including the Knights of Holy Judgment and the Knights of the Merciful Sword. Such knights—as well as judges, priests, and others who worship Tyr—wear thin strips of diaphanous cloth over their eyes as a symbol of their faith.

Tyr's Chosen have suffered in their commitment to pursuing justice, but Tyr's power strengthens them, helping them remain true to Tyr's strict code.

UMBERLEE

The Queen of the Depths, the Wavemother

ARTIST: CLINT LOCKWOOD



No seaside community can ignore the influence of Umberlee, the furious sea god whose tempestuous nature is reflected by the waters of the deep. Coastal villages and towns host festivals to propitiate the Wavemother, seek her favor, and avoid seafaring disaster. Although mercurial in temperament, she can be generous to those who do her honor, as any great queen should be. Some Druids worship Umberlee as a manifestation of nature in its cruelest form.

Umberlee manifests as a woman colored like the sea in blues and greens, with taloned hands and fins on her elbows. Clad in a cape of purple jellyfish and wielding a trident, she rises from the sea to terrify sailors. When she speaks through emissaries, she sends an **Air Elemental**, a **Water Elemental**, an awakened **Giant Shark**, or a **Kraken**.

The Wavemother is worshiped out of fear instead of adoration. Ship crews toss gems over the side as offerings to calm storm-tossed waters. She is capricious and cruel; the sea is a savage place, and those who travel it must be willing to pay the price of challenging her domain.

Umberlee's priesthood thrives in its lack of organization. Her priests roam coastal cities, warning of doom and demanding free passage on ships in return for ensuring the god's pleasure, or at least her indifference. They wear the colors of waves and decorative items reminiscent of the sea's dangerous nature—a necklace of shark teeth, seaweed wrapped around a bone, and so on. The preserved hand of a drowned person is thought to be a particularly holy object, and her priests use such severed hands as holy symbols. Sailors leave flowers or small candies at Umberlee's shrines in coastal cities in hope she will spare them on their next voyage. Both Waterdeep and Baldur's Gate have temples dedicated to Umberlee, staffed by priests whose loved ones were lost at sea.

Umberlee imbues aquatic people and creatures as her Chosen, counting mighty sahuagin warlords and krakens among their ranks. These Chosen enjoy power over the tides and storm and carry their queen's fury into the dry world.

WAUKEEN

The Coinmaiden, Our Lady of Gold, the Merchant's Friend

ARTIST: ALEJANDRO PACHECO



Waukeen is a god of wealth and trade. She is interested in anything that increases trade and the flow of money, whether new trade routes, new inventions, or the whim of changing fashion. Waukeen keeps cordial relationships with other deities, save for Mask, who is her only real enemy—larceny is bad for business, after all.

Waukeen takes the form of a splendidly dressed woman with long golden hair, often accompanied by two golden **Lions**. She might more subtly manifest as sprouting golden daffodils, or a stack of gold coins that writhes and slithers like a snake. When she sends an emissary, she sends an awakened golden **Cat**, **Lion**, or eagle (**Hawk**), or she might send a **Sphinx of Lore**.

Her ardent worshipers include shopkeepers, members of trade organizations, wealthy merchants, caravan guides, itinerant peddlers, moneychangers, and smugglers. Greed motivates those who take Waukeen as a patron, but the Coinmaiden frowns on misers and smiles on the industrious and the profligate. For these reasons, priests who bear her holy symbol are welcome in towns and cities.

Temples of Waukeen resemble guildhalls and serve as meeting places for trade associations. Those who follow Waukeen's ethos create opportunity for all and see competition for wealth as society's best method of progress. Thus, the faithful of Our Lady of Gold are at odds with guilds and others who form monopolies. It's common practice for her followers to set aside a tithe of ten percent of their profits, but rather than being given to a temple, the money is spent to help a struggling business, to finance a new endeavor, or, if all else fails, on frivolous fun.

Chosen of Waukeen possess their god's keen understanding of contracts and agreements and can rival powerful devils at unwinding convoluted terms. They intervene when the wealth of nations is at stake.



EQUIPMENT

The following equipment can be purchased through *Aurora's Whole Realms Catalog*.

ADVENTURING GEAR

This section describes adventuring gear used throughout the Realms.

ADVENTURING GEAR

Item	Weight	Cost
<i>Adventurer's Ring</i>	—	250 GP
Bright Fungal Cloak	4 lb.	25 GP
Desert Clothing	4 lb.	10 GP
Devil Mask	—	25 GP
Garb of Light and Shadow	6 lb.	50 GP
Genie Robe	6 lb.	50 GP
Locking Spellbook	3 lb.	35 GP
Monster Camouflage	6 lb.	50 GP
<i>Prosthetic Limb</i>	—	—
Warm Fungal Clothing	4 lb.	15 GP
<i>Windskiff</i>	—	4,000 GP
Winter Camouflage	4 lb.	50 GP

ADVENTURER’S RING (250 GP)

Dalelands Wares

Ring, Common

Lamps are a liability on adventures. Delicate and prone to oil spillage, lamps fill a hand that should otherwise be wielding a weapon or casting a spell. Once you try one of our elegant and practical rings, you'll never go back to cumbersome flint and fire.

While the cover on this ring is open, the ring produces a flame that creates no heat and consumes no fuel. It sheds **Bright Light** in a 20-foot radius and **Dim Light** for an additional 20 feet. As a Bonus Action, you can close the cover, smothering the flame, or open it again.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

BRIGHT FUNGAL CLOAK (25 GP)

Icewind Dale Wares

Never spelunk in the dark again! This cloak of bioluminescent fungus fibers is sure to brighten your day.

While wearing a Bright Fungal Cloak, you can take a Bonus Action to furl or unfurl it. When the cloak is unfurled, it sheds Bright Light in a 5-foot radius and Dim Light for an additional 5 feet.

One pound of fungus is sewn into a Bright Fungal Cloak. This fungus can be eaten as food. Once all the fungus is consumed, the cloak becomes a mundane set of Traveler's Clothes.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

DESERT CLOTHING (10 GP)

Calimshan Wares

Stylish but practical, our desert clothing protects you whether you're taking a caravan of camels through the Calim Desert or exploring an ancient Mulhorandi tomb.

When you are wearing Desert Clothing and not wearing Medium or Heavy armor, you automatically succeed on saving throws against the effects of extreme heat. See chapter 3 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide* for rules on extreme heat.

DEVIL MASK (25 GP)

Baldur's Gate Wares

Grant your sins plausible deniability by wearing one of these diabolical masks inspired by fiends from the Nine Hells. Also suitable for patriarchal galas in the city of Baldur's Gate.

While you are wearing a Devil Mask, other creatures have Disadvantage on Intelligence (**Investigation**) and Wisdom (**Insight**) checks made to discern your true identity or intentions.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

GARB OF LIGHT AND SHADOW (50 GP)

Moonshae Isles Wares

These outfits are fashionable among fey courtiers in the Moonshae Isles. After winning a riddle game and parting with a lock of hair, I secured enough samples to re-create them in my workshop.

This garb appeals to Fey from one Domain of Delight, such as the Gloaming Court or the Summer Court. While wearing the garb, you have Advantage on ability checks to influence Fey associated with that Domain of Delight.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

GENIE ROBE (50 GP)

Calimshan Wares

Channel the authority of genies with these elegant Calishite fashions.

This robe appeals to Elementals associated with a particular Elemental Plane (Air, Earth, Fire, Water). While wearing a Genie Robe, you have Advantage on ability checks made to influence Elementals associated with that plane.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

LOCKING SPELLBOOK (35 GP)

Dalelands Wares

The wise wizard keeps a copy of all their spells safely tucked away in case of disaster. We supplement our spellbook with a trusty lock secure enough to dissuade curious goblins.

This 100-page leather-bound tome can be used as a Spellbook. It is closed with a lock that comes with a key. As a **Utilize** action, a creature can try to pick the lock using **Thieves' Tools**, doing so with a successful DC 15 Dexterity (**Sleight of Hand**) check.

MONSTER CAMOUFLAGE (50 GP)

Icewind Dale Wares

The people of Icewind Dale have developed many strategies for safely traveling in dangerous wilderness. This outfit, adapted from hunting garb, deters strangers and animals alike.

A suit of Monster Camouflage looks like a Beast or Monstrosity, such as an owlbear. To discern that you're disguised, a creature must take the Study action to inspect your appearance and succeed on a DC 10 Intelligence (**Investigation** or **Nature**) check. The creature has Advantage on this check if it is within 30 feet of you and automatically succeeds on this check if you do anything the monster you're disguised as couldn't do.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

PROSTHETIC LIMB (0 GP)

Calimshan Wares

A perfect illustration of the notion that magic should make our lives easier. Thanks to the generosity of Sultana Songal, anyone who requires a Prosthetic Limb can have the device for free. Speak to one of our vendors in the Aurora's Emporium nearest you.

Prosthetic Limbs are detailed in the *Dungeon Master's Guide*.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

WARM FUNGAL CLOTHING (15 GP)

Icewind Dale Wares

Intrepid explorers from Highplume Station in Icewind Dale have descended steam vents to bring useful fungi up from the Underdark. Our expert crafters took it from there.

When you're wearing Warm Fungal Clothing, you automatically succeed on saving throws against the effects of extreme cold. See chapter 3 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide* for rules on extreme cold.

One pound of fungus is sewn into Fungal Clothing. This fungus can be eaten as food. Once all the fungus is consumed, this becomes a mundane set of Traveler's Clothes.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

WINDSKIFF (4,000 GP)

Moonshae Isles Wares

Wondrous Item, Rare

If you want to travel between the Moonshaes, you won't be able to on foot, by horse, or by cart. You'll need to sail. And while you could simply hire a boat, where's the fun in that?

This small piece of jewelry has 3 charges and regains all expended charges daily at dawn. While you are holding it, you can take a **Magic** action to expend 1 charge, which causes the jewelry to transform into a sail-powered personal vehicle. The vehicle is roughly the size and shape of a household door with a 10-foot-tall sail extending from one side. After 1 hour or until you use the item's command word (no action required), the transformation ends and the Windskiff reverts to its jewelry form.

In vehicle form, a Windskiff is a Medium object with the following statistics: AC 12, HP 30, and Speed 40 ft. The Windskiff hovers a few inches above whatever surface it's on and can glide; it moves 5 feet horizontally for every 1 foot it descends in the air. A Windskiff and its riders take no damage from falling.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

WINTER CAMOUFLAGE (50 GP)

Icewind Dale Wares

Whether you're hiding from horrifying tundra monsters or you just want a little privacy, this handsome garb can help you keep a low profile in the North.

While you wear Winter Camouflage in an appropriate environment, you have Advantage on Dexterity (**Stealth**) checks.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

Mechanical Wonders

Mechanical Wonders have revolutionized life in Calimport. Imagine a wound-up machine that does your laundry, washes your dishes, and cleans your house—then fulfill this dream in any emporium shop.

Calishites rely on the technological marvels known as *Mechanical Wonders*.

Mechanical Wonders

Item	Cost
<i>Mechanical Wonder</i> (domestic)	400 GP

A *Mechanical Wonder* is a semi-autonomous object imbued with magical power. *Mechanical Wonders* vary greatly in size and form depending on their function.

A *Mechanical Wonder* is a dormant object until activated. To activate a *Mechanical Wonder*, you must wind the wonder with a handheld key unique to that wonder. It takes 1 minute to wind a *Mechanical Wonder*. While you wind it, you must take the *Utilize* action each turn.

Once wound, a *Mechanical Wonder* remains activated for the duration specified in the wonder’s description below.

DOMESTIC WONDER (400 GP)

Calimshan Wares
Wondrous Item, Uncommon

This bipedal wonder is designed to assist with household duties. It vaguely resembles whatever species its creator used as inspiration. An activated domestic wonder uses the **Domestic Wonder** stat block. The wonder is an ally to you and your allies. In combat, the wonder shares your Initiative count, but it takes its turn immediately after yours. It obeys your verbal commands (no action required by you). If you don’t issue any, it takes the **Dodge** action and uses its movement to avoid danger. The domestic wonder is destroyed if it drops to 0 Hit Points.

Domestic Wonder

Medium Construct, Unaligned

AC 9 Initiative –1 (9)

HP 5 (1d8 + 1)

Speed 30 ft.

		Mod	Save
Str	13	+1	+1
Dex	8	–1	–1
Con	13	+1	+1

		Mod	Save
Int	3	–4	–4
Wis	8	–1	–1
Cha	1	–5	–5

Immunities Poison; **Exhaustion, Poisoned**

Senses Passive Perception 9

Languages Understands Common but can’t speak

CR None (XP 0; PB +2)

Traits

Mechanical Determination. If damage reduces the wonder to 0 Hit Points, it makes a Constitution saving throw with a DC of 5 plus the damage taken unless the damage is Lightning or from a Critical Hit. On a successful save, the wonder drops to 1 Hit Point instead.

Wind-Up Operation. The wonder has the **Unconscious** condition until another creature winds it with the wonder's unique key for 1 minute. Once wound, the wonder operates for 10 days or until a creature touches the wonder with its key as a **Utilize** action to deactivate it, after which the wonder has the **Unconscious** condition until it is wound again.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

MOUNTS AND OTHER ANIMALS

People in Faerûn use animals for transportation and other tasks.

MOUNTS AND OTHER ANIMALS

Item	Carrying Capacity	Cost
Axe Beak	210 lb.	50 GP
Flying Snake	60 lb.	25 GP
Sled Dog	210 lb.	50 GP



AXE BEAK
ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

AXE BEAK (50 GP)

Icewind Dale Wares

Don't let the grouchy reputation of these hardworking creatures deter you. A team of axe beaks can pull your sled with remarkable speed and efficiency.

Use the **Axe Beak** stat block (see the *Monster Manual*).



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

FLYING SNAKE (25 GP)

Baldur's Gate Wares

Our partners in the Zhentarim provide these remarkable pets, fully domesticated and trained to deliver messages. Always wear gloves when handling venomous creatures.

Pet flying snakes use the **Flying Snake** stat block (see the *Monster Manual*).

SLED DOG (50 GP)

Icewind Dale Wares

We recommend a team of these sled dogs to ease the burden on individual animals. Rotate your dogs through the lead positions to give weary animals a rest.

A sled dog uses the **Wolf** stat block (see the *Monster Manual*). A sled dog pulling a sled alone must take a Short Rest after pulling a sled for 1 hour; otherwise, it gains 1 **Exhaustion** level.

TOOLS

The Musical Instruments described here are used by musicians across Faerûn.

TOOLS

Item	Weight	Cost
Bandore	3 lb.	65 GP
Cittern	2 lb.	65 GP
Yarting	2 lb.	40 GP

MUSICAL INSTRUMENT (VARIES)

Moonshae Isles Wares

The yarting is the staple stringed instrument of minstrels across Faerûn. A cittern, distinguished by its pear-shaped bowl, produces a pleasing, richer sound. The bandore is a complex bass instrument with additional sets of strings, perfect for accompanying tenor and alto instruments in an ensemble.

The **Bandore**, **Cittern**, and **Yarting** are each a type of Musical Instrument. See the *Player's Handbook* for more details on Musical Instruments.



LEFT TO RIGHT: YARTING, BANDORE, CITTERN
ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

TRAVEL

Travelers in the Realms might use interesting modes of transport.

TRAVEL

Service	Cost
Black coach ride in Baldur's Gate	1 GP/trip
Sled services	4 GP/day



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

BLACK COACH SERVICE (1 GP/TRIP)

Baldur's Gate Wares
Travel in the city of Baldur's Gate should be comfortable, elegant, and discreet. Narwin Cottle's magical black coaches are all three. Tell your driver Aurora sent you.

Each of Cottle's black coaches is a Carriage (see the *Player's Handbook*) keyed to a unique sigil sequence. While inside a black coach, a creature can take a **Magic** action to turn a combination dial and input a sigil sequence belonging to another black coach. All creatures inside the coach then teleport to that destination coach. If the destination coach is occupied, the teleport fails and the action is wasted.

Alternatively, a creature inside the coach can use the combination dial to input a random sequence, teleporting all creatures inside to a random coach in Cottle's fleet.

SLED SERVICES (4 GP/DAY)

Icewind Dale Wares
We've contracted with expert sled drivers to provide travel services around Icewind Dale, the High Ice, the Great Glacier, and other realms of the North. Each guide brings their own sled and team of six sled dogs or axe beaks. Authentic local food is provided for you and your companions. Contracts are per journey, paid half in advance and half on arrival.

Sled service includes a **Scout** and six **Axe Beaks** or sled dogs (**Wolves**). See the *Monster Manual* for these stat blocks.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

VEHICLES

Often found in the Dalelands, the following vehicle is used by folk looking to protect their cargo.

VEHICLES

Item	Weight	Cost
Covered Wagon	1,300 lb.	250 GP

COVERED WAGON (250 GP)

Daleland Wares
Is it any wonder adventurers flock to the Dalelands? It's not just the majestic forests and flavorful ale; here, everyone minds their own business. These wagons, popularized by adventurers current and retired, can be found from Thunder Pass to Dragon's Reach.

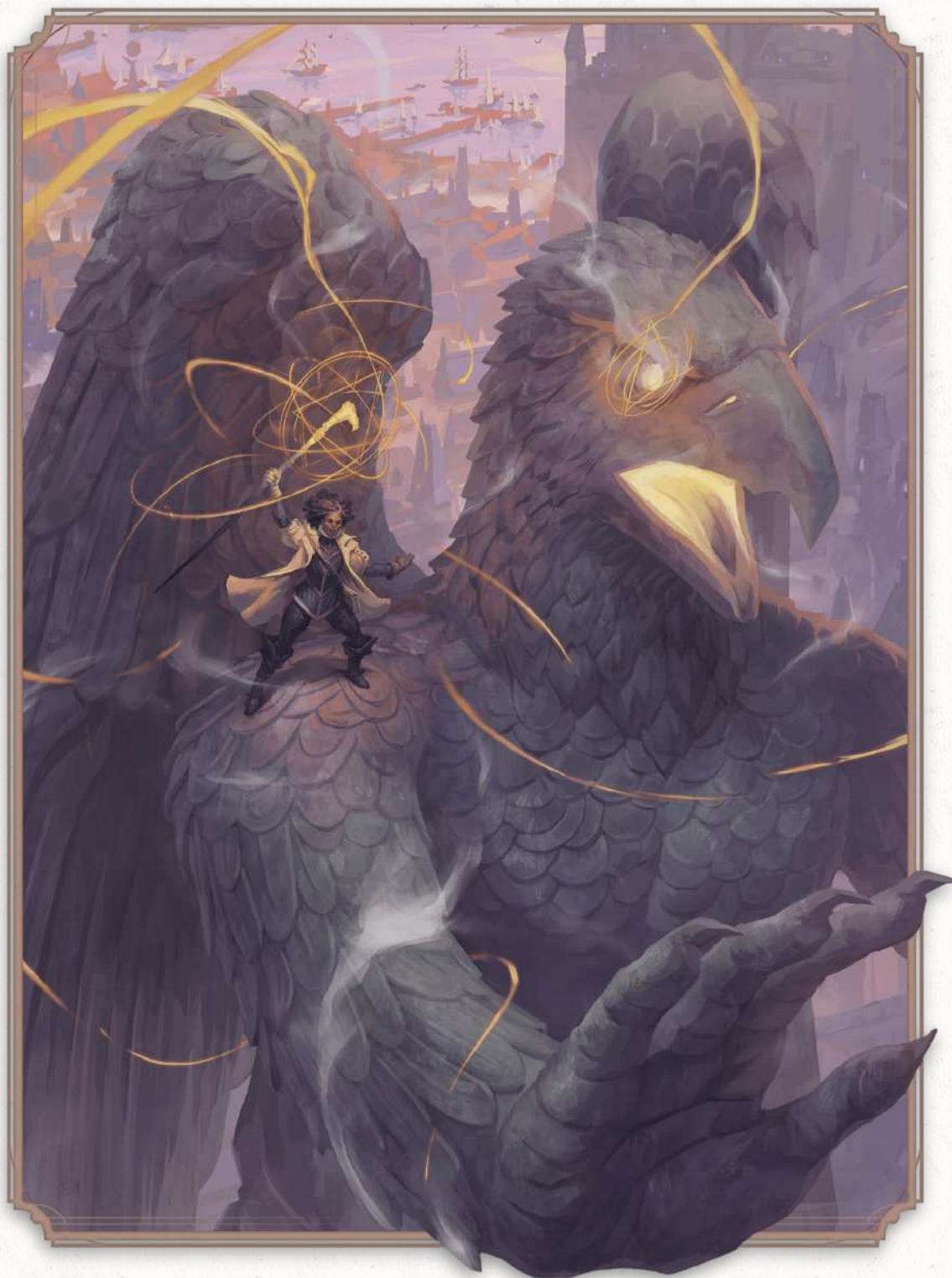
This vehicle is a Wagon (see the *Player's Handbook*) covered by durable canvas. A creature has **Three-Quarters Cover** while riding inside this vehicle.



ARTIST: POLAR ENGINE

CHAPTER 5

MAGIC OF FAERÛN



VAJRA SAFAHR COMMANDS THE MIGHTY WALKING STATUES OF WATERDEEP.
ARTIST: DENMAN ROOKE

FROM THE SIMPLEST CANTRIP TO THE MIGHTIEST WORKINGS OF HIGH MAGIC, FROM A HUMBLE **CURE WOUNDS** SPELL TO THE RAISING OF MIGHTY HEROES FROM THE DEAD, magic permeates the Realms. And any understanding of magic in Faerûn begins with understanding the Weave.

THE WEAVE

The Weave is the raw material from which the tapestry of magic is woven—an essential element of the universe that flows through all things. Some creatures, objects, and locations have especially deep connections to the Weave. Such creatures can perform extraordinary feats that come naturally to them (a beholder’s flight, a vampire’s charming gaze, a dragon’s breath weapon, and so forth), while individuals with the necessary talent and skill can cast spells by manipulating the Weave. The Weave isn’t normally visible or detectable, except through the use of spells.

The god Mystra is the Weave’s keeper and caretaker. All three times the god of magic died or was separated from her divinity (twice as Mystra, and once as her predecessor, Mystyl), magic was twisted or failed entirely. With Mystra’s most recent death and the arrival of the Spellplague, the Weave was thought to be destroyed. But in the Second Sundering, both Mystra and the Weave returned, and spells and magic items became reliable once more.

MAGIC ITEMS

While a spell is brought to life by manipulating threads of the Weave, the creation of a magic item ties those threads together. The Weave enables individuals to call forth the energy inside a magic item. When a creature attunes to a magic item, threads of the Weave from both wielder and magic item become entwined.

SPELLFIRE

Spellfire is the raw energy of the Weave. The ability to refine and control it is a gift bestowed on a handful of people every generation. Spellfire can manifest as a font of silver light or healing energy, it can absorb magic, or it can be a searing blue-white jet of all-consuming radiance.

The most powerful and direct form of spellfire is spellfire sorcery. But characters of any class can display a connection to spellfire by taking the Spellfire Spark and Spellfire Adept feats. See chapter 1 for more on these feats and the Spellfire Sorcery subclass.

WEAVE-AFFECTING MAGIC

The rules for spells and spellcasting found in the *Player’s Handbook* are true in Faerûn, but some spells and magical effects might interact in unique ways with the Weave.

Detect Magic. The *Detect Magic* spell reveals threads of the Weave woven together through spellcasting, and the way the threads are arranged reveals the school of magic. Similarly, active spells and areas imbued with magic are limned in a silvery network of threads, which might twist and reknit themselves depending on the magic involved. A magic item appears enmeshed in the silvery-blue threads of the Weave.

Dispel Magic. The *Dispel Magic* spell unravels woven threads of the Weave.

Antimagic. The *Antimagic Field* spell unravels magic woven from the Weave. While an otherwise-permanent effect is within an area of antimagic, the knots of the Weave untie, but the threads retie themselves once the magic is outside the antimagic effect.

Dead Magic. In areas of dead magic, the Weave is absent. Not only do spells and magic items cease to function, but even the supernatural abilities of creatures that are innately tied to the Weave might fail as the knot of the Weave they carry with them unravels.

Wild Magic. In an area of wild magic, the Weave becomes tangled, spontaneously forming its own magic. It also twists the magical creations of the Weave, causing unexpected results.

WILD MAGIC AND DEAD MAGIC

In some parts of Faerûn, the Weave is so warped or frayed that magic doesn’t function reliably, resulting in a wild magic zone. This damage might be due to magical disasters—such as those created during the Time of Troubles, the Spellplague, and the Second Sundering—or a powerful effect that distorts the Weave, such as a mythal (see below). Wild magic zones usually go unnoticed until they make some spell effect go awry. Some mages establish strongholds near wild magic zones. They chart the boundaries of the wild magic zone, lure enemies into it, and then take advantage of their foes’ confusion and weakness.

In other parts of Faerûn, however, the Weave has a tear or hole, resulting in a dead magic zone. Many were created where extreme concentrations of magical power were abruptly shattered or destroyed. The ruins of Myth Drannor, for example, boast large dead magic zones. Dead magic zones also might manifest at locations where Artifacts are destroyed or gods are slain, ripping a hole into the Weave.

The rules for dead magic and wild magic zones are in chapter 3 of the *Dungeon Master’s Guide*.

HIGH MAGIC

In Faerûn’s early ages, the Weave hadn’t yet stabilized. Elf mages at that time developed a spellcasting system called high magic. This system required many—sometimes hundreds—of spellcasters working in concert, and a single magical effect could take days or weeks to complete. But high magic was capable of incredible feats beyond the reach of ordinary spellcasters today. Elf high mages could heal hundreds of people at once, simultaneously create multiple magic items, restore large portions of forest, or destroy an entire city. The most famous examples of high magic are the raising of the island of Evermeet from the sea and the creation of mythals.

For ages, high magic was thought lost, its techniques supplanted by traditional spellcasting as the Weave settled into its current form. But some secrets of high magic have been preserved, though few living spellcasters retain this knowledge.

Examples of high magic can be found in chapter 1 of *Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn*.

MYTHALS

Mythals are some of the most powerful magic in Faerûn. These creations are permanent fields of overlapping magical wards that bind and shape the Weave in a particular location. Mythals are sometimes so powerful that they bend or rewrite the rules of magic or even reality.

In its original usage, the term “mythal” referred to works of high magic that protected ancient elven cities, such as Myth Drannor. Its meaning has since expanded to cover all manner of similar protections, such as the magic keeping the immense floating cities of fallen Netheril afloat, the wards of Silvermoon, and the smaller workings of magic that keep safe important locations like

Candlekeep. Some even consider the many-layered wards and effects of Undermountain beneath Waterdeep a mythal.

Most mythals restrict the kinds of magic that can be employed in the area they govern; for example, a mythal might restrict teleportation magic or spells of the Conjuraton school. Evereska's mythal influences the area's weather and wards its inhabitants against disease, while the mythal of undersea Myth Nantar makes its waters breathable and more comfortable for creatures not suited to underwater life.

In many ways, a mythal is less like a spell or a magic item than a living creation of magic, capable of growing stronger or weaker, absorbing damage, or dying. Mythals can sometimes heal themselves, as did the mythal of Silverymoon, blossoming out of the Moonbridge following Mystra's most recent return.

Each active mythal has one or more individuals especially attuned to it, and these individuals can ignore any restrictions on spellcasting, direct targetable effects of the mythal, and teach others of appropriate skill how to access its secrets.

Adventurers are most likely to encounter damaged or failing mythals in ruined locations where magic once had great influence. Although an *Identify* spell might reveal some of a mythal's simplest effects, spellcasters can discover spellcasting restrictions only by trying (and failing) to cast a prohibited spell. A powerful spellcaster might learn how to access or repair a mythal without assistance, but such feats are rarely attempted by even the most renowned mages. Any elven city with "Myth" in its name (Myth Drannor, Myth Glaurach, Myth Nantar, and others) has or had a mythal. The ruins of such places often exhibit unpredictable effects related to their damaged or destroyed mythals.



PRESTO CASTS THE BLADE OF DISASTER SPELL TO FIGHT OFF VENG.

ARTIST: SWATCHES STUDIO

CIRCLE MAGIC

Millennia ago, elf mages researching alternative magical traditions developed a technique by which many spellcasters working together could cast spells beyond the limit of any individual. This technique became known as circle magic, and although it was initially developed by elves, spellcasters in Thay and Rashemen reinvented the technique, and from there it quickly spread to other realms in Faerûn.

WHAT IS A CIRCLE SPELL?

When a group of spellcasters collectively channel their magic into a single spell, they can enhance and augment the spell's magic in powerful ways. A spell cast in this way is known as a Circle spell.

ELIGIBLE SPELLS

Any spell that has a casting time of an action or 1 minute or longer and is cast using a spell slot can be cast as a Circle spell. To cast a Circle spell, follow the usual rules for spellcasting, as described in the *Player's Handbook*, as well as the following rules for Circle spells.

CASTING A CIRCLE SPELL

A Circle spell has one primary caster ("you" in these rules). Unless otherwise specified, you as the primary caster decide the spell's targets, maintain Concentration if required by the spell's Duration entry, provide the spell's components, expend the slot for casting the spell, and decide any of the other options noted in the spell's description. The spell's effects originate from you.

INITIATING A CIRCLE SPELL

You take a **Magic** action to initiate casting a Circle spell. When you do so, choose which Circle casting option (see "Circle Casting Options" below) you're using for this casting; you must also meet any of the other requirements described in that option's text. Until the Circle spell's casting is complete (see below), you must maintain **Concentration** on the spell.

If a Reaction would trigger when a creature casts a spell—such as the Reaction taken to cast *Counterspell*—it also triggers when you take this action to initiate a Circle spell.

SECONDARY CASTERS

Casting a Circle spell requires that one or more other spellcasters, called secondary casters, lend their magic to the spell. A secondary caster must have either the Spellcasting or Pact Magic feature to participate in a Circle spell.

After you initiate the spell, each secondary caster takes the **Magic** action to contribute to the spell. A secondary caster can take this action only while within 30 feet of you and before the start of your next turn.

COMPLETING THE CASTING

If the spell has a casting time of an action, the Circle spell's effects occur immediately after the final secondary caster takes the required action to contribute to the spell. You decide which secondary caster is the final one.

If the spell has a casting time of 1 minute or more, you and each secondary caster must take the **Magic** action on each of your turns for the entire casting time, and you must each maintain Concentration while you do so. In this case, if any caster's Concentration is broken, the spell fails.

NPC SECONDARY CASTERS

Some Circle spells require secondary casters to expend one or more spell slots to participate in the spell's casting. At the DM's discretion, NPCs capable of casting spells—such as spellcasters hired in settlements—can meet this requirement by expending one or more limited uses of any spells of the same level or higher in place of the required spell slots.

SPELL FAILURE

If a Circle spell fails, nothing happens. You don't expend a spell slot, and any Material components aren't consumed. To cast the spell again, you must start over.



RED WIZARDS DEVELOPED CIRCLE MAGIC TO CAST SPELLS BEYOND THE POWER OF ANY SINGLE MAGE.
ARTIST: BRIAN VALENZUELA

CIRCLE CASTING OPTIONS

The following options provide ways to enhance a spell when casting it as a Circle spell. You can use only one Circle casting option on a spell at a time.

Some spells have a “Casting as a Circle Spell” section in their description. Instead of using one of the following options, you can create the effect described in that section when casting the spell as a Circle spell. Such effects are often uniquely powerful and specific to their respective spells.

AUGMENT

When you cast a spell with a range of at least 5 feet, you can increase the range of the spell by 1,000 feet per secondary caster contributing to the spell, up to a maximum of a 1-mile increase.

DISTRIBUTE

When you cast a spell that requires **Concentration**, you can distribute the mental load of the spell among you and the secondary casters. Once the casting is complete, you and all secondary casters can maintain Concentration on this spell. As long as at least one caster who contributed to the spell maintains this Concentration, the spell's effects remain active.

EXPAND

When you cast a spell that creates an area of effect, you can increase one dimension of the spell's area of effect for this casting by 10 feet per secondary caster contributing to the spell. For example, if a spell creates a 20-foot-radius **Sphere**, casting it as a Circle spell with two secondary casters would increase the radius to 40 feet. A spell that creates a **Line** that is 5 feet wide and 300 feet long, cast as a Circle spell with two secondary casters, could make a Line that is either 25 feet wide or 320 feet long.

Each secondary caster contributing to the spell must expend a spell slot (no action required). If the spell fails, these spell slots aren't expended.

PROLONG

When you cast a spell that has a duration of 1 minute or longer, you can increase the duration of the spell depending on the number of secondary casters contributing to the spell, as detailed in the table below.

Each secondary caster contributing to the spell must expend a spell slot (no action required). If the spell fails, these spell slots aren't expended.

Secondary Casters	The Spell Increases Duration By ...
1–3	1 hour
4–6	8 hours
7+	24 hours

SAFEGUARD

When you cast a spell that creates an area of effect, you can carve out a safe zone within that area of effect that is unaffected by the spell for its duration. This safe zone consists of a number of 5-foot **Cubes** equal to your spellcasting ability modifier plus the number of secondary casters contributing to the spell (minimum of one Cube). You can arrange the Cubes as you like, but each Cube must be contiguous with at least one other Cube.

If the spell's area of effect can be moved, the safe zone moves with it.

SUPLANT

When you cast a spell that requires at least one Material component with a specified cost that is consumed by the spell, you can reduce the minimum cost of one such Material component by 50 GP per each secondary caster contributing to the spell. For example, casting **Revivify** as a Circle spell with two secondary casters would reduce the Material component's minimum cost to 200 GP.

Each secondary caster contributing to the spell must expend a spell slot of a level greater than or equal to the spell's level (no action required). If the spell fails, these spell slots aren't expended.

CIRCLE MAGIC IN THE GAME

Circle magic provides unique and strategic ways of altering spellcasting. Here are some general guidelines for implementing circle magic in your game.

Character Level and Experience. Though characters of any level can use circle magic, characters with access to higher-level spells have more avenues to make the most of circle magic.

Know Your Spells. Casting a Circle spell benefits from a solid understanding of how regular spellcasting works. Be sure to study your prepared spells and Circle casting options before the game. Many Circle casting options provide the most benefits to spellcasting when used outside of combat!

Plan Ahead. Circle magic functions best when participants strategize ahead of time. To avoid bogging down combat, work together with fellow spellcasters to determine how and when to cast a Circle spell. Additionally, ensure all participants still have ample opportunity to cast spells and act independently beyond contributing to circle magic.



ALUSTRIEL SILVERHAND USES HER MOONCLOAK TO PROTECT HER ALLIES.

ARTIST: IRINA NORDSOL

SPELLS

The following spells are presented in alphabetical order.

ALUSTRIEL'S MOONCLOAK

Level 5 Abjuration (Bard, Druid, Ranger, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (a moonstone worth 50+ GP)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

For the duration, moonlight fills a 20-foot **Emanation** originating from you with **Dim Light**. While in that area, you and your allies have **Half Cover** and **Resistance** to Cold, Lightning, and Radiant damage.

While the spell lasts, you can use one of the following options, ending the spell immediately:

Liberation. When you fail a saving throw to avoid or end the **Frightened**, **Grappled**, or **Restrained** condition, you can take a Reaction to succeed on the save instead.

Respite. As a **Magic** action, you or an ally within the area regains Hit Points equal to 4d10 plus your spellcasting ability modifier.

BACKLASH

Level 4 Abjuration (Bard, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Reaction, which you take in response to taking damage

Range: 60 feet

Components: V

Duration: Instantaneous

You ward yourself against destructive energy, reducing the damage taken by 4d6 plus your spellcasting ability modifier.

If the triggering damage was from a creature within range, you can force the creature to make a Constitution saving throw. The creature takes 4d6 Force damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The damage reduction and Force damage from this spell both increase by 1d6 for every spell slot level above 4.

BLADE OF DISASTER

Level 9 Conjuration (Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard)

Casting Time: Bonus Action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You create a 3-foot-long blade-shaped planar rift that lasts for the duration. The rift appears within range in a space of your choice, and you can immediately make up to two melee spell attacks, each one against a creature or object within 5 feet of the rift. On a hit, the target takes 10d6 Force damage. This attack scores a Critical Hit if the number on the d20 is 18 or higher.

As a Bonus Action on your later turns, you can move the rift up to 60 feet and repeat the two attacks against a creature or an object within 5 feet of it. You can direct the attacks at the same target or at different ones.

The blade can harmlessly pass through any barrier, including ones created by spells like **Wall of Force**.

CACOPHONIC SHIELD

Level 3 Evocation (Bard, Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S

Duration: Concentration, up to 10 minutes

Thunderous reverberations fill a 10-foot **Emanation** originating from you for the duration. Whenever the Emanation enters a creature's space and whenever a creature enters the Emanation or ends its turn there, the creature makes a Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature takes 3d6 Thunder damage and has the **Deafened** condition until the start of your next turn. On a successful save, the creature takes half as much damage only. A creature makes this save only once per turn. When you cast this spell, you can designate creatures to be unaffected by it.

In addition, you have Resistance to Thunder damage, and ranged attack rolls against you are made with Disadvantage.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The damage increases by 1d6 for each spell slot level above 3.

CONJURE CONSTRUCTS

Level 3 Conjuration (Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S, M (a brass cog)

Duration: Concentration, up to 10 minutes

You conjure a group of intangible, orderly spirits that appear as a Medium group of modrons or other Constructs in an unoccupied space you can see within range. The spirits last for the duration.

When you cast this spell and as a **Magic** action on subsequent turns, you can command the spirits to target one creature or object you can see within 5 feet of the spirits and create one of the following effects:

Clockwork Force. The target makes a Dexterity saving throw, taking 3d6 Force damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Orderly Ward. The target gains **Temporary Hit Points** equal to 1d6 plus your spellcasting ability modifier.

When you move on your turn, you can also move the spirits up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space you can see.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The damage and Temporary Hit Points both increase by 1d6 for each spell slot level above 3.

DEATH ARMOR

Level 2 Necromancy (Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Touch

Components: V, S, M (an onyx worth 50+ GP, which the spell consumes)

Duration: 1 hour

For the duration, an inky aura surrounds one creature you touch. The target has Advantage on Death Saving Throws, and once per turn, when a creature within 5 feet of the target hits it with a melee attack roll, the attacker takes 2d4 Necrotic damage.

DERYAN'S HELPFUL HOMUNCULI

Level 2 Conjuration (Cleric, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action or Ritual

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (powdered gemstones worth 100+ GP, which the spell consumes, and one set of Artisan's Tools with which you have proficiency)

Duration: 8 hours

You summon a group of helpful spirits, which lasts for the duration. The spirits appear as homunculi or as another Construct of your choice but are intangible and invulnerable, and they are considered to have proficiency in the **Arcana** skill and with the set of Artisan's Tools used in the spell's casting.

If you are crafting an item, the spirits function as a single assistant for your crafting, halving the crafting time.

DIRGE

Level 6 Enchantment (Bard, Cleric)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Self

Components: V

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

Deathly power fills a 60-foot **Emanation** originating from you for the duration.

When you cast this spell, you can designate creatures to be unaffected by it. Any other creature can't regain Hit Points while in the Emanation. Whenever the Emanation enters a creature's space and whenever a creature enters the Emanation or ends its turn there, the creature makes a Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature takes 3d10 Necrotic damage and has the **Prone** condition. On a successful save, the creature takes half as much damage and its Speed is halved. A creature makes this save only once per turn.

Casting as a Circle Spell. Casting this as a Circle spell requires a minimum of two secondary casters. If the spell is cast as a Circle spell, its duration becomes Concentration, up to 10 minutes.

A creature that fails its save against the spell's effect also gains 1 **Exhaustion** level. While the creature has Exhaustion levels, finishing a Long Rest neither restores lost Hit Points nor reduces the creature's Exhaustion level.

When the spell is cast, each secondary caster must expend a level 4+ spell slot; otherwise, the spell fails.

DOOMTIDE

Level 4 Conjuration (Bard, Cleric, Warlock)

Casting Time: Action

Range: 120 feet

Components: V, S, M (soot and a dried eel)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You create a 20-foot-radius **Sphere** of inky fog within range. The fog is magical **Darkness** and lasts for the duration or until a strong wind (such as the one created by the *Gust of Wind* spell) disperses it, ending the spell.

Each creature in the Sphere when it appears makes a Wisdom saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 5d6 Psychic damage and subtracts 1d6 from its saving throws until the end of its next turn. On a successful save, a creature takes half as much damage only. A creature also makes this save when the Sphere moves into its space, when it enters the Sphere, or when it ends its turn inside the Sphere. A creature makes this save only once per turn.

The Sphere moves 10 feet away from you at the start of each of your turns.

Casting as a Circle Spell. Casting this as a Circle spell requires a minimum of five secondary casters. In addition to the spell's usual components, you must provide a special component (a string of three black pearls from Pandemonium), which the spell consumes. The spell's range increases to 1 mile, and its duration increases to until dispelled (no **Concentration** required). The spell ends early if any caster who participated in this casting contributes to another casting of *Doomtide* as a Circle spell.

When the spell is cast, each secondary caster must expend a level 3+ spell slot; otherwise, the spell fails.

ELMINSTER'S EFFULGENT SPHERES

Level 6 Evocation (Druid, Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (an opal worth 1,000 GP+)

Duration: 1 hour

Six chromatic spheres orbit you for the duration.

While the spheres are present, you can expend spheres to create the following effects:

Absorb Energy. When you take Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder damage, you can take a Reaction to expend one sphere and give yourself Resistance to the triggering damage type until the start of your next turn.

Energy Blast. As a Bonus Action, you send one sphere hurtling toward a target within 120 feet of yourself. Make a ranged spell attack. On a hit, the target takes 3d6 Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder damage (your choice). Regardless of whether you hit, the sphere is expended.

The spell ends early if you have no more spheres remaining.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The number of spheres increases by 1 for every spell slot level above 6.

ELMINSTER'S ELUSION

Level 2 Abjuration (Wizard)

Casting Time: Bonus Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S

Duration: Concentration, up to 10 minutes

Arcane wards protect you against magic for the duration. You have Advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects. Additionally, if you succeed on a saving throw against a spell or magical effect and would normally take half as much damage, you instead take no damage.

HOLY STAR OF MYSTRA

Level 8 Evocation (Cleric, Wizard)

Casting Time: Bonus Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You create a glowing mote of energy that hovers above you for the duration. The mote sheds **Bright Light** in a 5-foot radius and **Dim Light** for an additional 5 feet.

When you cast this spell and as a Bonus Action on later turns, you can unleash a shining bolt from the mote, targeting one creature within 120 feet of yourself. Make a ranged spell attack. On a hit, the target takes Force or Radiant damage (your choice) equal to 4d10 plus your spellcasting ability modifier.

In addition, while the mote is present, you have **Three-Quarters Cover**, and if you succeed on a saving throw against a spell of level 7 or lower that targeted only you and didn't create an area of effect, you can take a Reaction to deflect that spell back at the spell's caster; the caster makes a saving throw against that spell using that caster's own spell save DC.

LAERAL'S SILVER LANCE

Level 3 Evocation (Cleric, Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (a silver pin worth 250+ GP)

Duration: Instantaneous

Silver energy bursts out from you in a 120-foot-long, 5-foot-wide **Line**. Each creature of your choice in the Line makes a Strength saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 3d10 Force damage and has the **Proned** condition. On a successful save, a creature takes half as much damage only.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The damage increases by 1d10 for every spell slot level above 3.



ELMINSTER'S EFFULGENT SPHERES CAN BE USED TO BOTH ATTACK AND DEFEND.

ARTIST: BORJA PINDADO

SIMBUL'S SYNOSTODWEOMER

Level 7 Transmutation (Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Touch

Components: V, S

Duration: 1 hour

You imbue one creature you touch with magical healing energy for the duration. Whenever the target casts a spell using a spell slot, the target can immediately roll a number of unexpended Hit Point Dice equal to the spell slot's level and regain Hit Points equal to the roll's total plus your spellcasting ability modifier; those dice are then expended.

SONGAL'S ELEMENTAL SUFFUSION

Level 5 Transmutation (Druid, Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (a pearl worth 100+ GP)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You imbue yourself with the elemental power of genies. You gain the following benefits until the spell ends:

Elemental Immunity. When you cast this spell, choose one of the following damage types: Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder. You have Resistance to the chosen damage type.

Elemental Pulse. When you cast this spell and at the start of each of your subsequent turns, you release a burst of elemental energy in a 15-foot **Emanation** originating from yourself. Each creature of your choice in that area makes a Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 2d6 Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder damage (your choice) and has the **Prone** condition. On a successful save, a creature takes half as much damage only.

Flight. You gain a Fly Speed of 30 feet and can hover.

Casting as a Circle Spell. If the spell is cast as a Circle spell, its casting time increases to 1 minute, and its duration increases to **Concentration**, up to 10 minutes. For each secondary caster who participates in the casting, you can choose one additional creature, to a maximum of nine additional creatures. The chosen creatures also gain the benefits of the spell for its duration.

When the spell is cast, each secondary caster must expend a level 2+ spell slot; otherwise, the spell fails.



**SULTANA SONGAL HAS SUFFUSED HERSELF
WITH THE ELEMENTAL POWER OF GENIES.**

ARTIST: TNEH KEONG

SPELLFIRE FLARE

Level 1 Evocation (Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S

Duration: Instantaneous

You unleash a blast of brilliant fire. Make a ranged spell attack against a target within range; a target gains no benefit from Half Cover or Three-Quarters Cover for this attack roll. On a hit, the target takes 2d10 Radiant damage.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. You create an additional blast for each spell slot level above 1. You can direct the blasts at the same target or at different ones. Make a separate attack roll for each blast.

SPELLFIRE STORM

Level 4 Evocation (Sorcerer, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You conjure a pillar of spellfire in a 20-foot-radius, 20-foot-high Cylinder centered on a point within range. The area of the Cylinder is Bright Light, and each creature in it when it appears makes a Constitution saving throw, taking 4d10 Radiant damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one. A creature also makes this save when it enters the spell's area for the first time on a turn or ends its turn there. A creature makes this save only once per turn.

In addition, whenever a creature in the Cylinder casts a spell, that creature makes a Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the spell dissipates with no effect, and the action, Bonus Action, or Reaction used to cast it is wasted. If that spell was cast with a spell slot, the slot isn't expended.

When you cast this spell, you can designate creatures to be unaffected by it.

Casting as a Circle Spell. In addition to the spell's usual components, you must provide a special component (a blue star sapphire worth 25,000+ GP), which the spell consumes. The spell's range increases to 1 mile, and it no longer requires Concentration. When the spell is cast, each secondary caster must expend a level 3+ spell slot; otherwise, the spell fails.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The damage increases by 1d10 for every spell slot level above 4.

The number of secondary casters determines the spell's area of effect and duration, as shown in the table below. The spell ends early if any caster who participated in this casting contributes to another casting of Spellfire Storm as a Circle spell.

Secondary Casters	Area of Effect	Duration
1–3	40-foot-radius, 40-foot-high Cylinder	1 hour
4–6	60-foot-radius, 60-foot-high Cylinder	8 hours
7+	100-foot-radius, 100-foot-high Cylinder	24 hours

SYLUNÉ'S VIPER

Level 3 Conjuration (Druid, Wizard)

Casting Time: Bonus Action

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (a snake fang)

Duration: 1 hour

A shimmering, spectral snake encircles your body for the duration. You gain 15 Temporary Hit Points; the spell ends early if you have no Temporary Hit Points left.

While the spell is active, you gain the following benefits:

Climbing. You gain a Climb Speed equal to your Speed.

Venomous Bite. As a Magic action, you can make a ranged spell attack using the snake against one creature within 50 feet. On a hit, the target takes 1d6 Force damage and has the Poisoned condition until the start of your next turn. While Poisoned, the target has the Incapacitated condition.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. For each spell slot level above 3, the number of Temporary Hit Points you gain from this spell increases by 5, and the damage of Venomous Bite increases by 1d6.

WARDAWAY

Level 1 Abjuration (Bard, Cleric, Paladin, Wizard)

Casting Time: Action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S, M (a miniature clay hand)

Duration: Instantaneous

You hurl a disorienting magical force toward one creature within range. The target makes a Constitution saving throw; Constructs and Undead automatically succeed on this save.

On a failed save, the target takes 2d4 Force damage, its Speed is halved until the start of your next turn, and on its next turn, it can take only an action or a Bonus Action (but not both). On a successful save, the target takes half as much damage only.

Using a Higher-Level Spell Slot. The damage increases by 2d4 for every spell slot level above 1.

CHAPTER 6

FACTIONS OF THE REALMS



ARTIST: CHRIS SEAMAN

MANY IN FAERÛN SEEK POWER AND PROSPERITY, BUT FEW CAN ACHIEVE THEIR AMBITIONS ALONE. INSTEAD, INDIVIDUALS JOIN INFLUENTIAL GROUPS CALLED FACTIONS. Adventurers who join a faction stand to gain honors, privileges, wealth, and, above all, respect.

Each faction has its own vision for Faerûn, and these imagined ideals are rarely fully compatible. When their goals conflict, factions form rivalries. Conversely, when one faction overextends itself or becomes too strong, its rivals band together to balance the scales of power. Frequent cooperation might eventually lead to alliances, though these partnerships are rarely made official.

Throughout this chapter, if a creature's name appears in **bold** type, you'll find that creature's stat block in the *Monster Manual* unless otherwise specified.

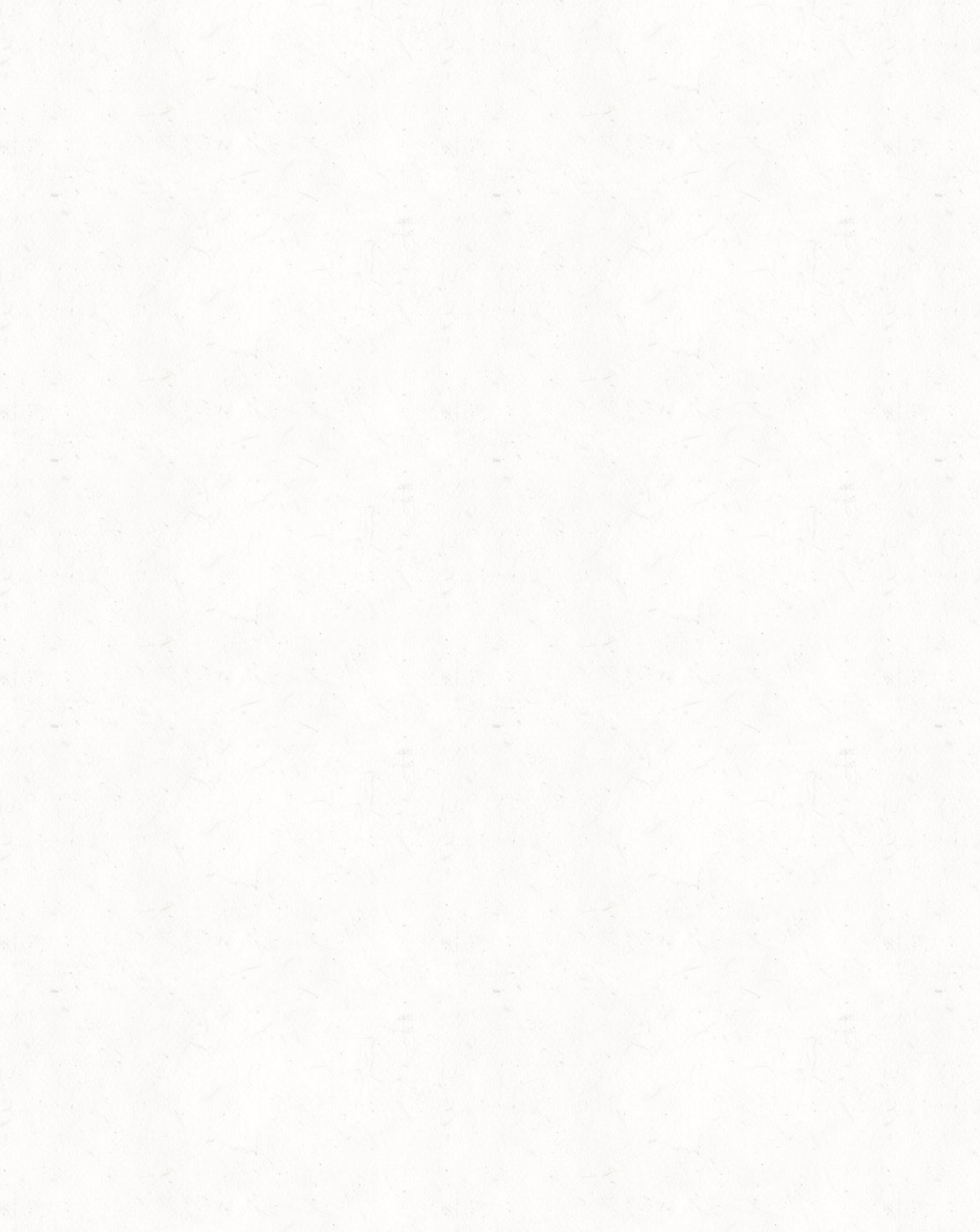
Faction Descriptions

This chapter includes details on the following factions:

- Cult of the Dragon.** The doomsayers of the Cult of the Dragon conduct profane rituals to create dracoliches and expedite the apocalypse.
- Emerald Enclave.** The druids and survivalists of the Emerald Enclave maintain the balance between nature and civilization.
- Harpers.** Skalds, sleuths, and spies make up the Harpers, an organization that aspires to make Faerûn a peaceful home for all.
- Lords' Alliance.** Cities across western Faerûn have banded together as the Lords' Alliance to ensure prosperity for their people.
- Order of the Gauntlet.** Zealous warriors of the Order of the Gauntlet smite evil in all its forms.
- Purple Dragon Knights.** Cormyr's elite warriors, the Purple Dragon Knights, bond with amethyst dragons, hunting evil and furthering Cormyr.
- Red Wizards.** Based out of the land of Thay but with enclaves all over Faerûn, Red Wizards master arcane magic and quest for ancient Artifacts.
- Zhentarim.** In the Zhentarim, greed and pride are virtues to be celebrated. Zhents wield these qualities in their pursuit of ever-greater fortunes.

SPECIAL FACILITIES

The factions detailed in this chapter each include a special facility that members of that faction can add to their Bastion. See chapter 8 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide* for the rules for Bastions.



Faction Relationships

The Faction Attitudes table summarizes the sentiments shared between the factions described in this chapter. Faction pairs marked with an *F* consider each other allies, and their members have a default attitude of **Friendly** toward one another. Faction pairs marked with an *H* consider each other rivals, and their members have a default attitude of **Hostile** toward one another. Members of factions marked with an *I* begin **Indifferent** toward one another. Exceptions might exist on an individual level.

Faction Attitudes

	Cult of the Dragon	Emerald Enclave	Harpers	Lords’ Alliance	Order of the Gauntlet	Purple Dragon Knights	Red Wizards	Zhentarim
Cult of the Dragon	F	H	H	H	H	H	I	F
Emerald Enclave	H	F	F	I	F	I	H	H
Harpers	H	F	F	F	F	I	H	H
Lords’ Alliance	H	I	F	F	F	F	H	H
Order of the Gauntlet	H	F	F	F	F	F	H	H
Purple Dragon Knights	H	I	I	F	F	F	H	I
Red Wizards	I	H	H	H	H	H	I	F
Zhentarim	F	H	H	H	H	I	F	F

CULT OF THE DRAGON



ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA

At its outset, the Cult of the Dragon primarily concerned itself with the creation and worship of dracoliches—powerful undead dragons the cult believes will inevitably rule Faerûn—through rituals detailed in the *Tome of the Dragon*. More recently, however, the cult has splintered, with many within the cult committing themselves to Tiamat, the evil Queen of Dragons. This splinter group elevates Tiamat above other divinities and looks forward to the Dragon Queen's return, believing that she—not dracoliches—will destroy civilization, usher in a glorious reign of dragons, and reward those who helped bring about draconic rule.

Dragon-themed symbolism and iconography pervade the cult's regalia: a cape or cloak cut to resemble dragon wings, plus clothing, jewelry, and draconic accessories reflecting the wearer's favorite type of dragon. Masks—especially masks of dragons—are common at cult gatherings, and many cultists craft their own masks.

Cultists avoid wearing this regalia in public, but anyone who knows what to look for can often pick an incognito dragon cultist out of a crowd. The most recognizable tell is the sign of Tiamat, a gesture cultists who revere the Dragon Queen use to greet one another: right hand extended, palm forward, with five fingers spread in imitation of Tiamat's five heads.

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

The cult has a simple hierarchical structure, consisting of initiates on the bottom, four ranks for cultists, and one highest rank for the Wearers of Purple—the leaders and cult masters of particular locales. The cult is ruled by secretive Wearers of Purple called wyrmspeakers—a term of respect given to those whose bond with dragons is supernaturally strong.

Rank in the cult is based on merit and fanaticism. As raw recruits, initiates have no rank and follow the orders of their superiors. Only initiates that prove their worth can advance. A Wearer of Purple can promote an initiate along the track of dragonclaw (first rank), dragonwing (second rank), dragonfang (third rank), and dragonsoul (fourth rank).

Cult operation groups vary in size, from a few low-ranking cultists operating on their own to hundreds of cultists of various ranks under the control of multiple Wearers of Purple, depending on their assigned tasks.

CELLS

The Cult of the Dragon consists of countless cells spread across Faerûn. Each cell is led by one or more Wearers of Purple who report to the cult's wyrmspeakers, typically via magical correspondence. Cells have their own agendas but must conform with the wyrmspeakers' doctrine or else face expulsion from the order.

Low-ranking cultists have little reason and few opportunities to interact with cultists outside their own cell.

RECRUITMENT

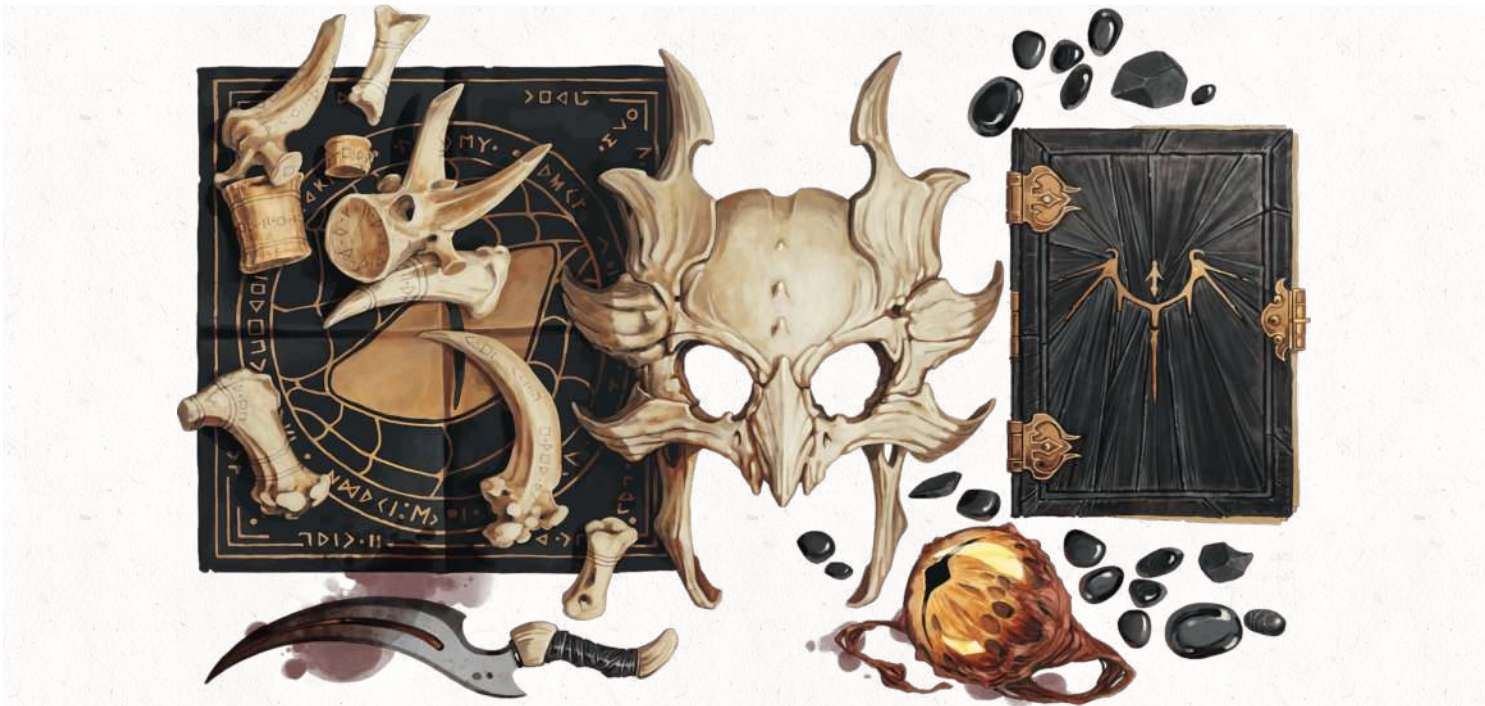
The Cult of the Dragon is always seeking to expand its ranks. New recruits are encouraged to bring trusted family members and friends for conversion. The next most common form of recruitment is tried-and-true abduction combined with cult indoctrination. Cultists also sometimes recruit undead, fey, or other monsters.

Cult leaders aren't opposed to hiring mercenaries for specific jobs or when ranks are thin. The cult casts a wide net with vaguely worded fliers on job boards or shadowy brokers posted in dark tavern corners; higher-ranking cultists then cherry-pick the most promising (that is, manipulable) prospects. In this way, countless soldiers of fortune, run-of-the-mill toughs, and even seasoned adventurers have unwittingly undertaken missions for the cult. Some complete their job none the wiser of their involvement in the cult's schemes. Others discover the ruse in time to flee. An unsavory few catch on to the true nature of their work and use the opportunity to seek admission to the cult.

The Cult of the Dragon is a centuries-old cabal of evil mages, doomsayers, and dragon worshippers. Its members believe in apocalyptic prophecies that center on dragons as the world's inevitable destroyers (or, rarely, its saviors). To hasten the end times, cultists enact elaborate rituals to empower or summon evil dragons.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

The plots of the Cult of the Dragon are secret, but its existence isn't. Most folk in Faerûn have heard of the cult but know only that its members revere evil dragons. The cult recruits new members in major cities, where many cultists engage in legitimate business or are assigned to ordinary academic research. Only a few serve as thieves, assassins, and spies.



ARTIST: COUPLEOFKOOKS

WEARERS OF PURPLE

The Wearers of Purple stand at the top of the cult’s hierarchy, and their word is law for the cultists in the cities, strongholds, and lairs they command. They are the only members of the cult to wear purple, and most are proud enough to flaunt the color. The Wearers of Purple have an affinity for talking to and negotiating with dragons—the gift of wyrmspeaking. Dozens of Wearers of Purple are spread throughout the Cult of the Dragon, and all can marshal the cult’s resources at will.

Only the cult’s inner circle can promote a dragonsoul to a Wearer of Purple, granting that character a base of operations and funds. Most new Wearers of Purple have already developed a working relationship with a dragon or dracolich as part of their power and authority. Those who don’t cultivate this relationship are sometimes demoted. Several priests of Tiamat have recently been made Wearers of Purple and are establishing temples for her open worship in Faerûn.

Wyrmspeakers. Five Wearers of Purple conduct the cult’s farthest-reaching plans. The members of this inner circle each wear a different colored dragon mask that hides their true identities. They call themselves wyrmspeakers, and members of the cult fear their power over dragons. Each wyrmspeaker has an affinity for a particular color of chromatic dragon. They treat with dragons of those colors to recruit more dragons to the cause, and plan cult missions that advance the cult’s plots.

LEAVING THE CULT

Once initiated, a cultist belongs to the cult for life. Those who escape the cult spend the rest of their days fearful of every shadow and stranger, for the cult doesn’t take kindly to deserters. In exceptionally rare cases, a cult member might be excommunicated yet allowed to live. The price of this mercy is never cheap; exiled cultists must usually give up all their memories to mind-obliterating magic or commit some unspeakable act the cult can later use as blackmail if needed.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Cult of the Dragon by working with dragons or by completing quests for the cult. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Cult of the Dragon Renown table. If your campaign doesn’t use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

CULT OF THE DRAGON RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	The Cult of the Dragon provides you a Poor lifestyle for free at its hideouts.
5+	You can hire Cult of the Dragon hirelings for half the usual cost.
10	You receive the honorary rank of dragonclaw. The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, the cult rewards you with one random Uncommon magic item.
15+	You receive the honorary rank of dragonwing. You can assign a squad of up to six Cultists to perform any task that doesn’t directly conflict with the cult’s doctrine. Once you use this reward, you can’t do so again until your Renown Score increases.
25+	You receive the honorary rank of dragonfang. You can request the aid of one Cultist Fanatic for a mission. Once you use this reward, you can’t do so again until your Renown Score increases.
30	The first time your Renown Score reaches 30, the cult rewards you with one random Rare magic item.
40+	You receive the honorary rank of dragonsoul. You can call in a favor to make a specific Humanoid creature “disappear” for 1d10 days. You must know the name of the target creature, but you don’t need to know their location. Once you use this reward, you can’t do so again until your Renown Score increases.
50+	You receive the honorary rank of Wearer of Purple. All cultists obey your instruction and openly provide you information. In addition, you can request an audience with the cult’s inner circle. Once you use this reward, you can’t do so again.

CULT OF THE DRAGON CHARACTERS

The Cult of the Dragon attracts members from all walks of life; soldiers, spellcasters, and scoundrels all have skills valuable to the cult.

Any character might associate with the Cult of the Dragon, even those who aren't evil. Desperate times can push good-natured people to beseech the cult for a favor. Cultists often blackmail innocent people—including cultists' own family members—into doing work for the cult. A character could be aiding the cult unwittingly (even if you, the player, know the truth).

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Cult of the Dragon, you receive the following benefits.

Tithing. You are expected to donate 100 GP or 10% of your earnings per month, whichever is less, to the leader of your cult's cell.

Trinket. Roll on the Cult of the Dragon Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Cult of the Dragon.

Vestments. As part of your initiation, you receive a set of Robes and a sinister dragon mask. You choose the color of these vestments: black, blue, green, red, or white.

Cult of the Dragon Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A dragon claw pendant on a leather cord
2	Ashes of a dracolich in a small brass canister
3	A map of an unknown dragon's lair
4	A black pearl etched with a Draconic rune
5	A drop of dragon's blood preserved in amber
6	A scrap of purple silk

MARKED BY THE DRAGON

The Cult of the Dragon conducts sacrificial rituals to advance its esoteric goals. But not all the cult's sacrificial victims perish in the ordeal. A rare few emerge from the ritual not just alive, but changed. Such survivors are said to be "marked by the dragon." Some call these individuals dragonscarred. Different cells treat dragonscarred differently. Some view them as monstrous and exile them from the cult's territory. Others treat dragonscarred well, elevating them to higher stations in the cult.

If your character has undergone a sacrificial ritual and yet survived, you can roll on the Dragonscarred Blessings table to randomly determine the physical feature your character bears from the ordeal. These features are superficial and serve no practical function.

DRAGONSCARRED BLESSINGS

1d8	Physical Feature
1	You bear a facial scar in the shape of a dragon.
2	You have vestigial dragon horns, vestigial wings, or a vestigial tail.
3	Your eyes have slitted pupils and vividly colored irises.
4	Parts of your skin are covered in patches of reptilian scales.
5	Your blood is icy cold.
6	A flame crackles inside your chest, and you exhale bits of ash with every breath.
7	You crave and can digest foods your species would normally find inedible, such as whole eggs, raw poultry, dirt, or bones.
8	Your hair stands on end and crackles with static electricity.

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Cult of the Dragon can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

CULT OF THE DRAGON ARCHIVE

Level 13 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Cult of the Dragon

Space: Roomy

Hirelings: 1

Order: Research

A Cult of the Dragon Archive contains extensive records on specific topics, including dragons.

Research: Helpful Lore. When you issue the Research order to this facility, you commission the facility's hireling to search the archive for lore. The work takes 7 days. The hireling gains knowledge as if they had cast the **Legend Lore** spell, then shares this knowledge with you the next time you speak with them.

Reference Books. Your Cult of the Dragon Archive contains a collection of draconic lore. You have Advantage on Intelligence (**Nature or Religion**) checks you make in your Bastion when you take the **Study** action to recall lore about Dragons, Tiamat, or the Cult of the Dragon.

Enlarging the Facility. You can enlarge your Cult of the Dragon Archive to a Vast facility by spending 2,000 GP. If you do so, you gain two reference books chosen from those listed in the Archive entry in chapter 8 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*.



A GOLD DRAGON'S SKELETON HANGS AT THE CENTER OF A CULT OF THE DRAGON ARCHIVE.

ARTIST: DOMENICO CAVA

EMERALD ENCLAVE

A ranger guards a caravan through monster-plagued wilds. Forest defenders dismantle a war camp polluting a vital river. A circle of druids enacts a rain ritual for a drought-stricken village. These are but a few examples of how the Emerald Enclave makes the world a peaceful, hospitable place for people and nature alike.

The Emerald Enclave is an organization of survivalists and nature worshipers who refer to themselves as Caretakers. Members of the enclave maintain the balance between wilderness and civilization and reinforce what they call “the natural order.” This natural order is exemplified by places where people and nature live in harmony—places where neither settlements nor wilds threaten to overwhelm the other. Caretakers protect such areas with their lives. To the Emerald Enclave, individual sacrifice is worthwhile if it means the preservation of the whole.



ARTIST: OLGA DREBAS

Caretakers wear green clothes made from natural, foraged materials such as plants and animal hides. The most powerful members have magically bright-green eyes. Most Caretakers are constantly surrounded by animals and can walk seamlessly between civilization and the wilds.

Members of the Emerald Enclave are loosely organized into diffuse subfactions called circles. Some Caretakers from the same circle might work together in small bands, but many operate in isolation. These lone wolves rely on the animals and plants around them to monitor other Caretakers (and non-Caretakers) in their vicinity.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

Caretakers preserve sacred natural sites by guarding them from logging, mining, and other exploitation. In areas where the natural order has already been compromised, the enclave restores the land so it is once again fruitful and hospitable. The enclave's spellcasters draw on nature magic to expedite labors such as planting trees and cleaning litter-filled waterways.

In dire situations—such as an undead-riddled battlefield—the Emerald Enclave leads coordinated assaults to root out the land's defilers. When necessary, Caretakers put impenitent evildoers to the sword. Members of the enclave don't relish violence against nature's children, but they know destruction is sometimes necessary for healing to begin. Caretakers do, however, proudly raise arms against unnatural forces such as aberrant monsters, reanimated dead, and machines of war. Members of the enclave believe such creatures exist to threaten the natural order and must be destroyed.

When they aren't healing broken lands or fending off the forces of chaos, Caretakers study and promote the ways that fauna and flora peacefully coexist in nature. Some spend time in settlements to forge new connections and encourage communities to tend the world around them. The enclave is always in search of allies, for, as one Caretaker saying puts it, the herd is strongest when its numbers are great. Thus, wise Caretakers hone their communication skills, knowing that a compelling speech or poignant adage can help others connect to the land.

LUNAR RITUALS

The cycle of the moon and seasons is important to the Emerald Enclave's rituals. New Caretakers are initiated to the enclave each month on the full moon. New moons are reserved for tribunals, when judgment is passed on enemies taken prisoner or on Caretakers who've failed to uphold their duties. Many Caretakers plan sojourns to coincide with the lunar cycle so that they venture away from home while the moon wanes, then return while it waxes.

Just as the enclave shares in times of bounty, so too it shares the onus of performing necessary evils. When a tribunal demands capital punishment or a lunar ritual requires animal sacrifice, the tribunal selects an executioner through a casting of holy stones or sacred sticks or the summoning of a nature spirit that temporarily possesses an individual. In this way, no single Caretaker must bear the entire weight of the grisly work that must be done.

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

A Caretaker who achieves acclaim might take an epithet. Typically such an epithet is bestowed by another Caretaker to commemorate a worthy deed. Storied Caretakers have multiple epithets, which are then appended to one another; for example, a veteran enclave member named Krodar might be referred to as “Caretaker Krodar, Axe Breaker, and Tamer of Owlbeards.”



FROM LEFT TO RIGHT: *CIRCLE OF AIR*, *CIRCLE OF THE ANCIENTS*, *CIRCLE OF THE GIANTS*, *CIRCLE OF THE LAND*, *CIRCLE OF THE MOON*, *CIRCLE OF WILDFIRE*
ARTIST: COUPLEOFKOOKS

ENCLAVE CIRCLES

A circle of the Emerald Enclave is a collective of Caretakers who study and practice the teachings of a particular aspect of the natural world to achieve the enclave's goals. Circles act independently, but they might seek one another's expertise when dealing with large-scale or far-ranging challenges.

There is some overlap between enclave circles and druid circles. But not all druids belong to the Emerald Enclave, and not all enclave members are druids. A druid of the Circle of the Moon, for example, might go their entire life without encountering the Emerald Enclave's circle of the same name, even though both groups practice similar teachings and rituals.

Each circle is led by its longest-serving and most accomplished members: sage rangers and ancient druids known as Verdant Ones. Verdant Ones lead lunar rituals, train new Caretakers, and coordinate missions with other circles. Often, a Verdant One passes judgment on issues where the balance between natural forces is unclear.

These are just a few of the enclave's circles in Faerûn:

The Circle of Air believes the world's eons-long natural cycle requires similarly lengthy study to fully comprehend.

The Circle of the Ancients is the oldest and most influential circle, tapping into primordial secrets.

The Circle of the Giants reveres the titans of the natural world: dinosaurs, dragons, and megafauna.

The Circle of the Land is the largest circle, protecting nature in all its forms and helping others survive in the wilderness.

The Circle of the Moon aids those who travel at night, and those threatened by nocturnal forces.

The Circle of Wildfire understands destruction is a fundamental part of the natural cycle and individual sacrifice is necessary for the greater good.

THE THREE

The leaders of the Emerald Enclave are called the Three. These legendary druids provide guidance to other enclave circles and pass judgment on the most serious offenses. They occupy and protect a sacred temple to Silvanus called Oakenhall. Rarely the Three might visit another sacred site; such visits are never announced and rarely portend good news.

Though rarely spoken of as individuals, the Three are sometimes identified by the leaf-shaped masks they wear: the Oak, the Elm, and the Willow. The Three began as ordinary people, but when an individual dons one of these three magical masks, the mask merges with their flesh and transforms the wearer into a faceless, ageless being of no known species—nine feet tall and identical to the other members.

SACRED SITES

All over Faerûn, Caretakers congregate at meeting grounds called sacred sites. Except for Oakenhall and a few other notable temples, the Emerald Enclave's sacred sites are naturally occurring locales of spiritual or magical import. The Emerald Enclave considers these sites—and any other locations where nature has worked its miracles—symbolically important and worth guarding closely. The following are a few notable sacred sites.

Coltree. In the foothills around the Spine of the World grows a massive fir called Coltree. It rises from a white granite slope ribboned with thick veins of exposed coal that give the landscape a zebra-like appearance.

Moraire. Moraire is a blue-tinted stone column in a valley of similar pillars off the west coast of the Sea of Fallen Stars. The valley is flooded most of the year, creating a unique ecosystem that's part bog, part canyon.

Silver Tear. The Silver Tearin Anauroch is an underground oasis at the center of a massive grotto. Its exact location is secret, but the entrance lies somewhere at the bottom of a steep gorge riddled with red caves.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Emerald Enclave by defending nature against would-be despoilers and by completing tasks for enclave members. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Emerald Enclave Renown table. If your campaign doesn't use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

EMERALD ENCLAVE RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	You can hire Emerald Enclave hirelings for half the usual cost.
5+	You can request a Caretaker (Scout) to accompany you on a journey and help you navigate, forage, and search. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases.
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, a Caretaker teaches you Druidic.
15+	You can buy Common and Uncommon potions and <i>Spell Scrolls</i> from the Emerald Enclave.
25+	If you or your companions are at risk of suffering from dehydration or malnutrition while within 10 miles of an enclave site, Caretakers bring you enough food and water to meet your needs.
30	The first time your Renown Score reaches 30, Caretakers provide you with 1d4 <i>Potions of Healing</i> (superior).
40+	Your eyes turn bright green. Centaurs, treants, unicorns, and all Beasts are Friendly to you by default.
50+	Members of the Emerald Enclave openly share information with you. In addition, you can request a single audience with the Three. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again.

EMERALD ENCLAVE CHARACTERS

Adventurers who commit their lives to the Emerald Enclave are often Barbarians, Druids, or Rangers, but anyone who honors and protects the natural balance can find a place in the enclave. Those who spent their formative years around the Emerald Enclave might have the Guide or Hermit background.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Emerald Enclave, you receive these benefits.

Modest Lifestyle. The Emerald Enclave provides its members with enough food, water, and shelter for a Modest lifestyle.

Trinket. Roll on the Emerald Enclave Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Emerald Enclave.

Emerald Enclave Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A pair of earrings made from oak leaves that never wilt
2	A miniature model cottage made of twigs
3	A green-glowing firefly in a bottle
4	A gourd that sounds like rustling leaves when held to one's ear
5	A preserved rabbit's foot on a leather strap
6	An antler shaped like an Elvish rune

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Emerald Enclave can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

EMERALD ENCLAVE GROVE

Level 9 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Emerald Enclave

Space: Vast

Hirelings: 2

Order: Recruit

Veteran agents of the Emerald Enclave create safe havens with trees, grass, and flowing water, where magical creatures that embody the power of nature live in peace and safety. The Emerald Enclave Grove can house one Huge creature or two Large creatures; four Small or Medium creatures or eight Tiny creatures can occupy the same space as one Large creature there.

Recruit: Creature of Nature. When you issue the Recruit order to this facility, you invite a creature from the Emerald Enclave Grove Creatures table to your Emerald Enclave Grove. Roll any die. If the number rolled is odd, the creature doesn't accept your invitation and you gain no benefit from having issued the order. If the number rolled is even, a creature accepts your invitation and moves into your Emerald Enclave Grove after 7 days. Your hirelings care for the creature and perform upkeep in the facility.

Creatures in your Emerald Enclave Grove count as Bastion Defenders. Deduct any you lose from your Bastion Defenders roster. You can choose not to count one or more of these creatures as Bastion Defenders, in which case they can't be called on to defend the Bastion. Instead, they act in accordance with their nature and use their stat blocks in the *Monster Manual*.

Emerald Enclave Grove Creatures

Creature	Size
Awakened Shrub	Small
Awakened Tree	Huge
Blink Dog	Medium
Centaur Trooper	Large
Dryad	Medium
Myconid Adult	Medium
Myconid Sprout	Small
Pixie	Tiny
Satyr	Medium
Sprite	Tiny
Treant	Large
Unicorn	Large



A CENTAUR CARETAKER ENJOYS AN IDYLIC DAY WITH BLINK DOGS AND A PIXIE IN AN EMERALD ENCLAVE GROVE.

ARTIST: SWATCHES STUDIO

HARPERS

Harpers are secretive spies, sleuths, and skalds who oppose evil throughout the Forgotten Realms. Harpers believe that power, fortune, and knowledge should be shared by all rather than hoarded by the few. They are disinterested in fame and glory—whatever they do, they do for the common good, with no expectation of reward.



ARTIST: OLGA DREBAS

Harpers employ magic, subterfuge, and wit to achieve their aims, preferably without arousing any suspicion of their interference. They favor subtle manipulation to overt action—a Harper is more likely to turn enemies against one another than to stick a dagger in a despot's back. Better yet is depriving bad actors of power in the first place, such as by securing dangerous magical weapons before they fall into the wrong hands. Yet for all their behind-the-scenes action, Harpers are well known among both downtrodden common folk, who laud them as heroes, and the forces of evil, who scorn them as meddlers.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

The Harpers' primary goals are to free the oppressed and dismantle the power structures that enable such oppression. To achieve the former, Harpers commit heroic deeds and dispense useful knowledge in equal measure. To someone who says, "Give folks a fish, and they'll eat today—teach them how to fish, and they'll eat for the rest of their lives," a Harper says, "Why not both?"

When it comes to disarming evildoers, Harpers monitor political powers and employ covert action when necessary. They don't rush into confrontation when there's time to study the situation and develop a cohesive plan. On the other hand, no Harper would hesitate to help someone in imminent danger. A Harper balances the desire to gather information and the need to act quickly.

Harpers' secondary goals are many, and the prioritization of these goals is a matter of individual discretion. Silver-tongued Harpers focus their talents on the advancement of the order's virtues, especially fairness and equality. Harpers with a penchant for magic undertake missions to protect or destroy potentially harmful magic items. And, of course, Harpers who simply want to punish the wicked and save the innocent have no trouble finding opportunities to do just that.

HARPER CODE

Harpers follow a loose set of guiding ideals called the Harper code. Like the order itself, the code is in a state of constant flux, growing, shrinking, and changing to fit the needs of the time. But some tenets, such as fairness and equality, remain much as they were when the order was first founded.

Watchwords. The Harper code is organized into a system of phrases called watchwords. Harpers coin and recite watchwords to guide their actions in uncertain situations. Harpers exchange watchwords with one another as pass phrases or to verify identities. Senior Harpers pass down watchwords in their sacred rites of initiation and in the training of new recruits.

Some Harpers carry a small book in which they collect or pen watchwords, but the Harper code has no official canon. Still, a few watchwords are so common that all Harpers can be expected to know them. Examples include the following:

No one is free until all are free.
Whatever it takes, a Harper will do.
Study the past to preserve the future.
For freedom to flourish, there must be balance.

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

The Harpers are scattered, with neither a strict hierarchy nor a centralized place of command. Rather, they consist of many small cells and lone agents who operate within a vast, loose network. This open and resilient structure has enabled the Harpers to form, disband, and re-form many times in the history of the Realms.

As befits their ethos, there is no one leader of the Harpers. Authority and responsibility are shared equally among members. That said, veteran Harpers have broader access to useful contacts and greater knowledge of goings on simply by virtue of having been around longer, and novice Harpers tend to take missions and receive counsel from their more experienced peers.

Harpers have strong bonds with their fellow Harpers. Feuds or even friendly rivalries among members are rare. A Harper never hesitates to help a fellow Harper in need.



ARTIST: RALUCA MARINESCU

HARPER CELLS AND STRONGHOLDS

Although they range across Faerûn, Harpers aren't a unified force. Some Harpers act mostly independently, but many belong to a local Harper cell—a collective of Harpers who share information and undertake missions together. These cells are differentiated by the location of their strongholds (if they have one), their local notoriety, and what parts of the Harper code they consider most important.

The Harpers of Twilight Hall in Berdusk, for example, work in coordinated groups to achieve long-range plans. Harpers based out of Silverymoon, on the other hand, emphasize the responsible use of magic and securing dangerous Artifacts. Yet another example is Harpers like those led by Storm Silverhand in Shadowdale: lone wolves who conduct themselves like secret agents.

JOINING THE HARPERS

A person doesn't simply become a Harper—they have to be chosen by a Harper to receive the honor. Harpers observe potential candidates from afar to assess their words and deeds. Candidates deemed worthy are approached by a Harper in disguise who poses a test of the individual's character. This test is typically a fabricated moral dilemma or a veiled choice between self-enrichment and self-sacrifice. To ensure their motives are true, a candidate shouldn't know they are being observed or tested.

A candidate who passes the secret test is eventually apprised of the gambit and invited to the Harpers. To join the order, the individual must swear an oath before a council of senior Harpers to uphold the Harper code. Once an individual swears this oath, they must uphold it for life.

Ex-Harpers are rare for two reasons. First, the process for testing new Harpers is rigorous enough to weed out most candidates unwilling to maintain the oath. Second, the punishment for betraying the Harpers is severe, summarized by this watchword: Traitors must die. The few Harpers who abandon their oath—or who commit an offense that doesn't warrant death—are cast out of the order. Atonement is sometimes possible, but it is a long and arduous endeavor.

HIGH HARPERS

Harpers are equal in rank with one notable exception: the High Harpers. These mysterious figures are responsible for the Harpers' long-term planning and the order's greatest campaigns against evil. High Harpers are voted into their position by a secret ballot among other High Harpers, who select candidates from among the order's most accomplished and capable individuals.

The High Harpers rarely convene, and when they do, it is a truly momentous—or dire—occasion. Someone who seeks an audience with the High Harpers might wait many moons before receiving their counsel, if it is ever granted. But the wait is worthwhile; the High Harpers' favor is a great honor and a tremendous resource.

HARPER PERSONAS

Harpers are masters of disguise and improvisation. The best Harpers develop a repertoire of false identities—called personas—to assume at a moment's notice. Veteran Harpers sometimes teach these personas to fellow Harpers or allies. Much in the way a knight might pass on their precious sword or shield to a squire, a Harper might bequeath the tale and attire of a persona to a less experienced Harper.

Harper personas share tropes or fall into recognizable archetypes. When allies recognize a persona, they realize it's a Harper and play along. When a persona becomes too well known, Harpers retire the character and develop a new one.

A character with a **Disguise Kit** can assume a Harper persona by succeeding on a DC 10 Charisma check to apply makeup. When you learn a persona in this way, you can roll on the Harper Personas table to randomly determine what persona you learn.

HARPER PERSONAS

1d8	Persona
1	Rusty Riba, a rowdy smith with a folksy accent, filthy fingernails, and a quick temper
2	Father Temino, a morose priest of Amaunator, Helm, Chauntea, or another well-known deity, who offers somber counsel in a monotone
3	Pippi Toobs, a talented but overeager busker, whose performances include whistling, sleight of hand, and foot juggling
4	Aargus, a humorless patriarch who's always complaining about his seven good-for-nothing kids who ran off to become adventurers
5	Aunt Cecilia, a silent sage, friend of animals, and inveterate winker, who's never without a bag of birdseed
6	Johann Overbridge, a scatterbrained rookie guard in ill-fitting armor who never has his papers in order
7	Vincent, a young thrill seeker and shameless heartbreaker with a fresh black eye and a cocky grin
8	Liza Lily, a flower seller with worried expression and a chronic cough, who looks even more pathetic than her wilted posies

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Harpers by completing Harper missions and upholding the Harper code. As their Renown Score with the Harpers increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Harpers Renown table. If your campaign doesn't use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

HARPER RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	You can stay in any Harper stronghold. While there, the Harpers provide you a Modest lifestyle for free.
5+	You can buy Common potions and scrolls at Harper strongholds.
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, you learn one persona from the Harper Personas table.
15+	You receive a 15 percent discount when you buy potions, scrolls, and adventuring gear at Harper strongholds.
25	The first time your Renown Score reaches 25, you receive a <i>Harper Pin</i> (silver) (see Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn) and learn an additional persona from the Harper Personas table.
30+	When you enter a settlement for the first time, local Harpers freely share any notable rumors and important intel with you.
40	The first time your Renown Score reaches 40, you receive a <i>Harper Pin</i> (golden) (see Forgotten Realms: Adventures in Faerûn) and learn an additional persona from the Harper Personas table.
50+	You can request a single audience with the High Harpers. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again.

HARPER CHARACTERS

Although many Harpers are Bards, musical talent isn't required. Rogues, Rangers, Sorcerers, and Wizards make fine Harpers.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Harpers, you receive these benefits.

Harper Kit. When you first join the Harpers, you receive a Musical Instrument and a **Disguise Kit**.

Trinket. Roll on the Harper Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Harpers.

Harper Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A broken harmonica
2	A powder compact with a hidden compartment
3	A 2-foot-long peacock feather
4	A trick coin that's heads on both sides
5	A pair of red-tinted spectacles
6	A scroll of sheet music for an unknown instrument

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Harpers can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

HARPER HIDEOUT

Level 5 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Harpers

Space: Roomy

Hirelings: 1

Order: Empower

You have a safe house hidden near your Bastion and connected to it by a tunnel no more than a quarter mile in length. Your hireling maintains the hideout, using a cover identity that doesn't link them to your Bastion. You can change the location of your Harper Hideout each time you gain a level.

Hideout Defenses. Your Harper Hideout is constantly protected by the *Alarm* spell. At level 9, your Harper Hideout can be connected to your Bastion by a magic doorway instead of a tunnel; anyone passing through the door from the Harper Hideout emerges from a specific door in your Bastion or vice versa, and your Harper Hideout can be located anywhere within 100 miles of your Bastion. At level 13, the facility can be located anywhere in Faerûn. At level 17, the magic doorway works across planes, and the facility can be anywhere in the multiverse.

Empower: Harper Training. When you issue the Empower order to this facility, the facility's hireling extends an invitation to another Harper agent nearby. Roll any die. If the number is odd, no Harper needs your facility and you gain no benefit from having issued the order. If the number rolled is even, a *Friendly* Harper takes up temporary residence in your hideout.

The Harper stays for 7 days. While at your Bastion, the Harper can share their knowledge. Any character who trains with the Harper here for at least 8 hours on each of those days gains proficiency in one of the following skills of their choice: *Deception*, *Investigation*, or *Performance*. This benefit lasts for 7 days.

The Harper won't defend your Bastion and departs immediately if the Bastion is attacked.



HARPER HIDEOUTS PROVIDE REFUGE FOR HARPERS FROM ACROSS FAERÛN.
ARTIST: EREL MAATITA

LORDS' ALLIANCE

The Lords' Alliance is an association of nobles and rulers representing settlements across western Faerûn. The alliance believes that solidarity is the surest means to keep the forces of chaos at bay and secure prosperity for people throughout the North. Agents of the alliance ensure the safety and prosperity of their settlements by proactively eliminating forces that threaten civilization.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

The alliance's primary goal is to ensure the safety and prosperity of cities and other settlements across Faerûn. To accomplish this, alliance members share information with one another about potential threats within and near alliance territory. Dangers are many in Faerûn, leaving the alliance spread thin, so settlements hire reputable adventurers and dispatch them where they are most needed.



ARTIST: OLGA DREBAS

Although the alliance's mere existence is a strong deterrent against evildoers, it has a reputation for internal bickering and dysfunction. Alliance representatives are aware of this reputation, and they go to great lengths to exhibit solidarity and coordination. Cities in the alliance frequently sponsor tournaments, festivals, and fundraisers to increase the perception of a unified North.

Many within the Lords' Alliance believe the best defense is a strong offense and that the alliance should proactively eliminate threats. Alliance leaders pressure one another to keep their borders well guarded. Members frequently hire adventuring parties for scouting missions and forays into monster nests, thieves' dens, and cultist hideouts.

Agents of the alliance swear allegiance to a specific lord. These lords tend to be self-concerned and proud, and they expect their agents to act nobly and bring honor to them. The lords engage in friendly competition over their agents' contributions. Should Waterdeep's militia prove integral to the routing of an invading army, for example, Open Lord Laeral

Silverhand is sure to casually mention this fact at the next Lords' Assembly.

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

Each member of the Lords' Alliance has an official representative on the alliance's governing body, the Council of Lords. Typically this representative is the settlement's ruler. When necessary, a representative can select a proxy to stand in the representative's place.

Representatives convene several times per year for a Lords' Assembly. These assemblies occur around the same time as the festivals that mark the changing of the seasons. Alliance members take turns hosting assemblies, with preference given to cities that have suitably large (and secure) forum spaces. During times of crisis, such as war or catastrophe, an emergency assembly might be called.



FROM LEFT TO RIGHT: AMPHAIL, BALDUR'S GATE, DAGGERFORD, LONGSADDLE, MIRABAR, MITHRAL HALL, NEVERWINTER, SILVERMOON, WATERDEEP, YARTAR

ARTIST: CONCEPTOPOLIS

ALLIANCE MEMBERS

Following are descriptions of some of the members of the Lords’ Alliance and their representatives on the Council of Lords. New members join occasionally, and members sometimes leave the alliance or are expelled.

Amphail. Rivaling Longsaddle for the honor of the alliance’s smallest settlement, Amphail is best known as a playground for bored nobles from Waterdeep. Petty family feuds are the order of the day in Amphail, as are minor catastrophes caused by the unabashed negligence of haughty aristocrats. Lord Warder Dauner Ilzimmer speaks for Amphail on the Council of Lords, but like most nobles in Amphail, he has little interest in matters that don’t endanger his cushy lifestyle.

Baldur’s Gate. The massive city of Baldur’s Gate is one of the Sword Coast’s most powerful trading ports, and Grand Duke Ulder Ravengard’s outsize influence on the Council of Lords reflects this. In Baldur’s Gate, criminals, cultists, and corruption hold as much (if not more) sway as the city’s nobles. The city requires frequent aid from the Lords’ Alliance to maintain order within its walls.

Daggerford. Lady Morwen Daggerford oversees the small, walled town of Daggerford, surrounded by floodplains and pastures. It is a key stopover for caravans headed to Waterdeep or Baldur’s Gate, and this function as a watering hole and supply outfitter makes Daggerford a vital member of the alliance. Daggerford is the kind of idyllic town that settlements in the North aspire to be, with lively taverns and merry festivals that draw visitors from all around.

Longsaddle. Longsaddle is an unassuming hamlet of ranchers, butchers, and farriers famous for a family of wizards, the Harpells, who call it home. Dowell Harpell is Longsaddle’s representative to the Lords’ Alliance, though the wizard exhibits little interest in foreign affairs and rarely speaks during assemblies.

Mirabar. Humans and dwarves are the primary residents of Mirabar, an ancient city built partly belowground. The city’s lifeblood is its gem mines, and Marchion Selin Ramur jockeys for resources from the Lords’ Alliance to protect Mirabar’s vast stores of wealth.

Mithral Hall. Mithral Hall is the ancestral home of the famous Battlehammer dwarven clan. Despite its status as an alliance member, Mithral Hall is more of a stronghold than a settlement, with tunnels to other dwarf holds hidden deep below its mines. Queen Dagnabbet Waybeard represents Mithral Hall on the Council of Lords; a bold leader and a fierce warrior, she firmly supports Mithral Hall’s membership in the Lords’ Alliance despite other dwarven settlements’ reluctance to join the coalition. The queen’s proxy on the council is Ambassador Connerad Brawnnavil.

Neverwinter. The City of Skilled Hands is no stranger to the threats that the Lords’ Alliance was formed to rally against—ancient monsters, agents of Thay, devils from the Nine Hells, and more have endangered Neverwinter in the course of its history. Those who call it home are a serious, resilient folk. Dagult Neverember is the city’s present lord protector, and he commands the people’s respect.

Silverymoon. The peaceful city of Silverymoon is a bastion for scholars, treasure hunters, and anyone who seeks respite from the harsher realities of the North. It is a famous haven for the Harpers and is known for its schools, shrines, and great library. The city’s current leader, Lord Methrammar Aerasumé, is a gruff tactician and Silverymoon’s proxy to the Council of Lords, but the city’s representative is Methrammar’s predecessor, the wise Lord Taern Hornblade.

Waterdeep. Many Waterdhavians become agents of the Lords’ Alliance to represent not Waterdeep as a whole but rather one of Waterdeep’s many power-hungry lords. For her part, the open lord of Waterdeep, Laeral Silverhand, uses spies to assess visiting adventurers. Those who show potential receive invitations from the city guard to undertake quests for the Lords’ Alliance.

Yartar. Yartar is a fortified town best known for its impressive barge-building operation and annual hiring fair, the latter of which attracts adventurers and patrons from across the North. Yartar’s leader and alliance representative, Waterbaron Nestra Ruthiol, is an underhanded, cunning aristocrat. Her vengeful schemes and petty rivalries typify the sorts of internal strife that limit Yartar’s potential influence in the alliance.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Lords’ Alliance by thwarting evil’s attempts to overrun the North and by expanding the influence of settlements that belong to the alliance. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Lords’ Alliance Renown table. If your campaign doesn’t use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

LORDS’ ALLIANCE RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	Nobles from Amphail, Daggerford, and Yartar are Friendly to you by default.
5+	While in an alliance settlement whose nobles are Friendly to you by default, you can buy potions and Spell Scrolls from an alliance quartermaster at a 10 percent discount. A <i>Spell Scroll</i> bought with this discount can contain a spell of level 3 or lower.
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, your lord gives you one random Uncommon magic item.
15+	Nobles from Longsaddle, Mirabar, and Neverwinter are Friendly to you by default.
25+	In any Lords’ Alliance settlement, you can enlist a spellcaster to cast the Sending spell for you at no charge, targeting an alliance representative.
30+	Nobles from Baldur’s Gate, Mithral Hall, Silverymoon, and Waterdeep are Friendly to you by default.
40	The first time your Renown Score reaches 40, your lord gives you one random Rare magic item.
50+	You can request an audience with any representative of the Lords’ Alliance. In addition, you can request a detail of up to three Knights to accompany you for one mission. Once you use this reward, you can’t do so again until your Renown Score increases.

LORDS’ ALLIANCE CHARACTERS

Alliance agents include proud warriors, talented mages, and silver-tongued diplomats. They are experts in combat, observation, and innuendo who are loyal to the alliance.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you’re a member of the Lords’ Alliance, you receive these benefits.

Lifestyle. You enjoy a Wealthy lifestyle while in the alliance settlement you represent and a Comfortable lifestyle within any other alliance settlement.

Mount and Tack. You receive a steed worth up to 75 GP, such as a **Riding Horse**, and a **Riding Saddle**.

Trinket. Roll on the Lords’ Alliance Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Lords’ Alliance.

Lords’ Alliance Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A scrap from a defeated army’s banner
2	A bit and bridle engraved with the name of a famous steed
3	The broken blade of a sword used in a famous battle
4	The left glove of a lord who went mysteriously missing
5	An articulated toy horse and knight
6	A spaulder emblazoned with the insignia of an unidentified lord

HERALDRY OF THE LORDS’ ALLIANCE

Each member of the Lords’ Alliance has a unique coat of arms that identifies them as a member of a house and reflects their reputation. Heraldry is displayed on armor, tabards, and standards.

DESIGNING A COAT OF ARMS

You can design a coat of arms using the following guidelines. A coat of arms is made of four parts.

Escutcheon. The escutcheon is the basic shape of the coat of arms, such as square, oval, diamond, or kite. A shape can be distinctive, such as the pinched shield of Waterdeep.

Division. A division is the way in which the escutcheon is partitioned: solid, halved, divided into three or four parts, split in half diagonally, checkered, and so on.

Charge. One or more charges, symbols associated with the lord’s reputation, are added. Common charges include weapons, armor, monsters, flowers, plants, celestial objects, and musical instruments.

Tinctures. Finally, the coat of arms is distinguished by its tinctures, the materials and colors used in the escutcheon and charges. While traditional tinctures include colors and metals (such as gold or silver), more fanciful tinctures use illusion magic to create shields seemingly made from pure radiance, prismatic light, or shadow.

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Lords’ Alliance can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

LORDS’ ALLIANCE NOBLE RESIDENCE

Level 9 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Lords’ Alliance

Space: Vast

Hirelings: 1

Order: Recruit

You maintain a luxurious apartment fit for the ruler of a city such as Neverwinter, Waterdeep, or Baldur’s Gate. Your hireling is a butler who tends to the resident’s needs.

After spending a Long Rest in your Noble Residence, you gain **Heroic Inspiration**.

Recruit: Visiting Noble. When you issue the Recruit order to your Lords’ Alliance Noble Residence, you forgo sleeping in it for 14 days and instead make it available to a noble from a settlement that is a member of the Lords’ Alliance. Roll any die. If the number rolled is odd, no one accepts your invitation and you gain no benefit from having issued the order. If the number rolled is even, a noble from the settlement you chose accepts your invitation, arriving within 7 days and staying for another 7 days.

The visiting noble gossips about events and inhabitants in their home settlement, revealing to you the location of any creature familiar to you if that creature is within 50 miles of the settlement from which the noble has come, if that creature isn’t hidden by magic, and if that creature isn’t confined to a location that the DM deems beyond the noble’s ability to know. If the noble knows the location of the individual, they also tell you where that creature was for the 7 days prior to the noble’s departure for your Bastion.

The visiting noble won’t defend your Bastion and departs immediately if the Bastion is attacked.



WORKING FOR THE LORDS' ALLIANCE HAS ITS PERKS, INCLUDING A HANDSOMELY FURNISHED NOBLE RESIDENCE.

ARTIST: SAM KEISER

ORDER OF THE GAUNTLET



ARTIST: OLGA DREBAS

A knight follows the order's creed, the Code of Scales and Weights. They're devoted to a patron deity: typically a good god such as Helm, Tyr, or Torm. Finally, a knight of the order defends their companions. To the order, faith is the greatest weapon against evil—faith in oneself, one's god, and one's friends.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

The Order of the Gauntlet is armed and vigilant against evil. Its knights use every resource available, including armed reconnaissance, magical scrying, and divine consultation with higher powers. To ensure they can act swiftly against the forces of evil, knights maintain fortified strongholds along border lands, keep well-stocked armories, and practice daily to remain in peak fighting condition.

The Order of the Gauntlet strives not only to expand the boundaries of just society but to maintain justice in lands where it has already taken root. Knights of the order strengthen their presence by

establishing chapters—fortresses and strongholds from which knights venture on missions.

In keeping with their mandate for swift, tough action, knights of the order are neither subtle nor discreet. In fact, many knights view any amount of deceit or trickery as cowardice unbefitting a member of the Order of the Gauntlet. "There is no shame in doing what is right" is a popular axiom used to encourage knights to serve the order openly.

The order emphasizes retribution rather than proactive measures. Its knights don't try to predict evil or preempt it, believing the practice of trying to preempt villainy, even if well meaning, is the first step on the road toward tyranny. As one line in the Code of Scales and Weights puts it, knights of the order should strive to "punish evil actions, but not evil thoughts." The order insists on personal freedom, believing that every individual, regardless of their past or associates, can act morally and honorably if given the choice.

CODE OF SCALES AND WEIGHTS

To enact judgment quickly and with certainty, the Order of the Gauntlet relies on a lengthy list of crimes and punishments called the Code of Scales and Weights. The Code defines crimes against the order ("scales"), as well as appropriate punishments ("weights").

A written version of the Code is available at every chapter of the Order of the Gauntlet. However, as every knight knows, evildoers won't wait patiently for a law enforcer to consult their notes. Thus, to be initiated to the order, every aspiring knight must commit the Code to heart and recite it before an audience of other knights.

ROLE IN WAR

In times of war, the order's troops are among the toughest, most steadfast soldiers on the Sword Coast. City-states and small nations call on the order to aid their campaigns against injustice. However, the order lends its sword only in conflicts of good versus evil; the order is reluctant to choose sides in morally ambiguous feuds or petty territorial disputes.

In addition to serving as infantry in their own units, veterans of the order act as sergeants or commanders for other units. Soldiers have few qualms taking orders from a knight of the Order of the Gauntlet; many know the leadership and tactical expertise of the order mean the difference between a disorganized defeat and a glorious victory.



LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

The Order of the Gauntlet is a new organization, eager for action. It doesn't take orders from any government or temple, although the opinions of holy figures are greatly esteemed within the order.

HIERARCHY

Knights who commit acts of great valor gain rank in the order: knight of the guard (lowest rank), knight of the banner (second rank), knight of justice (third rank), or chapter knight (highest rank). It's possible, though rare, for a knight to skip one or more ranks when ascending the order's hierarchy.

Members of the order must respect and follow their superiors. Failure to do so is punished by expulsion from the order. This strictness cuts both ways: a high-ranking knight discovered abusing their station is tried in the order's private judicial system, the Court of Justice, and punished severely.

TRIALS AND JUSTICE

The Order of the Gauntlet judges evildoers summarily and punish them promptly. To determine punishments, knights refer to the Code of Scales and Weights or, if in doubt, use a spell such as [Commune](#) to ask a divinity (typically Tyr or Torm) for guidance. Only in the most morally gray situations will knights arrest an offender. Arrested suspects are taken to the nearest chapter to undergo a Court of Justice.

A Court of Justice includes interrogations, cross-examinations, and follow-up investigations. Knights of justice use magic such as the [Zone of Truth](#) spell to determine the facts and identify wrongdoing. Suspects not convicted within a tenday are released.

Knights of justice monitor other knights and the order's larger activities, keeping an eye out for corruption and fanaticism.

CHAPTERS, LEADERS, AND FAITHS

The Order of the Gauntlet's bases are called chapters. The western heartland is home to the highest concentration of order chapters, but knights establish new chapters as the order's influence grows.

Each chapter is run by a chapter knight, overseen in turn by the justiciary sublime. The current justiciary sublime is a seasoned human paladin named Ardria Rightglaive, who oversees the construction of the order's new headquarters, Castle Invetrius in Elturel.

The Order of the Gauntlet's governing body is a tribunal called the Righteous Hand. This tribunal consists of the justiciary sublime (who is sometimes referred to as "the Gauntlet's thumb") and four veteran chapter knights called high champions ("the Gauntlet's fingers"). Historically, the four high champions have been selected from the upper echelons of the order's four most prominent faiths: the churches of Helm, Hoar, Torm, and Tyr, whose followers founded the Order of the Gauntlet.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Order of the Gauntlet by fighting evil or completing quests for the order. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Order of the Gauntlet Renown table. If your campaign doesn't use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

ORDER OF THE GAUNTLET RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	You can stay freely at any chapter of the Order of the Gauntlet, which provides you with a Modest lifestyle.
5+	You earn the honorary title of knight of the guard. Patrons and priests of any temple or shrine of Helm, Hoar, Tor, or Tyr are Friendly to you by default.
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, the order gifts you one random Uncommon magic item from the Armor, Ring, or Weapon category.
15+	You earn the honorary title of knight of the banner. Spellcasters at any temple or shrine at which priests are Friendly to you by default and will cast spells of level 2 or lower for you for free.
25+	When you visit a temple at which priests are Friendly to you by default, you can enlist 1d4 Knights to aid you for 10 days. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases.
30+	You earn the honorary title of knight of justice. Patrons and priests of any temple, shrine, or other established presence of a deity associated with a good-aligned plane of existence are Friendly to you by default.
40	The first time your Renown Score reaches 40, the order gifts you one random Rare magic item from the Armor, Ring, or Weapon category.
50+	You earn the honorary title of chapter knight. If you or one of your allies dies and the body is brought to a temple at which priests are Friendly to you by default, agents of the order cast the Resurrection spell, targeting the deceased. This reward is free the first time you use it. On subsequent occasions, you must provide any Material components normally consumed by the spell.

ORDER OF THE GAUNTLET CHARACTERS

The Order of the Gauntlet appeals primarily to good Clerics and Paladins. However, anyone who worships a righteous god and has a stake in the fight against evil is welcome to petition for knighthood. Fighters and Monks often exhibit the discipline expected of the order's knights. Bards (who memorize the Code of Scales and Weights with ease) and Rangers (whose practical survival skills take them far into lawless wilds) also find their way to the Order of the Gauntlet.

Knights of the Order of the Gauntlet often have training in religious customs, law enforcement, or tactical warfare. Characters with the Acolyte, Guard, and Soldier backgrounds fit in well.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Order of the Gauntlet, you receive these benefits.

Trinket. Roll on the Order of the Gauntlet Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Order of the Gauntlet.

Vestments. You receive a Holy Symbol and a tabard emblazoned with the symbol of the Order of the Gauntlet.

Order of the Gauntlet Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A white feather as heavy as lead
2	An empty vial made from stained glass
3	A single cone of gold-flecked incense
4	A silken blindfold
5	One half of a pair of manacles
6	A tarnished aspergillum

HIGHER CALLINGS

When knights of the Order of the Gauntlet speak of a higher calling, they are referring to the particular way in which a knight pursues and enforces the Order of the Gauntlet's creed. Higher callings come to knights from divine epiphanies, messages from higher powers, or omens witnessed during or after important events.

A knight's higher calling is summarized in a proverb called the knight's dictum. For example, a knight who strives to dismantle systems of oppression might espouse this dictum: "Disarm those who unjustly disarm others." Knights frequently decorate their weapons or armor with their dictums.

Even though a knight's higher calling is usually personal, many knights share higher callings. Knights with shared higher callings often congregate at particular chapters of the order.

Examples include the following:

- Slay cult leaders, crime lords, and other evil masterminds.
- Aid Celestials in their war against Fiends.
- Locate people in need and help them find their way.
- Pursue positions of authority to identify powerful evildoers.
- Construct and maintain a stronghold for the Order of the Gauntlet.
- Perfect virtues that should be undertaken by all.

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Order of the Gauntlet can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

ORDER OF THE GAUNTLET TOURNAMENT FIELD

Level 9 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Order of the Gauntlet

Space: Vast

Hirelings: 1

Order: Empower

The Order of the Gauntlet Tournament Field is a marked-off area for combat between two armed individuals. It includes room for spectators.

Your hireling is a **Knight** whose alignment matches your own. If your Bastion lacks facilities to house this knight, the knight secures accommodations in the inn or settlement closest to the Bastion. This knight isn't a Bastion Defender, but if your Bastion is attacked, the knight reduces by 1 the number of dice you roll to determine how many Bastion Defenders are lost in the attack.

Empower: Hold Tournament. When you issue the Empower order to this facility, you host a tournament at your Bastion. It takes 7 days for word of the tournament to spread to nearby settlements, and another 7 days for contestants to travel to your Bastion and participate in the tournament. You must spend 2,000 GP for prizes. At the conclusion of the tournament, your Renown Score with the Order of the Gauntlet increases by 1.



JOUSTERS ENTERTAIN A RAUCOUS CROWD IN A ORDER OF THE GAUNTLET TOURNAMENT FIELD.
ARTIST: CAIO E SANTOS

THE PURPLE DRAGON KNIGHTS

The Purple Dragon Knights have protected the kingdom of Cormyr for centuries. But a decade ago, the knights underwent a transformation led by the spirit of an ancient amethyst dragon named Eldenser. Eldenser was a scholar of the multiverse, and in his travels, he saw people partnering with dragons on the world of Krynn. Inspired by what he witnessed, Eldenser called other amethyst dragons to Cormyr and persuaded them to partner with the kingdom's Purple Dragon Knights to defend Cormyr while pursuing new knowledge and experiences. Now the knights ride amethyst dragons across Faerûn to oppose Cormyr's enemies, hunt aberrant monsters, and carry out the will of Cormyr's noble queen, Raedra.



ARTIST: HELDER ALMEIDA

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

The foremost obligation of the Purple Dragon Knights is to protect Cormyr and carry out the wishes of its ruler, Queen Raedra. The knights lead Cormyr's armies, defend its strongholds, and represent the crown and Cormyr more broadly across Faerûn. Many travel Faerûn as knights errant, assisting people in need and searching for potential squires.

The knights' amethyst dragon partners have goals of their own. First and foremost, amethyst dragons seek out new experiences. Their curiosity prompts them to explore and collect knowledge not just on Toril, but throughout the multiverse. They have a special hatred of aberrations and lead their knights on quests to hunt and kill such creatures.

Together, Purple Dragon Knights and their dragon partners oppose the Cult of the Dragon, rooting out and destroying secret cells of the cult whenever possible.

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

The Purple Dragon Knights have a simple rank structure. The leader of the organization is the Grand Knight, currently Dunstan Cormaeril, who has served in this role since the re-formation of the Purple Dragon Knights a decade ago. Dunstan is assisted and advised by the spirit of Eldenser, whose incorporeal form dwells inside Dunstan's magic sword. Because Dunstan doesn't have a living amethyst dragon partner, he can't travel around Faerûn as easily as other knights can, and his duties keep him at Purplemont, the knights' fortress in Suzail.

The Grand Knight is assisted by a council of twelve High Knights, experienced warriors whose loyalty to Cormyr is beyond question. They lead other knights of Cormyr in battle.

Most Purple Dragon Knights are simply knights, with no other rank. While knights aspire to become High Knights, few ever achieve that rank. Knights might be assigned quests by the Grand Knight or the queen, but between missions they live as knights errant. They travel Cormyr or anywhere their dragon takes them, pursuing justice for the oppressed, protecting the weak, and furthering the goals of Cormyr.

New knights carry the title of knight novice for a year and a day. During this time, they follow the orders of other knights and master the art of riding a dragon. But because the Purple Dragon Knights are few, knight novices must often rise to the occasion by undertaking perilous missions with only their dragons and fellow adventurers for allies.

Purple Dragon Knights sometimes take squires—aspiring knights who have not yet earned their dragon partner.



ARTIST: JANE KATSUBO

TAKING THE PURPLE

An individual who wants to join the Purple Dragon Knights—or “take the purple,” in Cormyrean parlance—must get the attention of a knight and ask to become the knight’s squire. For citizens of Cormyr, this is relatively easy; an aspiring squire who goes to Purplemont in Suzail can usually attract a knight’s attention in short order. But the legend of the Purple Dragon Knights has spread far and wide in recent years, and people from Icewind Dale to Calimshan dream of riding an amethyst dragon across Faerûnian skies. For these people, finding a knight can be a significant quest.

Knights decide who to take as a squire. Most knights expect a squire to demonstrate fighting skill, courage, a willingness to follow orders, and a keen sense of right and wrong. More eager candidates exist than there are amethyst dragons, so knights select only the best to become squires. Since it’s considered bad luck to accept a squire who has already been refused by another knight, few aspirants continue their quest for knighthood after facing rejection.

Squires usually train for a few years before they’re made a knight, but proving their courage, skill, and character in extraordinary circumstances can expedite their knighthood. But before a squire can become a Purple Dragon Knight, an amethyst dragon must choose the squire as its rider. Not every squire is chosen, and squires passed over by a dragon often get discouraged and quit their pursuit of knighthood. Others stick it out, continuing to serve the Purple Dragon Knights as squires or administrators in hopes to be chosen as a dragon’s rider one day.

THE DRAGON AND THE KNIGHT

The relationship between a Purple Dragon Knight and an amethyst dragon partner is complicated and intense. Amethyst dragons are telepathic; they routinely read their partners’ minds and communicate by thought. Every Purple Dragon Knight knows that secrets can’t exist between a dragon and its rider if both are to succeed; eventually the pair comes to know everything about each other.

Amethyst dragons are exceptionally powerful. A Purple Dragon Knight is usually far less formidable than the dragon they ride. But a dragon’s rider has courage, ambition, and hope—qualities admired by amethyst dragons. The best pairings strategically leverage their strengths and weaknesses. Against an especially dangerous enemy, a knight is apt to let the dragon take point. When a situation calls for diplomacy and a dragon might be seen as a threat, the knight leads.

Purple Dragon Knights make use of their amethyst dragons’ unique powers outside of encounters as well. For example, because amethyst dragons can breathe underwater and swim at great speed, many knights make temporary camps in undersea grottoes or in hidden pools accessible only by flooded tunnels. The Grand Knight even built a secret sanctuary for the knights in the Dragonmere, a small sea on Cormyr’s southern coast.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Purple Dragon Knights by defeating Aberrations and members of the Cult of the Dragon, defending Cormyr from its enemies, and assisting amethyst dragons. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks. If your campaign doesn't use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

PURPLE DRAGON KNIGHTS RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	The Purple Dragon Knights provide you a Comfortable lifestyle for free at Purplemont, the faction's fortress in Suzail.
5+	You can hire Cormyrean hirelings for half the usual cost.
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, the Purple Dragon Knights give you an Uncommon magic item from the Armor or Weapon category.
15+	You are given an honorary Cormyrean knighthood. The royal family of Cormyr is Friendly to you by default.
25+	Amethyst dragons are Friendly to you by default.
30+	You can command a troop of 1d6 Knights to help you on a mission or complete one task that doesn't go against the Purple Dragon Knights' core principles. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases.
40+	You are trusted by the Purple Dragon Knights' Great Knight, who confides in you and provides information.
50+	You are asked to take care of an amethyst dragon egg until it hatches. Additionally, you can call on a High Knight to perform a major favor for you, such as granting a private audience with the royal family. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases.

PURPLE DRAGON KNIGHT CHARACTERS

Adventurers who aspire to join the Purple Dragon Knights were often stricken with wanderlust from a young age or pursued occupations adjacent to knighthood. Characters with the Guard, Sailor, or Soldier background fit in well with this faction. The Purple Dragon Knights take members of all types, as long as a person's heart is untainted by evil and they swear to uphold the glory of Cormyr.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Purple Dragon Knights, you receive these benefits.

Equipment. You receive a Martial Melee weapon, a **Lance**, a suit of Medium or Heavy armor, and an **Exotic Saddle**.

Trinket. Roll on the Purple Dragon Knight Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Purple Dragon Knights.

Purple Dragon Knight Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	An amethyst dragon wyrmling's claw
2	A common purple quartz cut to resemble a dragon's eye
3	A signal whistle audible only to amethyst dragons
4	A robin's egg encased in amber
5	A whetstone that leaves any blade it hones faintly glittery
6	A vamplate taken from a slain rival joustier

DRAGON QUESTS

Before an amethyst dragon accepts a squire as its rider, the dragon sometimes asks the squire to undertake a heroic quest. Completion of this quest signals that the squire is worthy of the dragon's respect and ascension to knighthood. Such quests are rarely simple affairs; some amethyst dragons, now notorious, have assigned the same quest to many squires who failed—or even died—in their attempts.

An amethyst dragon rarely discloses the quest's details until after a petitioner has agreed to undertake it. What's more, a squire who's agreed to undertake an amethyst dragon's quest can't thereafter accept a different dragon's quest.

Some amethyst dragons offer their quests to non-squires, allowing unaffiliated adventurers a chance to join the Purple Dragon Knights without being squires.

If your character aspires to join the Purple Dragon Knights and has received a quest from an amethyst dragon, you can roll on the Amethyst Dragon Quests table to determine the quest.

AMETHYST DRAGON QUESTS

1d6	Quest
1	"Destroy a cell of the Cult of the Dragon, and bring me the cult leader's head."
2	"Find a lance that befits my majesty."
3	"Travel to another world. Return to me only once you have something worth showing."
4	"A psychic disturbance pains me. Locate the monster causing this, and slay it."
5	"I yearn to see an aerie atop a mountain of unparalleled beauty. Take this amethyst to such a place."
6	"I sense the presence of a wayward flumph somewhere on this world. Help this flumph find its cloister."

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Purple Dragon Knights can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

AMETHYST DRAGON DEN

Level 5 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Purple Dragon Knights

Space: Vast

Hirelings: 1

Order: Empower

This den for an amethyst dragon is an enclosed open chamber with a pool, and one of its entrances is underwater. The facility's hiring maintains the den and helps any visiting amethyst dragons feel comfortable.

Empower: Psionic Defenses. When you issue the Empower order to this facility, latent draconic power fills the facility, allowing you to train in psionic combat. This training takes 8 hours per day for 7 days, after which you gain Resistance to Psychic damage. This benefit lasts for 7 days.

AMETHYST DRAGONS

Amethyst dragons are detailed in *Fizban's Treasury of Dragons*, and you can find their stat blocks there along with more information on Eldenser. They are the most powerful kind of gem dragon. Whereas chromatic dragons are typically evil, and metallic dragons typically good, gem dragons are typically neutral. They have the same age categories as other dragons (wyrmling, young, adult, ancient) but their spellcasting powers are psionic in nature. The breath weapon of an amethyst dragon is a bead of exploding gravitational force. Amethyst dragons can breathe underwater and swim at great speed.



AN AMETHYST DRAGON DEN IS A PEACEFUL TRAINING GROUND FOR DRAGON AND KNIGHT ALIKE.

ARTIST: SAM KEISER

RED WIZARDS



ARTIST: SWATCHES STUDIO

When folk in Faerûn think of the Red Wizards, most imagine cabals of undead mages clad in blood-red robes and wielding unholy arcane powers. According to such tales, these vile spellcasters hail from Thay, a hellish nation of paranoid wizard-lords called zulkirs and their zombified minions. Red Wizards are universally evil, so the stories go, and should be treated as such.

The truth is more nuanced. Magic has restored Thay's environment, and trade has returned, despite the dangers posed by Thay's powerful undead ruler, Szass Tam. Szass Tam is a necromancer and lich who rules through fear and cruelty, but he is only one of eight rival zulkirs. These zulkirs—and the Red Wizards they command—can pursue their own interests so long as they don't displease Szass Tam.

Still, Red Wizards share enough common traits—namely their formidable skill at magic and their craving for arcane power—that, despite rivalry among the faction's leaders, the Red Wizards are still a unified group.

THAYAN KNIGHTS

Red Wizards from Thay are often served by one or more Thayan knights—proven warriors whose sworn duty is to protect the Red Wizards. Thayan knights resemble Red Wizards in some ways—shaved heads, arcane tattoos—but lack the faction's trademark red robes and favor sword and shield over staff and scroll. That said, since knowledge of the arcane arts is often necessary to protect their wards, Thayan knights typically boast impressive knowledge of wizardry. Some even wield minor forms of magic to augment their martial abilities.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

Red Wizards are experts in the arcane arts. Many serve a zulkir, while others travel Faerûn gathering magical secrets. Red Wizards often seek ways to extend their lives. In the past, necromancy was the go-to solution to the problem of mortality, but lately zulkirs have begun seeking other methods, such as pacts with devils or archfey or the use of powerful Artifacts.

Rivalry between the zulkirs is ubiquitous. Inside Thay, this rivalry is kept out of the public eye so that the supremacy of the zulkirs isn't questioned. But outside Thay, this rivalry frequently breaks out into the open, leading to battles between Red Wizards on the streets of settlements throughout Faerûn.

Some Red Wizards leave Thay and abandon the dangerous intrigue of their homeland. These Red Wizards travel Faerûn seeking magical power and ancient lore—not to bring back to their zulkir masters, but for their own benefit. Many of these Red Wizards become magic item brokers, financing their travels and arcane research by crafting and magic items.

DEMEANOR AND DISGUISE

As their name suggests, Red Wizards wear crimson robes. In Thay, they are the only caste permitted to wear this color; the penalty for others doing so is death. Most Red Wizards shave their heads and bear prominent arcane tattoos on their face or scalp. Red Wizards might wear silver, steel, or silken accessories, but they aren't ostentatious, nor are they spiritual or overly concerned with traditions or rites. To the Red Wizards, arcane power is everything—more important than all the gold, gods, or glory in the multiverse.

The reputation of a Red Wizard precedes them, and this can create difficulties for Red Wizards who leave Thay to pursue personal goals or simply carry out instructions from the zulkirs. When Red Wizards leave Thay, they often conceal their identities to avoid persecution. Red Wizards' skill at magic makes this a simple matter; unknown numbers of Red Wizards walk in plain clothes, shrouded by illusion, in every major cosmopolitan area of the Forgotten Realms.

TRAVELING AND TRADE

Many Red Wizards travel in groups so they can complement one another's different specialties; since Szass Tam's fall, the eight magic schools have become evenly represented among them. Traveling together also enables Red Wizards to practice circle magic (see chapter 5).

To fund their adventures, many Red Wizards trade in magic items, as well as traditional goods like silver and silk. In many parts of the world, Red Wizards are well known for their ruthlessness in commerce—and, in some cases, their predilection for spell-assisted deception. Common traders exercise great caution when dealing with Red Wizards.



ARTIST: JANE KATSUBO

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

Most Red Wizards hail from Thay and serve that nation's zulkirs—a council of the eight most powerful Red Wizards, one for each school of magic. Szass Tam seldom leaves the Citadel, his most formidable fortress on the slopes of Thaymount. The other zulkirs scheme against each other, pursue personal goals, and relish their lofty positions as corulers of Thay.

Beyond the zulkirs, Red Wizards have no official ranks or hierarchy. Unofficially, Red Wizards are sometimes given one of three titles—apprentice, master, or sage—that reflect magical prowess and respect among other Red Wizards. Apprentices are expected to blend into the background of Red Wizard meetings until they've proved themselves worthy of speaking. Sages are the Red Wizards' eldest, most accomplished arcanists, responsible for training apprentices and rearing future generations of Red Wizards. Masters fall between apprentices and sages and are the majority of Red Wizards.

THAYAN ENCLAVES

Over the last two centuries, Thayan wizards and merchants worked together to establish enclaves—small communities of Red Wizards who traded in magic items and spells—across Faerûn. Governments permitted these enclaves within their borders because they resulted in lucrative trade. According to the charters of the Thayan enclaves, the land within the walls of an enclave is Thayan soil, and Thayan law applies there.

Over the years, many enclaves were besieged or abandoned. But others survived through skillful negotiation on the part of the Red Wizards who lived there or simply because they were far enough away from Thay that even Szass Tam's onerous reputation meant little. A few converted to illicit markets hidden among the mundane trade of the local settlement.

But the old charters are still legally binding, and with a little persuasion, some concessions, and gifts of powerful magic items to the right rulers, Thayan enclaves are reopening in settlements across Faerûn. The typical Thayan enclave is walled and houses a handful of Red Wizards, their bodyguards, a garrison of soldiers to defend the enclave and project power into the nearby settlement, and a flourishing market for magic items. Profits generated by these enclaves go back to Thay to fuel the reconstruction of the nation.

For anyone who seeks an audience with the Red Wizards—or who aspires to become one—the first step is to seek out the nearest Thayan enclave.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Red Wizards by completing quests for the faction, acquiring powerful magic, and contributing to the reconstruction of Thay. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Red Wizards Renown table. If your campaign doesn't use renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

RED WIZARDS RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	You know the locations of Thayan enclaves around Faerûn and can enter and stay in them, providing you a Comfortable lifestyle for free.
5+	You can buy the following kinds of adventuring gear from Thayan merchants at half cost: Arcane Focus, Ink, Ink Pen, Paper, Parchment, <i>Potion of Healing</i> , and <i>Spell Scroll</i> (cantrip or level 1).
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, the Red Wizards give you an Uncommon magic item from the Rod, Staff, or Wand category.
15+	You have Advantage on ability checks made to influence a creature while bartering to buy or sell a magic item.
25+	You gain access to a tattoo artist who can ink <i>Thayan Spell Tattoos</i> on your body (see "Tattoo Magic" below).
30	The first time your Renown Score reaches 30, the Red Wizards give you a Rare magic item from the Rod, Staff, Wand, or Wondrous Item category.
40+	When preparing to cast a Circle spell (see chapter 5) in a town or larger settlement, you can recruit 1d4 Mages to assist you for free. The mages arrive in 1d10 days. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases.
50	The first time your Renown Score reaches 50, the Red Wizards give you a Very Rare magic item from the Rod, Staff, Wand, or Wondrous Item category.

RED WIZARD CHARACTERS

Red Wizards who take up the adventuring life serve Szass Tam or one of the other zulkirs. When not carrying out a superior's instructions, a Red Wizard seeks magical power and explores Faerûn for secrets and lore.

The archetypal Red Wizard is driven by ambition. They are loyal to friends, proven allies, and Thay itself. Altruism is a rare virtue among the Red Wizards, but it shines all the more brightly for that rarity. Most Red Wizard characters are Wizards. Rarely, Warlocks and Sorcerers find their way to the order.

Although not true Red Wizards, Thayan knights frequently deal with the order. To play a Thayan knight, consider taking levels in the Fighter class and selecting the Eldritch Knight subclass.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Red Wizards, you receive these benefits.

Red Robes. You receive a set of crimson robes. As long as you're a member of the Red Wizards, these robes magically mend and clean themselves each day at dawn.

Trinket. Roll on the Red Wizard Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Red Wizards.

Red Wizard Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A gnarled wand made from petrified yew
2	A glass jar containing the preserved heart of an unknown animal
3	A unicorn figurine carved from obsidian
4	A tattoo needle made from one of your own bones
5	A bronze amulet in the shape of a scorpion
6	A razor made of crimson steel

TATTOO MAGIC

Red Wizards often adorn their bodies with tattoos. Many of these tattoos are decorative or symbolic, signifying, for example, a Red Wizard's allegiance to a particular zulkir. Some, however, are magical tattoos, called *Thayan Spell Tattoos*, which allow the wearer to cast the spell contained in the tattoo's ink.

THAYAN SPELL TATTOO

Wondrous Item, Uncommon (Requires Attunement)

This magical tattoo contains the essence of a level 1–3 spell chosen by the tattoo's creator. While the tattoo is on your body, you always have the associated spell prepared, and you can cast the spell using any spell slots you have of the appropriate level. If you have the Spellcasting or Pact Magic feature, the spell uses your spellcasting ability; otherwise, if the spell requires a saving throw or an attack roll, the spell save DC is 13 and the attack bonus is +5. If your Attunement to the tattoo ends, the tattoo vanishes.

You can also cast the spell once without a spell slot and spell components. Once the spell is cast in this way, the tattoo vanishes.

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Red Wizards can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

RED WIZARD NECROPOLIS

Level 5 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Red Wizards, ability to use a Spellcasting Focus

Space: Roomy

Hirelings: 1

Order: Recruit

Red Wizards defend their strongholds with Undead minions. A Red Wizard Necropolis can accommodate up to eight Bastion Defenders.

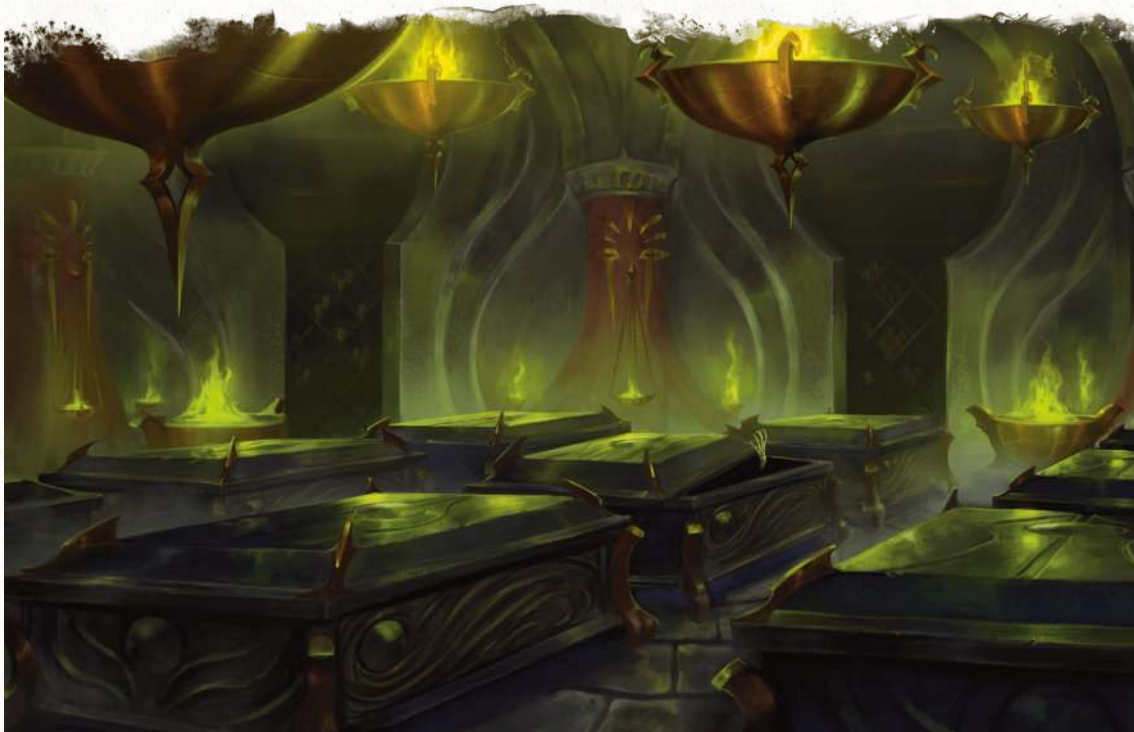
Recruit: Undead Defenders. Each time you issue the Recruit action to this facility, up to four Undead Bastion Defenders are created and take shelter in the crypts and burial chambers of your Red Wizard Necropolis. You can't issue the Recruit order to this facility if it's fully occupied.

Keep track of Undead Bastion Defenders you lose and deduct them from your Bastion Defenders roster. An Undead Bastion Defender returns to your Red Wizard Necropolis 14 days after being destroyed. Undead Bastion Defenders can't return from being killed if the facility is shut down or fully occupied.

INKING THAYAN SPELL TATTOOS

The Thayan art of magical tattooing is highly guarded by its practitioners, and thus, *Thayan Spell Tattoos* can't be crafted like other magic items. To learn how to ink *Thayan Spell Tattoos*, you must have a Renown Score of 50+ with the Red Wizards.

To ink a *Thayan Spell Tattoo*, you must have proficiency in the *Arcana* skill and with Calligrapher's Tools and have the spell prepared each day of the inking. You must also have at hand any Material components required by the spell; if the spell consumes its Material components, they are consumed when you complete the tattoo. Inking a *Thayan Spell Tattoo* takes the same amount of time and money as scribing a *Spell Scroll* of an equivalent level.



A SKELETAL BASTION DEFENDER ARISES FROM ITS COFFIN IN A RED WIZARD NECROPOLIS.

ARTIST: CAIO E SANTOS

ZHENTARIM

The Zhentarim—also known as the Black Network—is a loose affiliation of merchants, mercenaries, and malefactors. When a caravan needs escorts, a noble needs bodyguards, or a city needs soldiers, the Zhentarim provides the best-trained fighting forces money can buy. If the cargo is shady or the cause is questionable, the Zhentarim doesn't mind one bit—if there's money to be made, Zhents will dabble in just about any venture.

Zhentarim agents consider themselves part of an extended family, and membership in the organization comes with the perks—and tension—that familial relations imply. Resources and security are shared among the organization, but the Zhentarim recognizes and rewards personal ambition, granting its members autonomy to pursue their own interests. In this way, the organization is a meritocracy; those who do well for themselves do well in the Zhentarim at large. But woe be to any whose personal aims conflict with the Zhentarim's, for loyalists respond to treachery with fierce retribution.



ARTIST: OLGA DREBAS

The Zhentarim welcomes all whose primary motivator is money. This mindset has earned the organization a negative reputation among Faerûn's other factions. Harpers in particular have historically clashed with Zhents, and members of the Lords' Alliance and Order of the Gauntlet keep a close eye on the organization's effects on Faerûnian politics. At an individual level, however, adventurers have little to fear from Zhentarim allies on assignment—they just make sure to read the fine print before signing any Zhentarim contracts.

GOALS AND ACTIVITIES

The Zhentarim's public-facing philosophy is one of ruthless enterprise. According to Zhentarim doctrine, money left on the table benefits no one and only wastes precious resources. By this logic, the faction's activities are altruistic. No laws are being broken, after all; the laws are simply being used to their fullest potential.

In actuality, the Zhentarim has its fingers in many illegal industries and unsavory ventures, ranging from racketeering, intimidation, and smuggling to grand larceny, assassinations, and warmongering. Zhentarim veterans may go deep undercover for months at a time, disrupting well-established local power structures, or leading task forces of lower-ranking agents into volatile situations.

In places where laws prove too restrictive for the Zhentarim to achieve its fiscal goals, it pulls strings to change those laws. In some parts of Faerûn, the Zhentarim effectively is the authority, having rewritten the legal code to suit its own ends. Such is the case in many districts of cities like Waterdeep and Baldur's Gate as well as the Zhentarim's de facto headquarters in Darkhold.

The Zhentarim's ultimate aims are unknown. The most common theory is the Zhentarim wants to monopolize trade protection and become the richest organization in Faerûn. If merchants were ever wholly reliant on Zhentarim transport, the Zhentarim would control commerce across the entire globe. But no one knows what the Zhentarim would do with such power once the faction had it.

TIES TO EVIL DEITIES

The Zhentarim has a long history of involvement with two deities: Bane and Cyric. Presently the organization has no official affiliation with any god, but these deities still find many devotees among

the Zhentarim. Bane's ethos of domination over the weak is a natural complement to the ambitions of power-hungry Zhents, whereas Cyric's cunning and ruthlessness are admirable traits in Zhentarim circles.

Nowadays, religious Zhents are more likely to consort with diabolic divinities than world-famous gods. The Lords of the Nine boast countless patrons who can advance a mortal's social standing or wealth, and many Zhents beseech such powers. Some of the Zhentarim's most popular infernal sponsors include Mammon (the Nine Hells' principal miser), Fierna (coruler of Phlegethos with her father, Belial), and Glasya (Asmodeus's daughter).



ARTIST: COUPLEOFKOOKS

LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATION

The Zhentarim is based foremost out of Darkhold, a citadel in the western Heartlands. Darkhold Vale has a small militia that answers to a local captain named Sulvarn. But the true leader of the castle—and the entire Zhentarim organization—is the legendary Pereghost: a dark knight credited with leading the Zhentarim toward its current prosperity. No one knows the Pereghost's identity or whether he is even a single person; he's never been seen without his black iron armor and face-covering helm, and he's led the Zhentarim for over a hundred years.

FIVE THINGS EVERYONE KNOWS ABOUT THE ZHENTARIM

Anyone in Faerûn who didn't grow up under a rock knows the following about the Zhentarim:

If you want to move something unnoticed, hire Zhentarim mercenaries.

The Zhentarim considers itself one big family. If you cross one Zhent, you cross them all.

When trying to make an impression on a Zhent, a little coin goes a long way.

Zhents take great pride in their weapons and armor, which are often embellished with special insignias.

Zhentarim brokers are legal experts. Don't try to swindle a Zhent.

The Zhentarim famously conducts itself like a family. Some members take this to heart by assuming epithets like uncle, mother, or cousin. But the Zhentarim's official titles are far more sinister sounding. In order of lowest to highest rank, titles range from primal animal parts (such as fang) to the names of predators (wolf, viper) to original monikers of Zhentarim design (ardragon, dread lord).

ZHENTARIM OUTPOSTS

Although the Zhentarim's center of power is in Darkhold, the organization maintains outposts in virtually every region where there's money to be made. Whether Zhents are manipulating the knucklehead trout trade of Icewind Dale, inflating the price of sunmelons in the Dalelands, or hunting rare dinosaur pelts in Chult, they rely on Zhentarim outposts to relay news, refresh supplies, and relax after a successful job.

Many Zhentarim outposts are secret—unassuming locales such as abandoned warehouses and crumbling tenements that keep illegal doings hidden from public notice. Other outposts are ostentatious and richly appointed: handsome manors, lavish villas, and well-outfitted guild houses that loudly advertise the organization's services and reputation for success.

RENOWN REWARDS

Characters gain renown with the Zhentarim by completing Zhentarim jobs and expanding the organization's reach. As their Renown Score increases, characters gain access to various perks, as shown on the Zhentarim Renown table. If your campaign doesn't use Renown, your DM decides if and when characters earn these perks.

ZHENTARIM RENOWN

Renown Score	Reward
3+	You earn the honorary title of fang. You can stay in Zhentarim-controlled safe houses and inns, providing you a Poor lifestyle for free.
5+	You can reliably sell stolen goods in settlements.
10	The first time your Renown Score reaches 10, you receive a random Uncommon magic item.
15+	You earn the honorary title of wolf. You receive a 10% discount when buying weapons, armor, and adventuring gear in Zhentarim-controlled markets.
25+	You earn the honorary title of viper. In Zhentarim-controlled settlements, you have Advantage on Charisma (Intimidation) checks made to influence others.
30+	You can assign a group of up to six Spies to complete a task that doesn't interfere with the Zhentarim's business. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again until your Renown Score increases. In addition, the first time your Renown Score reaches 30, an ardragon gives you a writ for a Zhentarim insignia (see "Zhentarim Insignias" below).
40+	You earn the honorary title of ardragon and receive the authority and funds necessary to establish your own Zhentarim outpost. In addition, you can call on a Zhentarim-allied Beholder for help on a single mission. Once you use this reward, you can't do so again.
50+	You earn the honorary title of dread lord. In addition, the first time your Renown Score reaches 50, Zhentarim agents cast the Clone spell, targeting you, for free.

ZHENTARIM CHARACTERS

Adventurers of every stripe can excel in the Zhentarim. Fighter, Monk, and Rogue are good choices for a rank-and-file Zhentarim mercenary. Wizards, Warlocks, and Bards are well suited to the skilled work and high-level deals required to make it in the organization's upper echelons.

The fewer scruples a character has the better; lawful and good-aligned characters won't be comfortable doing the Zhentarim's ethically dubious work. When it comes to background, many Zhents trace their origins to prior work as a Criminal, Merchant, or Soldier.

MEMBER BENEFITS

If you're a member of the Zhentarim, you receive these benefits.

Loaner Gear. At the outset of a Zhentarim assignment, you can requisition a single weapon or suit of armor worth up to 50 GP. You must return the item to the Zhentarim on the job's completion or pay a fee equal to twice the item's price.

Steady Work. You can always find mercenary work while in a settlement.

Trinket. Roll on the Zhentarim Trinkets table to determine what trinket you have from your time with the Zhentarim.

Zhentarim Trinkets

1d6	Trinket
1	A broken dagger etched with your name
2	A glass eye that always turns to face you
3	A gold-colored serpent's tooth
4	A counterfeit gold coin
5	A crystal tattoo needle
6	A contract on a slip of parchment that's impervious to creases, tears, and fire

ZHENTARIM INSIGNIAS

Zhents take great pride in their tools of the trade. Many Zhents decorate their cherished weapons and armor with ornamental accessories, decorative etchings, and other custom flourishes.

Zhentarim artisans craft and apply specific motifs called Zhentarim insignias. These insignias, which must be authorized by a senior Zhent of rank viper or higher, recognize the recipient's good work, notable exploits, or continued loyalty. Zhents wear their insignias on their gear with great pride, much as soldiers wear badges of honor.

Only Zhentarim-affiliated artisans are permitted to apply an insignia; counterfeiters are rooted out and punished.

Work with your DM to determine what, if any, insignia your Zhentarim character has. The most common Zhentarim insignia is of a downward-flying dragon chasing an orb on a field of flames, which signifies an individual has completed their first successful job for the Zhentarim. Later, this initial design could be augmented with insignias that signify important deeds or special honors. For example, additional orbs usually signify the accumulation of wealth, and the number of flames on the field of fire signify lives taken during Zhentarim jobs.

SPECIAL FACILITY

Members of the Zhentarim can add the following special facility to their Bastions.

ZHENTARIM TRAVEL STATION

Level 5 Bastion Facility

Prerequisite: Membership in the Zhentarim

Space: Vast

Hirelings: 2

Order: Research

The Zhentarim maintain stations to facilitate safe and swift long-distance travel on journeys (see chapter 2 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*). Your travel station includes temporary stabling facilities for four Large creatures; two Medium creatures occupy the same space as one Large creature there. The facility's hirelings look after these creatures.

Long-Distance Travel Speed. Finishing a Long Rest in your Bastion better prepares you for travel; your group's maximum travel pace increases by one step (from Slow to Normal or from Normal to Fast).

Research: Reconnaissance. When you issue the Research order to this facility, you commission the Zhentarim Travel Station's hirelings to gather information that facilitates an upcoming journey. This work takes 7 days. For the duration of the journey, you have Advantage on Wisdom (*Survival*) checks to forage or navigate.



ZHENTS USE ZHENTARIM TRAVEL STATIONS TO PREPARE THEMSELVES FOR LONG-DISTANCE MERCANTILE JOURNEYS.

ARTIST: EREL MAATITA

CRIMINAL SYNDICATES

Thieves’ guilds, crime rings, and outwardly lawless factions are common in Faerûn. While some are so local in scale, short lived, or disorganized that they’re little more than common gangs, others—such as the Shadow Thieves of Amn or the Fire Knives of Westgate—enforce their edicts on monarchs and lords through intimidation, terror, and outright murder. Adventurers, justice seekers, and potential rivals (or accomplices) do well to keep tabs on these criminal organizations.

FIRE KNIVES

The Fire Knives is a syndicate of noble-born assassins, extortionists, enforcers, and spies based out of Westgate. The syndicate is run by the city’s ruling family, House Bleth, blurring the line between law and crime there.

Originally based out of Cormyr, the Fire Knives traces its roots to two disgraced noble families from that nation: House Bleth and House Cormaeril. Most Fire Knives are born into the organization from these families, though the syndicate occasionally recruits outsiders. Anyone who wants to influence Westgate society benefits from a good relationship with the Fire Knives.

Members of the Fire Knives take advantage of their noble bloodlines and aristocratic training to move freely within high society and get close to their favored targets: Cormyrean nobles—particularly House Obarskyr. Only the syndicate’s leader, the Grandmother of Assassins, knows the true reasons behind the Fire Knives’ bloodthirsty schemes.

Fire Knives agents work alone on assassinations, though they sometimes use accomplices to help them set up the killing and escape safely afterward. Most prefer poisoned blades—daggers, stilettos, or the like—to accomplish their deeds, using aristocratic wiles or clever disguises to get close to a target before eliminating them. When necessary, an agent slips a toxin into the target’s food or drink instead. The Fire Knives disdain what they consider “brutish” weapons, such as garrotes and crossbows.

NINE GOLDEN SWORDS

The Nine Golden Swords is a powerful crime syndicate based out of Thesk in northeast Faerûn. From there, the Swords’ power extends eastward along the Golden Way, the legendary trade route between Faerûn and lands to the east, as well as westward around the Sea of Fallen Stars, where cells operate in port cities like Telflamm and Westgate. The Nine Golden Swords’ operations include highway robbery, intimidation, and peddling vices in dens of iniquity. The leader of the Nine Golden Swords is a mysterious figure known as the Golden Throne.

The Nine Golden Swords has a strong foothold in Westgate, where they’re based out of the city’s Shou District. The syndicate opposes the ruling Fire Knives and claims to be an organization of the people, though most recognize it’s a criminal enterprise. Still, the Nine Golden Swords has publicly opposed the Fire Knives’ worst affronts against those too weak to defend themselves. Consequently, the Nine Golden Swords enjoys the favor of the working class.

Punishment, rather than reward, is the typical tool of control within the Nine Golden Swords. Members are referred to as soldiers and are treated as an elite military order, with defection punished by death. Conversely, a soldier’s loyalty might be rewarded in time, but advancement isn’t guaranteed. The hierarchy of the Nine Golden Swords is opaque, even to those inside the organization.

SHADOW THIEVES

The Shadow Thieves is the largest and most prosperous thieves’ guild in Faerûn. Its goals are simple—accumulate wealth and acquire power—and thus appeal to aspiring crooks and cons the world over.

The Shadow Thieves is based out of the nation of Amn, where it controls markets as well as politics and is even secretly supported by that nation’s ruling Council of Six. The Shadow Thieves once controlled the criminal underworld of Waterdeep, to the north; the guild’s leaders have nursed a grudge against the city and its rulers ever since their exile.

The Shadow Thieves’ influence is felt far and wide. According to common wisdom, the Shadow Thieves has a hand in everything that happens along the Sword Coast. Savvy merchants and aristocrats alike recognize the folly of ignoring the guild, so individuals of means make allies among the Shadow Thieves, or at least stay apprised of the faction’s activities.

The Shadow Thieves’ success is derived from its complex hierarchy, which is organized into layers like an onion. At the center of the guild is the Shadow Council, led by the Grandmaster of Shadow. Reporting to the council are senior administrators called cloakmasters, who are in turn served by the guildmasters and the guild’s countless rank-and-file operatives. Situated at each level of this hierarchy are arrays of blinds—stool pigeons with false titles who operate out of decoy hideouts and whose purpose is to throw off the Shadow Thieves’ enemies.

Joining the Shadow Thieves isn’t difficult, and recruits who survive their first few missions can quickly climb the guild’s ranks. Guildmasters have autonomy to recruit and promote within the local guild level.



ON THE STREETS OF A CITY LIKE BALDUR'S GATE, NONE ARE SAFE FROM THE SHADOW THIEVES.

ARTIST: IGNATIUS BUDI

XANATHAR GUILD

The Xanathar Guild is, despite its name, a criminal organization in Waterdeep with no official guild status. Anyone is welcome to join, and many runaways, street urchins, and common ruffians seek admittance to the Xanathar Guild in hopes of improving their poor lot. Before membership is granted, however, an applicant must pass a test that always involves committing a serious crime. Possibilities include murdering a guild member who has failed Xanathar in some fashion, kidnapping a Waterdhavian citizen, collecting a ransom, robbing a coach, or looting a warehouse.

Among low-ranking guild members, rampant speculation goes on about the true nature of Xanathar. Some say Xanathar is a beholder or another monster, perhaps an unusually patient minotaur or magically enlightened ogre, while others insist that the name belongs to a human who uses illusion magic to appear like a monster. Still others contend that Xanathar isn't an individual but rather a metaphor for a set of villainous ideals. (Intellectualism is held in low esteem in the Xanathar Guild, even by the standards of criminal gangs, so that last theory is scorned by guild members.)

Advancement in the guild is fiercely competitive and based on a member's wiles or their ability to dispose of rivals. Evil adventurers can thrive in this environment, but the risks are seldom worth the reward.

OTHER ORGANIZATIONS

Countless other factions, orders, and societies populate the Forgotten Realms. This section describes numerous organizations that, though less well known than the other factions in this chapter, have made a sizable impact.

ARCANE BROTHERHOOD

The Arcane Brotherhood is a cabal of powerful wizards that operates out of the Hosttower of the Arcane, a multispired structure that towers above the city of Luskan on the Sword Coast. The group's leadership consists of five renowned archmages who handpick the other members, favoring wizards of great accomplishment. Every year, scores of wizards from across Faerûn flock to the Hosttower in hopes of gaining admittance to the brotherhood's prestigious ranks. Nearly all candidates are dismissed out of hand without so much as a test, feeding rumors that the group's leaders are more interested in marketing their own brand of exclusivity than finding new talent. Yet prospective wizards are willing to debase themselves regardless, for admittance to the brotherhood grants access to the Hosttower's incredible libraries of magical lore.

Once welcomed into the organization, wizards are free to pursue their own interests so long as they place the security and sanctity of the Hosttower and the cabal above all else. When not rallying to defend their home, wizards of the Arcane Brotherhood are rivals to one another, striving to outdo their peers in magic. Open conflict between members is forbidden, yet members are adroit at finding underhanded ways to needle and sabotage one another.

AURORA’S EMPORIUM

Aurora's Emporium sells unusual and luxury goods in cities across Faerûn. Clients order items out of a detailed catalog, then pick up their purchases at any of the Emporium's many convenient locations. Purchases can also be delivered by special request. Among the catalog's unique array of offerings are useful adventuring gear; specialty curiosities; and staples such as wine, bread, and a dozen varieties of cheese.

The Emporium's goals are threefold: acquire quality goods, make these goods available to interested parties at a reasonable profit, and uphold the name of Aurora's Emporium as an honorable business with satisfied customers.

The business's namesake is Aurora, a former adventurer whose mission in retirement was offering the kinds of gear and supplies she wished she'd been able to purchase in her heyday. Because she was an adventurer herself, Aurora understood the importance of procuring reliable, quality merchandise, so she provided the best products and service money could buy. She became a legend in the adventuring community but passed many years ago after a long and happy life. Now the business is run by her great-granddaughter, also named Aurora, who employs storekeepers and mages to conduct day-to-day sales operations, and adventurers to procure new and interesting items for sale.

The first Emporium storefront opened in Waterdeep, and the enterprise has since spread throughout Faerûn. The Emporium now consists of dozens of shops and warehouses in locales both populous and remote. Emporium workers use magic to transport goods to stores—a practice that keeps valuable items from becoming targets for thieves.

One of Aurora's most popular offerings is the cheese bag: a pound of cheese randomly selected from a dozen different varieties from around Faerûn. According to the posters on many of Aurora's Emporiums, the cheese bag is the “Best Cheese Deal on the Material Plane.” One cheese bag costs 1 GP, and sales are limited to one per person per day. When a character buys a cheese bag, roll on the Cheese Bag Contents table to determine the kind of cheese therein.

CHEESE BAG CONTENTS

1d12	Cheese Variety
1	Arabellan cheddar
2	Chessentan lotus cheese
3	Damarite red
4	Elturian gray
5	Farmer's cheese
6	Green Calishite
7	Mist cheese
8	Nut cheese
9	Pepper cheese
10	Turmish brick
11	Vilhon blanc
12	Waterdhavian



A FLAMING FIST MERCENARY FIGHTS OFF DEVIL WORSHIPERS IN BALDUR'S GATE.
ARTIST: PINDURSKI

ELEMENTAL CULTS

Four cults of evil doomsayers scattered across Faerûn (and, indeed, the entire multiverse) are collectively known as the elemental cults. These cults are ancient and appear on every world. Whenever and wherever the cults manifest, heroes or gods usually seek to destroy them in due order. But the elemental cults never truly die, eventually returning in some fashion.

The elemental cults venerate a mysterious force or principle called Elemental Evil. Each cult worships Elemental Evil in its own way, favoring one of the four primordial elements: air, earth, fire, or water. The cults operate independently from one another, and each believes itself superior to the others.

AIR

Cultists of the Howling Hatred venerate the element of air. To them, powerful winds are the ultimate expression of power. Air cultists are among the most vengeful and petty members of the elemental cults, seeing slights in every social encounter and brooding on ways to get back at their rivals. The cult's numbers frequently include assassins, illusionists, and spies.

EARTH

The Cult of the Black Earth aims to destroy civilization by exerting the inexorable power of the land. Earth cultists conduct rituals to bring about mudslides, sinkholes, and earthquakes in the effort to wipe the world clean of those who defile it. This cult counts miners and quarry workers among its enemies and burrowing beasts like ankhegs and bulettes among its allies.

FIRE

The followers of the Eternal Flame cult worship the destructive power of fire in all its manifestations. Their ideal world is a wasteland of ash and cinders—a world purified by flames. Fire cultists tend to be reckless and brash. They launch themselves into dangerous situations with no regard for their own safety, seeking only to inflict as much damage as possible. To fire cultists, it is better to burn brightly and briefly than to live a long life of mediocrity.

WATER

Cultists of the Crushing Wave believe that all life is simply water waiting to be set free by way of bloodshed, drowning, or pulverizing pressure. Members of this cult are opportunistic and pragmatic, exploiting enemies' weaknesses whenever possible. They seek out wealth and magic items to advance their schemes. Among those who hear the call of Elemental Evil, fishers, sailors, and others who feel at home on water are typically drawn to this cult.

FLAMING FIST

The Flaming Fist is a mercenary company based in Baldur's Gate. It is led by the city's grand duke, Ulder Ravengard. Although the Watch is the city's official constabulary, the Flaming Fist is its true peacekeeping force. The mercenaries' red and gold colors are so ubiquitous in Baldur's Gate that they are commonly associated with the city itself.

Membership in the Flaming Fist is easy to achieve. The company offers employment and a sense of belonging to any who can lift a sword and follow orders, regardless of their origins. Thousands of soldiers currently serve in Baldur's Gate proper, at the Fortress of Wyrms' Rock on the Chionthar River, and at remote outposts such as Fort Beluarian in Chult.

Experienced adventurers swiftly advance in rank (and political influence) once they become members. Many ranking officers are former adventurers who have "retired" to the company.

KRAKEN SOCIETY

The Kraken Society is made up of seafarers and land dwellers alike who advance the cause of their patron, an enigmatic entity that dwells at the bottom of the Trackless Sea. They traffic in information and commit all manner of atrocities along the Sword Coast and throughout the Trackless Sea's islands in pursuit of their mysterious goals. Norlanders and other sailors of the Trackless Sea whisper the name Slarkrethel, a monstrous squid some call the King of the Trackless Depths, though just as many dismiss the creature as a mere fable.

Members of the Kraken Society are called Krakenar. To Krakenar, information is power, and this tenet guides their actions. Information can be sold to enrich the group's coffers or wielded as a weapon against the society's enemies. The right words whispered in the right ears can deliver great fortunes to society leaders—countless merchant ships, for instance, have sunk to the floor of the Trackless Sea as a result of Krakenar meddling.

Krakenar who accrue and disseminate information quickly are apt to climb the faction's ranks. Skilled diviners and spies make up most of the Kraken Society's upper echelons. Beyond information gathering, Krakenar conduct assassinations, kidnappings, torture, and other violence.

Most Krakenar join the Kraken Society with the sole aim of advancing their own personal power and wealth. But the watchful eye of Slarkrethel and the strict discipline enforced by the kraken's senior followers both ensure that Krakenar keep the Kraken Society's interests at top of mind.

ORDER OF DELVERS

The Order of Delvers is an explorers' guild dedicated to exploring and mapping Faerûn's vast subterranean underbelly. Guild members are called delvers, and chapter leaders are called delvemasters. The guild promotes the exploration of cave systems, natural tunnels, and the uppermost levels of the Underdark.

The Order of Delvers was originally founded by a devout dwarf explorer who sought to locate the mythical Soulforge—the hearth where, according to dwarven mythology, Moradin the All-Father created the first dwarves. The order has since expanded into a spelunking guild with chapters in dwarfholds throughout Faerûn. Many delvers are dwarves devoted to traditional dwarven religious beliefs, but anyone with an adventurous spirit and an appetite for discovery is welcome to join.

MEMBER BENEFITS

A member must pay regular dues to remain in the order. Delvers enjoy a variety of benefits, including the following.

Discounted Supplies. Delvers receive discounts on equipment and services purchased from guild-sponsored smithies and adventurers' shops.

Guild Support. Members are expected to share their discoveries and useful findings with fellow members of the Order of Delvers.

Recovery Services. In the event of a catastrophic mishap, the Order of Delvers can be hired to send a team of highly trained delvers to locate and recover a delver's belongings (and, if necessary, their corpse).

Special Equipment. The Order of Delvers commissions a variety of magic items available for delvers to purchase, including [Elven Chain](#), [Heward's Handy Haversacks](#), and [Orbs of Direction](#).

SPELLGUARD

The Spellguard is an order of militaristic mages based out of Silverymoon. Originally founded as the royal guard of Silverymoon's then-ruler, Alustriel Silverhand, the Spellguard's duties soon expanded to include the protection of the whole city. During times of peace, members of the Spellguard patrol Silverymoon's borders and monitor the roads between Silverymoon and its allied cities. Though most Spellguards remain close to Silverymoon in case of emergency, elite Spellguards are assigned to special missions in distant lands and even other parts of the multiverse.

The responsibilities of the Spellguard are too grave to entrust to a novice. To join this elite order, an individual must prove their prowess in battle magic, including creating and dispelling magical wards, scrying enemies' positions and intentions, and launching effective magical assaults. Many young mages strive to join the Spellguard both out of pride for their city and to enjoy the prestige and perks that accompany the station.

In time, the order's most experienced veterans can rise to the position of warder. Warders are responsible for testing and training new recruits and spend most of their time in and around Silverymoon's High Palace.

WATERCLOCK GUILD

The Waterclock Guild was a group of artificers, geomancers, and artisans based out of Neverwinter. The guild's members were responsible for crafting that city's once-famous waterclocks: beautiful, incredibly accurate timekeeping devices powered by the flow of water and—unknown to many—elemental magic.

Although the guild proper ceased operation long ago, vestiges of its works still litter forgotten crypts and abandoned ruins in Neverwinter. Recently, traveling gnome and dwarf crafters arrived in Neverwinter in search of the Waterclock Guild's lost inventions. These crafters claimed to be guild members returning from a centuries-long sojourn, and they sought to recover their fellows' relics so they could restore the guild and continue its work. Their labor is still underway, but the project, now known as the Waterclock Renaissance, seems destined for success.

The leaders of the Waterclock Renaissance are eager to bolster their numbers. Even novice clockmakers are being considered for positions in the small organization, as are woodworkers, metallurgists, and spellcasters with an aptitude for the craft and maintenance of clocks.



A RETINUE OF SPELLGUARDS FLANKS THE WIZARD ALUSTRIEL SILVERHAND IN SILVERYMOON.
ARTIST: IRINA NORDSOL

ATLAS OF FAERÛN

ARTIST: MIKE SCHLEY



CREDITS

Lead Designer: Jason Tondro

Designers: Bill Benham, Makenzie De Armas, Dan Dillon, Ron Lundeen, Ben Petrisor, Patrick Renie, Shahreena Shahrani, Carl Sibley, Chris Sims, David Sommerville

Rules Developers: Jeremy Crawford (lead), Makenzie De Armas, Ron Lundeen, Ben Petrisor, Patrick Renie

Editors: Adrian Ng Di Spaltro (lead), Judy Bauer, Michele Carter, James Wyatt

Art Director: Emi Tanji

Graphic Designers: Matt Cole (lead), Jino Choi, Meagan Kenreck, Paolo Vacala

Cover Illustrators: Billy Christian, Dominik Mayer

Interior Illustrators: Helder Almeida, Helge C. Balzer, Luca Bancone, Eric Belisle, Olivier Bernard, Zoltan Boros, Bruce Brenneise, Ignatius Budi, Ekaterina Burmak, Dmitry Burmak, Pedro Cardoso, Manuel Castanon, Domenico Cava, Conceptopolis, CoupleOfKooks, Olga Drebas, Polar Engine, Ioannis Fiore, Aurore Folny, Quintin Gleim, Patrik Hell, Jane Katsubo, Sam Keiser, Tneh Keong, Jonathan Kuo, Andrey Kuzinsky, Katerina Ladon, Titus Lunter, Erel Maatita, Erion Makuo, Agustín Marceillac, Raluca Marinescu, Dominik Mayer, Marcela Medeiros, Alex V. Ngo, Irina Nordsol, Gavin O'Donnell, Robin Olausson, Hinchel Or, Alejandro Pacheco, Miro Petrov, Borja Pindado, PINDURSKI, Anna Podedworna, Chris Rahn, Chris Rallis, Audy Ravindra, Denman Rooke, Caio E Santos, Chris Seaman, Leroy Steinmann, Swatches Studio, Taras Susak, Brian Valenzuela, Svetlin Velinov, Raoul Vitale, Sam White, Rafael Zanchetin

Cartographer: Mike Schley

Concept Art Director: Josh Herman

Concept Artists: Alex Branwyn, Michael Broussard, Daarken, Lake Hurwitz, Titus Lunter, Alex Ostrowski, Noor Rahman, Siren Song LLC, Anna Steinbauer

Consultants: Basheer Ghouse, James Mendez, Shareena Shahrani

Producers: Bill Benham, Siera Bruggeman, Rob Hawkey, Vanessa Hoskins

Special thanks to Ed Greenwood, Jeff Grubb, and all the many people who have created and contributed to the Forgotten Realms over its fantastic history.

ARTIST: HINCHEL OR



ON THE COVER

Vajra Safahr, Karlach, and Jarlaxle Baenre lead an army—and a gold dragon—into battle in this scintillating illustration from Dominik Mayer.



ON THE ALT-COVER

Vajra Safahr, Karlach, Minsc, Boo, and Jarlaxle array themselves for battle in the ruins of Myth Drannor in this majestic illustration from Billy Christian.

DUNGEONS & DRAGONS, D&D, Wizards of the Coast, the dragon ampersand, *Player's Handbook*, *Monster Manual*, *Dungeon Master's Guide*, Forgotten Realms, all other Wizards of the Coast product names, their respective logos, and The World's Greatest Roleplaying Game are trademarks of Wizards of the Coast in the USA and other countries. All characters and their distinctive likenesses are property of Wizards of the Coast. This material is protected under the copyright laws of the United States of America. Any reproduction or unauthorized use of the material or artwork contained herein is prohibited without the express written permission of Wizards of the Coast.

Printed in the USA. ©2025 Wizards of the Coast LLC, PO Box 707, Renton, WA 98057-0707, USA. Manufactured by: Hasbro SA, Rue Emile-Boéchat 31, 2800 Delémont. CH.